The Odyssey

Retold in English, with Explanations

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Preface

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A PREFACE, CONTAINING THE MINIMUM YOU NEED TO KNOW

This poem is a sequel, and its poet never pretends otherwise. He assumes that you have heard all about the Trojan War, because everyone he sang for had; and he assumes you know one other story besides, a story about a homecoming, which he never tells straight through but circles all the way to the end of the book. I do not intend to load you up with mythology here — everything else will be explained as it comes, in the text or in the notes below the line — but these two things you should have in your pocket before Book One, because the poem leans on them from its opening page.

First, the war. A prince of Troy — a rich city across the sea, in what is now Turkey — was a guest in the house of Menelaus, king of Sparta, and left with his host's wife, Helen, the most beautiful woman in the world. Whether she went willingly is a question the Greeks themselves never settled, and neither will we. Menelaus's elder brother was Agamemnon, the most powerful king in Greece, and he raised an army from every Greek kingdom to fetch her back; among the kings who sailed with him, not especially willingly, was Odysseus of Ithaca, a small rocky island in the west. The siege of Troy lasted ten years, and the city fell in the end not to strength but to a trick — the great hollow horse of wood, with armed men in its belly — and the trick was Odysseus's. And then, in the hour of winning, the Greeks behaved so foully in the sacked city that the gods who had favoured them turned around; the homeward fleets were scattered, wrecked, and drowned, and hardly anyone got home clean. That is where our poem stands: the war has been over for ten years when it begins, and one man has still not come home.

Second, the homecoming — the other one. Agamemnon came home from Troy in triumph, the war won, the ships loaded. In his ten years away, his wife, Clytemnestra, had taken a lover: Aegisthus, a cousin of the king's from the bitter side of the family. The two of them welcomed Agamemnon home, sat him down to the feast of his return, and murdered him at the table. For years the deed stood unpunished, until Agamemnon's son, Orestes, grew up, came back, and killed his father's killers. Every character in the *Odyssey* knows this story; it is the recent news of their world, and it stands behind our poem like a shadow behind a lamp. A man is missing at sea; his wife waits at home surrounded by other men; his son is coming of age with a debt to settle. The poem never once lets you forget that this exact arrangement has just ended, in another royal house, in blood — and every wife, son, and homecoming in our story will be measured against that one, openly, by the characters themselves.

The names you need, then, are six:

- **Agamemnon** — high king of the Greeks, leader of the war, murdered on the day he came home.
- **Clytemnestra** — his wife, who did the murdering.
- **Aegisthus** — her lover, who did it with her.
- **Orestes** — their son, who avenged it.
- **Atreus** — Agamemnon's father, whose name hangs over the whole family; "son of Atreus" is how the poem usually says *Agamemnon*.
- **Menelaus** — Agamemnon's brother, Helen's husband, king of Sparta; he got home late, but he got home, and we will be visiting him.

That is the whole kit. Zeus, Athena, Poseidon and the rest you will meet as we go, and I will introduce them properly when they arrive. Turn the page; the gods are holding a meeting, and they are talking, as it happens, about Aegisthus.

Book 01

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK ONE

In Which the Gods Hold a Meeting, and a Young Man Discovers He Has a Voice

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Before we begin, a word about beginnings.

The old poets never simply *started*. That would have seemed to them rather like sitting down to dinner without saying anything at all, or building a house without laying a foundation, or (to use a comparison they would have understood better than either) setting out on a long sea voyage without first pouring a little wine into the water for the gods and hoping they were in a good humour. A poet always began by asking for help. Not from his listeners — from a Muse.[1]

So the old poem begins with a request, and since we are going to be together for some while, you and I, I shall begin with one too, and then get on with it.

Tell me about the man of many turnings — the one who was clever in a hundred ways and got very little good out of any of them; who wandered a long, long way after he had knocked down the holy towers of Troy; who saw the cities of many peoples and learned what was in their minds; who suffered a great deal at sea, in his own heart, struggling to keep his life and to bring his companions home. He never did bring them home, though. They died of their own foolishness, the idiots — they ate the cattle of the Sun, and the Sun took away their day of homecoming. Begin wherever you like, goddess. Begin anywhere, and tell us too.

There. That is more or less how it went, and I have kept it, because it tells you three things straight off, and it is polite to tell people what a story is about before they are three hundred pages into it.

The first thing is that this is a story about a man who was extremely clever and it did not save him. The second is that he lost every single one of his men, and that it was not his fault, which is a thing the poem is at some pains to say early and say plainly. And the third — well, the third is the one that matters most. All of that business with the sea and the monsters and the cattle of the Sun: it is not the point of the story. It is the part everybody remembers, the way everybody remembers the dragon and not the will. The point of the story is a house. A particular house, on a small stony island, with a woman in it and a boy who has grown up in it without a father, and a great many uninvited guests eating everything in it. The sea monsters are on the way to the house. Do not lose sight of the house.

Now then.

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[1] **The Muses.** Nine goddesses, daughters of Zeus and of Memory — which is exactly the right parentage, as you will see. This poem was composed before writing was in general use in Greece, and it was not read; it was *performed*, from memory, by professionals, over several evenings, probably with a stringed instrument going underneath it. A poet who could hold twelve thousand lines in his head and produce them on demand did not feel that this was a thing he was doing entirely by himself, and he did not think he was being modest when he said so. When he asked a Muse to sing *through* him, he meant it fairly literally. The daughters of Memory were the ones who kept the words safe. Whether one man called Homer made this poem, or several, or a tradition of hundreds over centuries, is a question people have been arguing about for two thousand years, and it has a name — the Homeric Question — and no answer.

By the time our story opens, the war at Troy had been over for ten years, and every Greek[2] who was going to get home had got home. They had straggled back one by one, out of the storms and the shipwrecks and the long detours, and their wives had wept over them, and they had hung up their shields and settled down to complain about the weather and the young. The rest were dead — buried under the walls of Troy, or drowned on the way back, or (in one particularly nasty case, which we will come to) murdered on their own doorsteps by people who ought to have been glad to see them.

Only one man was still out.

His name was Odysseus, he was the king of a small rough island called Ithaca off the west coast of Greece, and he was, at this moment, sitting on a beach a very long way from it, crying.

He was being kept there by a goddess called Calypso, who lived alone on an island in the middle of nowhere, who was beautiful, who was in love with him, and who had told him — quite sincerely, and more than once — that if he would only agree to stay with her she would make him immortal, and he would never grow old, and they would live together forever in a cave with vines growing over the mouth of it and four springs running clear water in four directions. She was not being cruel. She thought she was offering him the best thing anyone had ever been offered, and by most reckonings she was.

He said no. He said no for seven years. He spent his days sitting on the rocks looking east over the water, hoping to see so much as the smoke going up from the chimneys of his own house, and wishing he were dead; and at night he went back to the cave and lay down beside her because there was nowhere else on the island to lie down. That is the situation, and I want you to sit with how uncomfortable it is for a moment, because a great many people have retold this part as though it were a holiday. It was not a holiday. It was seven years of being loved by somebody you have not chosen, on an island you cannot leave.

And the gods, on the whole, were sorry for him. All of them except one.

The exception was Poseidon, who was god of the sea and of earthquakes and of horses (an odd combination until you have seen surf coming in), and who had a grudge against Odysseus of the deepest and most personal kind, which we shall come to in its proper place. It is enough for now to say that Odysseus had blinded Poseidon's son, and that Poseidon was not the sort to let that go. He could not quite kill the man outright — that was not permitted him — but he could keep him from home, and he had been keeping him from home for a decade, with the patience of water working on stone.

It happened, however, that just now Poseidon was away. He had gone off to the far south to a feast among the Ethiopians, who lived at the ends of the earth where the sun rises and sets, and who were famous for two things: being the most distant people in the world, and being unusually good hosts.[3] He would be gone some while, and he had left no one minding the door.

Which was exactly what Athena had been waiting for.

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[2] **"Greeks."** The poem never uses the word. It calls them Achaeans, or Argives, or Danaans, more or less interchangeably, according to what fits the rhythm of the line. None of these means quite what "Greek" means today, and there was no country called Greece: there were many small kingdoms speaking related dialects who thought of themselves as one people only in certain moods — such as when sailing to Troy together. Throughout this book I say "Greeks", because saying "Achaeans" makes it sound like a story about strangers, and it is not.

[3] **The Ethiopians.** Not the people of the modern country, though the name survives there. To this poet the word meant, roughly, "the people at the far edge of the world where the sun is close," and they were understood to be exceptionally pious and to give exceptionally good dinners, for which reason the gods went to visit them and were reliably unavailable. It is the ancient equivalent of a character being out of mobile reception, and the plot needs it.

The gods lived on Mount Olympus, in the north, on a peak so high that it goes up out of the weather altogether; and while people down below imagined all sorts of things about their arrangements up there, the honest truth is that the arrangements were embarrassingly like a family. They ate together. They argued at the table. They took sides, and remembered slights, and worked round one another, and the whole enormous machinery of the world went grinding along beneath them as a sort of by-product of who happened to be annoyed with whom that week.

At the head of the table was Zeus, who was king, and who had been thinking about a murder.

"It really is extraordinary," he said, to no one in particular, in the tone of a man returning to a grievance he has aired before, "the way they blame us. Listen to them. Every disaster that comes to a mortal, and it's the gods, the gods, the gods — as if we sat up here inventing miseries for them. When the plain fact is that they manufacture the greater part of it themselves, out of their own recklessness, and then send up the bill to Heaven.

"Take Aegisthus. We *told* him. We sent Hermes down specially — went to some trouble about it — and said: do not murder that man, and do not marry that man's wife, because there is a son, and the son will grow up, and when he is grown he will come for you. We could not have been plainer. And he did it anyway, and the boy grew up, and came for him, exactly as advertised. And now I suppose we shall be told that was our doing as well."[4]

There was a small pause of the kind that falls when everyone at a table knows that somebody is about to use an opening.

"Father," said Athena.

Now I must tell you about Athena, since she is going to be in this story more than anyone else except the two people it belongs to. She was Zeus's daughter, and his favourite, and the goddess of exactly three things, which were: war (but only the kind that is planned and won, not the kind that is enjoyed), crafts and weaving and everything made carefully with the hands, and cleverness. That last is the important one. She was the patron goddess of good ideas, quick answers, and lies told well in a tight corner — and you can see at once why Odysseus was her particular favourite among all the men alive, because he was the finest liar in the world and she admired him for it the way a master carpenter admires a joint.

"Father," she said, "Aegisthus got what was coming to him, and so may everyone else who does what he did. But my heart is broken over Odysseus. Poor wretched man — he has been away from his own people all this time, on an island in the navel of the sea, in the house of Calypso, who keeps him there with soft words and coaxing so that he will forget Ithaca. And he cannot forget it. He would be glad to see the smoke going up from his own roof and then die. And it does not move you at all. Did he never sacrifice to you, out there beside the ships at Troy? Why are you so hard on him?"

"Child, what a thing to say." Zeus looked genuinely startled. "How could I ever forget Odysseus? There is no man alive with better sense, or who gave the gods their due more generously. It is my brother Poseidon, who is in a rage about the Cyclops — his son, whose eye Odysseus put out. He will

[4]**The murder Zeus is talking about.** Agamemnon was the commander-in-chief of the whole Greek army at Troy, the greatest king of his day. While he was away, his cousin Aegisthus seduced his wife Clytemnestra; and when Agamemnon came home in triumph after ten years of war, the two of them killed him at his own homecoming feast. Seven years later Agamemnon's son Orestes came back from exile and killed Aegisthus. — Now: keep that story in your hand for the whole of this book, because the poem is going to hold it up beside our story again and again, like a tailor holding cloth against cloth. A king comes home from Troy. There is a wife who has waited, and a son who has grown up, and men in the house who should not be there. It happened one way for Agamemnon. Everyone in this poem, gods included, is watching to see which way it will happen for Odysseus. Penelope is being measured against Clytemnestra every time she comes down the stairs. Telemachus is being measured against Orestes, and knows it, and it terrifies him.

not kill him. He simply moves him about the sea and will not let him come home. Well. Let us all put our heads together and settle it. Poseidon will have to give way. He can hardly hold out against every one of us at once."

"Then send Hermes," said Athena, who had had the plan ready for some time and was not going to waste the moment, "to Calypso's island, to tell her plainly that it is decided, and that Odysseus goes home. And I will go to Ithaca — to his son. I will put some spirit into the boy. I'll have him call the Greeks to assembly and speak out to the whole island against these men who are eating him out of house and home. And then I'll send him off to Pylos and to Sparta to ask after his father. He may hear something. And if he hears nothing, he will at least come back a man with a good name, which is worth having."

Zeus agreed, because he always did in the end, and because it was a good plan.

And Athena went down.

She went down from the peaks of Olympus and came to Ithaca, and stood at the outer gate of the courtyard of Odysseus's house, holding a bronze spear; and she had taken on the appearance of a man — a stranger, a sea-captain named Mentes, chief of a people called the Taphians, who were traders and part-time pirates, there being less difference between the two professions than either would have admitted.[5]

And what she saw, standing at that gate, was this.

The courtyard was full of young men. They were sprawled on the hides of oxen — oxen they had killed themselves, out of the herds of the house — and they were playing at dice, and shouting, and enjoying themselves enormously. Servants were running about among them at a half-trot, the particular half-trot of people who have been working too hard for too long with no end in sight: some mixing wine and water in the great bowls, some wiping down the tables with sponges and setting them out again, some carving up more meat than any household could afford. There were a hundred and eight of these young men. They were the sons of the best families of Ithaca and the islands round about. They had been living in that house, at that house's expense, for something over three years.

They were there to marry the queen.

Here I had better stop and explain, because this is the part that a modern reader stumbles over, and if you stumble over it now the whole book will limp.

Odysseus had been gone twenty years. There was no news of him, no body, no grave — nothing. Under the customs of the time a woman in that position was in an impossible middle place: not a wife, because her husband was almost certainly dead; not a widow, because nobody could prove it. And the kingdom was in the same middle place. Ithaca had no king, and its heir, Telemachus, had been an infant in arms when his father sailed and was now barely twenty — old enough to be angry, not yet old enough to be obeyed.

So the young men of the district had worked it out among themselves, as young men will. Whoever married Penelope would in all likelihood become king. Therefore they would all court her at once. Therefore they would all move into her house, and stay there, and eat and drink at her expense until she gave in and chose one — and the longer she held out, the more of the estate they would get through,

[5] **Mentes, and a word you already know.** Athena spends most of this poem in disguise, and this is the first of many. Later she will borrow the shape of another of Odysseus's old friends, an Ithacan called Mentor, to guide and advise Telemachus on his travels — which is where our word *mentor* comes from. The word entered English by a roundabout route (a French novel of 1699 that retold these events for the education of a prince), and it means what it means because of a goddess pretending to be somebody's uncle.

which they did not mind in the least, because the whole point of the exercise was that the estate would eventually belong to one of them.

You will want to know why she did not simply throw them out. She could not. A woman could not order armed men off the property, and the law of that country provided her no help she could call on. You will want to know why she did not simply *say no*. Then her father would have taken her home and married her to somebody of his choosing, and the house would have passed out of Telemachus's hands entirely; and there would still have been a wedding, only now she would have no say in it at all. You will want to know why Telemachus did not throw them out, and the answer is arithmetic: one young man and a handful of loyal servants against a hundred and eight armed sons of powerful families, every one of whom had a father and brothers who would want blood if he were harmed.

They were, in short, not besieging the house. They were doing something cleverer and much crueller. They were being *guests*. And that is the joke at the black heart of this entire book, because in that world there was no law more sacred than the law of guests — and these men had turned it inside out and were wearing it as armour.[6]

Telemachus saw the stranger at the gate before anyone else did, because he was not enjoying the party.

He was sitting a little apart from the rest, sick at heart, doing the thing he did most days, which was to imagine his father walking in through that gate: coming in out of nowhere, scattering the suitors like poultry, taking back his own house and his own honour and his own place at the head of his own table. It is a daydream that will be familiar to anyone who has ever been young and powerless in a house full of people behaving badly. It had the particular quality of all such daydreams, that it did not make him feel better afterwards.

And then he looked up, and there was a stranger standing at the gate — waiting, being kept waiting — and Telemachus was up and across that courtyard like a shot, appalled.

He took the stranger's right hand in his own and took the bronze spear with the other, and he said: "Welcome, sir. Sit down and eat something, and afterwards you shall tell us what you need."

Notice the order of that sentence. He did not ask the man's name. He did not ask his business, or where he was from, or how long he intended to stay. That was not merely good manners; it was the law, and Telemachus was following it to the letter in a house where nobody else had followed it for three years. First you take the stranger in, and feed him, and give him a bath and clean clothes and a good chair. *Then* you ask who he is. And when he leaves you give him a present, and if he ever comes back, or his children come, or his children's children, your house and his are friends forever and neither may lift a hand against the other. It was called *xenia* — guest-friendship — and it was under the personal protection of Zeus himself, who kept a special title for the purpose: Zeus of the Strangers, god of anybody who turns up at your door with nothing.[7]

[6] **The suitors, and why this is a horror story.** It is worth saying plainly what these men are doing, because our word "suitors" makes it sound like a Jane Austen problem. They have occupied a house whose master is missing and whose heir is a boy. They are consuming the estate deliberately — the estate they intend to inherit — as a way of applying pressure to a woman who has no legal means of removing them. They are doing this under the protection of a sacred custom, in numbers that make resistance suicide, and they are enjoying it. That is the situation, and everything else in this poem — the monsters, the shipwrecks, the twenty years — is the long way round to the door of that hall.

[7] **Guest-friendship (*xenia*).** The most important social institution in this world and the hardest for us to feel from the inside, because we have police, and hotels, and passports. In a world with none of those, a traveller far from home was a man with no protection of any kind, and the only thing standing between him and being robbed and killed on any road in Greece was a religious obligation — that the stranger at your door is sacred, and that Zeus himself watches how you treat him. Feed him first; ask his name afterwards; send him away with a gift. In return, the guest owes the host courtesy, honesty,

Which is why it is quite an important detail that the young man who kept the law that day, alone in that house, was giving a chair and a footstool and the best cuts of the meat to a god in disguise.

He led her in and set her spear in the rack against the great column, where his father's spears were standing — still standing, still there, and I do not think you need me to tell you what that rack of spears was doing to him every day of his life. He gave her a fine carved chair set a little apart from the crowd, with a linen cloth over it and a footstool, and drew up a seat for himself beside it, so that his guest would not have to eat within earshot of the noise and would not have to listen to men bellowing over dice while she ate.

A servant girl brought water in a golden jug over a silver basin and poured it over their hands, and set out a polished table, and the housekeeper brought bread and a great many small dishes, and the carver brought platters of meats and set gold cups beside them, and the steward went up and down keeping them filled.

And then the suitors came in.

They came in and took their places and set to, with a great deal of noise, and when they had eaten and drunk as much as they wanted they began to want other things — dancing and singing, which is the crown of a feast — and a herald put a beautiful lyre into the hands of a man named Phemius, who sang for those men because they made him, and who began to sing.[8]

And under the cover of the music, Telemachus put his head close to his guest's, so that no one else would hear, and said:

"Friend — I hope you won't take this badly. It's easy for *them*: they eat another man's living and pay nothing for it, a man whose white bones are lying out in the rain somewhere on land, or rolling in the sea's surf. If they saw him walk in through that door there is not one of them who would pray to be faster on his feet — they'd pray to be richer in clothes and gold, and much good it would do them. As it is, he has died badly, and there's no comfort anywhere, not even if somebody told me he was coming. His homecoming is finished.

"But tell me — who are you? Where do you come from? What ship? And this is what I really want to know: is this the first time you have been here, or were you a friend of my father's? A great many men used to come to this house. He got about, in his day."

And Athena — Mentes — said: "I'll tell you everything. My name is Mentes; my father was Anchialus, and I'm chief of the Taphians. I'm here with my own ship and crew, sailing the wine-dark sea to trade iron for copper. My ship's lying out of town under Mount Neion. My family and yours have been guest-friends since your grandfather's time; ask old Laertes if you doubt me. And I came because they told me your father was home. Apparently the gods have him tangled up somewhere still.

"He isn't dead, though. Odysseus is alive, and on some island, held by hard men who won't let him go. I'm no prophet and I don't read birds, but I'll tell you what I think: he will not be away much longer. He'd get out of an iron cage. He'll find a way.

"But tell me this. You're — what, Odysseus's son? You must be. That head, and those eyes; it's uncanny."

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and restraint. It goes both ways, and it binds the two families permanently. Once you have this in your head, you have the moral spine of the entire poem: nearly every episode in it is a test of hospitality, passed or failed. Odysseus's whole voyage is a series of doors he knocks on. The Cyclops fails the test at one end of the scale. The suitors fail it at the other.

[8] **Phemius.** Remember him. He is a professional bard in a hall he cannot leave, singing to men he did not choose to entertain — a fact that will matter very much indeed, several hundred pages from now, on a day when it is dangerous to be found in that hall. There is also a fine joke buried here, and I do not want you to miss it: this poem is being performed by a bard, in a hall, for a company of noblemen at dinner. Its audience were looking at a real Phemius while they listened. And the song he sings is *the Greeks coming home from Troy*, which is the song we are currently inside.

"My mother says so," said Telemachus, "and I suppose she would know. Though for my own part I sometimes wish I were the son of a man who had grown old on his own farm among his own things. As it is, I'm the son of the unluckiest man ever born. That's your answer."

Then Mentes said, "Well, the gods have not left your house without a name, whatever else they've done, if Penelope has a son like you. But now tell me about *this*." And the stranger looked out across the hall — at the shouting, and the meat going round, and the dogs, and the wreckage of it. "What is all this? A wedding? A public dinner? Because it certainly isn't people paying for their own food. They look to me like men eating another man's house down around his ears, and behaving very insolently about it. Any decent man walking in here would be disgusted."

And that opened the door, and out it all came.

"Stranger — since you ask — there was a time when this house was rich and respectable, back when *he* was still on the island. But the gods have decided otherwise, and they have made him vanish more completely than any man who ever lived. I could bear it better if he were dead. If he had gone down at Troy with his friends around him, or died in his own bed with the work of the war behind him, the Greeks would have built him a barrow, and I'd have had that at least to hand on. As it is the storm winds have carried him off with no name and no notice, and left me nothing but grief.

"And he isn't the only thing I have to cry about. Look at them. Every man of rank in Dulichium and Same and wooded Zacynthus, and every man of rank on this rock of an island, is courting my mother and wrecking my house. And she cannot refuse them — it would be the ruin of her — and she cannot bring herself to choose. And meanwhile they eat, and drink, and in a little while they will have eaten me down to nothing, and I expect me with it."

Athena was very angry when she heard that, and she said:

"By heaven, you need your father. If Odysseus were to come and stand in that doorway now, with a shield and two spears and a helmet on his head, the way I first saw him — if he came in on those men the way he was that day, they would find their marriages short and bitter. But that lies with the gods, whether he comes home and pays them out in that hall or not. So think about this instead: how are you going to get them out of the house *yourself*?

"Listen to me and do as I say. Tomorrow morning call the Greeks to assembly — all of them — and speak, and let the gods be your witnesses. Tell the suitors to go home. As for your mother, if she has a mind to marry, let her go back to her father's house, and let *them* deal with the dowry and the bride-gifts, as is proper for a daughter they think well of.

"And here is my advice for you. Take a ship — the best you can get — and twenty rowers, and go and ask after your father. Go to Pylos first, to old Nestor; and then to Sparta, to Menelaus, because he came home last of all the Greeks and he will have picked up more news than anybody.[9] If you hear your father is alive and on his way, then grit your teeth and put up with this for one more year. And if you hear he is dead, then come home, and heap up a barrow for him, and give him the funeral rites in full, and give your mother to a husband. And when that is done and finished — *then* think very carefully about how you are going to kill these men in your house, by a trick or in the open.

"You are too old to be a child any longer. Have you not heard what a name young Orestes got for himself among men, when he came home and killed the man who murdered his father? You are tall,

[9]**Nestor and Menelaus.** Nestor was king of Pylos, the oldest of the Greek commanders at Troy, famous for talking a very great deal and being, on balance, worth listening to. Menelaus was king of Sparta and the husband of Helen — whose departure to Troy, willing or otherwise, started the war in the first place. He got her back, and got home last of anybody, after being blown all the way to Egypt. They are the two surviving men most likely to know something, and Telemachus's journey to them takes up the next three books.

my friend, and you are handsome, and men will be talking about you for a long time yet. Be brave.

"And now I must go down to my ship. My crew will be getting restless. See to this yourself, and remember what I've said."

"Friend," said Telemachus, "you have spoken to me like a father to his son, and I will not forget it. But stay a little longer — bathe, and rest, and let me give you a present to take home with you, something fine, something worth keeping, the way friends give to friends."

"No — don't hold me now. I am in a hurry. Whatever gift you feel moved to give me, give it to me when I come back, and let it be a good one, and you shall have as good in return."

And with that Athena went out of the hall, and up — like a bird going up, straight up out of sight.

And she left something in the young man's chest that had not been there that morning. He stood a moment where she had left him, and then he understood, in the way one does understand such things, without being told: and he went across the hall towards the suitors, and he was not the same person who had been sitting in the corner an hour before.

The bard was still singing. He was singing about the Greeks coming home from Troy, and about all the ways it had gone wrong for them, and the suitors were sitting quiet for once and listening.

And upstairs, Penelope was listening too. She heard it from her room above the hall, and she could not bear it, and she came down the long stairs with two maids behind her and stood by the pillar at the edge of the room with her veil across her face; and she was crying, and she said:

"Phemius — you know a hundred songs. Sing them one of those. Let them sit here and drink their wine in peace and listen to anything else at all. Only stop singing *that* one, because it breaks my heart in my breast every time, and I have a grief in this house that will not be lifted, and a man I remember every hour of every day, whose name is spoken across the whole of Greece."

And Telemachus said: "Mother — why shouldn't he sing what he likes?"

I want you to notice that this is the first thing Telemachus says in the whole poem to his own mother, and that he has just come from a conversation with a goddess.

"It isn't the poets who cause these things," he said. "Zeus causes them; he gives out what he likes to each of us, and there's no arguing with it. There's nothing wrong in singing about the Greeks' bad end. People always praise the newest song loudest, whatever it's about. Set your heart to listen. My father was not the only man who never came home from Troy; a great many others were lost as well.

"Go back upstairs, and see to your own work — your loom, and your spinning, and keep the maids at theirs. Talking is men's business, and mine most of all, since I am the master of this house."

And Penelope went back upstairs, astonished, and turned that over in her mind for a long while, and cried herself to sleep. And I confess I have never been quite sure how to take that speech — whether it is a boy trying on his father's voice and finding it a size too large, or a young man discovering that being brave and being kind are two different accomplishments and that you can manage the first before you have learned the second. Probably it is both. Most people are unbearable for a little while just after they find their courage.

The suitors, meanwhile, broke into an uproar in the shadowy hall, every one of them praying to be the man who got into her bed. But Telemachus stood up in front of the lot of them and said:

"Suitors of my mother — you insolent, overbearing men — let us enjoy our dinner, and let there be no shouting, because it is a fine thing to listen to a singer like this one. But in the morning let us all take our places in assembly, all of us, and I will make my speech to you plainly. Get out of my house. Feast

somewhere else; eat your own food; go round from house to house and use up your own inheritances. Or if you think it better and more profitable to eat one man's living and pay him nothing for it — then go on doing it, and I will call on the gods, and Zeus may yet see that you are paid what you are owed; and you will die in this house, and there will be no vengeance taken for any one of you."

That silenced them. They bit their lips and stared at him, because they had never in three years heard him speak like that.

Then Antinous said — and Antinous is a man you may as well start disliking now, because you will be doing a great deal of it later — "Telemachus. The gods themselves must be teaching you to make speeches, and to make them so *boldly*. I hope Zeus never makes you king of Ithaca, even though it is yours by birth."

"Antinous," said Telemachus, "I'll say this even if it annoys you. I should be quite happy to take the kingship, if Zeus offered it. Do you think it's the worst thing that can happen to a man? There's nothing wrong with being a king: your house grows rich and you are held in honour. But there are plenty of other Greek princes on this island, young and old, and one of them can have the title, now that Odysseus is dead. What I *will* be master of is my own house, and my own servants, whom my father won for me."

And Eurymachus said, smoothly — for Eurymachus was the one who always spoke smoothly, and you should distrust him rather more than Antinous, not less — "Telemachus, which of us is to be king of Ithaca lies with the gods; but nobody is going to take your property from you while there are men living on this island. Now. Tell me about your visitor. Where was he from? What was his family? Did he bring news of your father, or was he here about some debt of his own? He got up and went off very quickly; he didn't wait to be introduced. He didn't look like a man of no account, either."

"Eurymachus," said Telemachus, "my father's homecoming is over and done with. I don't believe any news now, whoever brings it, and I have no time for prophecies. That man was an old guest-friend of my father's from Taphos: Mentes, son of Anchialus, chief of the seafaring Taphians."

So he said. And in his heart he knew perfectly well that he had been talking to a god.

Then they turned to dancing and singing again and enjoyed themselves until evening came on; and when it did, they went off to their own homes to sleep, which is the one thing that could be said in their favour.

And Telemachus went up to his own high room in the fine walled courtyard, in a place with a view all round it, and went to bed with his mind turning over and over.

Going with him, carrying blazing torches, went Eurycleia — daughter of Ops, son of Peisenor — who had been bought by his grandfather Laertes long ago, when she was a girl, for the price of twenty oxen; and who had nursed Telemachus as a baby, and loved him more than any of the servants in that house did.[10]

She opened the door for him, and he sat down on the bed and pulled off his soft tunic and put it into the old woman's hands, and she folded it and smoothed it and hung it on a peg beside the bedstead and went out of the room, drawing the door to by its silver handle and pulling the bolt home with the

[10]**Eurycleia, bought for twenty oxen.** She is a slave. So are most of the servants in this house, and in every great house in the poem, and the text says so without embarrassment, because it did not occur to anyone that it required one. I am not going to smooth this over, and I am not going to let it pass without comment either. Hold two things at once, as the poem does: Eurycleia was purchased, like livestock, at a price the poem is happy to quote you; and Eurycleia loves this boy, and he loves her, and she is going to be one of the two or three people in the entire story who can be relied upon absolutely when everything comes apart. Both of those are true, and the second does not excuse the first. It is a very old book. Twenty oxen, and a lifetime, and a lamp in a doorway at the end of a bad day.

strap.

And there he lay all night, wrapped in a fleece, thinking about the journey Athena had told him to make.

NOTES TO BOOK ONE

Book Two: In Which There Is a Meeting, and a Sign in the Sky, and a Ship Sails at Night.

Book 02

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK TWO

In Which There Is a Meeting, and a Sign in the Sky, and a Ship Sails at Night

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When Dawn came up, with her rosy fingers, Odysseus's dear son got out of bed.

I should say something about that dawn before we go any further, because you are going to meet her a great many times and I do not want you to think I have run out of ideas.

In the original, Dawn is a goddess with rose-red fingers, and she has them every single morning without exception, in this poem and in the other one, for the excellent reason that "rosy-fingered Dawn" is a block of six syllables that fits the metre exactly and can be dropped into the front of a line whenever the sun comes up. The sea is wine-dark. Ships are hollow. Athena is grey-eyed. Achilles is swift-footed even when he is sitting down sulking in a tent, which is most of the time. These are not lazy writing. They are the load-bearing timbers of a poem that had to be composed *while it was being performed*, out loud, in front of an audience, without a script; and a bard who had four hundred such phrases in his head, sorted by length, could build a line the way a mason builds a wall, reaching for the stone that fits the gap.[11]

So: rosy-fingered. Every time. I shall use it when it seems to want using, and you may take it as a small ceremonial noise the poem makes at sunrise, like a clock chiming.

Telemachus got up and dressed, and slung a sharp sword over his shoulder and tied good sandals on his shining feet, and came out of his room looking, the poem says, very like a god; and he told the heralds to sound the call and summon the Greeks of Ithaca to assembly.

They sounded it, and the men came in from all over the town — slowly at first, then faster, because word got round, and word had something remarkable in it. There had not been an assembly on Ithaca since Odysseus sailed for Troy.

Twenty years. Think about what that means. It is not that the island had been badly governed; it is that it had not been governed at all. No court had sat, no dispute had been judged in public, no decision had been made in the hearing of the men it fell on. Whatever machinery Ithaca once had for the ordinary business of a community had simply been let go, and grass had grown up through it, and everyone had got used to that — and the hundred and eight young men in the great house had grown from boys into men in a country where no one had asked anybody anything in front of witnesses for

[11] **Formulas.** In the 1930s a young American scholar named Milman Parry went to what was then Yugoslavia and recorded illiterate village singers performing enormously long heroic poems from memory, and discovered that they did it exactly this way — by assembling stock phrases of fixed metrical shape, improvising the joins. It settled an argument that had run for centuries. The repeated epithets in Homer are not decorative and they are not clumsy: they are the technology of oral composition, and to a listening audience they were not tiresome at all but reassuring, the way a returning chorus is reassuring. They are also, in translation, largely untranslatable in their original function, since English prose has no metre to fill. I keep the best of them for their flavour and let the rest go.

two decades. That is not a coincidence. That is the soil the whole disaster grew in.[12]

Telemachus went down to the meeting-place with a bronze spear in his hand and two quick dogs trotting at his heel. And Athena poured a supernatural grace over him as he came, so that the whole assembly stared as he walked in; and the elders made way for him, and he sat down in his father's seat.

The first to speak was an old, old man named Aegyptius, bent double with age and knowing a very great deal. He had had four sons. One farmed his fields at home. Two were sitting in that assembly among the suitors of Penelope, eating the estate of Odysseus with the rest. And the fourth had sailed with Odysseus to Troy in the hollow ships, and his name was Antiphus, and his father did not know what had become of him.

I am obliged to tell you what had become of him, because the poem's first audience knew it before Aegyptius opened his mouth, and the scene is built out of that knowledge. Antiphus was eaten. He was eaten alive in a cave by the Cyclops Polyphemus, in the dark, along with five of his shipmates — the very act that set Poseidon against Odysseus and is the reason none of these people have had a king for ten years past the end of the war. His father does not know. His father will never know. He is about to stand up and speak kindly to the son of the man who lost his boy, and there is nothing anyone can do about it, and the poem does not even pause. It simply lets you sit there holding it.

The old man leaned on his staff and said: "Listen to me, men of Ithaca. We have not held a session, we have not sat in assembly, since the day Odysseus went away in the hollow ships. Who has called us now? Which of the young men, or which of the older ones? Has he heard news of the army coming home, and does he mean to tell us plainly what he heard first? Or is it some other public matter he wants to raise? He seems to me a good man, and a lucky one. May Zeus bring to pass whatever good thing he has in mind."

Telemachus was very glad to hear that, and did not sit still long. He stood up in the middle of them all, and a herald put the speaker's staff into his hand, and he turned first to the old man.

"Sir, he is not far off — you are about to see him, and yes, I am the one who called you, and yes, I am in more pain than any man here. No, I have not heard news of the army coming home, and I have no other public business to raise. This is my own trouble. Two calamities have fallen on my house.

"The first is that I have lost my father — who was once *your* king, and a gentle one, like a father to every one of you. The second is worse, and it is the ruin of my whole house and everything I have. Men are courting my mother against her will — and they are the sons of the very men sitting in this assembly. They will not go to her father Icarius's house and ask him for her properly, and let him settle the bride-gifts and give his daughter to whichever man he likes best. Instead they come to my house, day after day, every day, killing my cattle and my sheep and my fat goats, feasting and drinking my bright wine, and there is no end to it. There is no man in the house like Odysseus to drive this ruin off. I cannot do it. I am not that man, not yet — and I know exactly how little I can do, and so do they.

"I tell you I would defend myself if I had the strength. This has gone beyond bearing. My house is being destroyed in a way that is not decent. Be angry, you men. Be ashamed in front of the neighbours who live round about. Be afraid of the gods, in case they turn on you in disgust at what is being done.

[12]**The assembly.** Not a parliament; nobody voted, and nothing was carried by a majority. It was a gathering of the free adult men of a community, called by whoever had the standing to call it, in which a man who held the speaker's staff had the right to be heard without interruption, and in which grievances were aired in public and pressure was applied by shame. Its power was entirely a matter of opinion — which sounds weak until you remember that these were small societies where a man's standing among his neighbours was the only capital he had. That is precisely why Mentor's speech later in the book lands where it does. The assembly's one real weapon was collective disapproval, and Ithaca had spent three years declining to use it.

I beg you, by Zeus and by Themis, who breaks up assemblies and calls them into session — *stop*, my friends, and leave me alone with my bitter grief. Unless — unless my father, good Odysseus, ever did some deliberate harm to the Greeks, and you are all paying me back for it out of spite. I would rather it were you eating my stores and my cattle. If you ate them I might at least be paid for them one day: I could go up and down the town pressing my claim until I got my property back. As it is you fill me with a hurt I have no way to answer."

And in a rage he threw the staff on the ground, with tears breaking out of him — and pity went through the whole assembly.

Everyone sat quite silent. No man had the heart to answer Telemachus harshly.

Except Antinous.

"Telemachus. That is a big speech, and an unbridled one, and you should be ashamed of yourself, trying to fix the blame on us. Your trouble is not the Greek suitors. It is your own mother, who is a past master at this sort of thing.

"Three years it has gone on — no, this is the fourth — and the whole time she has been leading us on. She holds out hope to every man of us, she sends each one private messages and encouragement, and what she is thinking is nothing like what she says.

"And here is the trick she pulled. She set up a great loom in the hall, and started weaving a wide fine web, and she said to us: *Young men, my suitors — Odysseus is dead. Be patient; do not press me to marry, however eager you are, until I finish this cloth, or all my thread will be wasted. It is a shroud for the lord Laertes* (*Odysseus's father*)*, for the day when the pitiless end of death takes him. I will not have the women of this country talking against me — that a man who won so much lay dead with no proper cloth to cover him.*

"That is what she said, and we agreed, because how could we not? So she wove at the great web in the daytime — and at night, by torchlight, she unravelled it. Three years she got away with it. She fooled the Greeks. And in the fourth year, when the seasons had come round again, one of her women told us — one who knew all about it — and we caught her in the act of pulling out the beautiful cloth. So she had to finish it, whether she liked it or not.

"Now here is our answer to you, and you may hear it, and so may all the Greeks. Send your mother away. Tell her to marry whichever man her father chooses and whichever man pleases her. But if she goes on tormenting the sons of the Greeks much longer, on the strength of the gifts Athena has given her — the beautiful handwork, and the excellent mind, and the tricks, which nobody in the old stories ever had the like of — then know this: we will go on eating your living and your goods for exactly as long as she keeps to this plan of hers. She is winning a great name for herself. You are losing a great deal of property. We are not going back to our own lands, or anywhere else, until she marries one of us."

Now.

I ask you to look at what has just been handed to us, because it is the finest single piece of characterisation in the first quarter of this poem, and it comes out sideways, in a hostile speech, from a man who thinks he is complaining.

For three years — three years — a woman with no legal power, no army, no husband and no adult son held off a hundred and eight armed men *with a piece of sewing*. And notice the shape of the trick, because the shape is everything. She did not refuse them; a refusal could be overruled. She agreed. She simply attached a condition to the agreement so pious that no man in Greece could object to it without looking like a monster in front of his neighbours: I am weaving a burial cloth for my husband's elderly

father, so that when he dies he will not lie uncovered and shame us all. Every man there had to nod. Every man there had to wait. And she used the one activity that was so entirely and unremarkably *women's work* that not one of them thought to check on it — for three years — and every night she picked out by torchlight what she had put in by daylight, so that the work went on forever and never grew.

Do you remember what I told you Athena was the goddess of? War, and weaving, and cleverness. Penelope, at her loom, in the dark, is all three at once.

And I want you to hold on to something else. This poem is about a man famous above all other men for being cunning, who lies his way across the entire known world; and we have not properly met him yet; and the first great feat of deception in the whole book belongs to his wife. They have been apart for twenty years, and they are still doing the same thing. That is not a detail. That is the marriage. Keep it in mind for the very end of the story, when the two of them are finally in a room together, and one of them sets a trap and the other one walks straight into it.

One thing more, and it is not a pleasant one. Antinous says a woman betrayed her — one of her own household, one who knew all about it. That is a small line, and it goes past very fast, and it will be paid for horribly. Remember that a maid told.[13]

Telemachus answered him.

"Antinous, I cannot possibly throw the mother who bore me and brought me up out of my house against her will — not while my father is somewhere else in the world, alive or dead. And if I sent her back to Icarius of my own accord, I would have to pay her father back a great deal, and it would go hard with me.[14] I would suffer at his hands, and the gods would give me worse, because my mother would call down the terrible Furies on me as she left the house — and I would be despised by every man alive. That word will never be spoken by me.

"If your own hearts are troubled by this, then get out of my house. Feast somewhere else. Eat your own goods, and take it in turns, going from one man's house to another. But if you think it better and more profitable to ruin one man's living and never pay for it — go on. And I will call on the gods who live forever, and see whether Zeus will let there be a settling. And you will die in this house, and there will be no payment taken for any of you."

That is the second time he has said that last sentence, and it is not a young man's bluster. It is very nearly a legal formula: it means *you will be killed lawfully, as men killed in the wrong, and no blood-price and no vengeance will be owed for you.* He is not threatening them. He is describing, quite accurately, what

[13] **The shroud.** A body was washed, dressed, and wrapped in cloth before burning or burial; to leave a great man uncovered was a public disgrace that fell on his family. Weaving that cloth for one's father-in-law was an act of conspicuous piety, and it also fell squarely within the work a noblewoman was expected to do — indeed the work she was *praised* for doing. This is why the trick is a masterpiece rather than merely a delay: Penelope hid three years of resistance inside the most approved behaviour available to her, and the suitors policed everything about her except the one activity they thought was harmless. — As for the woman who told: the poem will come back to this. When the reckoning arrives, it does not fall only on the suitors. Twelve of the household women are killed for having gone over to them, and the manner of it is the coldest passage in the book. I mention it now, a long way off, because I do not want it to arrive as a surprise, and because I would rather you carried the question with you through everything in between: whether these women were traitors, or captives with no good options, or both. The poem is quite sure. I am not.

[14] **Why sending Penelope home would ruin him.** Marriage in this world involved property moving in both directions — gifts from the suitor's family to the bride's, and a settlement from the bride's father with her. If Telemachus sent his mother back to Icarius on his own initiative, rather than her leaving of her own accord, he would owe her father substantial restitution — and he has no cattle left to pay it with, because the suitors have eaten them. They have engineered a situation where the one thing they demand is the one thing he cannot afford. He is being asked to solve his problem by bankrupting himself.

is going to happen in this hall in about twenty books' time, and he does not know it yet.

And Zeus, who arranges these things, sent two eagles.

They came down off a mountain peak and flew a long while on the wind, wing to wing, sailing side by side; and when they were exactly over the middle of the assembly, over all those upturned faces, they wheeled and beat their wings hard and glared down at every head, and there was death in their eyes. And then they clawed at each other's faces and necks, tearing, and swung away to the right, out over the houses of the town, and were gone.

The men stared after them, appalled, and turned it over in their minds, wondering what was coming.

And an old man named Halitherses stood up — much the best of his generation at reading birds and saying what they meant — and he said:

"Listen to me, men of Ithaca, and let me speak chiefly to the suitors, because this is rolling towards them. Odysseus is not going to be away from his people much longer. I think he is somewhere very close by at this moment, and that he is sowing the seed of death and doom for every man here — and it will not stop with them, either. A great many of the rest of us who live in bright Ithaca will suffer for it too.

"So let us think, well ahead of time, how we may put a stop to this — or rather, let *them* stop it themselves, which would be much the better way, and they had better be quick about it. I am not a beginner at prophecy; I know what I am talking about. Everything I said about that man is coming true, exactly as I said it would on the day the Greeks sailed for Troy and clever Odysseus went with them. I said he would suffer terribly, and lose all his companions, and come home in the twentieth year, unknown to everybody. And here we are."

And Eurymachus said, smoothly:

"Go home, old man. Go home and prophesy to your own children, before something unpleasant happens to them.

"I am a great deal better at reading this than you are. There are any number of birds flying about under the sun, and by no means all of them mean anything. Odysseus is dead, far away, and I only wish you had died with him — then we would not have to sit through all this prophesying of yours, and you would not be stirring up a boy who is already angry, in the hope that he will make you a present out of gratitude.

"Now, here is what I say, and it will happen. If you — an old man who knows better — talk this youngster round into losing his temper, it will be the worse for *him*, first of all, and he will still not be able to do a thing about any of it. And you, sir, we shall fine, and you will pay it, and it will hurt.

"And here is my advice to Telemachus, in front of everyone. Tell your mother to go back to her father's house. They will arrange the wedding and settle the very large bride-gifts that ought to go with a daughter people are fond of. I do not believe the Greeks will leave off this hard courtship until then. We are not afraid of anybody, and certainly not of Telemachus, however many speeches he makes. And we take no notice of prophecy — the sort of thing you dribble out, old man, that comes to nothing and only makes people hate you more."

I want to be careful here, because it would be easy to say that the difference between Halitherses and Eurymachus is that one believes in omens and the other does not, and that the poem is on the side of the believer. That is nearly right but not quite. Everyone in that assembly believed in omens; the question was always *what a given omen meant*, and men argued about that the way men argue about evidence. What condemns Eurymachus is not scepticism. It is that he does not actually offer a reading.

He announces that most birds mean nothing, threatens the old man's children, promises to fine him, and repeats what he wanted anyway. He is not weighing the sign. He is refusing to be interrupted. There is a particular kind of man who calls that clear thinking, and the poem has his number.

Telemachus had stopped arguing.

"Eurymachus — and the rest of you proud gentlemen — I am done pleading, and I will say no more about it. The gods know, and all the Greeks know. Just give me a fast ship and twenty men to work her, and I will go up and down the sea-lanes. I am going to Sparta and to sandy Pylos to ask about my father's homecoming, and how long he has been gone. Some man may tell me. I may hear a rumour out of Zeus, which is how news mostly gets about.

"If I hear my father is alive and on his way home, then for all my weariness I will hold out one more year. And if I hear that he is dead and gone, then I will come back to my own country and heap up a mound for him, and burn the offerings on it, all that is proper and in full measure — and I will give my mother to a husband."

And he sat down. And Mentor stood up.

Mentor was an old friend of Odysseus's — the friend, in fact, to whom Odysseus had handed over the whole household on the day he sailed, with instructions to keep everything in order and obey the old man Laertes. (You will recall from Book One's notes that this is the name Athena is going to borrow, and the name our word *mentor* comes from. That is still true. This is the actual man.)

And he did not attack the suitors. Please notice this, because it is the moral centre of the entire book and it is very easy to skim past.

"Listen to me, men of Ithaca.

"Let no sceptred king from this day on be kind, or gentle, or fair-minded, or have any justice in his heart at all. Let him be harsh, and let him do wicked things — since not one man remembers Odysseus among the people he ruled, and he was as gentle to them as a father.

"I do not particularly grudge the proud suitors doing violent things out of the wickedness of their own minds. They are staking their own heads on it when they eat that man's house down and tell each other he will never come back.

"It is the *rest of you* I am angry with — the way you all sit there, saying nothing. You are many. They are few. You have never once opened your mouths to hold them back."

And a man called Leocritus answered him:

"Mentor, you troublemaker, you lunatic — what are you talking about? Setting them on to stop us? It is a hard thing to fight men over a dinner, even when you outnumber them. Why, if Odysseus of Ithaca himself came home this minute and found us feasting in his hall, and set his heart on driving us out of it — his wife would get no joy of his coming, however much she has wanted it. He would meet a very ugly end, taking on so many single-handed. You are talking nonsense.

"Come on — break it up, all of you, and go back to work. Mentor and Halitherses can see the boy off on his journey; they were friends of his father's, after all. Though I think he will sit at home a good long while yet, getting his news in Ithaca, and never make that trip at all."

And with that he dissolved the assembly, and they went off to their houses, and the suitors went to the house of Odysseus.

Telemachus went away by himself, down to the edge of the sea, and washed his hands in the grey

salt water, and prayed.

"Hear me — you who came to my house yesterday, whoever you are, and told me to take a ship and go over the misty sea to ask about my father's homecoming. The Greeks are blocking every part of it, and the suitors most of all, in their arrogance."

And Athena came and stood beside him in the shape and the voice of Mentor, and said:

"Telemachus. You will not be a coward after this, or a fool, if you have any drop of your father's spirit in you — and he was a man who finished what he said he would do. This journey of yours will not come to nothing.

"But if you were *not* his son, and Penelope's, then I would have no hope of you finishing anything. Few sons turn out to be their fathers' equals. Most are worse. A very few are better. But you are not going to be a coward or a fool, and Odysseus's wits have not entirely failed to reach you, so there is every reason to think you will bring this off.

"Never mind what the suitors are plotting. There is no sense in them, and no justice either, and they have no idea that death is standing next to them and that they are all going to die on one day. As for your journey, it will not be delayed long. I was your father's friend, and I will find you a fast ship and come with you myself. Go home now, and mix with the suitors, and get provisions ready — wine in jars, and barley meal, the strength of men, in stout skins. I will go through the town and raise a crew of volunteers. There are plenty of ships in sea-girt Ithaca, new and old, and I will find the best of them for you, and we will get her fitted out and launched on the open sea."

And Telemachus went home.

He found the suitors in the courtyard, skinning goats and singeing pigs. And Antinous came straight over to him, laughing, and took him by the hand, and said his name, and said:

"Telemachus, you great orator, you unstoppable force — no more hard words and no more hard feelings. Eat and drink with us the way you used to. The Greeks will see to all of this for you: a ship and a picked crew, so that you can get to sacred Pylos quickly and hear about your noble father."

And Telemachus took his hand out of Antinous's hand.

"Antinous, there is no way in the world I can have a quiet dinner with you people, or take my ease, or enjoy myself. Was it not enough that you wore away all my best possessions while I was still a child? Now I am grown, and I have listened to what other men say, and there is a spirit rising in me — and I am going to try to send the black spirits of death down on you. I will go to Pylos, or I will go about it here in this country. I am going, and the journey I am talking about will not be for nothing — as a passenger, since I have no ship and no rowers of my own. I suppose you found that arrangement more convenient."

And he pulled his hand lightly out of Antinous's hand, easily, in front of everybody.

The suitors, meanwhile, were setting out the meal, and jeering at him, and needling him, and one of the insolent young men would say something like this:

"I do believe Telemachus is planning to murder us. He'll bring back allies from sandy Pylos, or from Sparta — he's frightfully keen on it. Or perhaps he'll get as far as Ephyra, that rich country, and bring back poison to drop in the wine-bowl and finish the lot of us."

And another would say:

"Who knows? He may go off in his hollow ship and die a long way from his friends, wandering about like his father did. That would make more work for us — we'd have to divide up all his property,

and give the house to his mother, and to whichever of us marries her."

That is what they said, to a young man's face, in his own house, about his father, and about his own death. And then they went in to dinner.

But Telemachus went down to his father's storeroom.

It was high-roofed and wide, and it held gold and bronze in heaps, and clothing folded in chests, and quantities of fragrant olive oil. And there were great jars standing along the wall in rows against the wall, full of old sweet wine, unmixed, waiting — the god's own drink — kept there in case Odysseus ever came home after all his suffering. The doors were double, close-fitted, double-locked. And the housekeeper was in there day and night, watching over everything with a very shrewd mind indeed: Eurycleia.[15]

He called her into the storeroom and said:

"Nurse, draw off some wine for me into jars — sweet wine, the best there is after the vintage you keep for my poor lord, in case he comes home from somewhere, having got out from under death. Fill twelve, and fit them all with lids. And pour me out barley meal into well-sewn bags — twenty measures of milled barley. And keep this to yourself. Have it all put together, because I shall come for it in the evening, once my mother has gone upstairs and is thinking about her bed. I am going to Sparta and to sandy Pylos, to see if I can hear anything about my dear father coming home."

And the old nurse cried out and burst into tears.

"Dear child — how did *this* get into your head? Where are you going, an only son and a beloved one, over all that country? He is dead, that man, far from home, in some place we do not know. And the moment you turn your back these people will start plotting, and you will die by a trick, and they will divide up everything you own. Stay here and sit on your own property. There is no need for you to suffer and wander about on the barren sea."

"Courage, nurse. There is a god behind this plan. But swear to me that you will say nothing to my dear mother — not until eleven days have gone by, or twelve, or until she misses me herself and hears that I have gone. I do not want her spoiling her lovely skin with crying."

So the old woman swore the great oath of the gods, and swore it properly; and then she drew off the wine into the jars, and poured the barley meal into the well-sewn bags; and Telemachus went back into the hall and mixed with the suitors.

And Athena thought of something else.

She went through the town in the likeness of Telemachus, and stood beside each man she wanted, and told him what to do, and said: be at the fast ship this evening. And she asked Noemon, son of Phronius, for a swift ship, and he was glad to give it.

The sun went down and the streets grew dark. Then she ran the fast ship down into the sea and put in her all the gear that well-benched ships carry, and moored her at the far end of the harbour; and the good crew gathered round her, and the goddess put heart into every one of them.

And Athena thought of one thing more. She went to the house of Odysseus, and there she poured

[15]**The storeroom.** Notice what wealth *is* here: no coins, because coinage had not been invented yet. Wealth was bronze and gold by weight, fine cloth, oil, wine, and above all livestock — which is why "eating the estate" is not a figure of speech but a precise description of what is happening to this family. It also explains why great households ran on gift-exchange rather than purchase, and why hospitality-gifts (see Book One, note 7) were serious economics and not just good manners. And it is why the locked room matters: a house's whole worth stood in jars against a wall, behind a double door, with one trusted old woman holding the key.

sweet sleep over the suitors — sent them wandering as they drank, and knocked the cups out of their hands. They did not sit long. They got up and went off through the town to find their beds, because sleep was falling on their eyelids and they could not keep them open.

Then grey-eyed Athena called Telemachus out of the great hall — in Mentor's shape, with Mentor's voice.

"Telemachus. Your crew are sitting at the oars already, waiting for you to start. Come on. Let us not hold up the journey any longer."

And she led the way, quickly, and he came on behind her, in her footsteps.

They came down to the sea and to the ship, and found the long-haired crew on the shore, and Telemachus said: "Come on, friends — let us fetch the provisions. Everything is stacked and ready in the hall. My mother knows nothing about it, and neither do the servants. Only one woman was told."

And he led the way, and they came behind, and they carried it all down and stowed it in the ship, the way Odysseus's dear son directed.

Then Telemachus went aboard, and Athena went first and sat down in the stern, and Telemachus sat beside her. The crew cast off the stern cables and climbed in and sat down at the oars.

And grey-eyed Athena sent them a following wind — the fresh West Wind, singing over the wine-dark sea.

Telemachus called out to his men and told them to lay hold of the tackle, and they heard him and did it. They raised the pine mast and stepped it in the hollow box and made it fast with forestays, and hauled up the white sail with twisted oxhide ropes; and the wind bellied out the middle of the sail, and the dark wave sang loud along the stem as the ship went, and she ran along on the swell, making her way.

Then they made the running-gear fast in the black swift ship, and set up mixing bowls brimming with wine, and poured out an offering to the gods who live forever and always — most of all, and above all, to the grey-eyed daughter of Zeus.

And all night long, and into the dawn, the ship ran on and cut her way.

NOTES TO BOOK TWO

Book Three: In Which an Old Man Talks a Great Deal, and Some of It Is Useful.

Book 03

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK THREE

In Which an Old Man Talks a Great Deal, and Some of It Is Useful

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The sun came up out of the beautiful water and into the brazen sky, to shine on the gods who never die and on men who do, on the grain-giving fields of earth; and the ship came in to Pylos, the well-built citadel of Neleus.

And there were four and a half thousand men on the beach, killing bulls.

That is not a figure of speech and I have not exaggerated it. They were sitting on the shore in nine great companies, five hundred men to a company, and each company had brought nine bulls, and they were sacrificing them to Poseidon of the dark hair — eighty-one black bulls, and the fires going, and the smell of it out over the water; and Telemachus of Ithaca came sailing in out of the dawn straight into the middle of the largest religious ceremony he had ever seen in his life.

You should understand what was actually happening on that beach, because *sacrifice* is one of those words that has gone strange on us. It sounds like waste — like good meat burned up and thrown away to buy favour from heaven. It was very nearly the opposite.

Here is the arrangement. When an animal was killed, the thigh bones were cut out and wrapped in a double fold of fat, with a few raw scraps laid on top, and burned on the altar with wine poured over them; and the smoke went up, and that was the gods' portion. Everything else — all the meat, every edible ounce of it — was roasted on the spot and eaten by the people standing there. That is what those five hundred men to a company were doing. They were having dinner.

In this world you did not, as a rule, simply slaughter an animal and eat it. Killing was a religious act, and a communal one, and the meal *was* the ceremony. The god got the smoke and the bones. The men got the beef.

And the Greeks knew perfectly well that this was a strange sort of bargain, and they had a story to account for it, in which the trickster Prometheus divided up the first ox and hid the good meat inside the ugly stomach-bag, and dressed the bare bones up in glistening fat, and invited Zeus to choose; and Zeus chose the fat, and got the bones, and has been getting them ever since. Whether he was fooled or was pretending to be fooled is a question the story leaves carefully open — and the answer, I think, is that when you are telling a story about why you get to eat all the steak, it is best to be a little vague about whose idea it was.[16]

[16] **Sacrifice, and the Prometheus bargain.** The story is told properly by Hesiod, a poet roughly contemporary with Homer, in a poem about how the world got organised. Prometheus divides the first ox at a place called Mecone and offers Zeus the choice; Zeus takes the fat-wrapped bones, and is angry, and takes fire away from men in return; and Prometheus steals it back, and is chained to a rock — the whole apparatus. What the tale exists to explain is a piece of ordinary practice: why, at every sacrifice, the god's share is precisely the part you could not have eaten anyway. It is the kind of story a culture tells to make a comfortable arrangement look like ancient law — and the Greeks were not fools about it either; the whole thing is shot through with a sense that Zeus knew exactly what he was choosing and let it stand. The practical point is the one to carry with you: eating meat was a public and religious act. When you read that a household "sacrificed" and then feasted,

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Athena, in the shape and the voice of Mentor, told him to get on with it.

"There is no need to be shy now, not for a moment. You crossed all that water for exactly one reason — to find out about your father — so go straight up to Nestor the horseman and ask him. He will not lie to you. He is far too sensible for that."

And Telemachus said, and I love him for it:

"Mentor — how am I to go up to him? How do I even *greet* him? I have no practice at making elegant speeches, and it is embarrassing for a young man to question an older one."

That is one of the truest lines in the poem. He has spent two books discovering his courage. He has faced down a hall of armed men and thrown the speaker's staff on the ground in front of the whole island. And now he has to walk up to a distinguished stranger and introduce himself, and he would rather do almost anything else. Courage and social nerve are different muscles, and nobody has both at twenty.

"Telemachus," said the goddess, "some of it you will think of yourself, and a god will put the rest into your head. I do not believe you were born and brought up without the gods' goodwill."

And she went off ahead of him, quickly, and he came on behind in the god's own footsteps.

They came up to the crowd of Pylian men sitting in their companies, and there was Nestor with his sons around him, and his people busy roasting meat and running spits through it. And when they saw strangers coming, the whole party got up together and waved them in and sat them down.

The first to reach them was Nestor's son Peisistratus, who took them both by the hand and settled them on soft fleeces on the sand between his father and his brother Thrasymedes; and he gave them helpings of the inner meat and poured wine into a golden cup and put it into Athena's hands first — because she looked the elder of the two, and that is how it was done — and said:

"Say your prayer to lord Poseidon, stranger, since you have come in on his feast. And when you have poured your offering and prayed, hand the cup to your friend so that he can pour as well. He is a young man, about my own age, and I imagine he prays like the rest of us."

I hope somebody is enjoying this as much as I am. A well-brought-up young man has just handed a golden cup to the goddess Athena and invited her to pray to Poseidon — who is the one god in the world who wants Odysseus dead, whose feast this is, and who is at this precise moment at the far ends of the earth so that Athena can get on with the rescue behind his back.

And she takes the cup. And she prays. She prays graciously and at length for glory to Nestor and his sons, and for a good return for the men of Pylos; and last of all, quietly, at the end, that Telemachus might get what he came for and go home.

She was, as I have said, the goddess of doing the sensible thing well.

They ate; and when they had eaten as much as they wanted, old Nestor started the talking, and asked at last who his guests were. Not before. Never before. You feed a man and then you ask his name.[17]

do not picture a bonfire of good food going to waste. Picture a barbecue with a grace before it that took an hour.

[17] **Feed first, ask afterwards.** See Book One, note 7. Nestor observes the law exactly — and even his blunt question about piracy is not the insult it appears to be. Raiding was a recognised occupation with no great shame attached to it, and asking a stranger about it was roughly like asking what line of work he is in. Telemachus takes no offence, and neither should you.

"Now is the proper moment to enquire, now that our guests have had their dinner. Strangers — who are you? Where do you sail from over the sea-roads? Are you here on business? Or are you cruising at random, like pirates, who wander about risking their own lives and making trouble for everybody else's?"

Telemachus took his courage in both hands — Athena had put it there — and answered.

"Nestor, son of Neleus, great glory of the Greeks. You ask where we come from, and I will tell you. We are out of Ithaca, and my errand is my own, not the state's. I am looking for word of my father, if there is any to be had anywhere: Odysseus, that great heart, who they say fought beside you once and sacked the city of Troy.

"Every other man who went to that war, we know about. We know where each of them died; we have their names. But this one Zeus has made unaccountable, and nobody can tell me where he went down — whether on land, beaten under by enemies, or somewhere out at sea in the waves.

"So I have come to your knees, in the hope that you will tell me how he died: whether you saw it yourself, or heard it from some other man wandering. His mother bore him for suffering, if anyone ever was. And do not soften it out of kindness or pity. Tell me plainly what you saw. I beg you — if my father ever promised you anything and made it good, in that country of the Trojans where we Greeks suffered so much, remember it now, and tell me the exact truth."

And Nestor took a breath.

Now: I must prepare you.

Nestor talks. He is the oldest of all the men who went to Troy; he has ruled through three generations of men; he has outlived nearly everyone he ever fought beside; and he cannot answer a direct question without going round by way of the entire war. In the other poem, the *Iliad*, he is famous for it, and the younger heroes can be seen visibly bracing themselves when he stands up. He is the sort of old man who says *that reminds me* and means it, and who will get to your point eventually, having said four useful things and eleven charming ones on the way.

And I want to defend him, because it is easy to find him funny and much better to find him necessary.

There was no writing worth speaking of in this world. No records, no dispatches, no lists of the dead. Everything anybody knew about a ten-year war fought overseas by men out of a hundred scattered kingdoms was stored in the memories of the men who came back, and nowhere else at all. When a man like Nestor died, the things that only he knew went out like a lamp.

That is why this journey is worth four books of a poem. Telemachus is not going to Pylos to interview a witness. He is going to the library. The library is ninety years old, has a shaky sense of what is relevant, and will not stop talking; and it is the only one there is.

So. Nestor told him about the war. About how they suffered there, the unmanageable ones, ranging the misty sea after plunder wherever Achilles led them, and fighting round the great city of Priam (last king of troy). And how the best men died there. *Ajax lies there, and Achilles, and Patroclus, who gave counsel like the gods themselves — and my own son, Antilochus, faultless and strong, a great runner and a fighter. And we suffered a great deal besides. No mortal man could tell the whole of it. If you stayed five years, six years, asking me what the Greeks went through there, you would give up and go home before I had finished.*

"For nine years we worked at them with every trick we could invent, and the god barely let us finish it. And in all that time no man tried to match himself against Odysseus in cunning, because your father won every time — if you really are his son. I am astonished, looking at you. Even the way you talk is

his; you would not think a young man could sound so like him. In all those years he and I never once spoke on opposite sides, in assembly or in council. We were of one mind, and we gave the Greeks the best advice we had.

"But when we had sacked the steep city of Troy, and gone down to the ships, and a god scattered the Greeks — then Zeus planned a wretched homecoming for them, because not all of them had been just or sensible; and a great many came to grief through the deadly anger of the grey-eyed daughter (Athena) of the mighty Father.[18]

"She set the two sons of Atreus quarrelling (Agamemnon and Menelaus). They called the whole army to assembly — carelessly, out of order, at sunset, and the Greeks came in heavy with wine — and each of them made his case. Menelaus (king of Sparta) said everyone should sail home at once. Agamemnon (king of Mycenae) would not have it: he wanted to hold the army there and burn sacrifices until Athena's terrible anger softened. The fool. He did not know that she would not be turned; the mind of the everlasting gods does not change so quickly. So the two of them stood there trading hard words, and the army sprang up with a noise like the sea, and the whole thing split in two.

"We slept that night thinking bitter things about one another. In the morning half of us hauled our ships down and put our goods aboard and sailed — and Odysseus with us, all his men, and then he turned back and sided with Agamemnon after all. As for me, I ran, with everything I had, because I could see a god was cooking up trouble.

"And we came home, some of us. Diomedes got his men back. Menelaus caught us up at Lesbos. And I came home without ever learning which of the others made it and which did not; but I can tell you what I have heard since, sitting in my own house, as is proper.

"They say the Myrmidons came home safe under Achilles's son. Philoctetes got home. Idomeneus brought back to Crete every man of his who came out of the fighting alive; the sea took none of them.

"And Agamemnon — well. Even living as far off as you do, you will have heard how he came home, and how Aegisthus killed him, and paid for it miserably. It is a fine thing when a murdered man leaves a son (Orestes) behind him. That one took his revenge on the murderer, on the crafty Aegisthus, who had killed his famous father.

"And you, my friend — and you are tall, and you look well — be brave, so that men born long after you speak your name kindly."

"Nestor, son of Neleus, great glory of the Greeks," said Telemachus, "yes — he took his revenge, and the Greeks will carry his name a long way, and singers will make a song of it for men to come. I only wish the gods would put strength like that round *me*, so that I could pay the suitors back for the outrages they commit, and the arrogant things they invent against me. The gods have spun out no such happiness for my father or for me. There is nothing to do now but endure it."

"Well, my friend, since you bring it up," said Nestor, "they do say a great crowd of men are courting your mother in your own house against your will, and doing you harm. Tell me — are you letting it happen? Have the people of your country turned against you, following some voice from a god? Who

[18] **Why Athena turned on her own side.** She had been the Greeks' most committed backer for the whole war — and then, on the night Troy fell, a Greek called Ajax (a different and lesser Ajax, son of Oileus) dragged the Trojan princess Cassandra away from Athena's own altar, where she had taken sanctuary, and raped her; and the army did not punish him for it. That is what Nestor means when he says the goddess's anger could not be bought off with sacrifices. It is worth pausing on, because the poem's logic is quite clear and quite bleak: the Greeks won, and then behaved so foully in victory that the gods scattered them on the way home and drowned a great many. Everything that happens to Odysseus happens downstream of that night. The *Odyssey* is not a poem about a triumph. It is a poem about the bill arriving.

knows: he may yet come home and pay them out for all that violence, alone, or with the whole force of the Greeks behind him.

"If grey-eyed Athena would only choose to look after you the way she looked after glorious Odysseus in the country of the Trojans, where we Greeks suffered — I never in my life saw the gods show their love so openly as Pallas Athena stood by that man — if she would care for you like that, and take it to heart, some of those gentlemen might stop thinking about marriage altogether."

"Sir," said Telemachus, "I do not think that will ever happen. It is too much. It frightens me even to talk about it. I could not hope for such a thing, not even if the gods wanted it."

And grey-eyed Athena said: "Telemachus. What a thing to let past your teeth. A god can bring a man home safe from a long way off, easily, whenever he chooses."

But Telemachus wanted the other story, and asked for it: how Agamemnon died, and where Menelaus had been all that while, and how Aegisthus ever dared it, killing a man so much better than himself.

And Nestor told him.

This is the third time in three books that we have been given this story (of Orestes and Aegisthus), and each time it has come a little closer and grown a little more detail — first as an example Zeus tossed out at dinner, then as a threat and an encouragement from a disguised goddess, and now at last in full, as history, from a man who lived through the same years. That is not the poem repeating itself. That is the poem's method. It circles a thing, and each time round you are standing nearer, and by the end you can see the whole of it.

And there is a new detail in this telling, and it is aimed straight at the heart of our story, so please do not read past it.

"We were away at Troy," said Nestor, "doing hard work. And he (Aegisthus) was at his ease in the meadow-corner of Argos, working on Agamemnon's wife with soft words.

"And at first she would have nothing to do with it. She refused the shameful thing. She had a good mind in her.

"And there was a man with her — a singer, whom Agamemnon had left behind when he sailed, with strict instructions to keep watch over his wife. But when the gods' will closed round her, Aegisthus took that singer off to a lonely island and marooned him there, to be a prize and a meal for the birds. And after that she was willing, and he was willing, and he took her to his own house.

"And he burned a great many thigh bones on the gods' altars and hung up a great many offerings, gold and woven cloth, because he had brought off a thing he had never in his life expected to bring off."

Sit with that a moment.

The first defence of a good marriage in this poem is a *bard*. Not a guard, not a wall, not a garrison — a singer, left behind on purpose, whose whole commission was to stay in the house and keep the queen in mind of who she was. And the seduction only became possible once he had been taken out and left on a rock to be eaten by birds.

Now recall a hall on Ithaca, three years running, with a singer in it who cannot leave and does not want to be there, performing for men who did not invite him and will not let him go. His name is Phemius. I told you to remember him in Book One, and I am telling you again. The house of Odysseus still has its bard. The house of Agamemnon did not. The poem thinks this matters, and it thinks the

difference between those two women may rest partly on it — which is either a very beautiful idea about what stories do for people, or a professional bard's advertisement for his own trade, and I am not at all sure it is not both.

"Meanwhile," Nestor went on, "Menelaus and I sailed out of Troy together, as friends. But when we came to holy Sunium, the headland of Athens, the god struck down Menelaus's helmsman with his gentle arrows — Phrontis, the best man in the world at holding a ship on course in a gale — with the steering oar still in his hands. So Menelaus had to put in and bury his companion and do it properly, though he was in a great hurry.

"And when he put out again, storms took him and carried him the whole way south to Egypt. And there he stayed, gathering a great deal of gold, wandering with his ships among people whose language he could not speak.

"And all that time Aegisthus was king in Mycenae, planning ugly things, and the people were ground down under him. Seven years he ruled there. In the eighth, Orestes (Agamemnon's son, Menelaus's nephew) came back from Athens and killed him; and he gave the Greeks a funeral feast over his hateful mother and over that coward Aegisthus. And on that very day Menelaus came home, with as much treasure as his ships would carry.

"So do not you wander far from home, my friend, and do not leave your property behind you with violent men in your house, or they will divide up everything you own and eat it, and your journey will have been for nothing. But go to Menelaus (in Sparta) — I tell you to go. He came home last of anybody, from a place no one comes back from, over a sea so wide that not even birds cross it in a year. Go by ship if you like, or go by land, and take a chariot and my sons, and they will bring you to bright Lacedaemon (another name for Sparta), to fair-haired Menelaus. Ask him for the truth yourself. He will not lie to you. He is far too sensible for that."[19]

The sun went down and darkness came on, and Athena said that they should cut the tongues of the sacrifice and mix the wine and pour out the offerings, to Poseidon and to the other gods, and then think about bed; for the light had gone, and it is not decent to sit long at a god's feast.

Then Telemachus said that he would go and sleep down on the ship, and old Nestor very nearly fell out of his chair.

"Zeus and the other immortals forbid that you should go from *my* house to a fast ship to sleep — as though I were a beggar, a man with no clothes in his house, no blankets, no covers, nothing soft to lie on for himself or his guests. I have plenty of good blankets. The dear son of that man Odysseus is not going to lie down on a ship's deck while I am alive, or while there are children left in this house to look after any guest who comes to it."

"You are quite right, sir," said Athena (still pretending to be Mentor), "and Telemachus should do as you say; it is very much better. Let him go up with you now and sleep in your house. As for me, I shall go down to the black ship and hearten our crew and give them their orders — I am the eldest of

[19] **Orestes and his mother.** Notice how little Nestor says. Aegisthus is killed at length and with satisfaction; Clytemnestra (Agamemnon's former wife and Orestes' mother) gets a few words in passing, at a funeral feast, and nobody describes the act or asks what it cost. This is one of the places where our poem stands at a real distance from the version most people half-remember — because three hundred years later the Athenian tragedians took this same story and made the matricide the entire point of it. Aeschylus wrote three plays running on it, in which Orestes is hounded mad by the Furies for killing his mother and has to be tried and acquitted by a court at Athens before the world can go on. None of that is here. In this poem Orestes is simply a good son who did the right thing, held up to a young man as a model, and nobody flinches. It is a useful reminder that "the Greeks" were not one people with one opinion, and that the distance between Homer and Aeschylus is greater than the distance between Shakespeare and us.

them; the rest are younger men, all of an age with Telemachus, who came along out of friendship. I shall sleep beside the black hull tonight; and in the morning I mean to go on to the Cauconians, where a debt is owed me, and not a small one, nor a new one."

And having said it, she went away in the form of a sea-eagle.

Everyone who saw it was astonished; and the old man took Telemachus by the hand and said his name and said:

"My friend, I do not think you will turn out a coward or a weakling, if the gods walk beside you at your age. That was no other of the ones who live on Olympus. That was the daughter of Zeus — the Glorious, the Third Daughter — who used to honour your father above all the Greeks.

"Be gracious to us, lady, and give a good name to me, and to my sons, and to my honoured wife; and I will sacrifice you a yearling heifer, broad in the brow, unbroken, that no man has ever led under the yoke. I will offer her to you with gold poured round her horns."

So he prayed, and she heard him.

And they went up to the fine house and slept: Telemachus on a corded bedstead in the echoing colonnade, and Peisistratus beside him — the one son still unmarried and living at home.

When Dawn came up, rosy-fingered, the old horseman (Nestor) was out of bed first, and went and sat down on the polished white stone benches outside his high doors, where his own father used to sit; and his sons came out of their rooms one after another, six of them, and gathered round him. And Nestor said:

"Quickly now, my children. I want to satisfy Athena, who came to me openly, before my own eyes, at the god's rich feast. One of you go out to the field for a heifer and have the herdsman drive her in. One go down to the black ship and bring up Telemachus's crew, and leave two behind. One send for Laerces the goldsmith, to pour the gold round the heifer's horns. The rest of you stay here, and tell the women in the house to make everything ready."

And they all set to. The heifer came in from the field; the crew came up from the ship; the smith came with his tools in his hands — his anvil and his hammer and the well-made tongs he worked the gold with. And Athena came too, to accept her offering.

And old Nestor gave out the gold, and the smith worked it and poured it round the heifer's horns, so that the goddess would be pleased when she saw it. And Nestor's sons led the animal in by the horns, and water was brought in a flowered basin, and barley grains in a basket; and Thrasymedes stood close with a sharp axe in his hand to strike her down, and Perseus held the bowl for the blood.

And old Nestor began the rite with the water and the scattered barley, and prayed hard to Athena as he began, and cut hairs from the animal's head and threw them into the fire.

And when they had prayed and thrown the barley, Thrasymedes, standing close, struck. The axe cut through the tendons of the neck and unstrung the heifer's strength; and the women cried out — the daughters, and the sons' wives, and Nestor's honoured wife Eurydice, eldest of the daughters of Clymenus. And the men lifted the animal's head from the trampled ground and held it up, and Peisistratus cut the throat.

And when the dark blood had run out and the life had gone from the bones, they broke the body down quickly, and cut out the thigh pieces in the proper way, and covered them with a double fold of fat, and laid raw meat on top. And the old man burned them on split kindling and poured bright wine over them, and the young men stood beside him with five-pronged forks in their hands. And when the thigh pieces were burned up and they had tasted the inner meat, they cut the rest into small

pieces and ran the spits through and roasted it, holding the sharp spits in their hands.

And meanwhile Telemachus was being bathed by Polycaste, Nestor's youngest daughter, who washed him and rubbed him with olive oil and put a fine cloak and a tunic on him; and he came out of the bath looking like one of the immortals, and went and sat down beside Nestor, the shepherd of the people.[20]

Then they roasted the outer meat and drew it off the spits and sat down and ate, and good men stood by to see that the gold cups stayed full.

And when they had eaten, Nestor said: "Boys — bring the horses out and get them under the yoke, so that Telemachus can be on his way."

They did it quickly; and a housekeeper packed in bread and wine and the sort of food kings eat. And Telemachus got up into the fine chariot, and Peisistratus got up beside him and took the reins in his hands and laid the whip on; and the horses went out over the plain, and Pylos and its steep citadel went away behind them.

All that day the yoke rocked on their necks.

And the sun went down, and all the ways grew dark; and they came to Pherae, to the house of Diocles, and slept there, and he treated them as a host should. And when Dawn came up again, rosy-fingered, they yoked the horses and got up into the chariot and drove out through the echoing gateway; and the whip cracked, and the horses ran on willingly, and the wheat-bearing plain went by underneath them.

And so they finished the journey — that is how well those fast horses ran.

And the sun went down, and all the ways grew dark.

NOTES TO BOOK THREE

Book Four: In Which There Is a Wedding Going On, Nobody Can Stop Crying, and a Man Wrestles the Sea.

[20]**The bath.** A young unmarried daughter of the house personally bathing a male guest and rubbing him with oil is not a scandal, not a seduction, and not even especially remarkable. It is high-status hospitality performed by a high-status member of the family, and handing the job to a servant would have been something of a slight. (The oil is because they had no soap.) There is also a later Greek tradition that Telemachus eventually married Polycaste, of which our poem knows nothing whatever — but somebody clearly read this scene and thought, well, *obviously*.

Book 04

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK FOUR

In Which There Is a Wedding Going On, Nobody Can Stop Crying, and a Man Wrestles the Sea

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They (Telemachus and crew) came down into Sparta, into the hollow of the hills, and drove up to the house of Menelaus; and they found him giving a wedding feast for a great crowd of his people, for a son and a daughter both at once.

The daughter he was sending away to the son of Achilles, who had been promised her years before at Troy, in the middle of the fighting, in the way such promises get made — and the gods were bringing it off at last, and she was going out that day with horses and chariots to the famous city where her husband was king. And for his son he was bringing home a girl from Sparta: a good match. The son's name was Megapenthes, and he was strong and well thought of, and he was the child of a slave woman, because after Hermione (his daughter) the gods gave Helen no more children.[21]

So they were feasting in the great high-roofed house, the neighbours and the family of Menelaus, enjoying themselves; and a singer was performing among them with his lyre, and two acrobats were going round and round in the middle of the floor, tumbling in time with the music.

And two young men and a chariot stopped in the gateway, and nobody noticed at all.

I want to point out, before anything else happens, that this enormous wedding is never mentioned again. Two marriages, a house full of guests, a girl leaving home for good — and the poem sets it all up like scenery and then walks past it and does not look back. It is there for one reason: so that you can see, straight away, the difference between this house and the house our story belongs to. Both are full of people eating. In one of them, it is a wedding.

Eteoneus, one of Menelaus's men, saw them and went in to ask what was to be done.

"Menelaus — there are two strangers at the gate, and they look like men of the line of great Zeus himself. Tell me: shall we unyoke their horses, or send them on to somebody else who will make them welcome?"

And Menelaus was disgusted with him.

"You were not a fool before this, Eteoneus. You are talking like a child. You and I ate other people's bread all the way home — the whole way, on the kindness of strangers, and only got here at all because

[21] **Megapenthes.** The poem gives you this in a single clause and moves on: Menelaus's only son is the child of an enslaved woman in his household, because Helen bore him no children after Hermione. It is stated the way one might state a man's age. There is no scandal in it, no concealment, and no suggestion that the boy's position is awkward — he is well thought of and is being married off at a great public feast on the same day as his half-sister. This is simply how great households worked, and how a man in this world made sure of an heir: the wife's children inherited first, the others were acknowledged and provided for, and the mother's own view of the arrangement is not recorded anywhere and was not thought worth recording. I mention it because it goes past in half a line, and because a reader who does not stop will not notice that they have just been told something quite large about the women of these houses. (See Book One, note 10, on Eurycleia.)

they took us in. Unyoke their horses. Bring the men in to eat."

So the man went, at a run, calling others to come with him; and they led the sweating horses out from under the yoke and tied them at the mangers and threw down spelt (wheat) and white barley mixed for them, and tipped the chariot up against the shining wall of the gateway. And they brought the two young men into the house.

And they stared.

There was a brightness like the sun and the moon through that high-roofed house — the gleam of bronze and gold and amber and silver and ivory going away in every direction — and Telemachus said quietly to Nestor's son, with his head close so nobody would hear:

"Look at it. This is what the court of Zeus on Olympus must be like inside. The quantity of it. I am staggered."

And Menelaus heard him anyway, and answered:

"Dear children, no mortal man competes with Zeus. His house and his belongings last forever. Men — well. There may be a man who could match me, and there may not.

"I brought all this home in my ships after a great deal of suffering. Eight years I was wandering: Cyprus, Phoenicia, Egypt; I got as far as the Ethiopians, and the Sidonians (modern Lebanon), and the Libyans, where the lambs are born with horns on their heads and the ewes lamb three times in the year, and no man there, master or shepherd, ever goes short of cheese or meat or sweet milk, because they milk all year round.

"And while I was going up and down out there collecting all this, another man killed my brother, behind my back, and never gave him a moment's warning — by the cunning of his own cursed wife. So I take no pleasure in being lord of all this.

"I would rather live here with a third of it, and have the men back alive who died out there on the wide plain of Troy, far from the grazing lands of Argos (Greece).

"I cry for all of them. Often enough I sit here in the house and let my heart out in grief, and then I stop, because a man gets his fill of cold grief soon enough. But there is one man I miss more than all of them together, and when I think of him I cannot eat and I cannot sleep — because no Greek took on the work Odysseus took on, and he got nothing for it, and I got a lifetime of sorrow that will not go away. He has been gone so long that we do not even know whether he is alive. Old Laertes must be mourning him, and Penelope, and Telemachus, who was a baby in the house when he sailed."

And that was too much for Telemachus, hearing his father named. He pulled his purple cloak up over his eyes with both hands and cried.

Menelaus saw it, and knew, and hesitated — should he leave the boy to bring the subject up himself, or should he ask him first and go through it all with him? — and while he was still turning it over, Helen came down out of her high scented room.

She (Helen) came down like Artemis (god of the hunt) with her golden arrows, and her women came with her: Adraste, who set the chair for her; Alcippe, who brought the soft wool rug; and Phylo with the silver work-basket that Alcandra had given her in Egyptian Thebes, out of a house with more treasure in it than anywhere on earth. Menelaus had had two silver bathtubs from that house, and two tripods and ten talents of gold; and separately, to Helen, the woman of the house had given a golden spindle and this basket, silver, on wheels, with a gold rim round the top.

Her woman set it down beside her, full of yarn already spun, with the spindle laid across it wound

with dark violet wool.

And she sat down in her chair with a footstool under her feet, and looked at the strangers, and said at once:

"Menelaus — do we know who these men say they are? I have never in my life — no, never — seen a likeness like it, in a man or in a woman. I am astonished, looking at him. That is Odysseus's son. That has to be Telemachus, the child that man left behind in his house, still a baby, when you Greeks came to Troy on my account. Shameless creature that I was."

"Wife, I think so too, now you say it," said Menelaus. "Those are his feet and his hands, and the way his eyes move, and the head, and the hair on it. And just now, when I was speaking about Odysseus — about everything he took on, for me — the boy put his cloak over his face and wept."

And then Nestor's son Peisistratus said: "Menelaus, you are right. He is that man's son. But he is a modest young man and it seems wrong to him to come here and start talking loudly the first time he is in your presence, when we both listen to your voice as if it were a god's. My father Nestor sent me to bring him, because Telemachus wanted to see you, and hoped you might advise him, or do something for him. A son has a very hard time in a house when his father is gone and there is nobody to take his side — which is where he stands now: his father gone, and nobody in the country to keep the trouble off him."

"Well," said Menelaus, "if the son of a man I loved that much is in my house — a man who took on so much for me — I had meant to give him a welcome above all the other Greeks, if only Zeus had let the two of us come home over the sea. I would have moved him out of Ithaca altogether, with his goods and his child and all his people. I would have cleared a city for him here in Argos (Greece) and built him a house, and we would have been together, and nothing would have come between us or spoiled it, until the black cloud of death came over us.

"And the god must have begrudged it. He alone got no homecoming."

And with that he set them all off, and every person in the room cried.

Helen cried, and Telemachus cried, and Menelaus cried; and Nestor's son cried too — but he was not crying for Odysseus. He was crying for his own brother, Antilochus, who had been killed at Troy by the splendid son of the shining Dawn (Memnon, ally of Troy), and whom he had never seen, and whom Nestor still spoke of. And he (Peisistratus)said, when he could:

"Menelaus — my father (Nestor) always said, whenever we talked of you at home, that there was nobody with sense like yours. So bear with me now. I do not enjoy crying after dinner, and there will be a new Dawn tomorrow morning. Not that I grudge anyone their tears for a man who is dead and has met his fate; it is the only honour we can pay the poor dead — cut off our hair, and let the tears come down our faces. I lost a brother out there myself. He was not the worst of the Greeks, either. You will have known him; I never did."

So Helen put a drug in the wine.

She had thought of something, and she did it while they were talking, quietly, as a hostess sees to the cups: she dropped into the bowl they were drinking from a drug that kills pain and anger and takes away the memory of everything bad. A man who swallowed that, once it was mixed in the bowl, would not let a tear down his cheek for a whole day — not if his mother died, not if his father died, not if his brother or his own son were cut down with a bronze blade in front of him and he watched it happen with his own eyes.

The daughter of Zeus had subtle drugs, and good ones, that Polydamna had given her in Egypt,

the wife of Thon; because there the fertile earth grows the greatest number of drugs, many of them healing when they are mixed, and many of them deadly; and every man there is a doctor, and knows more about it than anyone else alive.[22]

And when she had put it in, and told them to pour, she said: "Now let us sit and enjoy ourselves and tell stories. I will tell you one that fits.

"I could not begin to tell you everything Odysseus did and endured. But here is one thing that man brought off, in the country of the Trojans, where you Greeks suffered.

"He took a beating — his own, deliberately: he laid degrading marks all over his own body, and threw a bad cloth round his shoulders like a servant, and went into the enemy's wide streets looking like a beggar, which was nothing at all like what he looked like beside the Greek ships. He went into Troy like that, disguised, and every one of them was taken in.

"I was the only one who knew him. And I questioned him, and he slipped away from my questions, cleverly. But when I had bathed him and rubbed him with oil and put clothes on him, and sworn a great oath not to give him away to the Trojans until he was back at the ships — then he told me the whole plan of the Greeks.

"And he killed a great many Trojans with the long bronze on his way out, and went back with a great deal of information.

"The other Trojan women wailed and wailed. My own heart was glad — because by then it had already turned round, and I wanted to go home, and I was sick over the madness Aphrodite gave me when she led me away out of my own dear country, and made me leave my daughter, and my bedroom, and a husband who was not lacking in anything, not in mind and not in looks."

And Menelaus said: "Yes. All of that is true, my wife, exactly as you tell it.

"I have known a great many men's minds and a great many men's ways, and I have been about the world; but I never yet saw with my own eyes another heart like patient Odysseus's.

"Here is another thing that strong man did and endured — inside the wooden horse, where all the best of us were sitting, carrying murder to the Trojans.

"And you came out to us, wife. Some god must have put you up to it, a god who wanted to hand the Trojans the victory; and Deiphobus (prince of Troy) walked out there beside you.

"Three times you went round the hollow trap, feeling it, stroking it with your hands. And you called out to the Greek captains, every one of us, by name — and you did each man's wife's voice.

"Diomedes and I were sitting in the middle of it with Odysseus, and we heard you calling. The two of us started up, mad to get out, or else to answer you from inside, right then. And Odysseus held us. He held us down and stopped us, both of us, with the whole thing hanging on it.

"And every other Greek in there stayed quiet, except Anticlus, who wanted to answer you. And Odysseus put his hands over the man's mouth and clamped them there, and held on — and saved every Greek in that horse — and did not let go until Athena had led you away."

I am going to stop here, because two people have just told two stories that cannot both be true, in

[22]**The drug.** The Greek names it *nepenthes* — literally "no-grief" — and describes its effects with unusual precision: not sleep, not intoxication, but a chemical suspension of mourning lasting a day. Egypt was where such things came from, in the Greek imagination and probably in fact; Egyptian medicine was the most advanced in the eastern Mediterranean and its practitioners were famous abroad, which is why the poem says every man there is a doctor. What the drug actually was, if it was anything, has been guessed at for two thousand years — opium is the usual suspect. What matters more is that our poem, which is not otherwise interested in pharmacology, pauses to give it four lines, and gives it to *Helen*, and has her administer it to a room full of men without asking them.

the same room, ten minutes apart, over a bowl of drugged wine, and everyone in the house is going to go to bed perfectly happy.

Helen's story: Odysseus came into Troy in disguise, and I alone recognised him, and I bathed him and hid him and swore an oath and let him go, and I had already turned back to the Greek side by then, and my heart was glad when Trojans died.

Menelaus's story: the Greeks were sitting inside the horse in the dark, minutes from being discovered and burned alive, and Helen came out and walked round it three times, and called every man in it by name in the voice of his own wife, and had Deiphobus of Troy on her arm while she did it.

He does not say she was trying to kill them. He says a god must have been prompting her, a god who wanted Troy to win. That is a husband being extremely careful at his own dinner table.

And the second story is worse than it looks, because of the detail everybody skims: *she did the voices*. She stood in the dark outside a wooden box containing the fifty men who had wrecked her life and the life of everyone she had lived among for ten years, and she used their wives against them. She knew what to say. Diomedes and Menelaus nearly answered her; a man named Anticlus opened his mouth and would have, and Odysseus had to hold his jaw shut in the dark. Some tellings say he suffocated him. Ours does not say, and I think ours would rather you did not ask.

So which Helen is at the table? The one who was secretly loyal all along and helped the Greeks in disguise, or the one who nearly killed them all with a party trick?

I do not think the poem knows. I think the poem is showing us something it understands better than it can explain, which is a woman who has come back — who is *home*, in a house made of Egyptian silver, with a husband who worships her and a daughter going out to be married — and who has to live in the same room as everything she did and everything that was done to her; and who has, by the way, the only pharmaceutical in the ancient world that makes it possible to sit in that room.

Look again at the order of events. She has the drug in the bowl *before* the storytelling starts. She is not soothing anyone's grief; she is anaesthetising a room so that the past can be discussed in it safely. And then the very first story told under the influence of that drug is a story in which Helen behaved well.

She is the hostess. She is the historian. She is the pharmacist. It is her house, and it is her version.

I will only add this, and then we can go to bed. She says she was sick over "the madness Aphrodite gave me." A very great deal rides on whether you believe that — whether Helen went to Troy or was taken there, whether a goddess made her do it or she wanted to go, and whether "a goddess made me" was ever anything more than a way of putting it. The Greeks argued about it for a thousand years and never once agreed.[23]

They went to bed. Helen told the women to put out bedding in the porch, good purple rugs and blankets over them and thick cloaks on top; and the two young men slept there. And Menelaus slept in an inner room of the high house, and Helen of the long robes lay beside him.

[23] **Did Helen go, or was she taken?** The single most argued-over question in Greek literature, and there was never an answer. In the *Iliad* she loathes herself and speaks of Aphrodite compelling her, and it is left unresolved. The lyric poet Stesichorus is said to have been struck blind for slandering her, and to have recovered his sight only after writing a second poem taking it all back — in which she never went to Troy at all, and a phantom went in her place while the real Helen sat out the war in Egypt. The historian Herodotus, who visited Egypt, reported that the Egyptian priests told him much the same thing, and believed them, on the grounds that the Trojans would obviously have handed her over rather than lose their city. Euripides wrote a whole play on that version. — Notice what all of these have in common: they are attempts to make the story bearable. Ours does not take that way out. It puts her in a room with her husband, with the drug, and with two incompatible accounts of her own conduct, and lets her be a person rather than a verdict.

And when Dawn came up, rosy-fingered, Menelaus got out of bed and dressed and slung his sharp sword over his shoulder and tied good sandals on his feet and came out looking like a god, and sat down beside Telemachus and said:

"Well, Telemachus. What has brought you here to bright Sparta over the broad back of the sea? Public business, or your own? Tell me the truth."

And Telemachus told him. The suitors. A hundred and eight of them in the house, killing the flocks and the shambling cattle, courting his mother, insolent past bearing. And: *I have come to your knees, to ask you to tell me how my father died. Say you saw it, or say you heard it from somebody wandering. Do not soften it out of pity. Tell me exactly what you saw.*

Menelaus was disgusted, and let it out.

"Cowards. Weaklings. They want to lie down in the bed of a man with a heart like that — and they are like a deer that puts her two newborn fawns to sleep in a lion's den, and goes off to graze the mountain slopes and the grassy valleys, and then the lion comes home to his own bed and kills them both, and it is ugly. That is what Odysseus is going to be to those men.

"Father Zeus, and Athena, and Apollo — if he is still the man he was that day on Lesbos, when he stood up to wrestle Philomeleides (king of Lesbos, who wrestled visitors) and threw him flat, and every Greek there cheered — if Odysseus walks in among those suitors as he was that day, they will find their marriages short and their weddings bitter.

"Now: what you have asked me, I will not talk round, and I will not tell you anything untrue. Everything the Old Man of the Sea told me — the unerring one — I will pass on to you, and I will not hide a word of it."

And here is the story he told, and it is the best story in the first quarter of this poem, and it is the story that finally answers the question we have been asking since page one.

"The gods held me in Egypt. I wanted to come home, and they kept me there, because I had not made them the offerings I owed them. The gods always want us to remember what we owe.

"There is an island in the surf off Egypt — they call it Pharos — a day's clear sail out from the coast with a good following wind, with a harbour where ships can put in and take on dark (drinking) water. And there the gods kept me twenty days, and no wind ever got up. Every scrap of food was gone, and the spirit was going out of my men.

"And a goddess took pity on me. Eidothea, the daughter of Proteus, the mighty Old Man of the Sea. I had got at her heart somehow. She came on me wandering by myself, away from my men, who were forever going round the island fishing with bent hooks, because their bellies were driving them.

"And she stood beside me and said: *Are you a complete fool, stranger? Or a weakling? Or is this what you like — suffering? You have been shut up on this island a long time and you cannot find a way out, and your men are running out of heart.*

"And I said: *Whichever goddess you are, I am not stuck here because I want to be. I must have done something wrong to the gods who hold the wide sky. So tell me — you gods know everything — which of them has me tied up here? And how do I get home over the fish-filled sea?*

"And she said: *I will tell you exactly. There is a certain unerring Old Man of the Sea who comes here — deathless Proteus of Egypt, who knows the depths of the whole sea, and who serves Poseidon. They say he is my father. If you could somehow lie in wait for him and take hold of him, he would tell you the way, and the distances, and how to get home over the fish-filled sea. And he would tell you, if you wanted, what has been done in your own house, good and bad, while you have been away on this long miserable journey.*

"And I asked her how to trap the old god, because he would see me coming and slip out.

"And she said: *At the exact hour the sun stands over the middle of the sky, the unerring Old Man comes up out of the water under a dark ripple raised by the west wind, and lies down to sleep in a hollow cave; and the seals come up out of the grey water round him and sleep in a herd, and they smell bitterly of the deep sea. I will bring you there at first light and lay you out in a row. Choose three of your men, the best you have on your ships.*

"*And here is what the old man will do. He will count the seals over, going along the fives, and look them over; and when he has counted them all he will lie down in the middle of them, like a shepherd among sheep. The moment you see him asleep — that is the moment for strength and for holding on. Hold him there, however hard he fights to get away. And he will try. He will turn himself into every creature that moves on the earth, and into water, and into a blazing fire. Hold him. Grip harder. And when at last he asks you questions in his own shape — the shape he was in when you saw him lie down to sleep — then let go, and let the old man be, and ask him which god is angry with you, and how you get home over the fish-filled sea.*

"And with that she went down into the swell of the sea.

"She came back at dawn with four sealskins, freshly flayed, and she had scooped out four lying-places in the sand; and she laid us down in a row and put a skin over each of us.

"That was the most disgusting ambush ever laid. The stink of those sea-fed seals was murderous — nobody lies down happily beside a monster of the deep — but she saved us. She had thought of it, and it was the best of remedies: she brought ambrosia, and put it under each man's nose, sweet-smelling, and it killed the stench of the animals.[24]

"We waited all morning with our hearts steady, and the seals came up out of the sea in a crowd and lay down in rows along the edge of the water. And at midday the old man came up out of the sea and found his fat seals, and went along them and counted them; and he counted us in among the animals first of all, and never suspected a thing. And then he lay down himself.

"And we came at him shouting, and threw our arms round him. And the old man did not forget his cunning.

"He turned into a lion with a great mane. And then a snake, and a leopard, and a huge boar. And then he was running water. And then he was a tree in leaf with the branches going up.

"And we held on. We held on, steady, and we did not let go.

"And when at last the old man got tired of it, he asked me a question. *Which of the gods, son of Atreus (Menaleus), put you up to this? Ambushing me and taking hold of me against my will? What do you want?*

"And I said: *You know. Why put me off with questions? I have been stuck on this island a long time and I cannot find the way out and there is no heart left in me. Tell me — you gods know everything — which of the immortals has me tied up here, and how do I get home over the fish-filled sea?*

"And he said: *You should have made the proper offerings to Zeus and the rest of them before you sailed, if you wanted to get home quickly over the wine-dark water. It is not your fate to see your own people and your well-built house and your own country until you have gone back to the water of Egypt — the rain-fed river — and made holy offerings to the everlasting gods who hold the wide sky. And then they will give you the road you want.*

"It broke my heart to hear it. He was telling me to go back over the misty sea to Egypt, a long hard

[24] **Ambrosia.** The food of the gods; the word means, roughly, "the not-mortal stuff." It turns up here as a perfume smeared under the nose, and elsewhere as something eaten, and elsewhere again as a preservative rubbed on a dead body to keep it from decaying. It is best understood not as a substance with fixed properties but as *the divine version of a thing* — divine food, divine ointment, divine scent — and its one constant property is that it stops decay and death from doing their work. Which is exactly what it is doing on that beach: four men are lying under rotting sealskins, and the ambrosia keeps the smell of mortality off them.

way. But I answered him: *Old man, I will do it. All of it, exactly as you say. But tell me this as well, and tell me straight. Did all the Greeks come home safe in their ships — all the ones Nestor and I left behind when we sailed from Troy? Or did some of them die on their ships, or in their friends' arms, with the war finished?*

"And he said: *Son of Atreus, why ask me that? You would be better off not knowing, and not looking into my mind, and I do not think you will get through the answer without crying.*"

He was right, of course. And I will let Menelaus report the three answers as he got them, because they are the whole business of the poem so far, arriving at last, on a beach, out of the mouth of a shape-changing sea god who did not want to give them.

The first was Ajax — not the great Ajax, but the other one, the son of Oileus, and you have met him already in this book, though not by name. His ships were wrecked by Poseidon on the great rocks; and Poseidon saved him, actually saved him, and set him down alive out of the water. And he would have got away with it, hated by Athena as he was — except that he opened his mouth. He said, out loud, that he had escaped the great gulf of the sea *in spite of the gods*. And Poseidon heard him say it, and took his trident in both hands and struck the rock, and split it, and half of it stayed standing and half went down into the sea with the man on it; and it carried him under, and he drank the salt water and died.

(*That is the man who dragged Cassandra out of Athena's sanctuary on the night Troy fell. See Book Three, note 3. Everything in this poem eventually gets billed to somebody.*)

The second was Agamemnon. Proteus told it, and this is the fourth telling in four books, and it is at last the thing itself: he got past the great headland in his ships, hard as it was, and thought he was home. And then a bad wind took him and carried him to the edge of his own country — the very edge, the place where Aegisthus was living — and the wind turned kind again, and he came in and set foot on his own land, and touched it, and kissed it, and the warm tears came down his face because he was seeing his own country. And a watchman saw him. Aegisthus had put that watchman on the headland a year before and promised him two talents of gold to keep looking. And the man ran with the news. And Aegisthus set the trap at once: twenty men hidden in the hall, a feast laid on the other side of the room, horses and chariots sent down to bring the king up in honour. And he brought Agamemnon in, thinking of murder, and fed him, and killed him at dinner, the way a man kills an ox at the feeding trough. And not one of the king's companions was left alive, and not one of Aegisthus's either. They died on top of each other in that hall.

And the third, when Menelaus asked whether any of them was still alive:

"Son of Laertes. Odysseus. I saw him on an island, crying hard, in the house of the nymph Calypso, who is keeping him there against his will. And he cannot get back to his own country, because he has no ships with oars and no companions to carry him over the wide back of the sea."

That is it. That is the answer. Four books, three kingdoms, an assembly, a night crossing, two long dinners, an old man's memory and a sea god's arm — and what comes back is: *he is alive, he is on an island, he is crying, and he has no way off.*

And the boy who came all this way for it will not hear it for another sixteen books, because Menelaus is telling this to Telemachus, and Telemachus is not going to reach his father until much later and by a very different road. Everyone in the poem now knows where Odysseus is except the people who need to.

Proteus told Menelaus one thing more, about himself, and I include it because it is strange and

lovely and slightly outrageous.

It is not your fate to die in Argos (Greece). The immortals are going to send you to the Elysian plain, at the ends of the earth, where fair-haired Rhadamanthus is, and where living is easiest for men: no snow, no hard winter, no rain at all, and the ocean always sending up a clear west wind to blow cool on the people there. Because you have Helen, and because you are the son-in-law of Zeus.

Read that again. Menelaus is not going to die and go down into the dark like everybody else in this poem. He is going to a garden at the end of the world with perfect weather.

Not for courage, not for justice, ot for anything he did, but because of who he married.[25]

Then Menelaus wanted to give presents, and Telemachus wanted to go home.

"Do not keep me long here," he said. "I could happily sit in this house a whole year and never miss my parents, I am enjoying your stories so much. But my crew are already restless in sacred Pylos, and you are keeping me. Whatever gift you give me, let it be a keepsake. And no horses for Ithaca, please — leave them here, where you can enjoy them. You have wide plains here, with clover and reeds and wheat and rye and white barley. There are no wide runs on Ithaca and no meadows. It is goat country, and I like it better than horse country. None of the islands are good for driving or have good grass, and Ithaca least of all."

And Menelaus laughed, and stroked his hand, and said his name, and said: "Good blood, my boy. That is well said. Very well — I will change the gift; that is easy enough. Of everything stored in my house I will give you the finest and most valuable thing there is. I will give you a mixing bowl, worked all over. It is solid silver with a gold rim, and Hephaestus made it, and the king of the Sidonians gave it to me when his house sheltered me on the way home. That is what I want you to have."[26]

And now we must go back to Ithaca, where it is the same morning, and where something has gone wrong.

The suitors were in front of the great hall, amusing themselves throwing the discus and the spear on the levelled ground where they always did it, in their usual style. Antinous and Eurymachus were sitting there, the leaders, easily the best of them.

And Noemon came up — the man who had given the ship — and asked Antinous a question.

"Antinous, do we know at all when Telemachus is coming back from sandy Pylos? He has my ship, and I need it. I want to cross to Elis, where I keep twelve mares with hard-working mules under them,

[25] **Elysium.** Almost everyone else in this poem is going to the same place when they die, and it is not a nice one — a grey, sunless, memoryless holding-pen for the dead, which we will visit in person, at length, in Book Eleven, and where the greatest hero of the age will tell us to our faces what he thinks of it. Elysium is the exception, and at this early stage of Greek belief it is not a reward for virtue at all. There is no heaven for good men here, no judgement, no scales. Elysium is for a tiny number of people connected to the gods by blood or by marriage, and Menelaus qualifies on a technicality: he is married to a daughter of Zeus. That is the whole reason, and Proteus states it as a reason. Later Greeks, who found this unsatisfactory — as you may — quietly rebuilt the afterlife into something with a moral filter on the door. The version in front of us has none. It is worth knowing that when you read what happens to the people in this poem who behave well and die anyway.

[26] **"No horses for Ithaca."** A small speech, easy to skip, doing three things at once. It is good manners: refusing an unusable gift gracefully, and Menelaus laughs with pleasure because the boy has handled it beautifully — *good blood* — which is a compliment about breeding standing in for a compliment about upbringing, and Telemachus has had no father to give him one. It is geography: Ithaca is a poor, steep, goat-grazed rock, and the kingdom everyone is murdering each other over is worth strikingly little. And it is character: given the chance to pretend to be richer than he is, in the most gilded house he has ever stood in, the boy says plainly that his country has no meadows and that he prefers it. — The bowl, meanwhile, is a *gift*, in the technical sense (Book One, note 7): an object whose value is largely the relationship it records. Keep an eye on it. Objects like that do not stay where they are put in this poem.

unbroken. I want to drive one off and break it in."

They were astonished. They had had no idea he had gone anywhere. They thought he was out on the farm with the sheep, or with the swineherd.

"Tell me the truth," said Antinous. "When did he go? And who went with him? Picked men of Ithaca, or his own hired men and servants? Could he even manage that? And tell me this too, so I am clear: did he take the black ship from you by force, against your will — or did you hand it over because he asked you nicely?"

"I gave it to him," said Noemon. "What else would anybody do, when a man like that, with all that trouble on him, asks a favour? It would be hard to refuse.

"And the young men who went with him are the best in the country after us. And I saw Mentor go aboard as their captain — or a god who looked exactly like him.

"But that is the strange thing. I saw Mentor here myself, yesterday morning, at dawn. And he had already sailed for Pylos."

And he went off to his father's house.

And the two of them were left with their hearts full of it. They made the rest of the suitors sit down and stop their games, and Antinous stood up and spoke, black with anger, his eyes like fire burning.

"This is a disgrace. Telemachus has brought off a journey — arrogantly, in style, and we all said it would never happen. A boy. Against every one of us. He has launched a ship and picked the best men in the country and gone.

"He is going to be a menace. May Zeus break his strength before he grows into it.

"Give me a fast ship and twenty men, and I will lie in wait for him in the strait between Ithaca and rocky Samos, and he will find out what sailing after his father costs."

They all approved, and told him to do it, and got up and went into the house.

Now Penelope was not long finding out what they were plotting, because Medon the herald heard it. He was outside the courtyard while they were weaving it together inside, and he went straight through the house to tell her; and she met him on the threshold.

"Herald — what have those men sent you for now?"

"They mean to kill your son," he said. "They are going to ambush him on his way home and kill him with the sharp bronze. He has gone after news of his father, to sacred Pylos and to bright Sparta."

And her knees gave under her, and her heart, and she could not speak for a long time; her eyes filled with tears and her voice would not come. And at last she said:

"Herald — why has my son gone? He had no need to go on board any ship. Ships are the horses of the sea for men; they carry them over the water. Was it so that even his *name* would not be left among men?"

"I do not know," said Medon, "whether a god started him or whether it was his own heart. He has gone to Pylos to ask about his father — how he died, or whether he is coming home."

And he went back through the house.

And a grief that eats the heart came down over her, and she could not bring herself to sit on any of the chairs in the room, though there were plenty; she sat down on the threshold of her own richly-made bedroom, crying pitifully, and all the women of the house cried round her, young and old.

"Listen to me," she said, sobbing. "Of all the women brought up in my generation the Olympian

has given me the most grief. First I lost a husband with a lion's heart, a man better in every way than any of the Greeks, whose name goes right across the country. And now the storm winds have snatched my beloved son out of the house with no word said, and I never even heard he was going.

"You are hard women. Not one of you thought to get me out of my bed — and you knew perfectly well, every one of you, the night he went down to the hollow black ship. If I had known he meant to make that journey he would have stayed, however much he wanted to go, or he would have left me dead in this house.

"Somebody call old Dolius to me — the servant my father gave me when I came here, who keeps my orchard — and let him go to Laertes (father of Odysseus) and sit down beside him and tell him all of it. Laertes may think of something. He may go out and appeal to the people, and tell them what these men are doing — these men who want to wipe out his line, and the line of godlike Odysseus."

And Eurycleia the nurse said: "Dear child, kill me with the pitiless bronze or let me live in the house, whichever you like, but I will not hide it from you.

"I knew. I gave him all of it, the bread and the sweet wine. And he made me swear a great oath not to tell you until twelve days had gone, or until you missed him yourself and heard that he had gone, so that you would not spoil your lovely skin with crying.

"Now wash, and put clean clothes on, and go upstairs with your women, and pray to Athena, the daughter of Zeus who holds the storm cloud. She can save him even out of death. And do not trouble the old man; he is troubled enough. I do not believe the family of Arceisius is altogether hated by the gods. Someone will be left to hold this high-roofed house and the rich fields all round it."

So she quieted her, and stopped her crying; and Penelope washed and put clean clothes on and went up with her women and put the barley grains in a basket, and prayed to Athena.

"Hear me, Unwearied One, daughter of Zeus. If ever Odysseus burned you the rich thigh pieces of an ox or a sheep in his house, remember it now for me, and save my son, and keep these suitors and their arrogance away from him."

And she cried out in prayer, and the goddess heard her.

And the suitors made a noise in the shadowy hall, and one of them said: "The queen must be arranging her wedding. She has no idea that her son has been marked for killing." That is what they said. They had no idea what had been arranged for *them*.

Then Antinous told them to stop talking. And they took a fast ship down to the sea and stepped the mast and fitted the oars in their leather straps and hauled up the white sail, and their servants brought their armour; and they moored her well out in the water and got out and had their dinner and waited for the evening.

And Penelope lay upstairs without eating, without touching food or drink, turning over and over the one question — whether her decent son would get away, or be beaten down by the arrogant men. And she turned it as a lion turns, cornered in a crowd, frightened, when the men close their treacherous ring round him. And in the middle of it, sweet sleep came over her and she lay back and slept, and all her joints let go.

And Athena thought of something else.

She made a phantom. She made it in the shape of a woman — of Iphthime, another of the daughters of great Icarius (Penelope's father), whom Eumelus had married and who lived far away in Pherae — and she sent it into the house of Odysseus to stop Penelope's crying and her sobbing and her grief.

It came into the bedroom past the strap of the door-bolt, and stood over her head, and said:

"Penelope. Are you asleep, with your heart in pain? The gods who live easy will not let you cry or be distressed. Your son is coming home. He has done nothing to offend them."

And Penelope answered her, sleeping very sweetly at the gate of dreams:

"Sister — why have you come here? You never used to; you live so far away. And you tell me to stop grieving, and stop all the pain going round and round in my mind, when I have already lost a husband with a lion's heart, better than any of the Greeks, whose name goes right across the country — and now my boy has gone away in a hollow ship, and he is only a child, and he knows nothing about hardship or about talking to men. I cry for him even more than for the other one. I shake for him, in case something happens to him out there in the country he has gone to, or on the sea. He has enemies, and they are plotting against him, and they want to kill him before he can get home."

"Take heart," said the dim phantom, "and do not be too frightened. He has a companion going with him that other men would pray to have standing beside them, because she has the power: Pallas Athena. She pities you in your grief. It is she who sent me here to tell you this."

And Penelope said: "If you are a god, and you have heard a god's voice — then tell me about that other unhappy one as well. Is he alive somewhere? Is he still looking at the light of the sun? Or is he dead already and in the house of the dead?"

"I will not tell you about him," said the dim phantom. "Whether he is alive or dead. It is a bad thing to talk on the wind."

And it slipped out past the door-bolt into a breath of wind.

And Penelope woke, and her heart was warm in her, because a clear dream had come to her out of the dark of the night.

And the suitors went aboard and sailed the watery ways, planning murder in their hearts.

There is a rocky island in the middle of the sea, halfway between Ithaca and rugged Samos — not a large one — called Asteris, with a double harbour in it where ships can lie hidden.

There the Greeks lay in wait for him.

NOTES TO BOOK FOUR

Book Five: In Which We Finally Meet the Man Himself, and He Is Crying on a Beach.

Book 05

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK FIVE

In Which We Finally Meet the Man Himself, and He Is Crying on a Beach

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Dawn got up out of bed, from beside her husband Tithonus, to carry the light to the immortals and to men.[27]

And the gods sat down to a meeting, and Zeus who thunders on high sat among them, the strongest of them all. And Athena started in again about everything Odysseus had suffered; because it was on her mind that he was still in the nymph's house.

"Father Zeus, and the rest of you gods who live forever.

"Let no sceptred king from this day on be kind, or gentle, or fair-minded, or have any justice in his heart at all. Let him be harsh, and let him do wicked things — since not one man remembers Odysseus among the people he ruled, and he was as gentle to them as a father.

"He is lying on an island in dreadful pain, in the house of the nymph Calypso, who keeps him there by force, and he cannot get back to his own country. He has no ships with oars and no companions to carry him over the wide back of the sea.

"And now they mean to kill his beloved son on his way home. He has gone after news of his father, to sacred Pylos and to bright Sparta."

Those first four sentences are not new. Mentor said them, word for word, in the assembly on Ithaca in Book Two, standing up in front of a crowd of men who would not meet his eye. Athena has taken an old man's speech and carried it up a mountain and said it again to the king of the gods.

I do not think that is an accident, and I do not think it is the poem running short of material. It is the poem telling you that the complaint is the same complaint at both ends of the world. Down in the dust of a village square, an old man says: *this is what comes of being a decent ruler — nothing.* And up on Olympus, in front of the being who is supposed to be in charge of how the world is arranged, his own daughter says exactly the same thing, in exactly the same words, with the same edge on it.

Zeus was not pleased.

"My child. What a thing to let past your teeth. Did you not plan the whole of this yourself? Was it not your own idea that Odysseus should come home and pay those men out? As for Telemachus — you are perfectly capable of managing him; use your skill and bring him back to his own country unhurt, and let the suitors sail home again with nothing done."

Then he turned to his son Hermes and said:

[27] **Tithonus.** Dawn's husband, and a joke the poem does not stop to make, though it puts him in the first line of a book about a man refusing to be made immortal. Dawn fell in love with a mortal prince and asked Zeus to make him deathless, and Zeus granted exactly what she asked for — and she had forgotten to ask for youth. So Tithonus did not die. He got older, and older, and older, past strength, past sight, past speech, until in the end there was nothing left of him but a voice, and she shut him in a room, and he is in there still. The Greeks had a number of stories about people acquiring immortality and every single one of them is a horror story. It is worth carrying that into the cave with you when Calypso makes her offer.

"Hermes — you are our messenger for these things. Go and tell the nymph with the beautiful hair (Calypso) that this is settled and final: the enduring man goes home. And he goes with no escort — no gods, no mortal men. He goes on a raft, lashed together, and he will suffer, and on the twentieth day he will come to Scheria, to the country of the Phaeacians, who are near cousins to the gods. And they will honour him in their hearts like a god, and put him on a ship and send him to his own land, and give him bronze and gold and clothing, more than he would ever have carried out of Troy if he had come home unhurt with his fair share of the plunder. That is how it is laid down that he sees his own people again, and his high-roofed house, and his own country."

And Hermes went, and did not argue.

He bound the beautiful sandals under his feet, the immortal golden ones that carry him over the water and over the endless land like a breath of wind; and he took up the wand he uses to close men's eyes when he wants them closed, and to open them again out of sleep. And with that in his hand he flew.

He came down past Pieria and dropped out of the sky onto the sea, and went skimming over the waves like a shearwater — the bird that hunts down the terrible troughs of the barren salt water and soaks its close wings in the spray. He went along like that over the crowding waves.

And when he reached the island, which was very far away, he stepped up out of the violet-coloured sea onto dry land and walked until he came to the great cave where the nymph with the beautiful hair was living. And he found her at home.

There was a big fire burning on the hearth, and the smell of split cedar and juniper going up all over the island, and she was inside singing in a lovely voice, going up and down at her loom, weaving with a golden shuttle.

And round the cave the trees had grown up in a wood: alder, and black poplar, and sweet-smelling cypress. Long-winged birds roosted in them — owls and falcons and the long-tongued sea-crows, whose business is on the water. And a garden vine had been trained round the hollow of the cave itself, heavy and flourishing, with the grapes on it.

And four springs, close together, ran clear water — four of them, turned to run in four directions. And on both sides there were soft meadows of violet and wild parsley.

Even a god, coming there, would have stopped and looked at it and been glad.

And Hermes stood there and looked at it, and admired it, and then he went inside.

Now: I have described that at the length the poem describes it, which is a good deal of length for a poem in a hurry, and I want to be sure you have taken in what it is.

It is the most beautiful place in the entire book. There is nowhere else in twenty-four books — not Menelaus's house full of amber and ivory, not the orchards we are coming to, not Ithaca itself — that gets four springs and violets and a singing voice and a fire of cedarwood and a considered opinion that a god would stop to admire it.

And it is a prison. There is a man on the far side of it, on the rocks, who has been looking at the sea for seven years and would like to die.

That is a hard trick to bring off and the poem does it without saying a word about it. It simply builds the loveliest place it can build, and then walks you round the headland.

They knew each other on sight, gods always do. She sat him down in a shining chair and asked him

why he had come, and — because she was a proper host, and this is a poem about hospitality — she fed him first: she set out ambrosia at his side and mixed the red nectar; and only when the messenger had eaten and satisfied himself did she ask her question.

"Hermes of the golden wand. Why have you come here? You are honoured and welcome, but you do not visit. Tell me what is in your mind. I want to do it, if I can do it, and if it is a thing that can be done. But first come and let me put something in front of you."

"You are a goddess asking a god," said Hermes. "I will tell you straight. Zeus told me to come. I did not want to. Who would want to cross that much salt water — you cannot even measure it — with no city of mortals anywhere on the way, nobody sacrificing to the gods, no choice cuts of meat? But there is no getting round the will of Zeus and no getting past it.

"He says you have a man here — the unluckiest of all the men who fought round the city of Priam (Troy) for nine years, and sacked it in the tenth, and started home, and offended Athena on the way out, so that she raised a bad wind and heavy seas against them. All the rest of his crew died there. The wind and the water carried this one here.

"And now Zeus tells you to send him off. Immediately. It is not his fate to die here, far from his own people. It is laid down that he sees them again, and his high-roofed house, and his own country."

And Calypso shuddered when she heard it, and answered him with wings on the words:

"You are cruel, you gods, and jealous past all others. You cannot bear it when a goddess sleeps with a man — when she takes one openly and makes him her husband.

"When Dawn of the rosy fingers took Orion, you gods who live easy could not leave it alone until pure Artemis of the golden throne went to Ortygia and killed him with her gentle arrows.

"And when Demeter of the beautiful hair gave way to her feeling and lay with Iasion in the ploughed field — three times turned — Zeus found out about it soon enough, and threw the white lightning at him and killed him.

"And now you gods begrudge me a mortal man staying beside me. A man I saved. He was alone, riding the keel of his ship, when Zeus split his fast vessel with the white lightning and smashed it in the middle of the wine-dark sea. All the rest of his crew died there; the wind and the water carried this one here. And I loved him and looked after him, and I told him I would make him immortal and ageless, forever.

"But since there is no getting round the will of Zeus and no getting past it, let him go — if that is what Zeus wants and orders — out onto the barren sea. I am not going to send him anywhere myself. I have no ships with oars and no companions to carry him over the wide back of the sea. But I will advise him honestly, and hide nothing, so that he gets home to his own country in one piece."[28]

I have to give her the argument, because she has one.

She is quite right about the double standard, and the two examples she reaches for are the right examples. Gods take mortal women constantly, in this mythology, by every means including deception and force, and the world goes on. Goddesses who take mortal men find that their men have accidents.

[28] **Calypso, and what a nymph is.** Her name is built on the Greek verb *kalyptō*, to cover, to conceal, to hide away — the same root as the veil Ino gives him later in this book. She is, by name, the Concealer, and what she conceals is a man: for seven years nobody in the world, god or mortal, knew where Odysseus was. — As for what she is: a nymph is a minor female divinity attached to a place, a spring, a tree, a stretch of coast. Deathless, but not an Olympian; powerful in her own patch and nowhere else. Note what she cannot do. She cannot defy Zeus. She cannot build a ship. She cannot leave. She has spent seven years on an island in the middle of the sea with one man and no way of going anywhere either, and there is a reading of this book — not the only one, but a real one — in which two prisoners are talking to each other on that beach and only one of them knows it.

She is a minor immortal complaining to the messenger of the ruling one that the rules run one way, and she is not wrong.

She is also his jailer, and she is telling the story of it in a particular way. *I saved him. I loved him. I looked after him. I offered to make him a god.* Every word of that is true. And she has left out the seven years and the word *no*.

Both of those things are the case at once. If you want the poem to make one of them cancel the other, it will not do it for you.

Then she went to find him, because Zeus's message had gone into her.

And she found him sitting on the shore. His eyes were never dry. The sweetness of his life was running out of him while he grieved for his home, because the nymph did not please him any more. At night, it is true, he slept beside her in the hollow cave — unwilling beside the willing one. But by day he sat on the rocks and the sand, tearing himself with tears and grief and pain, and looked out over the barren sea, and wept.

And she came and stood near him and said:

"Poor man. Do not sit here grieving any longer. Do not waste your life away. I am going to send you off, and gladly.

"Come — cut long timbers with the bronze and build yourself a broad raft, and fix decking across it, high up, so that it can carry you over the misty sea. And I will put bread aboard, and water, and red wine, plenty of it, to keep the hunger off you; and I will put clothes on you; and I will send a wind behind you, so that you get home to your own country in one piece — if that is what the gods want, the ones who hold the wide sky, who are stronger than I am at planning and at bringing things off."

And the man who had endured everything shivered, and said:

"You have something else in mind, goddess, and it is not sending me home. You are telling me to cross the great gulf of the sea on a *raft* — a thing that is hard and frightening, that fast ships do not always manage even with a good wind out of Zeus.

"I am not getting on any raft unless you can bring yourself to swear me the great oath that you are not planning some new trouble for me."

And Calypso smiled at that, and stroked his hand with hers, and said his name, and said:

"You are a rogue, and there is nothing simple about you, and it says something about you that you should think of a thing like that to say.

"Very well. Let the Earth know this, and the wide Sky above, and the water of the Styx running down — which is the greatest and most terrible oath there is for the blessed gods — that I am not planning any new trouble for you.

"I am thinking, and I will advise you, exactly as I would plan for myself if I were in your position. I have a decent mind. The heart in me is not made of iron; there is pity in it."[29]

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[29]**The oath by the Styx.** The Styx is a river of the underworld, and swearing by its water is the one oath even the gods cannot wriggle out of. Hesiod (playwright like Homer), who is precise about the penalties, says a god who swears falsely by it lies breathless and speechless for a year, cut off from nectar and ambrosia, and is then barred from the councils and the feasts of the other gods for nine more. — What matters here is that Odysseus demands it. A goddess who has just been ordered by the king of the gods to release him tells him he is free to go, and his response is to require a legally binding oath, and hers is to laugh and call him a rogue and give him one. That is the relationship in miniature. It is also, exactly, why he is going to survive the next nineteen books: he does not believe good news.

And she turned and led the way, quickly, and he came on behind in the goddess's footsteps; and they came to the hollow cave, the god and the man, and he sat down in the chair Hermes had got up from, and she put every kind of food in front of him, the things mortal men eat and drink.

And she sat down facing him, and her women put ambrosia and nectar in front of *her*; and the two of them put out their hands to the good things laid ready.

And when they had eaten and drunk, Calypso began.

"Son of Laertes. Odysseus. Resourceful man.

"Is that really what you want, then? To go home now, to your own country? Straight away?

"Well. Goodbye, in spite of everything.

"But if you knew, in your own mind, how much suffering it is laid down for you to go through before you get to your own country, you would stay here with me, and keep this house, and you would be immortal. However much you want to see your wife — and I know you long for her, every day, all the time.

"And I do not think I come off worse than she does, in the body or the figure. It would hardly be decent for a mortal woman to compete with an immortal in looks."

And Odysseus, who had a great deal of sense, answered her.

"Lady, goddess — do not be angry with me over this.

"I know it perfectly well. All of it. I know that sensible Penelope is less than you to look at, when you set the two side by side. She is mortal, and you will never die and never grow old.

"And even so, what I want — what I am hungry for, every day — is to go home and see the day of my homecoming.

"And if one of the gods smashes me out there on the wine-dark sea, I will endure it. I have a heart in me that has taken a great deal of punishment already. I have suffered plenty and worked hard, on the waves and in the war. Let this be added to it."

Let's stop here for a moment.

This is the middle of the poem's argument and everything else is standing round it.

A goddess has offered a man immortality and eternal youth on the most beautiful island in the world, and she has offered it in good faith, and she is not lying about any part of it — not about her looks, not about the suffering coming, not about the fact that his wife is a mortal woman who will age and sicken and die, and that he will too, and much sooner.

And he says no. He said no for seven years, and now he says it out loud, with reasons.

But look at the *reasons*, because this is where people go wrong with this scene. He does not say that Penelope is more beautiful. He does not say that human love is deeper, or that mortal life is precious *because* it is short, or any of the fine things later writers have had him say. He agrees with Calypso. He says: yes, you are better looking, and yes, you are deathless, and I know what I am giving up.

He wants to go home anyway.

That is the whole of it. Not a philosophy — an appetite. He is hungry for a particular stony island, and a particular middle-aged woman, and his own smoke going up from his own roof, and he would rather have those and die than have paradise and not.

And notice the last thing he says, because it is the sentence this man is made of, and you should learn to hear it under everything else he says for the next nineteen books. He does not say he hopes to

survive. He says: *if I am smashed, I will endure it. I have taken a lot. Let this be added to it.*

That is not courage in the way a young man understands courage. It is the thing that is left when courage has been used up and the man is still standing there. It is why the poem, which has a hundred words for cleverness, keeps calling him *the man who endured*.

The sun went down and darkness came on, and the two of them went into the innermost part of the hollow cave and took their pleasure of love, staying beside each other.

I will not smooth that line out and I will not pretend it is simple. Four paragraphs ago the poem told you that he lay beside her unwilling, beside a willing goddess, because there was nowhere else on the island to lie down. Now, on the last night, with the oath sworn and the leaving agreed and everything he was frightened of taken off the table, the poem says they took their pleasure of it. Both sentences are in the book. I do not think the poem is confused. I think it is describing seven years of something that had a great deal of coercion in it and was not made of nothing else, which is an uncomfortable and adult thing for a poem to notice, and it notices it without comment and moves on to the carpentry.

Because in the morning there is carpentry, and this is the first thing in the whole book that we see Odysseus actually *do*.

Four books we have been hearing about him. He is the cleverest man alive; he thought of the horse; he crawled into Troy in rags; he held a man's mouth shut in the dark. All hearsay, all in the past tense, all told by other people at dinner. And here he is at last, in the present tense, doing something — and what he does is *build a boat*, correctly, from felling to launching, in four days, and the poem tells you exactly how.

He put on the clothes she gave him. She gave him a great axe, bronze, sharpened on both edges, sitting well in the hands, with a good olive-wood handle fitted to it; and then a smoothing adze. And she led him to the far end of the island where the tall timber was — alder and poplar and fir going up to the sky, long seasoned and dry, that would float light for him. And when she had shown him where it grew she went back to her house.

And he started cutting. It went quickly. He brought down twenty trees and trimmed them with the bronze, and planed them expertly, and trued them to a chalked line. Then she brought him augers, and he bored every timber and fitted them to each other and hammered them home with pegs and joints.

He made the floor of it as broad as a man who knows the trade lays out the bottom of a wide merchant ship. He set up the decking, fitting it to close-set ribs, and finished it off with long gunwales down the sides. He made a mast, and a yard to fit it. And he made a steering oar to hold her on course. And he fenced the whole thing about with willow withies to keep the water off, and put in a good deal of loose ballast. And Calypso brought him cloth to make the sail with, and he made that expertly too. And he lashed on the braces and the halyards and the sheets. And then he levered her down on rollers into the bright sea.

Four days, and it was finished; and on the fifth she let him go.

Now — you may skip a passage like that. Most readers do; it reads like an instruction manual with the poetry switched off. I would like you not to skip it, for two reasons.

The first is that the audience did not skip it. These were island people. A very large number of the men listening had built or repaired a boat, and every one of them could hear the difference between a poet who knew what an adze was and a poet who did not. That passage is the poem showing its

papers.

The second is more important. This man is about to spend nineteen books being famous for lying. He will invent five false lives, at least, and tell them beautifully to people who deserve better. It matters enormously that the first thing we ever watch him do with his own hands is make something true — measure it, line it, peg it, and make it hold.

Keep that in mind. He is a carpenter. It comes up again, a very long way from here, in a room he built himself, and it settles everything.

She bathed him and dressed him in sweet-smelling clothes, and put aboard a skin of dark wine, and a bigger one of water, and a leather bag of provisions with plenty of good things in it; and she sent him a following wind, warm and gentle. And he spread his sail to it, delighted, and sat down and steered with the oar, expertly, and sleep never fell on his eyelids.

He watched the Pleiades (star constellation), and Boötes going down late, and the Bear — which men also call the Wain — that turns round in one place and keeps a lookout on Orion, and is the only one that never bathes in the Ocean.

Calypso had told him to keep that one on his left hand as he crossed. And he did.[30]

Seventeen days he sailed, and on the eighteenth the shadowy mountains of the Phaeacians' country came up, the nearest part of it to him, and it lay there on the misty sea like a shield.

And Poseidon came back from the Ethiopians.

He was a long way off, in the mountains of the Solymi, and he saw him — saw him out there on the sea, sailing — and the anger went all through him, and he shook his head and said to his own heart:

"Well. So the gods have changed their minds about Odysseus while I was away with the Ethiopians. He is nearly at the country of the Phaeacians, where it is laid down he escapes the great net of misery that has hold of him.

"But I think I can still drive him a good long way into trouble."

I want to be sure the timing has registered, because the poem has arranged it with real cruelty. Poseidon went off to the ends of the earth in the first hundred lines of Book One, and the entire rescue was scheduled into his absence. Twenty days were needed. He has come home on the eighteenth.

He gathered the clouds together and took his trident in his hands and stirred up the sea, and he called up every storm of every wind at once, and covered the land and the water together with cloud, and night came down out of the sky. The East Wind and the South Wind fell on each other, and the hard-blowing West, and the North that is born in the bright air and rolls a great wave in front of it.

And Odysseus's knees went, and his heart, and he said to himself:

"This is bad. What finally becomes of me?

"I am afraid the goddess told me nothing but the truth when she said I would have my fill of suffering at sea before I got home. All of it is coming true. Look at the sky. Zeus is roping the clouds round the whole of it; the sea is churning; every wind there is has jumped on me at once. Now I am certain

[30] **Steering by the Bear.** Greek sailing was mostly coastal and mostly in daylight and mostly in summer, hopping from headland to headland; there was no compass, no chart, and no instrument of any kind. What there was, was the sky. The constellation the poem calls the Bear or the Wain — our Plough, or Big Dipper — is circumpolar in these latitudes, which is what the poem means by saying it is the only one that never bathes in the Ocean: it wheels round the pole all night and never sets. So it is always in the north. And if you keep the north on your left hand, you are sailing east. That is the whole of Calypso's sailing direction, and it is a real one; a man could cross with it. Notice also that Odysseus does not sleep for seventeen days and nights. He is single-handing a small boat across open water with no crew to take a watch, and the poem knows precisely what that costs.

to be destroyed.

"Three times, four times over, luckier were the Greeks who died back there on the wide plain of Troy, doing a favour to the sons of Atreus (Agememnon and Menaleus). I wish I had died there. I wish it had been me, on the day the Trojans in their crowds were throwing their bronze-headed spears at me over the body of Achilles. Then I would have had my rites, and the Greeks would have carried my name. As it is, it is laid down that I am taken by a miserable death."

And as he said it a great wave came down on him from above, terribly, driving, and spun the raft round; and he was thrown clear of the timbers, and the steering oar went out of his hands. The mast broke in the middle under the awful blast of the mixed winds, and the sail and the yard went far out into the water. And the wave held him under a long time. He could not get up quickly out from under the rush of it, because the clothes Calypso had given him weighed him down.

At last he came up, and spat the bitter brine out of his mouth, and it was running down off his head in streams. And even then, wrecked as he was, he did not forget his raft. He went after it through the waves and got hold of it and pulled himself into the middle of it and sat there, dodging the end of his life; and the big waves took it and carried it up and down the current — the way the North Wind in autumn drives thistles across a plain, and they stick together as they go.

But Ino saw him.

She was Cadmus's daughter, with the pretty ankles; and once she had been a mortal woman who spoke like one, and now she has a share of honour in the salt water and they call her Leucothea, the White Goddess. And she pitied him, wandering out there, in that much trouble.

She came up out of the water like a gull on the wing and settled on the raft, and said:

"Poor man. Why does Poseidon hate you so unspeakably, that he plants all this trouble for you?

"He will not finish you, though, however much he wants to.

"Now do this. You do not look like a fool. Take those clothes off, and let the raft go where the winds take it, and swim for it with your arms — strike out for the land of the Phaeacians, where it is laid down that you get out of this alive.

"Here. Take this veil, this immortal thing, and spread it under your chest, and then you need not be afraid of suffering or of dying. But when you get your hands on dry land, untie it and throw it back into the wine-dark sea, well away from the shore, and turn your own head away as you do it."

And she gave him the veil, and went back down into the surging water like a gull, and the black wave closed over her.[31]

And the man who had endured everything thought it over, and did not like it.

"No. No — I am afraid some god is weaving me another trap, telling me to leave the raft. I am not doing it yet. That land she says I can escape to is a long way off; I saw it with my own eyes.

"Here is what I will do, and it seems the best plan. As long as the timbers hold in their joints, I will

[31] **Ino, who is called Leucothea.** She had been a mortal woman: a princess of Thebes, sister to the mother of Dionysus, and she took the infant god in and nursed him — for which Hera drove her mad, and she went off a cliff into the sea with her own son in her arms, and the sea took her in and made her a goddess. She now spends her immortality pulling drowning men out of the water. Bear that in mind when a veil comes up out of the sea and a voice says *you need not be afraid of dying*; the poem has chosen, out of everyone available, the one divinity in the Mediterranean who knows from the inside what it is to go under. — And notice what Odysseus does with the help: he takes it, thanks nobody, and then refuses to follow the instructions until the raft is smashed out from under him. He is right, too. She told him to abandon a floating vessel two days from land. Being rescued by a goddess is not the same as being told the truth by one, and he has learned to tell the difference.

stay here and put up with it, whatever it costs. And when a wave finally smashes the raft to pieces, then I will swim; there will be nothing better to think of by then."

And while he was still turning that over, Poseidon raised a great wave, terrible and hard and arching over, and drove it down on him.

The way a strong wind hits a heap of dry chaff and scatters it every way at once — that is how it scattered the long timbers. And Odysseus got astride a single plank, riding it like a man riding a horse, and stripped off the clothes Calypso had given him and got Ino's veil round his chest and tied it, and put his arms out and threw himself head first into the sea to swim.

And the lord of the earthquake (Poseidon) saw him, and shook his head, and said: "Right. Now go and drift about like that, in real misery, until you fall in with people the gods have favoured. I do not think you will find your suffering small." And he lashed his horses and drove away to Aegae, where his famous house is.

And Athena, daughter of Zeus, thought of something else.

She stopped the tracks of all the other winds and told them to fall off and go to sleep, and she raised the fast North Wind and broke the seas down in front of him, so that he could reach the Phaeacians, who love the oar, and get away from death.

Two nights and two days he drifted on the heavy swell, and his own heart told him a great many times that he was going to die.

But when the third morning came, the wind fell and there was a windless calm; and he lifted up on a big wave and looked out, straining, and saw land close by.

And it came to him the way it comes to children when their father's life begins again — a man who has lain a long time in a sickness, wasting, with some hard spirit wearing away at him, and then, thank god, the gods let him go; and that is how welcome the land looked to Odysseus, and the trees on it. And he swam hard, driving to get his feet on solid ground.

But when he was as close in as a man's voice will carry, he heard the sea booming on the reefs. Great waves were roaring against the dry land and breaking, and everything was covered in spray; there were no harbours and no roadsteads for a ship, nothing but jutting headlands and rocks and cliffs.

And his knees went, and his heart, and he said to himself:

"So Zeus lets me see land I never hoped to see, and I have cut my way through all that water — and now there is no way out of the grey sea at all.

"Sharp rocks outside, and the surf howling round them, and the cliff going up sheer, and deep water close in with no place to stand on my two feet and get clear of it. If I try to climb out, a big wave will pick me up and throw me on the stone, and it will have been a wasted effort.

"And if I swim on further, looking for a beach that slopes, or a river mouth, I am afraid the storm will pick me up again, groaning as I go, and carry me back out into the fish-filled sea. Or some god will send a monster up at me out of the water. Amphitrite keeps a great many of those, and I know how much the famous Earthshaker hates me."

And while he was turning it over, a big wave carried him in at the rough shore. He would have been stripped of his skin and had his bones smashed, if Athena had not put it into his mind to grab at a rock with both hands as he came in; and he held on, groaning, until the great wave went by.

He got past that one. And then the backwash hit him as it came out, and struck him hard, and threw

him far out to sea again.

And the way the pebbles come away stuck all over the suckers of a squid when it is dragged out of its hole — that is how the skin came off his strong hands on the rock. And the great wave closed over him.

Then and there the wretched man would have died before his time, if Athena had not given him a clear head. He came up out of the surge that was vomiting in against the land, and swam along outside it, watching the shore, hoping for a beach that sloped, or a river mouth.

And swimming, he came to the mouth of a river with a good current; and that seemed the best place to him, clear of rocks, and sheltered from the wind.

And he felt the water running out, and he prayed in his heart:

"Hear me, lord, whoever you are. I have come to you, as a man comes to what he has been praying for, running from the sea and from Poseidon's threats. Even the immortal gods respect a man who arrives as a wanderer — and that is what I am now, coming to your current and to your knees after a great deal of suffering. Pity me, lord. I claim to be your suppliant."

And the river checked his current, and held the wave back, and made calm water in front of him, and brought him safe into his own mouth.

And he came out with both his knees bent under him and his strong hands hanging, because the salt water had beaten the heart out of him. His whole body was swollen and the sea was running out of his mouth and his nostrils in streams. He lay there without breath and without a word, hardly able to move, and a terrible tiredness had come over him.

And when he got his breath back and the spirit came together in him again, he untied the goddess's veil and dropped it into the river running out to sea. A big wave carried it back down the current, and Ino caught it in her hands.

And he crawled up out of the water and lay down in the reeds and kissed the earth that gives men grain.

And then, because he was still in the world and the world does not stop, he had a new problem, and he put it to himself:

"What now? What finally becomes of me?

"If I keep watch by the river through this miserable night, I am afraid the hard frost and the wet dew together will finish me off — weak as I am, with the breath barely in me — and the wind off a river blows cold before dawn.

"And if I climb the slope into the dark wood and lie down in the thick brush, and the cold and the tiredness let go of me, and sweet sleep comes — I am afraid I become prey and a meal for wild animals."

And thinking it over, that seemed the better of the two; and he went up into the wood, and found a place near the water, in a clearing.

He crawled in under a pair of bushes growing out of the same spot: one of them a wild olive, one a grafted olive. No wet wind ever blew through them; the sun never struck through them with its rays; the rain never got through, they were grown together so close. And Odysseus crawled in under them and at once heaped himself a wide bed with his own hands, because there was a great drift of fallen leaves lying there — enough to cover two men or three, in the winter season, however hard the weather.

And when he saw it he was glad, and he lay down in the middle and poured the leaves over himself.

The way a man on a lonely farm, out at the edge of everything, with no neighbours, buries a burning log in the black embers and keeps the seed of the fire alive so that he does not have to go somewhere else to fetch it — that is how Odysseus lay covered over in the leaves.

And Athena poured sleep over his eyes and closed the lids of them, so that the exhaustion he had suffered would let go of him soonest.

NOTES TO BOOK FIVE

Book Six: In Which a Girl Does the Washing, Plays a Ball Game, and Finds Something Dreadful in the Bushes.

Book 06

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK SIX

In Which a Girl Does the Washing, Plays a Ball Game, and Finds Something Dreadful in the Bushes

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So the man who had endured everything slept there, buried in his leaves, worn out with exhaustion.

And Athena went to the town of the Phaeacians.

They had lived once in a wide open country called Hyperia, next door to the Cyclopes — who were stronger than they were, and violent, and kept raiding them. So their king Nausithous had got them up and moved the whole nation to Scheria, far away from everybody who works for a living, and run a wall round the town and built houses and put up temples for the gods and marked out the fields. But he had gone down into the dark by now, and Alcinous ruled there, and the gods had taught him what he knew.

Hold on to that piece of family history for three books. These people are refugees. They live at the far edge of the world in a walled town full of gardens and dancing and ships, and the reason they live there is that they could not go on living next to the Cyclopes.[32]

Athena went to the house, and into a richly-made room where a girl was sleeping who looked like one of the immortals in shape and in her face: Nausicaa, the daughter of great-hearted Alcinous. Two maids slept on either side of the doorposts, and they had beauty from the Graces, and the shining doors were shut.

And the goddess went through like a breath of air and stood over the girl's head, and took on the look of the daughter of Dymas, a man famous for his ships — a girl of her own age, and dear to her.

"Nausicaa. How did your mother come to have such a careless daughter?

"Your good clothes are lying about the place unwashed, and your marriage is very close, when you will have to be beautifully dressed yourself and find clothes for the people who walk with you. That is how a good name gets built up among people, and how a father and a mother are made glad.

"So let us go washing as soon as it is light. I will come with you and work beside you, so that you get it all done quickly, because you are not going to be unmarried much longer. The best men in the

[32]**The Phaeacians.** They are the hinge of the whole poem and it is worth knowing what they are before you meet them. For five books we have been in the ordinary world — Ithaca, Pylos, Sparta, places with politics and taxes and inheritance law. For the next four books we will be somewhere else entirely, and after that we go into a world of one-eyed giants, witches, singing monsters and the country of the dead. The Phaeacians stand exactly on the border. They are recognisably a real society, with a king and a council and a harbour and gossip; and they are also a fairy-tale people, dear to the gods, living past the edge of the map, whose ships need no steersman and know by themselves where every man wants to go. Everything before them is history. Everything after them is a story told at their dinner table — because it is here, and only here, that Odysseus tells his own adventures, in his own voice, to an audience. Keep that in view. From Book Nine to Book Twelve, the most famous events in this poem come to you as a shipwrecked man's after-dinner account of himself, given to strangers he needs something from. — And note the one hard fact in their history: they emigrated because they could not live near the Cyclopes. The monsters are not in another kind of world from this one. They are just up the coast.

whole country here are already asking for you, and you are Phaeacian yourself.

"Go on — ask your father, first thing in the morning, for the mules and the wagon to carry the sashes and the robes and the bright coverlets. It is much better than walking. The washing pools are a long way from the town."

And she went away to Olympus, where they say the gods have their seat forever. The wind does not shake it, and the rain never wets it, and the snow never comes near it; there is a great clear air spread cloudless over it, and a white light running along it; and there the blessed gods take their pleasure, all their days.

Dawn came up on her fine throne and woke Nausicaa, and she wondered at the dream, and went through the house to tell her parents about it.

She found her mother indoors, sitting at the hearth with her women round her, spinning yarn dyed with the purple of the sea. And she caught her father in the doorway on his way out to a meeting of the chiefs, where the Phaeacian nobles were calling him.

And she stood in front of him and said:

"Daddy — could you get the wagon out for me? The high one, with the good wheels. I want to take the good clothes down to the river to wash; they are all lying dirty.

"And it is only right that you should have clean clothes on you when you sit in council with the leading men.

"And there are five sons of yours in this house — two of them married, and three of them fine young bachelors who are always wanting freshly washed things to wear when they go out dancing. And I am the one who has to think about all of it."

That is what she said, because she was too shy to mention her own marriage to her father.

But he understood every word of it, and he answered:

"I do not grudge you the mules, child, and I do not grudge you anything else. Go on. The servants will get the wagon out for you, the high one with the good wheels and the box on top."

I would like to stop here for a moment, having just come out of the North Wind and the squid and the drowning, and point out that we are now in a domestic comedy and it is one of the best-observed things in ancient literature.

A girl has had a dream that has made her think about getting married, and she wakes up embarrassed about it, and she goes to her father and constructs an entire practical case for a trip to the river which is about everybody's laundry except her own. Your council robes, father. The boys' dancing clothes. And the poem tells you plainly what she is doing — *she was too shy to mention her own marriage* — and then tells you, in the next line, that he knew perfectly well.

And he does not tease her. He does not say *ah, so that's it*. He gives her the wagon and the mules and asks no questions, and goes off to his meeting.

There is a great deal of grand machinery in this poem — gods in council, storms raised by tridents, oaths sworn on the rivers of the dead. This is the other thing it can do, and it does it in nine lines: a father and a daughter, both of them knowing exactly what the conversation is about, and neither of them saying so, out of kindness.

The servants brought out the mule wagon and yoked the mules, and the girl carried the good clothes out of the room and packed them in. And her mother put a chest of food in for her, all sorts of good

things, and something to go with it, and poured wine into a goatskin bag; and she gave her a golden flask of soft olive oil, for the girl and her women to rub on themselves after bathing.

And Nausicaa took the whip and the shining reins and cracked the whip to start them, and there was a clatter of mules, and they pulled steadily, carrying the clothes and the girl — not alone; her women went along with her.

They came to the beautiful stream of the river, where the washing pools were, always full, with plenty of clear water welling up through them, enough to clean the dirtiest things. And they turned the mules loose out of the wagon and drove them along the eddying river to graze on the honey-sweet clover, and took the clothes down off the wagon in armfuls and carried them into the dark water and trod them in the pits, racing each other at it.

And when they had washed everything and got all the dirt out, they spread it in rows along the shore, where the sea washed the shingle cleanest.

Then they bathed and rubbed themselves with the oil, and had their meal on the river bank, and waited for the sun to dry the clothes.[33]

And when they had all had enough to eat, they threw off their headscarves and played at ball, and Nausicaa of the white arms led the singing for them.

The way Artemis (god of the hunt) who showers arrows goes down a mountain — down the long ridge of Taygetus, or Erymanthus — happy among the boars and the running deer, and the wild nymphs, the daughters of Zeus, play along with her, and Leto is glad in her heart, because her girl holds her head and her forehead higher than all of them and is easy to pick out, though every one of them is lovely: that is how the unmarried girl stood out among her women.

And when she was about to yoke the mules and fold the good clothes and go home, Athena thought of something else — so that Odysseus would wake up, and see her, and be brought into the city.

The princess threw the ball at one of her women and missed her, and it went into a deep eddy of the river.

And they all screamed.

And Odysseus woke up.

He sat up and turned it over in his mind. *What now? Whose country am I in this time? Are they violent and wild, with no sense of right, or do they take strangers in, and do they have god-fearing minds? Something went past me just then that sounded like girls — nymphs, who live on the steep tops of the mountains and the springs of the rivers and the grassy meadows? Or am I somewhere near people who use speech? Well. I shall go and look for myself.*

And he crawled out from under the bushes, and with his great hand he broke off a leafy branch to hold in front of himself and cover what a man does not want seen.

And he came out.

The way a lion goes, bred in the mountains, sure of his own strength, driving on through rain and

[33] **The laundry.** Trampled in stone pits with the feet, rinsed, and spread out on the shingle at the tide line, where the sea has scoured the pebbles clean and the salt and sun bleach the linen. It is heavy physical work and it takes all day, and it is being done by the king's daughter with her own feet, on an outing she had to ask permission for. This is worth registering because it is easy to picture these households wrongly. Nobody is idle. Penelope weaves; Helen spins with a golden spindle and keeps a work-basket at her chair; Arete will be found spinning in the firelight; the queen of the Phaeacians and the princess of the Phaeacians both work with their hands, and it is a mark of standing rather than the opposite. The distinction that mattered was not between working and not working. It was between working in your own house and working in somebody else's.

wind with his eyes on fire, in among the cattle or the sheep or the wild deer of the hills — his belly tells him to go, and he will try even a well-fenced fold: that is how Odysseus was about to come among those girls with their beautiful hair, naked as he was. He had no choice left.

And he was horrible to look at, all crusted over with dried sea-salt.

And they ran. They ran in every direction, along the spits of the beach.

Only the daughter of Alcinous stood still, because Athena put courage in her heart and took the fear out of her legs; and she stood and faced him.

And Odysseus had a decision to make, and it took him about a second and a half.

The correct and binding way to beg a stranger for your life in this world was to get down and take hold of their knees with one hand and their chin with the other. It was a physical act and it worked like a legal one: once you were holding on, the person you were holding was under an obligation the gods were watching, and to shake you off was a serious impiety. It is the strongest claim a helpless person can make. Every instinct this man has, after twenty years of getting out of things, is to make the strongest claim available.

And he looked at her — a girl on a beach, on her own, ten feet from a naked stranger the size of a lion with salt in his beard — and worked out that if he touched her she would never forgive him, and that he would win the argument and lose the case.

So he stayed where he was, and used words instead. He made a soft and cunning speech.[34]

"I am at your knees, my lady. Whatever you are — a goddess, or a mortal woman.

"If you are a goddess, one of those who hold the wide sky, then I take you for Artemis, the daughter of great Zeus: you have her looks, and her height, and the way she is put together.

"And if you are one of the mortals who live on the earth, then three times blessed is your father, and your honoured mother, and three times blessed your brothers. Their hearts must warm right through with pleasure every time they watch you go into the dancing — a young shoot like you.

"And blessed beyond all of them, in his heart, is the man who wins the argument with his gifts and takes you home.

"I have never seen anything like you with my own eyes — no man, no woman. I am afraid, looking at you.

"Once, on Delos, beside the altar of Apollo, I saw a young palm shoot coming up out of the ground. I had gone there too, with a great many men behind me, on a journey that was going to end badly for me. And I stood and stared at that tree for a long time, and could not stop, because no shaft like it had ever come up out of the earth.

"And that is how I feel now, my lady. I am amazed by you, and I am afraid, and I do not dare to take hold of your knees.

[34] **Suppliancy, and the touch he does not make.** To supplicate formally was to take hold of a person's knees with one hand and their chin or beard with the other, and then to speak. The physical hold was the point: it made the claim binding, put the suppliant under the protection of Zeus, and made refusal a religious offence rather than merely a rudeness. It is what Odysseus is about to do to the queen, on this girl's own instructions, with his arms round her knees at the hearth. — Here he declines it, and says so out loud, and dresses the refusal up as awe: *I am amazed by you, and I do not dare*. Read it as flattery and it is charming. Read it as tactics and it is one of the shrewdest things he does in the poem. He gives up the strongest available claim on her, in exchange for her not being frightened of him — and he is right, because the claim would have been worth nothing from a naked stranger who had just grabbed a girl on an empty beach, and her goodwill is worth everything. He also, and this matters, does not lie to her. He tells her the truth about Ogygia and the twenty days. He lies to nearly everyone else on this island. He does not lie to her.

"Hard grief has come on me. Yesterday, on the twentieth day, I got out of the wine-dark sea. All that time the swell and the racing storms carried me away from the island of Ogygia (where Calypso lived). And now some god has thrown me down here to suffer some more — because I do not think it is over. I think the gods have a good deal more in store for me before it is finished.

"Pity me, my lady. You are the first person I have come to, after everything I have been through, and I do not know one other human being in this country. Show me the town, and give me a rag to throw round myself — anything, whatever you had the clothes wrapped in when you came.

"And may the gods give you everything your heart wants: a husband, and a house, and *one mind between you*. There is nothing better in this world, nothing stronger, than a man and a woman keeping house together with one mind. It is a great pain to the people who hate them, and a joy to the people who love them — and they know it themselves, better than anyone."

I said in Book One that we would be a while getting to the point of this poem, and that the point was a house.

That is the point of the poem. He has just said it, in the last sentence of that speech, on a beach, to a stranger, holding a branch.

The word is *homophrosynē*, and there is no clean English for it. Like-mindedness. Same-thinkingness. Two people whose minds run the same way. He does not say love, and he does not say fidelity, and he does not say passion — all of which he could have said and none of which are the thing he means. He means the arrangement in which two people want the same things and think about them in the same way and can therefore trust each other, and he says that when it exists it is a weapon against your enemies and a comfort to your friends, and that the two people inside it know something the people outside it do not.

He has one. It is nineteen hundred miles away and he has not seen it for twenty years and he is not sure it is still there.

And he wishes it on a girl he met four minutes ago, as a blessing, in the middle of begging her for a scrap of cloth to cover himself with.

That is the sentence to carry with you into the rest of this book. Everything Odysseus turns down — a goddess, deathlessness, the girl who is about to appear in his path, the kingdom that will be offered to him with her — he turns down because of a thing he can describe in one clause and cannot get home to.[35]

And Nausicaa answered him.

"Stranger — you do not strike me as a bad man, or a stupid one.

"Zeus himself hands out good luck to people, to bad men and good men, whichever way he likes; and he has given you this, I suppose, and you have to put up with it.

"But now, since you have arrived at our city and our country, you shall not go short of clothing, or

[35] **Like-mindedness (*homophrosynē*).** The poem's own definition of a good marriage, given in this speech and nowhere else so plainly: not desire, not loyalty, not even love, but two people whose minds work the same way. It is a startling thing to find as the stated ideal in a heroic poem from the eighth century before Christ, and it is worth saying that the poem means it structurally and not just sentimentally. It is the reason Penelope's shroud trick was set beside Odysseus's cunning in Book Two. It is the reason the last recognition in this book, twenty thousand lines from here, is not a matter of scars or proofs of identity but of one person laying a trap and the other spotting it. And it is the standard by which the poem quietly judges the other marriages it shows you: Menelaus and Helen, who love each other and tell incompatible stories over a drugged bowl; Agamemnon and Clytemnestra, who came to a very great oneness of purpose indeed, and it was murder.

of anything else that a suppliant who has been through it deserves when he comes to us.

"I will show you the town, and tell you the name of the people. The Phaeacians hold this city and this land. And I am the daughter of great-hearted Alcinous, and the strength and the power of the Phaeacians rest on him."

And she called to her women, who had run off.

"Stand still! Where are you running to, at the sight of a man?

"You surely do not think he is an enemy? There is no man alive, and never will be, who comes to the country of the Phaeacians carrying war. We are very dear to the immortals. And we live out here at the edge of things, in the middle of the surging sea, the last people anywhere, and no other human beings have anything to do with us.

"This is some unlucky man who has come here off his course, and we have to look after him now. All strangers and beggars come from Zeus, and a small gift is a welcome one.

"So give the stranger food and drink, women, and wash him in the river, somewhere out of the wind."

They stopped, and called to each other, and settled him in a sheltered place as Nausicaa told them; and they laid out clothes for him, a cloak and a tunic, and gave him the golden flask of soft oil, and told him to wash in the streams of the river.

And Odysseus said: "Girls — stand back over there while I get the salt off my shoulders myself, and rub the oil on. It has been a long time since my skin had any oil on it. I am not going to wash in front of you. I am ashamed to stand naked among girls with lovely hair."

So they went away and told the princess.

And he washed the brine off his back and his broad shoulders, and scrubbed the crust of the sea out of his hair. And when he had washed and oiled himself all over and put on the clothes the unmarried girl had given him, Athena made him look taller and stronger, and made the hair come down curling off his head like hyacinth flowers.

The way a skilled craftsman washes gold over silver — a man Hephaestus and Athena have taught the whole art, so that everything he finishes has grace in it — that is how she poured grace over his head and shoulders.

And he went off and sat down apart on the beach, shining with good looks and grace.

And the girl looked at him.

And she said to her women: "Listen to me. This man has not come among the Phaeacians against the will of the gods. A moment ago I thought he was appalling. Now he looks like the gods who hold the wide sky.

"I wish a man like that might be called my husband, living here, and that it might please him to stay.

"Well. Give the stranger food and drink, women."

They heard her and did as she said; and they put food and drink in front of him, and the man who had endured everything ate and drank like an animal, because it had been a very long time since he had tasted anything.

Then Nausicaa thought of the rest of it.

She folded the clothes and put them in the good wagon, and yoked the strong-hoofed mules, and got up herself; and she called Odysseus over and told him what to do, and there is more calculation

in it than most people notice.

"Get up now, stranger, and come into the town, and I will send you on to the house of my father, who is a wise man, where I promise you will meet the best of the Phaeacians.

"But do it like this — you do not seem to me to lack sense.

"While we are going through the fields and the farmland, come along quickly behind the wagon with the women; I will lead the way.

"But when we are about to enter the city — there is a high wall round it, and a fine harbour on either side of the town, and the entrance is narrow; the curved ships are drawn up along the road, and every man has his own slip for his; and there is the meeting-ground round the beautiful temple of Poseidon, built of quarried stone set deep in the earth; and there the men see to the tackle of the black ships, the cables and the sails, and there they plane down the blades of the oars — because the Phaeacians do not care about bows and arrows; it is masts and oars and balanced ships they care about, and they love crossing the grey sea in them —

"when we are about to enter the city, I want to keep away from their nasty talk, in case somebody blames me afterwards. There are some very insolent men about, and one of the worse sort might say this if he met us:

"Who is this tall handsome stranger with Nausicaa? Where did she pick him up? Some husband for herself, no doubt. Perhaps she has taken in some wandering man off a ship — some foreigner, since we have no neighbours. Or some god she has been praying hard for has come down out of the sky in answer, and she will have him for the rest of her days. Better if she has gone out and found herself a husband somewhere else, since she is clearly too good for the Phaeacians here at home — and there are plenty of them courting her, and good men too.

"That is what they would say, and it would be thrown at me afterwards. And I would blame another girl who behaved like that — who went about with men before her wedding day, with her father and mother still living, and without their knowing.

"So do this instead. There is a grove of Athena beside the road, a poplar wood, with a spring running in it and a meadow round about — my father's estate, and his orchard in full bloom, as far out of town as a man's shout will carry.

"Sit down there and wait, for as long as it takes us to get into the city and reach my father's house. And when you think we have got there, then go into the town yourself and ask for the house of my father, great-hearted Alcinous. It is easy to recognise; a small child could take you to it. None of the other Phaeacian houses are built anything like it.

"And when the house and the courtyard have closed round you, go quickly through the hall until you reach my mother. She sits at the hearth in the firelight, leaning against a pillar, spinning sea-purple yarn — a wonder to look at — with her women sitting behind her.

"My father's chair is against the same pillar, and he sits in it drinking his wine like an immortal.

"Go straight past him. Put your arms round my mother's knees, if you want to see the day of your homecoming quickly and with gladness, however far away your home may be.

"If she takes to you in her own mind, then there is hope for you — that you will see the people you love, and get back to your own well-built house and your own country."

There is a great deal in that speech and I want to take two things out of it.

The first is the practical brilliance of it, which is of a piece with everything else in this book. She has looked at a man who cannot walk into a foreign city alone and unknown, and she has designed

him a way in: an approach route, a waiting point, a landmark, and — crucially — the name of the one person in the building whose good opinion decides everything. She is seventeen years old, if that. She would have made an excellent minister.

The second is what it costs her.

She has just told a strange man, out loud, in front of her women, that she wishes he could be her husband. And now she is arranging to be seen arriving home alone.

Not because she has changed her mind. Because there are men in her town who talk, and she knows exactly what they will say, and she can quote it — she performs the sneer, word for word, in the voice they would use. *She's picked up some sailor. She's too good for the local boys.* She has clearly heard it said about somebody else. And then she says the hardest sentence in the book: that she would think badly of a girl who did that.

She is a princess of a people who are the finest sailors in the world, at the edge of the earth, dear to the gods, walled and rich and safe from every enemy — and she cannot walk into her own town beside a man without it costing her something she cannot get back.

So she sends him round the long way, and she drives home by herself, and that is very nearly the last we shall hear from her.

She cracked the whip and the mules went on, and stepped out well, and they made good time; and she drove carefully, so that the women and Odysseus, on foot, could keep up, and she used the whip with judgement.

And the sun went down, and they came to the famous grove, the sacred ground of Athena, and Odysseus sat down there.

And he prayed to the daughter of great Zeus:

"Hear me, child of Zeus who holds the storm cloud — Unwearied One. Hear me now, since you did not hear me before, when the famous Earthshaker was smashing me.

"Let me come to the Phaeacians as a man they will care for and pity."

So he prayed, and Athena heard him.

But she did not show herself to him face to face, not yet. She was keeping out of the way of her father's brother (Poseidon) — who was still burning with anger against the godlike man, and would go on being angry until he reached his own country.

NOTES TO BOOK SIX

Book Seven: In Which There Is a Garden That Is Always in Fruit, and a Queen Who Recognises the Laundry.

Unreferenced Footnote Definitions These note definitions are present in the source Markdown even though no footnote marker links to them.

Note 5. "Go straight past my father." The oddest instruction in the book, and the poem does not explain it here. A shipwrecked stranger arriving at a foreign court is told to walk past the king on his throne without stopping and throw his arms round the queen's knees — and told it by the king's own daughter, as though it were obvious, and told that everything depends on the queen's opinion. Alcinous rules the Phaeacians and the strength and power of the people rest on him; his daughter says

so herself, thirty lines earlier. And it is his wife you supplicate. The explanation, such as it is, arrives at the start of the next book, and I will let it arrive there rather than spoil it; but note in the meantime that this is the third great house we have visited, and that in Sparta it was Helen who identified the guest, named him, and controlled the room, and in Ithaca it is Penelope's decision that everything is waiting on. This poem is extremely interested in what wives actually decide, as against what kings appear to.

Book 07

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK SEVEN

In Which There Is a Garden That Is Always in Fruit, and a Queen Who Recognises the Laundry

So he prayed there in the grove, while the strong mules carried the girl on into the town.

And when she came to her father's famous house she pulled up at the gateway, and her brothers came out and stood round her looking like immortals, and unyoked the mules and carried the clothes indoors; and she went off to her own room. And her old nurse lit the fire for her — Eurymedousa, who had been brought over from Apeira long ago in the curved ships, and had been picked out of the plunder and given to Alcinous, because he was king over everybody and the people listened to him as though he were a god. She had brought Nausicaa up in that house, and now she lit the fire and set about getting her supper.[36]

And Odysseus got up to go into the town.

Athena, who was looking after him, poured a thick mist round him as he went, in case one of the great-hearted Phaeacians should meet him on the road and pass some remark and ask him who he was. And just as he was about to step into the town she came to meet him herself, in the shape of a young girl carrying a water pitcher; and she stood there in front of him, and Odysseus said:

"Child, could you take me to the house of a man called Alcinous, who is king over the people here? I am a stranger. I have been through a great deal. I have come a long way, out of a distant country, and I do not know a single soul who lives in this town."

"Certainly, sir," said Athena. "I will show you the house; my own father lives close by it. But go quietly, and let me lead the way, and do not look at anybody and do not ask anybody anything. These people are not very tolerant of strangers, and they do not exactly make a foreigner welcome. What they trust is their fast ships, and crossing the great gulf of the sea, because Poseidon (god of the sea, and the one who has been keeping Odysseus from home these ten years) gave them that."

I hope you have noticed that this is not at all what the girl on the beach told him a few hours ago, and I think the difference is worth a moment of our time before we go in through the gate. Nausicaa said that all strangers and beggars come from Zeus, that a small gift is a welcome one, and that her people are dear to the gods; and she was speaking honestly and out of a generous nature, and every word of it was true. Athena, who has been watching this nation for rather longer than seventeen years, says: keep your head down, they do not much care for outsiders. And that is true as well. The Phaeacians are about to treat this man magnificently — feed him, bathe him, entertain him, load him with gold and

[36] **Eurymedousa.** She was taken from a place called Apeira in the curved ships and given to Alcinous as his share of the plunder, because he was king; and then she raised his daughter. She gets two lines and no further mention, and she is the fourth household we have been shown — after Ithaca, Sparta and Pylos — in which the woman who brought up the children arrived as somebody's property. The pattern is worth naming plainly this once and then leaving alone: whenever this poem wants to show you a house running warmly and well, there is a woman at the centre of the domestic arrangements who was carried there in a ship against her will. See Book One, note 10, and Book Four, note 1.

carry him home for nothing — and they are also, every one of them, going to make him prove himself first, and one of them is going to insult him to his face in public before the day is out. Hospitality in this world is a law; but laws are kept by people, and people are a mixed business, and a poem that told you otherwise would not be worth reading.

She led the way, quickly, and he came along behind her in the goddess's own footsteps; and the Phaeacians, the famous sailors, never noticed him going through the middle of their town, because Athena would not allow it. And as they walked she told him about the woman whose knees he was going to take hold of.

"That house you asked about, sir — the king sits in it, and his wife is called Arete, and she comes of the very same stock the king himself comes from.

"Poseidon began that line, with Periboea, who was the loveliest woman of her time and the youngest daughter of Eurymedon, who was king over the Giants once, and destroyed them, and himself along with them. Poseidon lay with her and she bore a son, Nausithous, who ruled the Phaeacians; and Nausithous had two sons, Rhexenor and Alcinous.

"Apollo (god of prophecy, and of the bow, whose arrows bring sudden death) shot Rhexenor down when he was newly married and had no son in the house, and he left one daughter behind him: Arete. And Alcinous made her his wife, and honours her as no other woman on this earth is honoured — no other woman anywhere who keeps a house under a husband.

"That is the honour she has, and has always had, from her own children, and from Alcinous himself, and from the people, who look at her as though she were a god and speak to her that way when she goes through the town. There is nothing lacking in her own good sense either, and she settles quarrels, even quarrels between men, for the people she thinks well of.

"If she takes to you in her own mind, then there is hope for you: that you will see the people you love, and get back to your own high-roofed house and your own country."

And with that Athena went away over the barren sea, and left lovely Scheria behind her, and came to Marathon and to Athens of the wide streets, and went into the strong house of Erechtheus.

Now, at the end of the last book I pointed at Nausicaa's instruction — walk straight past my father and put your arms round my mother's knees — and told you that the explanation was coming and that I would let it arrive in its own good time rather than spoil it. Here it is; and I have to tell you, in all honesty, that it does not explain anything at all.

What we are given is a family tree. A god fathered the line; the elder brother died young leaving one daughter; her uncle married her; and she is honoured as no woman on earth is honoured. And then the same fact three more times over, which is generally a sign that somebody is filling a silence: her children honour her, her husband honours her, the people honour her like a god when she walks down the street.

Notice what is missing from all of that. There is no office. She is not a priestess, and not a judge, and not a co-ruler under any constitutional arrangement that anybody troubles to name; and the one line in the whole speech that describes her actually doing something — that she settles disputes, *even between men* — is thrown out in half a breath as though it followed naturally from what has gone before, which it does not. It follows from nothing. It simply sits there, remarkable and unexplained, in the middle of a genealogy.

So we have been handed an answer with a hole in the middle of it, and the hole is the shape of a

woman with real power that nobody in the building can quite account for. And I have come to think that this is the truth of the matter rather than a failure of the poem, because there have been such women in every society that has ever existed, including a great many societies with no legal room for them whatsoever, and the way you can always tell is exactly this: everybody knows to go to her, nobody can point to the rule that says so, and if you ask a local why, you are given a genealogy and a list of the people who respect her.

There is one other thing in that speech which slides past very fast, and I shall mention it once and then leave it alone. She is his brother's daughter, and he married her, and the poem reports this in the same breath as everything else without the smallest flicker of embarrassment — because to its first audience this was not scandal but administration. A royal house that has suddenly lost its heir has a succession problem and a property problem at the same moment, and marrying the orphaned niece to her nearest kinsman solves both of them at a stroke.[37]

Then Odysseus came to the famous house, and stopped where he was, with his heart turning over a great many things, before he stepped onto the bronze threshold.

Because there was a brightness like the sun and the moon over that high-roofed house. The walls ran bronze on both sides, all the way in from the threshold, with a cornice of dark blue enamel round the top of them. Golden doors shut the strong house in; silver doorposts stood on the bronze threshold, with a silver lintel above and a golden handle. And on either side of the doors there were dogs made of gold and silver, that Hephaestus (the lame smith of the gods, who makes everything the immortals cannot make for themselves) had built with his own skill and knowledge, to keep watch over the house of great-hearted Alcinous — deathless dogs, that do not grow old, ever.

Inside, chairs stood along the wall on both sides, the whole way in from the threshold, and light finely-woven covers were thrown over them, the work of the women of the house; and the Phaeacian leaders sat there to eat and drink, because there was always something going on. And there were young men made of gold standing on their well-built pedestals, holding burning torches in their hands, to light the hall at night for the people at dinner.[38]

And there were fifty serving women in that house. Some of them grind the yellow grain at the millstone; others weave at the loom, or sit twirling the spindles, and their hands move like the leaves of a tall poplar; and the close-woven linen is so smooth that the oil runs off it. For the Phaeacian men are the best sailors in the world at driving a fast ship over the sea, and their women are the best in the world at the loom, because Athena gave them the skill for it, and good sense besides.

[37] **Arete.** On the marriage: an uncle marrying his brother's orphaned daughter would have raised no eyebrows in a royal house that had just lost its heir, since it kept the succession, the property and the claim inside one family at a single stroke. Greek practice in later centuries permitted marriage between an uncle and a niece for exactly this reason — an heiress with no brothers was very often married to her nearest kinsman on the father's side, precisely so that the estate should not walk out of the family. The poem states it flatly because to its audience it was administration and not scandal. — On the name: it stands close to a Greek verb meaning to pray for or to entreat, and so carries a faint shadow of *the one who is prayed to*, which suits a woman whose knees a suppliant is instructed to grasp; and it is also close to *aretē*, excellence. The Greeks enjoyed this sort of resonance and were not at all systematic about it. I would not build very much on it, but it is there.

[38] **The gold dogs and the gold torch-bearers.** These are not ornaments. The dogs are deathless and ageless and they are on guard, and the young men holding the torches are standing on pedestals doing a job of work; they are made things that function — machines in the shape of servants and animals, built by the smith of the gods — and they are among the earliest of their kind in European literature. Hephaestus does this elsewhere too: in the *Iliad* he owns twenty tripods on golden wheels that roll into the gods' assembly by themselves and roll home again afterwards, and he is attended by handmaids made out of gold who can think and speak and have strength in them. What strikes me most is how completely untroubled everybody is. Nobody in this poem finds the golden dogs uncanny, or asks whether they are alive, or wonders what they do when the smith is not watching. They are simply the finest work of the finest craftsman there is, and the mark of the finest house there is, and the guests walk past them in to dinner.

And outside the courtyard gate there was an orchard of four acres, with a hedge running round both sides of it and tall trees flourishing inside: pears and pomegranates and apples with their bright fruit, and sweet figs, and olives in their prime. And the fruit of those trees never dies and never fails, winter or summer, the whole year round; there is always a west wind blowing there, and it is always bringing some fruit on and ripening others, so that pear grows old upon pear, and apple upon apple, grape upon grape and fig upon fig. And there was a vineyard rooted in the same ground, heavy with grapes, and part of it a level drying-floor where the bunches lie in the sun; and other clusters they are gathering, and others they are treading; while in the front rows the unripe grapes are still dropping their blossom, and others just beginning to darken. And at the far end of the vineyard there were neat beds of vegetables of every kind, green all the year. And two springs ran there: one of them led all through the garden, and the other going the other way, out under the courtyard threshold and up towards the high house, and the townspeople came and drew their water from that one.

That was the gods' shining gift in the house of Alcinous.

And Odysseus stood outside in the road and looked at it, and I should like to stand there with him a moment, because he has been in a rich house before and this is not the same thing at all.

You will remember Menelaus's palace in Book Four, where this same young man's own son stood in the doorway and said out loud that it must be what the house of Zeus looks like inside, and was gently corrected by his host. But that house was full of *treasure*: gold and amber and ivory and silver, every piece of it carried home in a ship, and every piece of it a receipt for eight years of wandering about the eastern sea while his brother was being murdered at his own front door. Menelaus recited the inventory and then told the boy, in the same breath, that he would hand over two thirds of it tomorrow to have the dead men back.

This is not treasure. What Odysseus is looking at over that hedge is a working farm with the seasons taken out of it.

And I would ask you to notice what the poem chooses to dwell on, at length and with evident pleasure, in the wealthiest house it will ever show us. Not the gold. The gold gets a line and a half. It is the fruit that gets the paragraph: four acres of pears and figs and olives, and a vineyard standing at every stage of the year all at once, some of it being picked and some of it being trodden and some of it still in flower; and the vegetable beds; and the two springs, one of which is led out under the wall so that the neighbours can fill their jars at the king's water. The marvel of the place is not that its owner is rich. It is that nothing there ever fails, and nobody there ever has to wait.

That is a fairy-tale, of course, and the poem knows quite well that it is a fairy-tale; no one has ever farmed a country where the wind is always westerly and the apples are always coming. But it is a very particular fairy-tale, and it is precisely the one that a farming people would dream, because it is made entirely out of the absence of the things that frighten them. No hungry gap in February. No hail the week before harvest. No year when the olives simply do not come.

And there is a man standing at the gate looking at it who has been at sea for ten years; whose own orchard is on a stony island where the goats do better than the grain; and whose father, at this moment, is sleeping in the ashes by the fire with the servants, out in the real dirt and the actual weather, grieving.

He looks at it for a long time. Then he goes in.

Inside, the Phaeacian leaders were pouring the last of their wine to Hermes (the messenger of the gods, and the one who walks with travellers), which is what they always did at the end of an evening

before they began thinking about bed. And Odysseus went through the house wrapped in the thick mist Athena had poured round him, until he came to Arete and to the king, and threw his arms round Arete's knees.

And at that moment the miraculous mist fell away from him, and every person in that hall found themselves looking at a man who had not been there a second before. They went silent. They stared. They wondered.

And he made his appeal.

"Arete, daughter of godlike Rhexenor. I come to your husband, and to your knees, and to these guests, after a very great deal of suffering. May the gods grant them all good lives, and may every man here hand on to his children the wealth in his house and whatever honour the people have given him. But arrange an escort for me, so that I can get to my own country quickly. I have been away from the people I love a long time, and I have suffered."

And he sat down in the ashes of the hearth, beside the fire.

And nobody said a single word.

That is the most awkward pause in the poem so far, and it deserves to be looked at rather than hurried past, because a great deal is going on inside it.

A man has appeared out of nothing in the middle of a closed room and taken hold of the strongest position their law allows to a helpless person: his arms are round the queen's knees, which puts him under the protection of Zeus himself and makes shaking him off an act of impiety rather than mere rudeness. Then he lets go and sits down in the fireplace — in the ash, at the hearth, which is at once the sacred centre of the house and the coldest and lowest place in it to put a guest. It is a gesture of complete self-abasement, and, this being Odysseus, it is also completely unanswerable. Every person in that room now has a religious problem sitting in their fire, and not one of them can think what to say about it.

What breaks the silence is an old man. Echeneus was the oldest Phaeacian present and the best speaker among them, and he knew a great many old things; and he said, in effect, what everybody in the room should have said several seconds earlier — that this would not do, that it did the king no credit to have a stranger sitting on the ground in the ashes, that everybody was holding back and waiting for him, and that the man should be got up out of the fireplace at once and put in a silver-studded chair, and the wine mixed, and a proper supper brought out of the stores.

And two things happen next which I would not like you to miss, because they are small and they tell you a great deal about how this poem thinks good rule works. The first is that the correction comes from the oldest man in the room, in front of the whole council, and the king takes it instantly and without the smallest flicker of resentment — which is the point. Good kingship in this poem is not a matter of never getting it wrong; it is a matter of what happens when a man of ninety tells you that you have. And the second is that when Alcinous needs a seat of honour for the stranger, he turns his own favourite son out of one: he tells Laodamas, who was sitting next to him and whom he loved best, to get up and go and sit somewhere else. That is how honour worked in a world with no money in it. There were only so many good chairs, and giving one to somebody always meant taking it away from somebody else, and everybody in the hall saw who moved.

Then a maid brought water in a beautiful golden jug and poured it out over a silver basin for him to wash his hands, and drew up a polished table beside him; and the housekeeper brought bread and

a great many good things out of her stores; and the man who had endured everything ate and drank.

And Alcinous told the herald to mix the bowl and serve everyone in the hall, so that they could pour out to Zeus, who walks in beside anybody who deserves respect. And when they had poured, and drunk as much as they wanted, the king dismissed the council for the night. In the morning, he said, they would call in more of the elders and entertain the stranger properly and make good sacrifices, and then see about his escort, so that this man could get to his own country without trouble and without pain, however far away it was; and after that he would suffer whatever his fate was, and whatever the heavy Spinners spun into his thread on the day his mother bore him.[39]

"But if he is one of the immortals come down out of the sky," he added, "then the gods are up to something new. Because up to now they have always shown themselves to us plainly whenever we make them a proper sacrifice, and they sit down and eat beside us; and if one of us meets them out on the road on his own, they do not hide themselves, because we are close to them — the way the Cyclopes are, and the wild tribes of the Giants."

And Odysseus said:

"Alcinous, get that out of your head. I am nothing like the immortals who hold the wide sky, not in my body and not in what I am. I am like men who die.

"Whoever you know who carries the heaviest load of sorrow among human beings — I will set my griefs against theirs and match them. And I could tell you a great deal more, and everything I have suffered through the will of the gods.

"But let me eat, in spite of my grief. Because there is nothing more shameless than a man's cursed belly, which insists on being remembered, however badly he is hurt and however much sorrow he has in his mind. I have sorrow in my mind. And it keeps telling me to eat and drink, and it makes me forget everything I have been through, and it will not stop until it is filled.

"But hurry, all of you, at first light. Put me down on my own country, wretched as I am. I have suffered enough. Let the life leave me the moment I have seen my own property, and my servants, and my great high-roofed house."

That is one of the strangest and best speeches in the poem, and it is not heroic in the least, and that is exactly the point of it.

A man is being asked, in the politest possible terms, whether he might not be a god in disguise. And his answer is that he is not, and his proof is that he is hungry.

Set it for a moment beside the other poem, because the two of them are arguing here and it is worth hearing the argument. In the *Iliad*, when Achilles's dearest friend is killed and he is torn to pieces by grief, they bring him food and he will not touch it; and his refusal to eat is presented as the true and towering response of a great soul, so that in the end a goddess has to come down and feed him in secret because he will not do it for himself. Grief in that poem is a thing you starve on. It lifts you clear of the ordinary business of the body and sets you above other men.

[39]**The Spinners.** The Fates: three of them in the developed mythology, one who spins the thread of a life, one who measures it and one who cuts it. But notice how lightly the poem holds all this. Alcinous says the stranger will suffer whatever was spun for him at his birth, and then in the very same speech makes elaborate practical arrangements to see that he suffers as little as possible — and nobody present feels the least tension between the two. That is characteristic. Fate in this poem is not a machine that removes choice; it is closer to the shape of a life as seen from the outside, or from the end. People still deliberate, take advice, change their minds and are held responsible for what they do; and Zeus himself, in the first hundred lines of Book One, complains bitterly that men blame the gods for troubles they have manufactured entirely on their own.

This poem does not believe a word of it.

What this poem says, through the mouth of a man sitting in borrowed clothes at a stranger's table, is that the belly is shameless; that it nags; that it will not permit you to concentrate properly on your own tragedy. However much you have lost, however far from home you are, however many of your friends have been eaten or drowned in front of you, there comes a point in the afternoon when the appalling fact is that you would like your dinner — and you will eat it, and while you are eating it you will actually stop thinking about the thing for a few minutes, which is somehow the most humiliating part of the whole business.

And he is not saying this lightly or as a joke. He says it with real bitterness — *the cursed belly*, the thing that makes you forget. He would very much rather be the sort of man who cannot eat. He is not that sort of man. Almost nobody is.

And the poem's judgement on him, offered quietly and without any fuss at all, is that this is not a failure. It is how a person gets through twenty years. The man who can eat when he is heartbroken is the man who is still alive when the ship goes down; and the reason he gets home in the end is not that his grief was smaller than anybody else's. It is that he kept eating.

Then they poured the last of the wine and went off home to bed, and Odysseus was left in the hall with Arete and Alcinous sitting beside him, while the maids cleared the dishes away.

And Arete spoke first, because she had recognised the clothes. She had looked at the cloak and the tunic on his back and known them at once, having made them herself with her own women.

"Stranger. There is something I should like to ask you first, myself. Who are you? Where are you from? Who gave you those clothes? Did you not say you came here wandering, over the sea?"

And Odysseus told her — and told her the truth, which is worth pausing on, because he is going to spend a great deal of the rest of this poem doing nothing of the kind. He told her about the island of Ogygia and the goddess Calypso; about the ship split open by lightning and the crew drowned, and nine days clinging to the keel; about the seven years, and the offer of deathlessness that never once persuaded him; about the raft, and the seventeen days of open water, and Poseidon smashing him within sight of land; about the river, and the leaves.

And then he came to the part with the girl in it, and there he was careful.

"And I saw your daughter's maids playing on the shore, and her among them, looking like a goddess; and I asked her for help. And she showed better sense than you would ever expect from somebody of that age — you do not generally find young people being sensible; they are usually thoughtless. She gave me bread, and red wine, and had me washed in the river, and gave me these clothes. That is the truth, painful as it is to tell."

And Alcinous said: "Stranger, there is one thing my child did not handle properly. She should have brought you here herself, with her women, since it was to her that you first appealed."

And Odysseus lied to him.

"Sir, do not blame your blameless daughter for that. She did tell me to follow her with the women. I was the one who refused. I was afraid, and I did not want you to be angry at the sight of it. We are a suspicious lot, we people on this earth."

I have been waiting several books to say this, so you will forgive me for stopping in the middle of a dinner party to say it properly.

That is the first lie we ever watch Odysseus tell. Not the first he has ever told, of course — this is the man who walked into Troy dressed as a beggar and walked out again over a pile of bodies, and we have heard two separate people describe it — but it is the first one told in the present tense of this poem, in front of us, in a room, in real time. And from here to the very last pages he will be lying almost continuously: false names, false countries, four or five entirely invented lives, told to swineherds and beggars and princes and, in the end, to his own wife.

And this first one is a lie told by a shipwrecked stranger with nothing in the world, to the king whose goodwill is the only thing standing between him and dying on that island, for the sole purpose of lifting a mild fatherly criticism off the shoulders of a seventeen-year-old girl who helped him.

He gains nothing whatever by it. It costs him a small risk, at the worst possible moment to be taking small risks. And notice precisely where the falsehood lies, because it is beautifully placed: he does not lie about whether she behaved well. He lies about *whose decision it was*. He takes her careful calculation about the gossips in the town — which she made deliberately, and explained to him at length on the road — and quietly moves it onto his own account, where a father's disapproval cannot reach it.

Keep that firmly in mind two hundred pages from now, when he is telling an enormous falsehood to somebody who loves him and you find yourself wondering what to think. It is the same faculty at work. Lying is not a moral quality in this man at all; it is a tool, and it does whatever the hand holding it wants done. Which is why the interesting question about him is never *is he lying* — he is, almost always — but *what is he protecting*.

And Alcinous answered him, and it must be said that Alcinous is a thoroughly decent man.

"Stranger, my heart is not the kind that gets angry for no reason. Everything is better done properly. By Father Zeus, and Athena, and Apollo — a man like you, thinking the way I think, I could wish you would have my daughter, and be called my son-in-law, and stay here. I would give you a house and everything in it, if you stayed of your own free will. But nobody in this country will hold you against it; Zeus forbid.

"Your escort I shall fix for tomorrow, so that you may know it is settled. You will lie down and sleep, overcome, while they row you over the calm water until you reach your own country and your own house, or wherever else you like — even if it is further off than Euboea, which the people here say is the furthest place there is. Some of our men saw it once, when they carried Rhadamanthus over to visit Tityos; and they went all that way and came home again the same day without turning a hair.

"You will find out for yourself how good my ships are, and how good my young men are at throwing up the sea with the flat of an oar."[40]

And Odysseus was delighted, and prayed aloud: "Father Zeus, let Alcinous do everything he has said. Let his fame never go out over the grain-giving earth. And let me get to my own country."

Now I want you to notice what he did not say, because the silence is the whole of it.

A king has just offered him a daughter, a house, an estate and a place among a people the gods sit down to dinner with; and has said, in the same breath and with real grace, that he will not be held to

[40] **Euboea, and the size of the world.** Alcinous names Euboea as the furthest place his people have ever heard of, out at the very rim of things, so distant that his sailors still talk about the voyage. Euboea is a long island lying off the east coast of mainland Greece, close enough to the shore in places to shout across. It is, in other words, extremely near — near to Athens, near to Boeotia, near to the poet and near to his audience. The joke is aimed gently at the Phaeacians: for all their magical ships, their sense of the world is a fairy-tale sense, and the ends of the earth to them are somebody else's back garden. It is also, in a poem so preoccupied with distance, a quiet piece of consolation. The furthest place in the world is a day's sail, if you have the right ship.

any of it and may leave whenever he likes. It is the third such offer he has been made in this poem — a goddess offered him deathlessness, a girl on a beach said out loud in front of her maids that she wished he could be her husband, and now this — and it is by some way the best-made of the three, coming from a good man who means it kindly and who has taken care to leave the door open behind it.

And Odysseus neither accepts nor refuses. He prays for a safe journey, out loud, in front of the man who has just made the offer, and lets that stand as his answer.

There is nothing else to be said, and he knows it. He said the true thing yesterday morning, on a beach, to this man's daughter, when he had nothing on but a branch: that there is nothing in this world better or stronger than a man and a woman keeping house together with one mind between them. He has one. It is a very long way from here, and he has not seen it for twenty years, and he is not certain it is still there. Everything he turns down, he turns down for that.

Then Arete told her women to put a bed under the covered walk, and to lay beautiful purple blankets on it and spread rugs over them and put fleecy cloaks on top for a covering. And they went out of the hall with torches in their hands, and when they had made the bed up they came and stood beside Odysseus and said: "Come and lie down, stranger; your bed is made."

And he was very glad to sleep.

So the man who had endured everything slept there, in the corded bed, under the echoing colonnade. And Alcinous lay down in an inner room of the high house, and his wife lay beside him, and she had made up the bed.

NOTES TO BOOK SEVEN

Book Eight: In Which a Blind Man Sings, a Young Man Is Rude About Sport, and a Stranger Cries Into His Cloak.

Book 08

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK EIGHT

In Which a Blind Man Sings, a Young Man Is Rude About Sport, and a Stranger Cries Into His Cloak

When Dawn came up, rosy-fingered, Alcinous got out of bed, and so did Odysseus, the sacker of cities; and the king led the way down to the Phaeacian meeting-ground, which is laid out beside the ships.

Athena went through the town in the likeness of the king's own herald, stopping beside one man after another. "Come along, leaders and counsellors of the Phaeacians — come to the assembly and hear about the stranger who has arrived at the house of Alcinous. He has been driven over the sea, and he looks like one of the immortals."

And she poured a supernatural grace over Odysseus's head and shoulders and made him taller to look at, and broader, because she wanted the Phaeacians to find him formidable and worth respecting — and because he was going to have to get through a great many tests before the day was out. It looks like a party, this day. It is an examination.

The seats filled up, and the crowd stared at him, and Alcinous stood and spoke.

"A stranger — I do not know who — has come to my house, wandering, out of the east or out of the west, and he is asking for an escort. Let us get one ready, the way we always do; nobody who comes to my house sits about here for long, grieving over his send-off.

"So drag a black ship down to the bright sea, a new one on her first voyage, and pick out fifty-two young men from the whole country, the best there are. Lash the oars in place and then come up to my house and get a meal inside you. That is my instruction to the young men. As for the rest of you — the sceptred kings — come to my house, so that we can entertain our guest properly indoors. Nobody refuse.

"And send for Demodocus, the singer whom heaven has favoured. The god gave him song beyond anybody else, to delight us however his heart moves him to sing."

So the ship was hauled down and the mast stepped and the oars fitted into their leather loops, and they moored her out in deep water and went up to the great house. The colonnades and the courtyards and the halls filled with men, young and old, and there were a great many of them; and Alcinous killed twelve sheep for them, and eight white-tusked boars, and two shambling oxen, and they dressed them and got a very fine dinner ready.

And the herald came bringing the singer, whom the Muse loved above other men, and to whom she had given good and evil together: she took his eyes away, and she gave him sweet song.[41]

[41] **The songs we have lost, and what a bard actually was.** Demodocus sings three times in this book, and every one of his songs is a summary of a story that existed and is now gone. The quarrel of Odysseus and Achilles comes from no poem we possess; nor does the wooden horse, which — and this surprises people — does not appear in the *Iliad* at all. That poem ends

He was given a silver-studded chair in the middle of the diners, backed against a tall pillar; and the herald hung the clear-toned lyre on a peg above his head and showed him how to reach up and take it down, and put a basket beside him and a good table and a cup of wine to drink when he wanted it.

And when they had all eaten and drunk as much as they wanted, the Muse stirred the singer to sing about the famous deeds of men — out of a song whose fame had gone right up into the wide sky in those days.

He sang about the quarrel of Odysseus and Achilles: how the two of them had once fallen out at a rich feast of the gods, with terrible words, and how Agamemnon had been secretly delighted to see the best of the Greeks quarrelling, because Apollo (god of prophecy, and of the bow) had told him at Delphi that this would be the sign. And it was the beginning of the disaster that rolled over the Trojans and the Greeks alike, by the will of Zeus.

And Odysseus took the great purple cloak in his strong hands and drew it down over his head and hid his handsome face, because he was ashamed to be seen crying by the Phaeacians. Every time the singer stopped he would push the cloak back and wipe the tears away and take his two-handled cup and pour an offering to the gods; and every time the singer started again — because the Phaeacian nobles kept urging him on, they were enjoying the story so much — he would cover his head and cry.

He got away with it. Nobody noticed except Alcinous, who was sitting next to him and could hear him breathing.

Consider what has just happened, because as far as anybody can tell it had never happened in a story before. A man is sitting in disguise at a foreign dinner table listening to a professional performer sing a well-known number about the Trojan war, and he is in it — not as a veteran in the audience but as one of the two men the song is about; and the crowd, who have heard it before and like it, are calling for more. That is what undying fame turns into. It becomes something a stranger performs at parties, in a town you have never visited, to people who will applaud and then ask for the one about the horse; and the man it belongs to sits under his cloak and waits for it to stop so that he can wipe his face and pour his wine like everybody else.

Alcinous, who was quick, said that they had all had enough of dinner and the lyre and had better go out to the games — so that the stranger could tell his friends at home how far the Phaeacians outdid everybody at boxing and wrestling and jumping and running.

Out they went, with a great crowd behind them, and a number of fine young men stood up to compete. Their names, and I give them because they are worth having, were Acroneus and Ocyalus and Elatreus, Nauteus and Prymneus and Anchialus, Eretmeus and Ponteus and Proreus, Thoon and Anabesineus and Amphialus; and Euryalus, who was as good as murderous Ares to look at, the best-built of all the Phaeacians after the faultless Laodamas; and the three sons of Alcinous, Laodamas and Halius and Clytoneus.[42]

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with Hector's funeral, before the horse, before the fall, before any of it. What survives to us are two poems out of a whole library: there was once a cycle of epics covering the entire war from its causes to the last homecoming, and they were known and quoted and loved, and they have all vanished, leaving titles, summaries, and quotations in other men's books. When Demodocus takes requests he is thumbing through a shelf that no longer exists. — Which also tells you what a working singer was. Not a man who recited one long poem, but a man with an enormous repertoire who could start anywhere in it, at a customer's request, and take it up in the right order. Note too what the Muse gave and took: the blindness and the song arrive together, in the same line, as a single transaction. Later ages built a legend that Homer himself was blind, and this passage is very likely where they got it.

[42] **The Phaeacian athletes' names.** Read them again. Acroneus is roughly Topship; Ocyalus is Swiftsea; Nauteus is Sailor; Prymneus is Sternman; Eretmeus is Oarman; Ponteus is Seaman; Proreus is Prowman; Thoon is Speedy; Anchialus is Seaside; Amphialus is Sea-all-round. Even the king is Alcinous, "strong of mind," his father was Nausithous, "swift with ships," and

Clytoneus won the footrace by a distance. Euryalus won the wrestling, Amphialus the jump, Elatreus the discus, and Laodamas the boxing.

And when they had enjoyed the games, Laodamas said: "Friends, let us ask the stranger whether he knows any sport. He is not badly built — look at his thighs and his calves, and those arms, and the thick neck on him. There is a great deal of strength there, and he is not past it either; he has just been broken up by hard usage. There is nothing on earth like the sea for finishing a man off, however strong he is."

So he went and stood in the middle and said, politely: "Come and try, sir, if you know any games. You look as if you would. There is no greater glory for a man, as long as he lives, than what he can do with his hands and his feet. Come and have a try, and shake the cares off your heart. You will not be kept waiting for your journey much longer; the ship is launched and the crew are ready."

"Laodamas, why are you all pressing me and making fun of me? I have more grief in my mind than games. I have been through a great deal and worked very hard, and I am sitting here in your assembly wanting to go home, and asking your king and your people for it."

And Euryalus answered him to his face, and insulted him.

"No. I did not think you looked like a man who knows about contests — not the sort men hold everywhere. You look more like a man who goes up and down in a ship with a lot of oars, in charge of a crew of traders, keeping an eye on his cargo and watching his freight charges and his greedy profits. You do not look like an athlete."

That is not an insult about sport, and I hope you heard what it actually was. He is saying: you are in business; you are the sort of man who counts things. To a young nobleman of this world there was no deeper cut available, since the whole value system he was raised in held that a gentleman shows his quality with his body, in public, for honour — and that a man who works for gain is a lesser article. It also happens to be aimed at somebody who has spent ten years calculating, weighing, counting his men and getting what he could out of every place he landed in, and who is at this moment working a room in order to extract a passage home. Which is very likely why it lands.

And Odysseus looked at him from under his brows.

"That was ugly, sir, and you talk like a reckless man. The gods do not give every good thing to every man — not beauty and brains and eloquence together. There is a man whose looks are nothing much, and the god crowns his words with a shape, and people watch him with pleasure; he speaks steadily on, with a winning modesty, and he stands out in any gathering, and when he walks through the town men look at him as if he were a god. And there is another man who is as handsome as the immortals, and there is no grace in anything he says.

"You, for instance. You are outstanding to look at; a god could not improve you. And your mind is empty.

"You have stirred me up. I am not a beginner at games, whatever you say; I was among the best of them while I could still trust my youth and my hands. Now I am held down by hardship and pain, because I have got through a good deal of war and a good deal of heavy water. Even so — I will try. Your words bit me, and you have provoked me."

And he got up, still in his cloak, and picked up a discus: a big one, bigger and thicker and a great

his daughter Nausicaa has ships in her name as well. An entire nation of sailors is walking about with sailing for a surname, and a Greek audience got the joke instantly and for nothing — which is exactly the sort of pleasure that evaporates in translation. It is the kind of thing an English reader would meet if a village of blacksmiths turned out to be called Forge, Hammer, Smith, Anvil and Sparks.

deal heavier than the ones the Phaeacians had been throwing at each other. He swung it and let it go, and the stone hummed as it went; and the Phaeacians, the long-oared men, the famous sailors, ducked at the noise of it going over.

It went past every one of their marks. It flew light out of his hand.

And Athena, in the shape of a man, set the marker down where it fell and called out: "Even a blind man could find your mark, stranger, feeling for it — because it is not mixed in with the crowd of them at all. It is out in front, well out. Take heart about this event. There is not a Phaeacian here who will reach it, let alone pass it."

And Odysseus was delighted, because there was somebody in that crowd who was on his side; and being thoroughly wound up by now, he challenged the lot of them.

"Reach that, young men. And when you have, I shall throw another one as far or further. Anybody else who feels moved to it — since you have made me angry — come out. Boxing, wrestling, running, I do not care. Any Phaeacian you like, except Laodamas, because he is my host, and only a lunatic quarrels with the man who is feeding him.

"I am not bad with any of the usual weapons. I know how to handle a polished bow. I would be first to hit my man in a crowd of enemies, even with a lot of my own friends standing beside me shooting at the same target. There was only one man at Troy who beat me with a bow, and that was Philoctetes. Beyond him I say I am far the best of everyone alive now who eats bread on this earth — though I would not set myself against the men of former times, not against Heracles, and not against Eurytus of Oechalia, who used to shoot against the immortals themselves, which is why Eurytus did not live to be old; Apollo was angry with him and killed him, because he had challenged him to a shooting match.

"And I can throw a spear further than another man can shoot an arrow. It is only in the footrace that I am afraid one of you might beat me. I have been badly knocked about in a great deal of water, with no steady food on board, and my legs have gone."

Everybody went very quiet. And of all the things this man might have boasted about — he is an eloquent liar with twenty years of material — he chose the bow, which nobody had asked about and on which he was not going to be tested. It is the first time in eight books that a bow has been mentioned. I should keep it, if I were you.

Alcinous stepped in and smoothed the whole thing over, and did it beautifully.

"Stranger, nothing you have said is ungracious. You wanted to show what is in you, because you were angry, and because this man stood up in front of everybody and insulted you. No one who knew how to talk sense would find fault with your quality.

"But listen now, so that you can tell your own heroes about it later, when you are at dinner in your own house with your wife and children and you happen to think of us. We are not perfect boxers, and we are not wrestlers. But we run fast, and we are the best seamen there are. And we love our dinner, and the lyre, and dancing, and clean clothes, and hot baths, and bed.

"Come on then — the best dancers among the Phaeacians. Dance. So that the stranger can tell everyone at home how far we are ahead of the rest of the world at sailing and running and dancing and song. And somebody fetch Demodocus his clear-toned lyre."

He does not scold Euryalus in public, you notice; he accepts the visitor's anger as reasonable, changes the subject, and changes it to the thing his people are honestly best at — telling the truth about what they are not good at while he is about it. There is no shame in him at all.

So they cleared a dancing floor and widened the ring, and the boys who were best at it, in the first bloom of youth, struck up and beat out the holy dance with their feet; and Odysseus stood watching the twinkle of the feet, and was amazed.

And the singer struck the lyre and began a song, and it was a rude one.

He sang about Ares (god of war) and Aphrodite (goddess of love): how they first went to bed together in the house of Hephaestus (the lame smith of the gods, and her husband), secretly, and how Ares gave her a great many presents and disgraced the marriage bed.

And the Sun, who sees everything, saw them, and went and told him.

And when Hephaestus heard the story that goes to the heart, he went off to his forge with murder in his mind and put the great anvil on the block, and hammered out chains that could not be broken and could not be got out of, so that the two of them would stay exactly where they were put. And when the trap was made he went to the bedroom where his own bed stood and threw the chains all round the bedposts in a circle, and hung a great many more of them down from the roof beam, fine as spider silk, so fine that not one of the blessed gods could see them. It was very cunning work. And when he had got the whole thing round the bed he pretended to leave for Lemnos, which was his favourite place in the world.

Ares was not keeping a blind watch. He saw the great craftsman go, and came to the house wanting Aphrodite, and found her just back from her father's, and took her hand. "Come to bed, love. Hephaestus is not at home; he has gone off to Lemnos."

And she thought it was a very good idea.

So the two of them went to bed and lay down — and the chains came down round them, and they could not move a limb or lift anything, and then they understood that there was no getting out of it.

And back came the great lame god, having turned round before he ever reached Lemnos, because the Sun had been keeping watch for him. He stood in the doorway of his own house with a savage rage on him and gave a dreadful shout, and called out to all the gods:

"Father Zeus, and the rest of you blessed immortals — come here and look at this. It is a joke, and it is not to be borne. Because I am lame, Aphrodite is always insulting me, and she loves destructive Ares because he is handsome and sound in the legs, and I was born crooked. And nobody is to blame for that but my two parents, who should have thought twice.

"Come and see where those two are sleeping — in my bed — and how it hurts me to watch it. I do not think they will want to lie like that much longer, however much they are in love. But my trap and my chain will hold them until her father gives me back every one of the courtship gifts I paid over for that shameless girl. His daughter is beautiful, and she has no self-control."

And the gods came crowding to the house with the bronze floor. Poseidon (god of the sea) came, and Hermes the runner came, and lord Apollo who works from far off came. The goddesses stayed at home, every one of them, out of modesty.

And the gods stood in the doorway, and unquenchable laughter went up among the blessed gods when they saw the cleverness of it. And one would look at the man next to him and say: "Bad deeds do not prosper. The slow one catches the quick one. Look at Hephaestus — slow as he is, and lame — catching Ares, who is the fastest of all the gods on Olympus. And now he owes the fine for adultery."

And Apollo said to Hermes: "Would you be willing to sleep in bed beside golden Aphrodite, even held down by those heavy chains?"

And Hermes said: "I only wish it, lord Apollo. Let there be three times as many chains, and no way out of them, and let all of you gods look on, and all the goddesses too — I would still sleep beside

golden Aphrodite."

And the immortals roared with laughter.

Only Poseidon did not laugh. He kept asking Hephaestus to let Ares go, and in the end offered to stand surety and pay the fine himself if Ares defaulted; and Hephaestus said, well, if Ares runs off owing me, I shall be chaining *you* up instead — and released them. And the moment the chains were off the two of them jumped up and went: Ares straight to Thrace, and Aphrodite to Cyprus, to Paphos, where she has her sanctuary and her fragrant altar; and there the Graces bathed her and rubbed her with the immortal oil that shines on the gods who live forever, and dressed her in beautiful clothes, a wonder to look at.[43]

That was the singer's song, and Odysseus enjoyed it as much as anybody.

I hope you enjoyed it too, and I hope you also noticed what the Phaeacians did not, which is that they have just been told the plot. A wife; a husband who finds out; a lie about where he is going; a trap built in secret out of the one thing he is better at than anybody alive; and everybody caught in it at once, in the hall, with the whole household looking on. The only reason it is a comedy is that nobody in it can die. Take the immortality away and it is Agamemnon at his own homecoming dinner with twenty men behind the door — the same story exactly, and human beings stay dead. Which is why this poem can put its funniest scene in the middle of its saddest evening and not think itself frivolous.

Then Halius and Laodamas danced on their own, because nobody could match those two; and they took a beautiful purple ball, and one would lean back and throw it up towards the shadowy clouds and the other would spring off the ground and catch it easily before his feet came down. And when they had finished with throwing it straight up they began passing it back and forth, dancing all the while, and the other young men stood round the ring beating time, and a great noise of it went up.

"My lord," said Odysseus, "you said your dancers were the best. There it is, exactly as you said. I am astonished, looking at it."

Alcinous was very pleased, and turned to the Phaeacians. "The stranger seems to me a man of excellent sense. Let us give him a proper guest-gift. Twelve kings rule in this country as leaders, and I am the thirteenth. Let every one of us bring him a clean cloak and a tunic and a talent of gold, and let us bring it all together now, so that the stranger can go in to dinner with the gifts in his hands and a glad heart. And Euryalus is to make it up with him, in words and with a present, because what he said was not decent."

They all agreed, and Euryalus did it, and did it well. He gave him a bronze sword with a silver hilt and a scabbard of new-sawn ivory round it, worth a great deal. "Sir, and father — if anything was said here that was out of order, let the storm winds pick it up and carry it off. And may the gods let you see your wife, and get you home to your own country; you have been away from your friends far too long, and suffering."

"And to you, my friend — good luck, and may the gods give you a good life, and may you never miss this sword you have just given me, having made it right with words." And he slung it over his

[43] **The fine for adultery.** There is law in the joke, and the law is the point of the ending. Hephaestus does not want revenge; he wants to be paid. He demands that Aphrodite's father hand back the courtship gifts — the substantial property a suitor transferred to a bride's family to make a marriage — on the grounds that the goods were paid over for a wife who has not behaved like one. And Poseidon settles the matter by standing surety, like a man guaranteeing a neighbour's debt. That is not divine justice; it is property, and a bad debt, and every man listening had seen something of the kind settled in his own village. Which makes the joke sharper than it looks: the gods on Olympus are not living in some other moral universe. They are living in a Greek village with no funerals.

shoulder.

The sun went down, and the splendid gifts were carried up to the house, and Alcinous told Arete to bring out the best chest there was and put a fresh cloak and tunic in it herself; and he added a beautiful gold cup of his own, so that the stranger would remember him every time he poured a drink for the gods at home. And Arete told her women to set the great cauldron on the fire and heat a bath; and she packed the chest with the clothes and the gold, and said:

"Look at the lid yourself now, and tie it up quickly with a knot of your own — so that nobody robs you on the voyage, while you are lying asleep in the black ship."

And Odysseus heard her, and fitted the lid down at once, and put a cunning knot on it that lady Circe had taught him, long ago.

You have not met her yet. He does not explain. He simply ties the knot, and the poem tells you where he learned it and moves on — and there is a name sitting in the middle of that sentence which means nothing to anybody in the room and everything four books from now.

Then the housekeeper told him to get into the bath, and he was glad to see the warm water, because he had not been looked after like that since he left Calypso's house.

And when the women had bathed him and rubbed him with oil and put a fine cloak and tunic on him, he came out and went towards the men who were drinking their wine.

And Nausicaa was standing by the doorpost of the strong-built hall.

She looked at him, and she was amazed, and she said: "Goodbye, stranger. When you are back in your own country, remember me sometimes — because it is to me, first of anybody, that you owe your life."

"Nausicaa, daughter of great-hearted Alcinous — if Zeus grants that I get home and see my day of homecoming, then there, every day of my life, I will pray to you as to a god. Because you gave me my life, girl."

And he went and sat down beside the king.

That is the last we see of her. She does not weep, and she does not ask him to stay, and she asks for the smallest thing she could possibly have asked for, on the strongest grounds there are — which is that he would be dead in the reeds without her.

They were carving the meat and mixing the wine, and the herald came up leading Demodocus and set him down among them, propped against a tall pillar. And Odysseus cut a piece off the chine of a white-tusked boar, a rich piece with plenty of fat along both sides, and there was more left on it than he kept for himself; and he called the herald over.

"Give this to Demodocus, so that he can eat it; I want to say something civil to him, sorry as I am. Singers get honour and respect from every man on earth, because the Muse has taught them the paths of song and she loves the whole tribe of them."

And the herald carried it over and put it in the hands of the great man, and he took it and was glad. And when they had eaten, Odysseus said to him:

"Demodocus, I praise you above every mortal man. Either the Muse taught you or Apollo did, because you sing the fate of the Greeks so very rightly — everything they did and suffered and worked through — as if you had been there yourself, or heard it from a man who was.

"So change to another part of it now, and sing about the making of the wooden horse: the one

Epeius built with Athena's help, and which Odysseus got up into the citadel by a trick, filled with the men who sacked Troy. If you can tell me that part of it in the right order, I shall say to every man alive that a god was generous to you and gave you divine song."

He asked for it, you notice. Nobody made him. He has spent the whole day pulling a cloak over his head to get through this man's songs, and now he puts down his cup and asks, politely, by name, for the one that is entirely about him.

The singer began, and took it up from where the Greeks burned their huts and went aboard and sailed away, and the men with Odysseus were already sitting inside the horse in the Trojans' own meeting-place, because the Trojans had dragged it up there themselves. And it stood there while they sat round it arguing, and they could not decide, and there were three ways it might have gone: split the hollow wood open with the pitiless bronze; or drag it to the top of the rock and push it over; or leave it standing as a great offering to please the gods. And that was the way it was going to end, because it was laid down that they would be destroyed when their city closed round that great wooden horse with all the best of the Greeks inside it.

And he sang how the sons of the Greeks poured out of the horse and sacked the city; how they went through it, this way and that, wrecking the steep town; and how Odysseus went like Ares to the house of Deiphobus with Menelaus beside him, and dared the most terrible fight of all there, and won it through great-hearted Athena.

That is what the famous singer sang. And Odysseus melted, and the tears ran down his cheeks out of his eyes and wetted them.

And the way a woman cries, falling on the body of her own husband, who has gone down in front of his city and his people trying to hold the day of destruction away from his town and his children; and she sees him dying, gasping for breath, and winds herself round him and shrieks aloud; and behind her men are hitting her back and her shoulders with the butts of their spears, driving her off into slavery, to have hard work and misery, and her cheeks waste with the most pitiful grief —

that is how Odysseus cried, and the tears were pitiful under his eyelids.

The poem has just compared him to a woman being dragged away from her husband's body on the night her city fell, and there are women in exactly that position, at Troy, on that specific night, because of the wooden horse. Which he built; and which he has just asked, by name, to hear a song about; and which he is weeping at.

I have read a good many attempts to soften that and I do not believe any of them. It has been coming since Book Three, when Nestor mentioned in passing that Athena turned against her own side over what the Greeks did in that city; the whole homeward voyage is the invoice. And here, at the moment of maximum self-pity, the poem reaches out without a word of comment and hands him the grief of the people he did it to. It does not say he deserves it. It says: this is what that felt like, and now it is what you feel like. And then it goes straight back to the story.

Nobody noticed him crying except Alcinous, who was sitting next to him and could hear him. And Alcinous stopped the music.

"Let Demodocus put the lyre down. Not everybody here is enjoying this. Ever since we sat down to dinner and the singer started, our guest has not once stopped grieving; some very heavy sorrow has got into him. Let the singer stop, so that all of us can enjoy ourselves together, hosts and guest alike. Everything we are doing is being done for our honoured visitor: the escort, the gifts, the friendship.

Any man with the least sense treats a stranger and a suppliant like a brother.

"So do not go on hiding what I am about to ask you behind some clever evasion. Tell me the name they call you at home — your mother and your father, and the people in your town. Nobody in the world is nameless, good or bad; parents give a name to everyone once they are born.

"And tell me your country and your people and your city, so that the ships can carry you there by thinking about it. Because our ships have no steersmen and no steering oars, the way other ships do. They understand by themselves what men are thinking and what they want; they know every city and every rich field there is, and they cross the open water at enormous speed, wrapped in mist and cloud, and there is never the least fear of damage or of going down.

"Though I did hear my father Nausithous say, once, that Poseidon was angry with us for giving everybody safe passage home. He said that one day a well-built Phaeacian ship, coming back from an escort, would be smashed on the misty sea, and a great mountain would be set down over our city. That is what the old man said. The god may bring it about, or leave it undone, whichever pleases him.[44]

"But come — where have you been driven to? What countries did you reach, what people? Were they cruel and wild, with no sense of right, or did they take strangers in, and have they god-fearing minds?

"And tell me why you cry. Why does your heart go, inside you, when you hear about the fate of the Greeks and of Troy? The gods made that. They spun destruction for those men, so that there would be a song in it for people who have not been born yet.

"Did some relation of yours die in front of Troy? A good man — a son-in-law, or a father-in-law? They are the nearest to us after our own blood. Or was it a companion? A man who understood you? Because a companion with an understanding mind is no worse a thing than a brother."

NOTES TO BOOK EIGHT

Book Nine: In Which the Stranger Gives His Name at Last, and Tells About a Cave.

[44]**The prophecy hanging over the Phaeacians.** Alcinous mentions it in passing, in the middle of a boast, and then shrugs — the god may do it or not. It is worth pinning down, because it is the one dark thing in this bright country and it is stated plainly. These people ferry everybody home; it is their national vocation, and their pride, and the reason the gods sit down to dinner with them. And Poseidon resents it, being the god who keeps men *from* getting home, and there is an old warning in the family that the price will eventually be a wrecked ship and a mountain dropped on the harbour. Hold on to it. The poem has not raised it for atmosphere.

Book 09

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK NINE

In Which the Stranger Gives His Name at Last, and Tells About a Cave

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Before he answers, I am going to get out of the way, because for the next four books the story is not mine to tell.

He is about to say his own name aloud for the first time in this poem, and then he is going to keep talking until the end of Book Twelve — the giant, the witch, the singers on the rock, the country of the dead, all of it. It is the most famous stretch of storytelling in Europe, and almost none of it happens where people think it does. It happens in a dining hall on Scheria, after supper, in the mouth of a shipwrecked man describing himself to a king whose ships he needs. There are no witnesses left; every man who sailed with him is dead. His audience are a people who packed up and emigrated because they could not go on living next to the Cyclopes. And there is a ship in the harbour outside that has not sailed yet.

So when the prose says *I* from here on, it is Odysseus and not me. Where a line breaks across the page like the one below, that will be me coming back for a moment, and then going away again.

Lord Alcinous, most distinguished of all your people — it is a fine thing to listen to a singer like this one, with a voice like a god's. I do not think there is any better end than this: good cheer through a whole people, and men sitting in rows down a hall listening to a singer, and the tables beside them full of bread and meat, and a steward drawing wine out of the bowl and carrying it round and filling the cups. That seems to me about the most beautiful thing there is.

But your heart has turned to asking me about my miseries, so that I shall cry even harder than I have been. What shall I tell you first, then? What last? The gods have given me a great many.

My name first, so that you know it, and so that if I get out from under the day of my death I shall be your guest-friend afterwards, even though I live a long way off.

I am Odysseus, the son of Laertes. Men know me for every kind of trick, and my fame has gone up to the sky.[45]

I live in Ithaca, where you can see for miles. There is a mountain on it, Neriton, with the leaves shaking on it, and it stands out. There are islands round about, close in to each other — Dulichium, and Same, and wooded Zacynthus. Mine lies low, and furthest out in the sea towards the dark; the

[45]**The name he finally gives.** Greek names carried their meanings on the surface, the way English surnames do — Baker, Smith, Fletcher — and everybody heard them. This one is built on a verb meaning to hate, to be furious with, to cause pain, and it runs in both directions at once: the man who is hated, and the man who deals out trouble. The Man of Wrath, roughly, or the Man Others Have It In For. It is not a compliment and was never meant as one, and there is a story about how he came by it which the poem is keeping until much later. — Which makes his self-introduction worth reading twice. He gives his name, and his father's, and then in the same breath tells a room full of strangers how famous it is. Eight books of anonymity, and the first thing he does with the name is polish it.

others lie away towards the dawn and the sun. It is rough country, but it raises good young men, and I have never seen anything sweeter than a man's own land.

Calypso kept me in her hollow cave, a goddess, and she wanted me for her husband. Circe kept me in her house on Aeaea, and she wanted the same. Neither of them ever persuaded my heart. There is nothing sweeter than your own country and your own parents — not if you live in a rich house somewhere else, in a foreign country, away from them.

Very well. I shall tell you about the miserable voyage home that Zeus gave me out of Troy.

The wind carried me from Troy to the Cicones, at Ismarus. I sacked the town and killed the men. We took their wives out of it, and a great deal of property, and divided it up so that nobody went short of a fair share.

Then I told my men to run for it, quickly. The fools would not listen. There was a great deal of wine drunk, and they slaughtered a great many sheep on the beach, and cattle with their shambling walk and their bent horns.

And meanwhile the Cicones went and called the other Cicones, their neighbours inland, who were more numerous and better men, and knew how to fight from a chariot and on foot as well. They came at first light, as thick as the leaves and the flowers come in spring, and a bad fate from Zeus stood beside us, and we suffered a great deal. They set the battle up beside the ships and we threw our bronze spears at each other; and all morning, while the sacred day was still growing, we held them off, though there were more of them. But when the sun moved round to the hour when a man unyokes his oxen, then the Cicones broke us, and the Greeks gave way.

Six armed men off each ship were killed. The rest of us got away, and got out from under our death.

That is the first adventure, and it is the one most people have never heard of, and I should not like you to go past it. Before there is a single monster in this poem the hero stops at a town on the way home from a war that is already over and takes it — and says so himself, in his opening sentence, with no provocation offered and none expected. *We took their wives out of it and divided them up so that nobody went short.* One book ago the poem compared this man, at length and with no comment whatever, to a woman being beaten away from her husband's body and driven off into slavery. Here is the same sentence from the other side, in his own mouth, at dinner, as background. He is not confessing. It has not occurred to him that there is anything to confess, and that is precisely why it is worth a moment of your time.

The other thing in it is the shape of the disaster, which you will meet again: he told them to go, and they would not, and it cost seventy-two men. Remember the form of words, because he is scrupulous about it, and there is a place further on where he cannot use it.

Zeus who gathers the clouds set the North Wind on us, an enormous storm, and covered the land and the sea alike with cloud, and night came rushing down out of the sky. The ships were driven sideways, and the sails torn into three and four pieces by the force of it. We got them down and rowed hard for the shore, and lay there two nights and two days, eating our hearts out with exhaustion and pain.

On the third morning we stepped the masts and hoisted the white sails and sat still, and the wind and the steersmen kept us straight; and I would have got home to my own country without a scratch. But as I was rounding Cape Malea the swell and the current and the North Wind pushed me off and

drove me past Cythera.

For nine days after that I was carried over the fish-filled sea by ruinous winds. On the tenth we came ashore in the country of the Lotus-eaters, who eat a flowering food. We went ashore and drew water, and my men had a meal beside the fast ships; and when we had had food and drink I sent some of them off to find out what sort of men lived there and ate the bread of that country — two, and a third as a herald with them.

They went, and fell in with the Lotus-eaters. And the Lotus-eaters did not plan any harm to my men at all. They gave them lotus to taste.

And whoever ate that honey-sweet fruit no longer wanted to bring back a report, or to come back at all. They wanted to stay there among the Lotus-eaters, chewing the lotus, and forget the way home.

I brought them back to the ships crying, and I had to use force. I dragged them under the benches and tied them up, and told the rest of my trusty companions to get aboard the fast ships in a hurry, in case one of them ate the lotus and forgot about going home. They went aboard at once and sat down at the oars and struck the grey water with the blades.

From there we sailed on with our hearts full of trouble, and came to the country of the Cyclopes — a violent and lawless people.

They put nothing in with their own hands and they plough nothing. They trust the gods for it, and everything comes up for them unsown and unploughed: wheat, and barley, and vines with great heavy clusters that make wine, and the rain of Zeus swells it all. They have no assemblies for making decisions, and no laws. They live on the tops of the high mountains in hollow caves, and each one lays down the rules for his own wives and children, and none of them takes any notice of the others.[46]

There is a wooded island lying across the mouth of their harbour — neither close in nor far out — and it is full of wild goats without number, because no human foot disturbs them there. No hunters go through it, the sort who wear themselves out in the woods going over the tops of the mountains. It is not grazed by flocks and it is not ploughed; it goes unsown and unbroken all its days, empty of men, and it feeds bleating goats.

Because the Cyclopes have no ships with painted cheeks, and there are no shipwrights among them who might build them well-benched vessels to get things done — going across to other men's towns, the way people constantly do go over the sea to one another. Men like that would have made this island a good place to live in.

It is not a bad island at all. It would bear anything in season. There are soft watered meadows along the shore of the grey sea; vines would never fail there; the ploughing is level; they could cut a deep crop off it every summer, because the soil underneath is rich. And there is a harbour where you need no moorings — no anchor stones, no stern cables. You run in and lie there as long as your sailors feel like it and until the wind gets up. And at the head of the harbour bright water runs out from under a cave, and poplars grow round it.

[46] **What "lawless" means here.** The Greek word is *themis* and its plural: not statutes, but the settled customs by which decisions get made and quarrels judged — what is done, what is not done, and who says so. The Cyclopes have none, and it is worth setting out the poem's indictment in full, because it amounts to a definition of civilisation by its absence: no assemblies where matters are decided in common; no customary law; no agriculture; no ships; no shipwrights; no traffic with other communities; and each male laying down the law inside his own cave and taking no interest whatever in anyone else's. — Notice what is *not* on that list. Nobody says they are stupid, and nobody says they eat people; Polyphemus turns out to eat people, but that is his own contribution, and the charge against his whole nation is that they do not farm, do not sail, and do not hold meetings. To this poem a household that answers to nobody is not free. It is the definition of a monster.

That is where we sailed in. Some god guided us through a black night; there was nothing to see. The fog lay thick round the ships and the moon did not show in the sky, but was shut up in cloud. Not one of us saw that island with his eyes, and we never saw the long waves rolling in to the beach either, until we had run the ships aground. We took down the sails and went out onto the shore of the sea, and slept there, and waited for the bright morning.

That, if you will forgive me for pointing at it, is a colonist talking. Water supply, anchorage, soil, level ploughing, two crops off it and vines that would never fail; and nobody living there, and the people across the water with no ships to do anything about it. Read his description of the Cyclopes again and it turns out to be the same passage: no hulls, no shipwrights, no assemblies, no laws, no farming, and every household answering to nobody. That is a checklist, and every item on it is something he has. This poem was made in a century when Greeks were pouring out across the Mediterranean in exactly such ships, looking at exactly such coasts, and finding people on them who did not farm as Greeks farmed — and were therefore not, in the settlers' judgement, really using the place. I shall not tell you what to make of it. I only say that when a man in a story remarks that the natives are savages who have never made anything of a fine piece of land, you are hearing a very old sentence, and it is worth hearing it as one.

When the dawn came up we walked round the island and admired it, and the nymphs put the mountain goats up for us so that my men could eat. We got our curved bows out of the ships, and our long boar-spears, and split into three parties and started shooting, and the god gave us a satisfying bag: twelve ships were with me, and nine goats fell to each of them, and for me alone they cut out ten.

So all day until sunset we sat and feasted on meat past counting and sweet wine. The red wine had not run out yet; there was still plenty, because we had all drawn off a great deal in jars when we took the sacred citadel of the Cicones. And we looked across at the country of the Cyclopes, which was very close, and saw smoke, and heard voices, and the noise of sheep and goats. And when the sun went down and the darkness came, we lay down to sleep on the beach.

In the morning I called my men together. "The rest of you stay here, my trusty companions. I am going over with my own ship and my own crew to find out about these people — whether they are violent and wild and unjust, or whether they take strangers in, and have god-fearing minds."

We rowed across, and it was not far, and right at the edge of the land we saw a cave, high up, with laurels round the mouth of it. A great many flocks were penned there for the night, sheep and goats, and round it there was a yard built high with quarried stone and tall pines and oaks with their high crowns. A giant of a man slept in there. He pastured his flocks alone, and a long way off, and he did not go near anybody else; he kept apart, and his mind was lawless. He was a monstrous piece of work — not like a man who eats bread, but like a wooded peak standing up by itself in a range of high mountains, away from the others.

I told the rest of my companions to stay and guard the ship, and I picked out the twelve best of them and went. And I took a goatskin of dark sweet wine with me, which Maron had given me — the son of Euanthes, the priest of Apollo (god of prophecy, and of the bow) who protects Ismarus — because we had protected him and his wife and his child, out of respect, since he lived in the wooded grove of Apollo. He gave me splendid presents: seven talents of well-worked gold, and a mixing bowl of solid silver, and then wine, twelve jars of it, all of it neat, a drink for gods. Not one of the servants in his house knew about that wine, and not one of the maids — only himself and his wife and one

housekeeper. And whenever they drank it he would pour one cup of it into twenty measures of water, and a smell would come up off the bowl that was sweet past describing; and it was not a time when anybody wanted to hold back.[47]

I filled a big skin with that and took it, and food in a bag as well. Because straight away, in my proud heart, I had a feeling that a man was going to come at us — a great brute, clothed in enormous strength, who knew nothing about justice or law.

We got to the cave quickly, and he was not in it; he was out pasturing his fat flocks. So we went in and looked round at everything. There were crates loaded with cheeses, and the pens were crowded with lambs and kids, each lot penned separately: the spring ones in one place, the summer ones in another, and the newborn in a third. And there were vessels swimming with whey, pails and bowls, all well made, and he did his milking into them.

And straight away my men started begging me to take some of the cheeses and go — to come back and drive the kids and the lambs out of the pens to the fast ship and sail off over the salt water.

And I would not listen to them. It would have been very much better if I had. But I wanted to see him, and I wanted to see whether he would give me guest-gifts.

He was not going to turn out delightful to my companions when he appeared.

So we lit a fire and made an offering, and helped ourselves to the cheeses and ate, and sat in the cave waiting until he came back with his flock. He came carrying an enormous weight of dry wood to burn at his supper, and threw it down inside the cave with a crash; and we bolted in terror to the deepest corner of it. He drove his fat flocks into the wide cave — all the ones he milked; the males, the rams and the he-goats, he left outside in the deep yard. Then he lifted a great doorstone and set it in place. It was huge. Two and twenty good four-wheeled wagons could not have shifted it off the ground. That was the size of the rock he put in his doorway.

Then he sat down and milked the ewes and the bleating goats, all of it in order, and put the young under each one. And half the white milk he curdled and gathered up and stored in wicker baskets; and the other half he stood in vessels, so that he could take it and drink it at his supper.

And when he had got through all his work, he lit his fire — and saw us.

"Strangers, who are you? Where do you sail from over the watery ways? Are you here on business, or do you wander about at random, like pirates, who wander about risking their own lives and bringing trouble to other people?"

Our hearts broke in us at that: we were terrified by the deep voice of him and by the size of him. But even so I answered him.

"We are Greeks. We are coming from Troy, and all sorts of winds over the great gulf of the sea have driven us off course — making for home, we came another way, by another road. That is how Zeus wanted it, I suppose. We say we are men of Agamemnon's army, whose fame is the greatest under heaven just now, so great a city did he sack and so many people did he destroy.

"And we have come to your knees, hoping you will give us a guest's welcome, or make us some

[47] **Maron's wine, and how the Greeks drank.** One cup to twenty of water, and still so strong that nobody could stop — an extreme ratio, quoted precisely to tell you this is no ordinary wine; the ordinary run was something nearer one to three or four. But the important thing for a modern reader is the practice itself. Greeks watered their wine as a matter of course, always, and the mixing bowl standing in the middle of every hall in this poem is there for exactly that purpose. Drinking it neat was what foreigners did, and barbarians, and men who came to a bad end. So when the Cyclops takes the bowl three times and swallows it undiluted, a Greek audience did not need to be told he was making a mistake; they had just watched him do something no civilised person at that dinner would have done.

other present, which is the right of strangers. Respect the gods, sir. We are your suppliants. Zeus is the avenger of suppliants and strangers — Zeus of the Strangers, who walks in beside honourable travellers."

And he answered me straight out of a pitiless heart.

"You are a fool, stranger, or you have come a very long way, telling me to be afraid of the gods and keep clear of them. The Cyclopes do not care about Zeus who holds the storm cloud, or about any of the blessed gods, because we are a great deal stronger than they are. I would not spare you or your companions to avoid making an enemy of Zeus. Not unless my own heart told me to.

"But tell me — where did you leave your ship when you came? Somewhere far along the coast, or close by? I should like to know."

He was testing me. He did not get anywhere; I know too much. And I answered him with a crooked answer. "Poseidon (god of the sea) smashed my ship. He drove it against the rocks at the edge of your country and brought it up against a headland, and the wind carried it in off the sea. I got out from under a sheer destruction, with these men here."

He did not answer me a word. He sprang up and put his hands on my companions, and grabbed two of them together and knocked them against the ground like puppies, and their brains ran out and wetted the earth. He cut them up limb from limb and made his supper of them. He ate like a lion bred in the mountains, and left nothing: the guts, the flesh, the bones with the marrow in them.

We cried, and lifted our hands up to Zeus, watching this appalling thing done, and there was nothing we could do; helplessness held our hearts.

And when the Cyclops had filled his enormous belly with human meat and milk drunk neat on top of it, he lay down inside the cave, stretched out among his sheep. And I made a plan in my great heart to go up close to him and draw my sharp sword off my thigh and stab him in the chest, where the midriff holds the liver, feeling for the place with my hand. And another thought held me back. We would have died there too, and died on the spot, because there was no way our hands could have pushed that enormous stone off the high doorway.

So we waited, groaning, for the bright morning.

When Dawn came up he lit his fire and milked his fine flocks, all of it in order, and put the young under each one; and when he had got through all his work he grabbed two more of my men and made his meal. And when he had eaten he drove his fat flocks out of the cave, lifting the great doorstone easily — and then he put it back, the way a man puts the lid back on a quiver. And with a great deal of whistling he turned his flocks up towards the mountain, and left me there, working out how to do him harm.

And this is the plan that seemed best to my heart.

There was a great club of the Cyclops's lying beside a pen: green olive wood, which he had cut so that he could carry it when it had dried out. Looking at it, we thought it about the size of the mast of a black ship, a twenty-oared merchantman, broad in the beam, that crosses the great gulf of the sea. That was its length, and that was its thickness. I stood over it and cut a fathom's length off it and handed it to my companions and told them to smooth it down. They made it even, and I stood over it and sharpened the end, and then took it and hardened it in the blazing fire. And I hid it carefully under the dung, of which there was a great deal spread about the cave.

And I told the others to draw lots, to see which of them would have to take the risk with me — to lift that stake and grind it into his eye when sweet sleep came over him. And the lot fell on the four I

would have picked myself, and I counted as the fifth with them.

He came back in the evening with his fine-fleeced flock, and this time he drove all of them into the wide cave and left nothing in the deep yard outside. Either he had begun to suspect something, or a god told him to. Then he lifted the great doorstone and set it in place, and sat down and milked, all of it in order, and put the young under each one. And when he had got through all his work he grabbed two more men and made his supper.

And then I stood close to him with an ivy-wood bowl of the dark wine in my hands.

"Cyclops — here. Have some wine, now you have eaten human meat, so that you know what sort of drink our ship was carrying. I was bringing it to you as an offering, in case you might pity me and send me home. But you are past all bearing. You cruel thing — how is any man in the world ever going to come to you after this? You have not behaved rightly."

He took it and drank it, and he was terribly pleased with the sweet drink, and asked for another. "Give me more, generously, and tell me your name — now, at once — so that I can give you a guest-gift, one you will be glad to have. The grain-giving earth grows wine of great clusters for the Cyclopes too, and the rain of Zeus swells it. But this is a runnel of ambrosia and nectar."

So I handed him the flaming wine again. Three times I brought it and gave it to him, and three times he drank it down, the fool. And when the wine had got round the Cyclops's wits, I spoke to him with honeyed words.

"Cyclops, you asked me my famous name. I shall tell you. And you give me the guest-gift you promised me.

"Nobody is my name. Nobody is what they call me — my mother, and my father, and all my companions."

And he answered me out of a pitiless heart. "Nobody I shall eat last, after all his companions. The others first. That is your guest-gift."[48]

He went over backwards and lay with his thick neck bent to one side, and sleep that beats everything took hold of him; and the wine came up out of his throat with gobbets of human flesh in it, and he vomited in his drunken sleep.

And I drove the stake in under the deep ashes until it should get hot, and talked to all my men and put heart into them, so that nobody would lose his nerve and back out. And when the olive stake was on the point of catching fire, green as it was, and was glowing terribly, I brought it up out of the fire; and my companions stood round me, and some god breathed a great courage into us.

They took the olive stake, sharp at the end, and drove it into his eye. And I leaned on it from above and spun it.

The way a man bores a ship's timber with an auger, and the men below him keep it turning with a

[48] **"Nobody."** The most famous pun in European literature, and it does not survive the crossing into English, so here is what is actually happening. The name he gives is *Outis*, which is simply the Greek for "no one" — which is why the neighbours outside the cave go away again: they ask whether somebody is killing him, he shouts back the word for nobody, and they take it as an answer rather than as a name. That much comes across in translation. — What does not come across is the second turn of the screw. When those neighbours frame their question, the Greek idiom requires a different form of the negative, and the phrase that comes out — *mē tis*, "if nobody" — is indistinguishable in sound from *mētis*, the ordinary word for cunning, the practical intelligence that finds a way out. It is Odysseus's own defining quality, and the poem uses it of him constantly. So the Cyclopes stand outside the cave and unknowingly announce the exact truth: *cunning is killing you*. And a few lines later Odysseus tells us his heart laughed at how his name and his faultless scheme had taken them in — using, of course, the same word. It is a triple joke, set up and paid off across forty lines, and airtight in Greek. I can explain it to you. Nobody can translate it.

strap, holding the two ends, and it runs round and round and does not stop: that is how we held the fire-pointed stake in his eye and spun it, and the blood ran out round the hot thing. The flame singed his eyelids and his brow all round as the eyeball burned, and the roots of it crackled in the fire.

The way a smith plunges a great axe or an adze into cold water to temper it, and it screams aloud — because that is what gives iron its strength — so his eye hissed round the olive stake.

He screamed horribly and the rock rang with it, and we bolted away in terror. And he pulled the stake out of his eye, thick with blood, and threw it away from him, raving; and he shouted aloud to the Cyclopes who lived round about in caves on the windy heights.

They heard him and came from all directions and stood round the cave and asked him what was the matter. "What is wrong with you, Polyphemus? Why are you shouting like this through the immortal night and keeping us all awake? No mortal man is driving your flocks off against your will, surely? Nobody is killing you, surely, by force or by trickery?"

And out of the cave the mighty Polyphemus answered them: "My friends — Nobody is killing me. By trickery. Not by force."

And they answered him with words that went straight out of them and away. "Well, if nobody is doing you violence, and you are on your own, there is no escaping a sickness that comes from great Zeus. Say a prayer to your father, the lord Poseidon."

And off they went. And my own heart laughed inside me, that my name and my faultless scheme had taken them all in.

The Cyclops, groaning and in agony, felt about with his hands and took the stone away from the doorway, and sat down in the entrance himself with his arms spread wide, to catch anybody who tried to go out among the sheep. That is evidently how much of a fool he thought I was.

And I was planning how it might turn out best — how I might find some way out of death for my companions and for myself. I wove every kind of trick and scheme, as a man does when his life is at stake, because a great evil was very near.

And this is the plan that seemed best. There were rams there, well fed, thick in the fleece, big handsome animals with wool as dark as violets. I bound these together, silently, with the twisted withies the monster used to sleep on: three at a time, and the middle one of each three carried a man, and the two on the outside walked alongside and covered him. Three sheep to each man. And for myself there was a ram, far the best of the whole flock. I got hold of him by the back and curled myself up under his shaggy belly and lay there, and gripped that marvellous fleece with my hands, twisted into it, and held on with a steady heart.

And so, groaning, we waited for the bright morning.

When Dawn came up the males rushed out to pasture, and the females bleated round the pens unmilked, because their udders were bursting. And their master, worn out with the pain of it, felt along the backs of all the sheep as they stood up in front of him — and never noticed, the fool, that my men were tied underneath the chests of the woolly animals.

The last of the whole flock to go out was the ram, weighed down with his own fleece and with me, and I was thinking hard. And the mighty Polyphemus felt him and said:

"Ram, my old friend. Why are you going out of the cave last of the flock, like this? You have never before been left behind by the sheep. You were always far the first to graze the tender bloom of the grass, striding out; the first to reach the running rivers; and the first to want to come home to the fold in the evening. And now you are the last of them all.

"You must be grieving for your master's eye. A bad man blinded it, with his wretched companions, after breaking my wits down with wine. Nobody. And I do not say he has got out from under his death yet.

"If only you could feel with me, and had speech, and could tell me where he is dodging about away from my anger. Then his brains would be knocked out all over the floor of this cave, and my heart would get some relief from the trouble that worthless Nobody has brought on me."

And he let the ram go out through the door.

And when we had got a little way from the cave and the yard, I got out from under the ram first, and then untied my companions. And quickly, keeping turning to look behind us, we drove those long-striding animals, rich with fat, down to the ship. And our companions were very glad to see us, the men who had got away from death — and they started to cry for the others. But I would not let them cry. I stopped each man with my eyebrows, and told them to throw all that fine-fleeced stock aboard at speed and sail out on the salt water. They went aboard at once and sat down at the oars and struck the grey water with the blades.

And when I was as far off as a man's shout will carry, I called back to the Cyclops, jeering at him.

"Cyclops. So it was not some weakling's companions you were going to eat by main force in your hollow cave. Your own foul deeds were bound to come down on your own head, you brute — you did not shrink from eating guests in your own house. So Zeus has paid you, and the other gods with him."

That made him angrier still. He broke the top off a great hill and threw it, and it landed in front of the dark-prowed ship, and the sea heaved up under the stone, and the backwash off the deep water carried the ship in and drove it towards the land. I got hold of a long pole and shoved us off, and gave my men the nod to throw themselves on the oars; and they bent to it and rowed.

And when we were twice as far out as before, I started calling to the Cyclops again — and my men were all round me trying to stop me, one after another, with soft words. "You reckless man. Why do you want to provoke a wild creature like that? He threw something into the sea just now that drove the ship back to land, and we thought we were finished. If he hears one of us make a sound, he will smash our heads and the ship's timbers together with a jagged lump of rock, that is how far he throws."

They said that, and they did not persuade my great heart. I called out to him again with my anger up.

"Cyclops. If any mortal man ever asks you about the shameful blinding of your eye, tell him this: that Odysseus blinded it, the sacker of cities, the son of Laertes, whose home is in Ithaca."

That is the most expensive sentence anybody speaks in this poem.

Everything up to it has been faultless. The false name worked so well that the neighbours went home; the men came out under the bellies of the sheep; he is at sea, out of reach, with the wine and the cheeses and the flocks aboard, having beaten something forty times his size by pure invention and lost nobody in the escape. And then he turns round and hands the creature his name, his father's name and his address, with his own crew hanging off his arms begging him not to.

He is never stupid, and he is not being stupid here. He is doing something the Greeks understood far better than we do and had no word of reproach for: he is claiming the deed, because a story with nobody's name on it is not a story, and because a man who has spent his life being famous cannot bear to have been Nobody at the one moment it counted. In the older poem men die on purpose to

have their names said afterwards; that is the whole economy of the thing, and every person in that Phaeacian hall grew up inside it. This poem, being the sequel, shows you the bill. He is ten years from home, and every man on those twelve ships is going to die, and it begins here, with a shout across the water that nobody asked him to make — and he tells the story himself, at dinner, to a king, and does not leave the bit out.

He groaned, and answered.

"So the old prophecies have come home. There was a prophet here, a good man and a tall one, Telemus the son of Eurymus, who was outstanding at prophecy and grew old among the Cyclopes as their prophet. He told me all of this would happen in time — that I would lose my sight at the hands of Odysseus.

"But I was always expecting a big handsome man to turn up here, with enormous strength in him. And now a little one, a nothing, a weakling, has put my eye out, after knocking me down with wine.

"Come here, Odysseus, and let me give you guest-gifts, and let me urge the famous Earthshaker (Poseidon) to send you on your way. I am his son, and he says he is my father. And he will cure me, if he chooses to, and nobody else will — none of the blessed gods and no mortal man."

"I only wish I could take the life and the soul out of you as surely as I know the Earthshaker will never cure that eye."

And then he prayed to the lord Poseidon, stretching his hands up towards the starry sky.

"Hear me, Poseidon, holder of the earth, with the dark hair. If I am really yours, and you say you are my father, then grant that Odysseus, the sacker of cities, the son of Laertes, whose home is in Ithaca, may never reach his home.

"And if it is laid down that he is to see his own people and come to his well-built house and his own country — then let him come late, and in a bad way, having lost all his companions, in someone else's ship. And let him find trouble in his house."

That was his prayer, and the god with the dark hair heard him.[49]

And then the Cyclops picked up a much bigger stone and swung it and threw it with immeasurable force, and it fell just behind the dark-prowed ship, and only just missed the end of the steering oar. The sea heaved up under the stone, and the wave carried the ship forward and drove it on to the far shore.

We came back to the island where the rest of the ships were lying together, and our companions were sitting round them crying, waiting for us and expecting the worst. We ran her ashore and stepped out onto the beach, and got the Cyclops's flocks out of the hollow ship, and divided them up so that nobody went short of a fair share. But the ram — my well-greaved companions gave that to me alone, over and above the division, when the flocks were shared out.

And I sacrificed it on the beach to Zeus of the dark clouds, the son of Cronos, who rules over everybody, and burned the thigh pieces.

And he took no notice at all of my sacrifice. He was thinking about how every one of my well-

[49] **The curse, which is also the synopsis.** Count the terms of that prayer. Let him not get home at all — and if he must, then let him come *late*; let him come *in a bad way*; let him have *lost every one of his companions*; let him arrive *in a ship belonging to somebody else*; and let him *find trouble in his house*. Every one of those comes true exactly, including the ship, which is at this moment tied up in the harbour outside the hall where he is telling the story. The whole remaining shape of the poem sits in a blind man's prayer on a beach, and the man it was aimed at is reciting it aloud, from memory, to the people whose ship will fulfil the fourth clause. This is characteristic: the poem tells you what is going to happen with striking regularity, and it costs nothing, because knowing the destination has never yet spoiled the road.

benched ships and every one of my trusty companions might be destroyed.

So all that day until sunset we sat and feasted on meat past counting and sweet wine. And when the sun went down and the darkness came, we lay down and slept on the shore of the sea. And when the rosy-fingered Dawn came up I roused my companions and told them to get aboard and cast off the cables. They went aboard at once and sat down at the oars and struck the grey water with the blades.

And from there we sailed on, glad to be out from under our death, and grieving in our hearts for the dear companions we had lost.

NOTES TO BOOK NINE

Book Ten: In Which There Is a Bag of Wind, a Good Deal of Bad Luck with Doors, and a Woman with a Wand.

Book 10

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK TEN

In Which There Is a Bag of Wind, a Good Deal of Bad Luck with Doors, and a Woman with a Wand

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We are still in the hall on Scheria, after supper, and the cups are still going round. Twelve ships came out of Troy under his command, and one of them has been emptied in a cave. In this book he loses the other eleven, and I mention it now because the poem is not going to give you time to notice.

We came to the island of Aeolia, where Aeolus lives, the son of Hippotas, whom the immortal gods love. It is a floating island, and there is a wall of unbreakable bronze running all the way round it, and the rock goes up sheer.

He has twelve children in his palace: six daughters and six sons in the prime of their youth. And he gave the daughters to the sons as their wives. They eat, always, beside their own father and their good mother, with an endless supply of good things in front of them; and by day the house is full of the smell of cooking and echoes with the sound of the flutes in the courtyard; and at night they sleep beside their honourable wives on blankets and corded bedsteads.[50]

We came to their city and their fine house, and he gave me a month of hospitality and asked me about everything — about Troy, and the ships of the Greeks, and the way the Greeks came home. And I told him the whole of it, in the right order.

And when I asked him for my road, he did not refuse me anything, and he got the escort ready. He gave me a bag made out of the hide of a nine-year-old ox, flayed whole, and in it he had tied up the courses of all the boisterous winds — because Zeus had made him the steward of the winds, to stop any of them or start any of them, whichever he liked. And he lashed the bag down in the hollow ship with a shining silver cord, so that not the smallest breath could get out of it. And then he sent me the West Wind to blow, to carry the ships and the men along.

He was not going to bring it off. We were destroyed by our own stupidity.

Nine days we sailed, night and day alike. And on the tenth our own fields came up over the water — and we were near enough to see men tending their fires.

And then sweet sleep came over me, because I was exhausted. I had been handling the sheet myself

[50] **The house of Aeolus.** Six sons, six daughters, and the daughters married to the brothers — stated in one line, with no comment, as part of a description of a happy and well-run household. It is worth stopping on, because the poem plainly does not intend it as horror. Aeolus is a favourite of the gods, generous, hospitable and helpful, and his home is the most perfectly self-contained thing in the book: an island that floats free of any coast, with a wall of unbreakable bronze round it, where the family eat together every day and there is music in the courtyard and nobody ever has to go outside for anything, including a spouse. Greek myth has other such families and generally attaches no scandal to them at the level of gods and half-divine beings; the rules that governed actual Greek households were not thought to apply upward. What the detail is *for*, I think, is the enclosure. This is a household that needs nothing from the world — which makes what happens next exact. The one thing Aeolus gives away is a sealed bag, and when it is opened and the man comes back, the door shuts and does not open again. Perfectly self-sufficient people can afford to be perfectly unforgiving.

the whole way and never given it to anybody else, so that we would get home faster.

And my companions started talking to each other. They had decided I was carrying gold and silver home from Aeolus, and this is the sort of thing they said, looking at one another:

It is extraordinary how this man is loved and honoured by everybody, whatever city and country he comes to. He is bringing home a great deal of fine plunder out of Troy, and we — who have made exactly the same journey — are going home with empty hands. And now Aeolus has given him all this out of friendship. Come on, let us have a quick look and see what it is, and how much gold and silver is in that bag.

And that was the plan that won, and they untied the bag, and all the winds burst out. The storm snatched them up straight away and carried them out to sea, crying, away from their own country.

And I woke up, and turned it over in my faultless heart — whether to go over the side and die in the water, or to endure it in silence and stay among the living. I endured it, and stayed, and covered my head and lay down in the ship. And they were carried back to the island of Aeolia by that evil blast, and my companions were groaning.

Everybody remembers that as the crew being greedy and stupid, so it is worth looking at what they actually say to each other. Not *let us steal it*: rather, *we did the same ten years he did, and he is going home rich and we are going home with nothing* — and then, how much is in there? They think it is treasure because a king who entertained them for a month has given their captain a large heavy sealed sack, lashed down with silver cord, and in nine days and nine nights nobody has told them what is in it; and because he has not let another man touch the steering sheet in all that time, which is either magnificent seamanship or a commander who does not trust his crew, and looks identical from the rowing bench.

He never told them. That is the whole of it, and you can hear it in what is missing: nowhere does he say *I explained what Aeolus had given me and warned them*. At the Cicones his defence was precise and he repeated it — I told them to run; they would not listen. He is scrupulous about that formula, and here he cannot use it. What went wrong on that ship went wrong before anybody touched the cord.

We went ashore and drew water, and my companions had a meal beside the fast ships. And when we had had food and drink I took a herald and one companion and went up to the famous house of Aeolus, and found him at dinner with his wife and his children. We came in and sat down on the threshold beside the doorposts, and they were astonished.

How did you get here, Odysseus? What evil spirit has been at you? We sent you off with great care, so that you would reach your own country and your house and anything else you love.

And I answered them with a sick heart. *My wretched companions ruined me — and a cruel sleep along with them. Put it right, my friends. You have the power.*

That is what I said, speaking gently. And they went dead silent. And their father answered:

Get off this island. Now. You are the most contemptible thing alive. It is against all right for me to help a man on his way when the blessed gods hate him. Get out. You have come here hated by the immortals.

And he drove me out of the house, and I was groaning heavily.

We sailed on from there with our hearts full of trouble, and the men's spirits were worn down by the hard rowing, because of our own foolishness; and there was no sign of a passage anywhere. Six days we sailed, night and day alike. And on the seventh we came to the steep citadel of Lamus — to Telepylus of the Laestrygonians, where one herdsman calls to another as he drives his flock in, and the other answers him as he drives his out. There a man who never slept could earn double wages: one

lot for herding cattle, and another for pasturing white sheep. The paths of the night and of the day are close together there.[51]

We came into a splendid harbour, with a sheer cliff running unbroken along both sides of it, and two headlands jutting out opposite each other at the mouth, and the entrance is narrow. And every one of the other captains steered his curved ship inside, and they moored them close together in the hollow of the harbour — because there is never a swell in there, great or small, but a bright calm all round.

I alone kept my black ship outside. I moored her at the very edge, with the cables made fast to a rock.

Then I climbed a rugged lookout and stood there. There was no sign of work — no oxen, no men — nothing but smoke going up off the land. So I sent men to go and find out what sort of people ate the bread of that country: two of them, and a herald as a third.

They went ashore and followed a smooth road, the one the wagons use to bring wood down from the mountains to the town. And in front of the town they met a girl drawing water, the strong daughter of Antiphates the Laestrygonian, who had come down to the clear-running spring. They went up and asked her who was king of these people, and she pointed out her father's high-roofed house at once.

They went in and found his wife inside — as big as a mountain top — and they loathed the sight of her. And she called Antiphates in from the meeting-place, who set about arranging a miserable death for them. He grabbed one of my men on the spot and made his meal of him. The other two bolted and got back to the ships.

And he raised the cry through the town, and the powerful Laestrygonians heard it and came from every direction, thousands of them, and they were not like men at all but like giants. And they threw rocks down at us off the cliffs, boulders a man could barely lift. And an appalling noise went up out of the ships: men dying and timbers being smashed at the same time. And they speared them like fish and carried them home for a disgusting supper.

And while they were killing the men inside the deep harbour, I drew the sharp sword off my thigh and cut through the cables of my dark-prowed ship, and shouted to my own crew to fall on the oars if they wanted to get out of it. And every man of them threw the water up in terror of dying. And my ship got out past the beetling cliffs into the open sea, and was glad of it.

The rest went down there together.

Five hundred and forty men, give or take, and eleven ships, gone in about a page. Nobody is named; there is no last stand and no dying speech; and every one of those men had come through ten years at Troy and had somebody at home counting. They die at a pretty anchorage without a fight, and the one man who lives does so because his ship was tied to a rock outside a harbour that every other captain in the fleet had sensibly gone into. Whether that was caution or luck he does not say, and I notice he does not explain it either.

[51] **"Where the paths of night and day are close together."** A herdsman driving his flock in at dusk calls out and is answered by one driving out at dawn, and a man who could do without sleep might draw two wages a day. That is a description of a place where the nights are so short they barely happen — high-latitude summer, where the light never entirely goes. Nobody knows what to do with it. It sits in the middle of a Mediterranean poem, unexplained, and it has been argued over for two thousand years: a garbled traveller's report carried south along the amber routes; a memory of a Norwegian summer that reached Greece through four sets of hands; a coincidence; an invention that happens to describe something real. I have no answer and neither has anybody else. But it is worth knowing that the strangest line in the strangest book of this poem is not about a monster. It is about the light.

We sailed on, glad to be out from under our death, and grieving for the dear companions we had lost. And we came to the island of Aeaea, where Circe lives — the goddess with the braided hair, terrible, who speaks like a human being, the full sister of the deadly-minded Aeetes. Both of them were born of Helios who gives light to men, and of Perse their mother, the daughter of Ocean.

We brought the ship into a harbour that will hold a ship, and some god guided us; and there we lay for two days and two nights, eating our hearts out with weariness and pain. On the third morning I took my spear and my sharp sword and went up quickly from the ship to a place with a view, hoping to see some work of men's hands and hear a voice. And I saw smoke coming up off the wide-wayed earth, through the thick brush and the woods, from the house of Circe.

And I thought about going down to look into it; and what seemed best, thinking it over, was to go back to the fast ship and give my men a meal, and then send some of them to find out. And on the way, when I was close to the ship, one of the gods took pity on me, alone as I was, and sent a great stag with tall antlers right across my path, going down to the river out of his woodland pasture to drink, because the heat of the sun was on him.

I hit him in the middle of the back as he came out, and the bronze spear went straight through, and he dropped in the dust screaming, and the life went out of him. I put my foot on him and pulled the spear out; and then I picked willow shoots and twisted a rope of them, a fathom long, and bound the feet of that great animal together, and slung him round my neck and carried him down to the black ship, leaning on my spear — because there was no possibility of carrying him on one shoulder with one hand; he was a very big beast.

And I threw him down in front of the ship and roused my men, going up to each one and speaking to him gently. *Friends. We are not going down into the house of Hades before our day comes, whatever grief we are in. Come on: while there is still food and drink in the fast ship, let us remember to eat, and not waste away with hunger.*

They did as I said at once. They uncovered their heads on the shore of the barren sea and stared at the stag, because he was a very big beast; and when they had had their fill of looking at him they washed their hands and got a magnificent dinner ready. So all that day until sunset we sat and feasted on meat past counting and sweet wine; and when the sun went down and the darkness came, we lay down to sleep on the shore of the sea.

When Dawn came up I called them all together.

Listen to me, my companions, for all the bad things you have suffered. My friends, we do not know where the darkness is and we do not know where the dawn is; we do not know where the sun that shines on men goes down under the earth, or where he comes up. So let us think quickly whether there is any plan left. I do not believe there is. I climbed a rugged lookout and I saw that this is an island, and the endless sea has it in a crown, and it lies low. And in the middle of it, with my own eyes, I saw smoke, through the thick brush and the woods.

And their spirits broke in them, because they remembered what Antiphates the Laestrygonian had done, and the violence of the great-hearted man-eating Cyclops. They cried aloud and let the big tears fall. And no good came of their crying.

So I counted off my well-greaved companions into two parties and appointed a leader for each. I led one; godlike Eurylochus led the other. And we shook the lots quickly in a bronze helmet, and the lot of great-hearted Eurylochus jumped out. So he went, and twenty-two companions with him, crying. And they left us behind, crying too.

In the glades they found the house of Circe, built of polished stone in a place with a view all round it. And there were mountain wolves round it, and lions, which she had bewitched herself by giving them evil drugs. They did not attack my men. They stood up on their hind legs and fawned on them, wagging their long tails — the way dogs fawn round their master when he comes back from dinner, because he always brings them something. That is how the wolves with their strong claws and the lions fawned round my men. And my men were terrified, looking at those dreadful animals.

They stood in the gateway of the goddess with the beautiful hair, and they could hear Circe inside, singing in a lovely voice, going up and down in front of a great web, imperishable, the kind of work goddesses do: fine and lovely and full of light.

And Polites spoke first, a leader of men, the dearest and steadiest of all my companions. *Friends. There is somebody inside, going up and down in front of a great web and singing beautifully; the whole floor rings with it. Some goddess, or some woman. Let us call out to her at once.*

So they called, and she came out and opened the shining doors and asked them in. And they all followed her inside, in their innocence. Eurylochus alone stayed behind; he suspected it was a trap.

She brought them in and sat them down on chairs and benches, and mixed them cheese and barley meal and yellow honey into Pramnian wine — and into the food she stirred ruinous drugs, so that they would completely forget their own country. And when she had given it to them and they had drunk it off, she struck them with her wand at once and penned them in the pigsties.

And they had the heads and the voices and the bristles and the bodies of pigs. But their minds were the same as before, exactly.

So there they were, shut in, and crying; and Circe threw down acorns and beech mast and cornel berries for them to eat, the things that pigs lying in the mud always eat.

Eurylochus came straight back to the fast black ship to tell us about our companions and the miserable fate they had met. He could not get a single word out, however much he wanted to; his heart was struck through with a terrible grief and his eyes were full of tears. And when we had all questioned him in amazement, at last he told us what had happened.

And I slung my silver-studded sword over my shoulder, the great bronze one, and my bow, and told him to lead me back by the same road. And he took hold of my knees with both hands and begged me. *Do not take me back there against my will. Leave me here. I know you will never come back yourself, and you will not bring any of the others either. Let us get out of here quickly with the men we have got. We may still escape the evil day.*

Eurylochus, you stay here then. Stay in this place and eat and drink beside the hollow black ship. I am going. A hard necessity is on me.

So I went up from the ship and the sea. And when I was going through the sacred glades and was about to reach the great house of Circe, Hermes of the golden wand met me on my way, looking like a young man with the first down on his lip, at the age when youth is at its most charming. And he took my hand and said my name.

Where are you off to now, you unlucky man, going alone over the hills, and you do not know the country? Your companions are penned in Circe's house, in close-fitting sties, like pigs. Have you come to set them free? I do not think you will get away yourself either. You will stay where the others are.

But listen. I will get you out of it. Take this good herb and go to Circe's house, and it will keep the evil day off your head. And I will tell you all of Circe's deadly tricks. She will mix you a drink and put drugs into the food. And even so she will not be able to bewitch you, because the good herb I am giving you will not let her.

And when Circe strikes you with her long wand, then draw the sharp sword off your thigh and go at her as though you meant to kill her. And she will be terrified, and she will tell you to go to bed with her. And do not refuse the bed of a goddess then — not if you want her to release your companions and look after you. But make her swear the great oath of the blessed gods first: that she will not plot any new harm against you, so that she does not make you a weakling and unman you when she has you stripped.

And the slayer of Argus (Hermes) gave me the herb, pulling it out of the ground, and showed me what it was like. Its root was black and its flower was as white as milk. *Moly*, the gods call it. It is hard for mortal men to dig, but the gods can do anything.[52]

Then Hermes went away to high Olympus, and I went on to Circe's house, and my heart was very dark as I went.

I stood in her gateway and called; and she came out at once and opened the shining doors and asked me in. And I followed her, sick at heart. She sat me down on a silver-studded chair, beautifully made, with a footstool under my feet, and mixed me a drink in a golden cup, and put a drug into it, with murder in her mind.

And when she had given it to me and I had drunk it off — and it did not bewitch me — she struck me with her wand. *Now go to the sty and lie down with the rest of your friends.*

And I drew the sharp sword off my thigh and went at her as though I meant to kill her. And she gave a great cry and ran in under the blade and got hold of my knees, and her words came out fast.

Who are you? Where do you come from? Where is your city, and where are your parents? I am amazed that you drank these drugs and were not bewitched. No other man alive has ever withstood this drug once it has gone past the barrier of his teeth. But there is a mind in you that cannot be got round.

You must be Odysseus. You must be. The man of many turns, whom the god of the golden wand always told me would come here, on his way back from Troy in a fast black ship. Come — put the sword back in its sheath. Let the two of us go to bed together, so that we may lie down and make love and trust each other.

Circe. How can you tell me to be gentle with you? You have turned my companions into pigs in your own house, and now you have got me here and you are plotting something, and you tell me to go into your room and up into your bed — so that when you have me stripped you can make me a weakling and unman me. I am not going up into your bed unless you can bring yourself, goddess, to swear me a great oath that you are not planning any new harm against me.

And she swore it at once, the way I told her to. And when she had sworn it and got through the whole of the oath, I went up into Circe's beautiful bed.[53]

[52]**Moly.** Black root, milk-white flower, hard for mortals to dig — and the poem tells you that *moly* is what the gods call it, which is one of a small handful of places in Homer where we are told that the immortals have their own names for things and that this is not the human one. People have been trying to identify the plant for a very long time, and the most persistent modern candidate is the snowdrop, which grows wild in Greece, has a dark bulb and a white flower, and contains a compound that is a genuine antidote to the class of poisons that produce delirium and hallucination — the sort of thing you might get from thorn-apple or henbane, both of which grow in the region and both of which have been used to make people compliant. On that reading Circe's drink is a real drug and Hermes' herb a real counter to it, and somebody in the Bronze Age Aegean knew it. It is a lovely theory and I would not bet the house on it. What is certain is the shape of the thing: the goddess who knows every drug is defeated by a better one, handed over by a god who does not stay to watch.

[53]**What Circe threatens.** Hermes' warning is specific, and the Greek is blunter than English likes to be: when she has him naked and unarmed she will make him worthless and not a man. It carries both senses at once, cowardice and unmanning, and the poem does not separate them, because in this world they were not separate. What is being described is the standard fear about a woman with power over a man in a bedroom, and the standard defence is a binding oath sworn before the act. — Note what the scene does structurally. He arrives with a sword out, and the encounter is settled on his terms: she swears, he goes to bed with her, and afterwards she is his ally for a year and gives him the sailing directions that save his life. It is a seduction converted into a treaty. Whether one should read her as beaten, or as having got precisely what she wanted from

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I said in Book Five that this man does not believe good news and that it would keep him alive; and there it is again, word for word, from a different mouth in a different house. But something else happens here that happens nowhere else in the poem, and I should like it on the record before we go on: he does not solve this one. Every other trap in these four books he gets out of with his own head — the false name, the sheep, the stake in the fire, the rock at the harbour mouth. Here a god walks up to him on a garden path and hands him the antidote, the tactics and the script, and he does exactly as he is told, and it works exactly as he was told it would.

While I was in her bed, four handmaids were working in the house — the ones who keep house for her, born of the springs and the groves and the sacred rivers that run down to the sea. One threw beautiful purple covers over the chairs with linen underneath; one drew silver tables up in front of the chairs and set golden baskets on them; the third mixed honey-sweet wine in a silver bowl and set out gold cups; and the fourth brought water and lit a great fire under a big cauldron.

And when the water boiled in the bright bronze she sat me in a bath and washed me, mixing it warm to my liking, and poured it over my head and my shoulders until she had taken the weariness that eats a man's spirit out of my limbs. And when she had washed me and rubbed me with rich oil and put a fine cloak and tunic on me, she led me in and sat me down on a silver-studded chair with a footstool.

And a maid brought water in a gold jug and poured it over a silver basin for me to wash my hands, and drew a polished table up beside me; and the housekeeper brought bread and a great many good things, giving freely of what she had. And she told me to eat.

And I did not want it. I sat there with my mind on other things, and my heart saw trouble coming.

And when Circe saw me sitting like that, not putting my hands out to the food, she came and stood beside me. *Why are you sitting there like a man who has lost his tongue, eating your own heart, and not touching food or drink? Do you suspect some other trick? There is no need. I have already sworn you a powerful oath.*

Circe — what man with any decency in him could bring himself to taste food or drink before he had got his companions free and seen them with his own eyes? If you really mean it kindly, then let them go.

So Circe went out through the hall with her wand in her hand, and opened the doors of the sty, and drove them out. They looked like nine-year-old boars. They stood there facing her, and she went through them and rubbed each one with a different drug. And the bristles fell off them — the bristles the ruinous drug had grown on them — and they turned back into men. Younger than they had been before, and much better looking, and taller.

And they knew me, and every man of them took my hand. And a longing to weep came over all of them, and the house rang with it, terribly. And the goddess herself was moved to pity.

She told me to go down to the ship and haul her out and stow the gear in the caves, and then come back with the rest of my men. I went, and found them beside the fast ship crying, letting the big tears fall.

And the way farmyard calves come round the herd of cows coming back to the yard when they have had their fill of grass — all of them skipping together in front of them, and the pens no longer hold

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the start, the poem leaves entirely open — and I notice that she was expecting him. Hermes had told her, years before, that he would come.

them, and they run round their mothers lowing without stopping — that is how those men crowded round me, in tears, when their eyes saw me. And it felt to them exactly as though they had got home; as though this were their own country, and the city of rugged Ithaca itself, where they were born and brought up.

And I told them to haul the ship out and stow the gear, and then follow me to Circe's sacred house. And every one of them obeyed at once, except Eurylochus, who tried to hold them all back.

Where are we going, you poor fools? Why are you so hungry for trouble that you would go down to Circe's house — where she will turn the whole lot of us into pigs or wolves or lions, and we will be made to guard her great house for her? It is exactly what the Cyclops did, when our companions went into his yard, and this reckless Odysseus went with them. They died there too, through his stupidity.

And when he said that I thought hard about drawing the long sword off my sturdy thigh and taking his head off and rolling it on the ground, close relation by marriage though he was. But my companions held me back with soft words, and said to leave him by the ship to look after it. So they went up from the ship and the sea; and Eurylochus did not stay behind either. He came with us. He was afraid of my terrible anger.

Meanwhile Circe had bathed the rest of my companions in her house and rubbed them with rich oil and put fleecy cloaks and tunics on them; and we found them all having a good dinner in the hall. And when they saw each other face to face and knew each other, they wept and wailed, and the house rang round them.

And the goddess came and stood beside me. *Son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices. Do not go on raising this great lamentation any longer. I know myself what you have all suffered on the fish-filled sea, and how unfriendly men have done you harm on land. Come. Eat food and drink wine, until you get the spirit back in your breasts that you had at the beginning, when you first left your own country, rugged Ithaca. As you are now, you are withered and dispirited, always thinking about your hard wandering, and there is never any gladness in your hearts, because you have been through a great deal.*

And we did as she said. And we stayed there day after day, for a full year, feasting on meat past counting and sweet wine.

A year.

Set it beside Ogygia. He was with Calypso seven years, which is a great deal longer, and the poem takes enormous trouble to tell us what those years were like: he sat on the rocks every day and cried and looked at the water, the sweetness went out of his life, and he lay beside her unwilling beside the willing one. Here he stays a year in a beautiful house with a goddess who looks after him extremely well, and the poem records not one day of grief. No rocks, no weeping, no looking at the sea. The wine goes round and the meat comes in and the year goes by. And it is not Odysseus who ends it. It is the men — the same men he went unarmed into a witch's house to rescue — who have to take him aside and say, in effect, *sir. Ithaca.* And he goes to her that night and asks to be released, and she releases him at once, and never argues, and never held him at all.

I shall ask the question once and then leave it alone: what exactly was he doing for a year? Not because I think he had stopped wanting to go home — I do not believe he stopped for an hour in twenty years, and the poem has proved it to me more than once — but because wanting to go home and going home are different things, and this is the most honest thing in the book about how people fail to do what they want most. Not by choosing against it. By being comfortable, among friends, for a while, and then for a while longer.

When the year was up and the seasons had come round again, my trusty companions called me out. *Strange man. It is time you thought about your own country — if it is really laid down that you are to be saved and get back to your high-roofed house and your own land.*

And my proud heart was persuaded. So all that day until sunset we sat feasting; and when the sun went down and the darkness came, they lay down to sleep through the shadowy hall. But I went up to Circe's beautiful bed and took hold of her knees, and the goddess listened to me.

Circe. Keep the promise you made me — to send me home. My spirit is set on it now, and so are my men's; they wear my heart away, sitting round me grieving, whenever you happen to be somewhere else.

Son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices. Do not stay in my house any longer against your will. But there is another journey you have to make first. You must go to the house of Hades and dread Persephone, to consult the spirit of Teiresias of Thebes — the blind prophet, whose mind is still whole. Persephone has granted understanding to him alone, dead as he is. The others go flitting about as shadows.

And my heart broke when I heard it. I sat there on the bed and cried, and I did not want to go on living and see the light of the sun any more. And when I had had enough of crying and rolling about, I answered her. *Circe — who is going to guide us on that journey? Nobody has ever got to Hades in a black ship.*

And she told me, and I shall set down what she said exactly as she said it, because I did every part of it afterwards, in order, and my life turned on it.

Do not give a thought to wanting a guide beside the ship. Set up the mast and spread the white sail and sit down; the breath of the North Wind will carry her. And when you have crossed the stream of Ocean, where there is a level shore and the groves of Persephone — tall poplars, and willows that drop their fruit — then beach your ship there and go yourself to the mouldering house of Hades. There the river of fire and the river of wailing run into Acheron, and there is a rock where the two roaring rivers come together.

Then go close in, hero, and do exactly as I tell you. Dig a pit, about a forearm's length each way. And pour a drink offering round it to all the dead: first with milk and honey, then with sweet wine, and the third time with water. And sprinkle white barley meal over all of it.

And make a long prayer to the strengthless heads of the dead. Promise them that when you get to Ithaca you will sacrifice a barren heifer in your halls, the best you have, and pile the altar with good things; and that to Teiresias by himself you will sacrifice a ram, a black one, all black, the finest in your flocks.

And when you have finished praying to the great crowds of the dead, then sacrifice a ram and a black ewe, turning their heads towards the darkness — but turn yourself away, facing towards the streams of the river. And then a great many souls of the dead and gone will come.

Then call your companions and tell them to flay the sheep that are lying there killed by the pitiless bronze, and to burn them, and to pray to the gods. And you: draw the sharp sword off your thigh, and sit there, and do not let the strengthless heads of the dead come near the blood until you have asked Teiresias. And the prophet will come to you very soon, and he will tell you your way, and the stages of it, and how you are to get home over the fish-filled sea.

And the Dawn came up on her golden throne while she was still speaking. And she put a cloak and a tunic on me, and dressed herself in a long shining robe, finely woven and lovely, and put a beautiful golden belt round her waist and a veil over her head.

And I went through the house rousing my men, standing over each one and speaking gently. *Do not go on lying there sleeping. Let us go. Lady Circe has told me everything.*

And their proud hearts were persuaded. But not even from there did I get all my men away unhurt.

There was one called Elpenor, the youngest of them, not very brave in a fight and not very sound in the head, who had lain down apart from the others on the roof of Circe's house, wanting the cool air, because he was heavy with wine. And he heard the noise and the stir of his companions moving about, and jumped up suddenly, and forgot to go back down by the long ladder, and fell headlong off the roof; and his neck was broken out of its spine, and his soul went down to the house of Hades.[54]

And I said to the others as they came: *You think you are going home now. Circe has marked out another road for us — to the house of Hades and dread Persephone, to consult the soul of Teiresias of Thebes.*

And their spirits broke in them when they heard it. They sat down where they were and cried and tore their hair. And no good came of their crying.

And while we were on our way down to the fast ship and the shore of the sea, grieving and letting the big tears fall, Circe went on ahead of us and tied a ram and a black ewe beside the black ship.

She passed us easily. Who could see a god going to and fro, if the god did not wish it?

NOTES TO BOOK TEN

Book Eleven: In Which He Digs a Hole, and the Dead Come Up to Talk.

[54] **Elpenor.** The youngest man aboard, no good in a fight, not clever, drunk, asleep on a flat roof for the cool air; he hears everyone moving, jumps up, forgets there is a ladder, and breaks his neck. It is the least heroic death in the poem and quite possibly in all Greek literature, and it takes four lines. Every other man who dies in these four books is eaten by something, or drowned, or crushed by a rock thrown by a giant; this one falls off a roof at a party. I mention it because it would be easy to read as a throwaway, and it is not: he is going to matter, very shortly, and the poem's willingness to spend real feeling on a man it has just told you was neither brave nor bright is one of the more decent things about it.

Book 11

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK ELEVEN

In Which He Digs a Hole, and the Dead Come Up to Talk

This is the middle — not roughly the middle, but the middle. Everything before this book goes away from home and everything after it comes back towards home, and the hinge is a hole in the ground at the edge of the world with a man sitting beside it holding a sword. It is also the first descent to the country of the dead in European literature, and every one that came afterwards walks in its footprints. One warning and then he can have it back: about halfway through, the poem will stop him and take us out to the dining hall for a few minutes. That is not a join in the manuscript. Wait for it.

We went down to the ship and dragged her into the bright water and put the mast and the sail in her, and took the sheep aboard, and went aboard ourselves, in a bad way, letting the big tears fall. And Circe sent us a following wind behind the dark-prowed ship, a good companion, to fill the sail. All day her sail was stretched as she crossed the sea, and the sun went down and all the ways grew dark.

And she came to the edge of deep-flowing Ocean, where the country and the city of the Cimmerian people are, wrapped in fog and cloud. The shining sun never looks down on them with his rays — not when he climbs up towards the starry sky, and not when he turns back down again — and a deadly night is stretched over those wretched people.

We ran the ship ashore and got the sheep out, and went along beside the stream of Ocean until we came to the place Circe had described. There Perimedes and Eurylochus held the animals, and I drew the sharp sword off my thigh and dug the pit, a forearm's length this way and that. And I poured the offering round it to all the dead: first with milk and honey, then with sweet wine, and the third time with water; and I sprinkled white barley meal over all of it. And I prayed hard to the strengthless heads of the dead, and promised them that when I got to Ithaca I would sacrifice a barren heifer in my halls, the best I had, and pile the altar high with good things; and that to Teiresias by himself I would offer a ram, black all over, the finest in my flocks.

And when I had finished praying I took the sheep and cut their throats over the pit, and the dark blood ran into it.

And they came up out of the darkness underneath. Brides came, and unmarried boys, and old men who had suffered a great deal, and soft young girls with hearts new to grief; and a great many men wounded with bronze spears, killed in war, still in their bloodied armour. They came crowding round the pit from every direction with an unearthly crying, and a pale fear took hold of me.

And I told my companions to flay the sheep and burn them and pray to the gods — to mighty Hades and to dread Persephone (his queen, who rules the dead beside him). And I drew the sharp sword off my thigh and sat there, and would not let the strengthless heads of the dead come near the blood

until I had asked Teiresias.[55]

The first soul that came was my own companion Elpenor. He had not been buried under the wide-wayed earth; we had left his body in Circe's house, unwept and unburied, because another task was pressing us.

I cried when I saw him. *Elpenor — how did you get down here under the fog and the dark? You have come quicker on foot than I did in my black ship.*

And he groaned and answered me. *Son of Laertes. An evil fate from some god did for me, and an immeasurable quantity of wine. I lay down on Circe's roof and never thought to go back down by the long ladder, and I came down head first, and my neck was broken out of its spine.*

And now I beg you by the ones left behind, who are not here — by your wife, and by your father who brought you up, and by Telemachus, the only son you left in your halls — because I know that when you go from here you will bring your ship in at Aeaea again — there, my lord, remember me. Do not go away and leave me unwept and unburied and turn your back on me, or I may become a reason for the gods to be angry with you. Burn me with my armour, all that I have, and heap up a mound for me on the shore of the grey sea, for an unlucky man, so that people yet to come will know. Do that for me. And plant on the mound the oar I used to row with, when I was alive and with my companions.

I will do all of it, my poor friend. I will see to it.

So the two of us sat there exchanging these unhappy words, I on one side holding my sword over the blood, and the ghost of my companion on the other side, saying a great deal.

And then came the soul of my dead mother, Anticleia, the daughter of great-hearted Autolycus, whom I had left alive when I sailed for holy Troy. I cried when I saw her, and I pitied her in my heart. And even so I would not let her come near the blood, however badly it hurt, until I had asked Teiresias.

And the soul of Teiresias of Thebes came, holding a golden staff, and he knew me.

Son of Laertes. Why have you left the light of the sun, you unlucky man, and come to see the dead and this place where there is no joy? Stand back from the pit and hold that sharp sword away, so that I can drink the blood and tell you the truth.

I stepped back and pushed the silver-studded sword into its sheath. And when he had drunk the dark blood, the faultless prophet spoke.

You are asking about a sweet homecoming, glorious Odysseus. And a god is going to make it hard for you. Because I do not think you will get past the Earthshaker (Poseidon). He has stored up anger against you in his heart, and he is furious about his own dear son, whose eye you put out.

Even so, you may still get home, though you will suffer for it — if you can hold your own spirit in, and your

[55] **The pit, the blood, and where this is.** Three things a modern reader needs, and none of them are what most people expect. — *First:* he does not go down. Circe's directions send him to the far edge of Ocean, to a beach, where he digs a small pit and the dead come *up*. There is no descent, no gate, no guide, no tour; he never sets foot in the house of Hades and never sees it. The full underworld journey — the crossing, the ferryman, the levels — is later machinery, mostly Virgil's and Dante's, and it is not here. — *Second:* the blood. The dead in this poem are not spirits in the modern sense but worn-out images, without strength, without voice, and without recognition; they cannot even *know* him until they have drunk. What the blood gives back, briefly, is not life but the power to remember and to speak, which is why he has to sit there rationing it with a sword, and why his own mother sits by the pit in silence and cannot look at her son. — *Third:* this is not hell. As promised in Book Four, note 5: there is no judgement at the door, no sorting, no reward for the good and no fire for the wicked. Everybody goes to the same grey place, Achilles and Agamemnon and Elpenor who fell off a roof, all together. Minos is down there judging, but look at what he is doing — settling disputes *among* the dead, the way a king settles disputes among the living. He is a magistrate, not St Peter.

companions'. When you first bring your ship in at the island of Thrinacia, escaping the violet sea, you will find the cattle grazing there, and the fat flocks of Helios, who sees everything and hears everything. If you leave those alone and keep your mind on getting home, then all of you may still reach Ithaca, badly off as you will be. But if you harm them, then I am telling you now: destruction for your ship and for your men. And if you get out of it yourself, you will come home late, and in a bad way, having lost every one of your companions, in somebody else's ship. And you will find trouble in your house — arrogant men eating up your living, courting your godlike wife and offering her bride-gifts.

But you will pay them out for their violence when you come. And when you have killed the suitors in your own halls, whether by a trick or openly with the sharp bronze — then go. Take a well-made oar and go on until you come to men who know nothing about the sea, and eat their food without salt in it, and have never heard of ships with painted cheeks, or of the shaped oars that are the wings of ships. And I will tell you a very clear sign, and you will not miss it. When another traveller meets you on the road and says you have a winnowing fan on your broad shoulder — then plant your shaped oar in the ground, and make a fine sacrifice to the lord Poseidon: a ram, a bull, and a boar that mates with sows. And go home, and offer sacred hecatombs (great sacrifices, like 100 cattle) to the immortal gods, to all of them in their order.

And death will come to you far from the sea. A very gentle death. It will take you when you are worn down with a sleek old age, and your people will be prosperous around you. That is the truth I am telling you.

Teiresias — I suppose the gods themselves have spun all this out. But tell me this. I see the soul of my dead mother there. She sits by the blood without a word, and she cannot bring herself to look straight at her own son, or speak to him. Tell me, lord — how can she know who I am?

That is easily said. Any one of the dead you let come near the blood will speak the truth to you. Any one you refuse will go back again.

And the soul of lord Teiresias went away into the house of Hades, having said his prophecy.

And I stayed where I was until my mother came up and drank the dark blood. And she knew me at once, and cried.

My child. How did you come down here under the murky dark, and you alive? It is hard for the living to see these things. There are great rivers between, and terrible waters, and Ocean first of all, which nobody can cross on foot; you must have a well-built ship. Have you only now come here from Troy, wandering all this time with your ship and your men? Have you not been to Ithaca yet? Have you not seen your wife in your own house?

Mother — necessity brought me down to Hades, to consult the soul of Teiresias. I have not been near Greece yet. I have not set foot on my own country. I have been wandering, and there has been nothing but trouble, since the first day I followed Agamemnon to Ilium (Troy). But tell me this truly. What death took you? Was it a long illness? Or did Artemis (goddess of the hunt, whose arrows bring a quiet death to women) come and kill you with her gentle shafts? And tell me about my father, and about the son I left behind. Is my position still theirs? Or does some other man hold it now? And tell me about my wife — what she intends, and what is in her mind. Is she still with the boy, keeping everything safe? Or has one of the Greeks married her by now?

She is still in your halls, and her heart is steady, and she is enduring it. The nights waste away for her, wretchedly, and the days, and she is crying. Nobody holds your position. Telemachus keeps your lands undisturbed, and dines at the feasts a man who deals out judgements ought to dine at; everybody invites him.

But your father stays out on the farm and does not come into the town at all. He has no bedstead now, and no cloaks, and no bright coverlets. In the winter he sleeps in the house where the servants sleep, in the ashes by the fire, and wears bad clothes. And when the summer comes, and the rich autumn, there are beds of fallen leaves heaped low all over the slope of his vineyard, and he lies down on those, grieving, feeding a great sorrow in his

heart and longing for you to come back. And a hard old age has come on him.

And that is how I died too. It was not the sharp-eyed archer goddess who came and killed me in my house with her gentle arrows, and it was not a disease, the sort that most often takes the spirit out of the limbs by a horrible wasting. It was missing you. It was longing for you, and for your good sense, glorious Odysseus, and for your kindness. That took my honey-sweet life away.

And I wanted to take hold of the soul of my dead mother. Three times I went for her, and my heart urged me to hold her. Three times she went out of my hands like a shadow, or like a dream. And the grief in my heart got sharper every time.

Mother — why do you not stay for me, when I want to hold you? Why can we not put our arms round each other, even here in Hades, and take our fill of cold grieving? Is this some phantom that dread Persephone has sent me, to make me cry even harder?

My child. Most unlucky of all men. Persephone is not deceiving you. This is simply the way it is with mortals when a person dies. The sinews no longer hold the flesh and the bones together. The great force of the blazing fire destroys all that, as soon as the life leaves the white bones. And the soul flutters off like a dream and goes to and fro.

Get back to the light, quickly. And take all of this in, so that you can tell your wife afterwards.

That last instruction is the thing to keep. She does not say *remember me*, or *avenge me*, or *bury me properly*. She has one child in front of her whom she died of missing, and what she does with her few words is send him home to somebody else and give him something to say when he gets there. It is the only thing left that she can do about twenty years of waiting for a man to walk in at the door.

Then Persephone sent up the souls of the women, all of them the wives and daughters of great men, and they gathered in a crowd round the dark blood; and I drew the long sword off my thigh and would not let them all drink together, but let them come one at a time, and each of them told me her lineage.

Tyro came, who fell in love with a river and was loved by Poseidon in the river's shape, and bore Pelias and Neleus. Antiope came, who bore Amphion and Zethus, the two who first built the foundations of seven-gated Thebes and walled it, because for all their strength they could not live in Thebes without walls. And Alcmene came, who bore Heracles to Zeus; and Megara, the daughter of Creon, whom Heracles married.

And I saw the mother of Oedipus, the beautiful Epicaste, who did a monstrous thing without knowing what she was doing, and married her own son; and he had killed his own father and married her. And the gods made it known among men straight away. And he stayed on in lovely Thebes, ruling the Cadmeans, suffering, through the destructive plans of the gods. And she went down into the house of Hades, having tied a noose to a high roofbeam, in the grip of her own grief. And she left him pains past counting — everything a mother's avenging Furies bring about.[56]

And Chloris came, and Leda who bore Castor and Polydeuces, whom the earth holds, and they are alive, and even under the earth they have honour from Zeus, and live on alternate days and are dead on

[56] **Oedipus, three hundred years before Sophocles.** Here is the whole story as this poem has it: he killed his father and married his mother in ignorance; the gods made it known at once; his mother hanged herself; and *he went on ruling in Thebes*. He is not blinded. He does not put out his own eyes; there is no exile, no wandering, no daughter leading him by the hand to Colonus. He suffers, and he keeps the throne. Set that beside what happens to the material later, when the Athenian tragedians take hold of it and make the discovery and the self-blinding the whole point, and you have the same lesson as Book Three, note 4, on Orestes. These stories were not fixed. The versions we treat as *the* myth are almost always somebody's later, harder-edged rewrite. Homer knew a different one and told it in nine lines, on the way past.

alternate days. And Iphimedeia came, who bore Otus and Ephialtes, the two tallest and handsomest men the grain-giving earth ever fed after Orion: at nine years old they were nine cubits across and nine fathoms tall, and they threatened to raise war against the immortals themselves, and set about piling Ossa on Olympus and Pelion on Ossa so as to climb into the sky — and they would have brought it off, if they had reached the full measure of manhood, but Apollo killed them both before the down flowered on their cheeks.

And I saw Phaedra, and Procris, and beautiful Ariadne, the daughter of Minos, whom Theseus tried to bring from Crete to holy Athens and got no joy of, because Artemis killed her first on the island of Dia. And Maera, and Clymene, and hateful Eriphyle, who took gold as the price of her own husband.

I could not tell you or name all of them, all the wives and daughters of heroes that I saw; the immortal night would be used up first. And it is time to sleep, either on board the fast ship with my crew, or here in your house. My escort is a matter for the gods and for you.

That is the sound of a man putting his cup down. He has been talking since dinner; he has just walked a hall full of listeners along a wall of famous names; and he has stopped in the middle of it and said, in effect, *goodness, look at the time.*

And the whole room stayed silent, held in the spell of it, through the shadowy hall. And the first person to speak was the queen.

"Phaeacians. What do you make of this man — his looks, his size, and the balance of the mind inside him? He is my guest, but every one of you has a share in the honour of him. So do not be in a hurry to send him off, and do not be mean with your gifts to a man in such need. You have a great deal of treasure lying in your houses by the will of the gods."

And the old lord Echeneus said: "Friends, our wise queen has not spoken wide of the mark, and not wide of what we were all thinking. Do as she says — though the word and the deed rest with Alcinous here."

And Alcinous said: "What she says will stand, as surely as I am alive and rule over the Phaeacians who love the oar. Let our guest hold on, however much he wants to be off, until tomorrow — until I have made the gifts complete. The escort will be the men's business, and mine most of all, since the power in this country is mine."

And Odysseus said: "Lord Alcinous. If you told me to stay here for a year, and were getting my escort ready and giving me splendid gifts, I would take that too. It would be much better to reach my own country with a fuller hand; I would be more respected, and better loved, by every man who saw me come home to Ithaca."

And Alcinous said: "Odysseus — looking at you, we do not take you for a cheat or a liar, the sort the black earth breeds in great numbers, men who fashion falsehoods out of things nobody could ever check. There is a shapeliness on your words, and there is a good mind inside you. You have told your story with skill, the way a singer does.

"But tell me this. Did you see any of your godlike companions down there — men who went with you to Ilium (Troy) and met their fate? The night is long. Immeasurably long. It is not time to sleep in the hall yet. Tell me the marvellous things. I could hold out until the bright dawn, if you could bear to stay in this hall and tell me your troubles."

A king has just praised his guest for not being the sort of man who invents stories out of things

nobody can verify, and has given as his reason that the man tells a story as well as a professional storyteller. The evening's material so far has included a one-eyed giant, a floating island, a woman who turns men into pigs and a conversation with the dead. I do not think Alcinous is a fool — he has been the most sensible man in four books — and I think the poem is grinning at us over its own frame. Note what else the interval does. The cups come back, and the queen says *do not be mean with your gifts*, and the guest replies that he would happily stay a year if the presents were good enough, because he would rather arrive home rich. He is not confessing at a dinner party. He is earning his fare.

Lord Alcinous — there is a time for many words and there is a time for sleep. But if you are still eager to listen, I would not grudge you things more pitiful still: the sufferings of my companions, who got out from under the war-cry of the Trojans and then died on the way home, through the will of an evil woman.

When Persephone had scattered the souls of the women, there came the soul of Agamemnon, grieving; and round him were gathered the others who had died with him in the house of Aegisthus. He knew me at once when he had drunk the dark blood. He wept shrilly and stretched his hands out towards me, wanting to hold me; but there was no strength left in him, and none of the force his supple limbs used to have.

I cried when I saw him. *Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of men. What death took you? Did Poseidon take you on your ships, raising a foul blast of cruel winds? Or did enemies do it on dry land, while you were cutting out their cattle and their fine flocks, or fighting for a city and its women?*

It was not Poseidon on the ships, and it was not enemies on dry land. Aegisthus arranged my death and my fate, and killed me with the help of my accursed wife. He asked me to his house. He gave me dinner. And he killed me the way a man kills an ox at the manger.

So I died the most pitiful death. And round me my companions were slaughtered without a pause, like white-tusked pigs killed in the house of a rich and powerful man for a wedding or a feast day. You have been present at the killing of a great many men, cut down one at a time or in the press of a battle. But you would have been sorriest of all in your heart if you had seen that: how we lay in the hall among the mixing bowls and the loaded tables, and the whole floor swam with blood.

And the most pitiful thing I heard was the voice of Cassandra, whom treacherous Clytemnestra (Agememnon's wife, remarried to Aegisthus, and Helen's twin sister) killed beside me. And I lifted my hands and beat the ground with them as I died, with the sword in me. And that shameless woman turned her back and walked away. She would not even use her hands to close my eyes and shut my mouth, though I was going down to Hades.

So there is nothing more terrible, nothing more shameless, than a woman who can put a thing like that in her mind. I thought I was coming home welcome to my children and my household. And she has poured shame on herself, and on the women who come after her, and even on the decent ones.

Zeus has been terribly hard on the house of Atreus (Agememnon's father) from the beginning, through the plans of women. A great many of us died for Helen's sake, and Clytemnestra was laying her trap for you while you were far away.

So never be gentle to your own wife either. Do not tell her every plan you know. Tell her part, and keep part hidden. Though death will not come to you from your wife, Odysseus. She is far too sensible, and knows too well what good counsel is — Penelope, the daughter of Icarius. We left her behind a young bride when we went off to the war. There was a boy at her breast, an infant. He must be sitting among grown men by now, and lucky, because his father will see him when he comes, and he will put his arms round his father, which is how it should be. My wife did not let me have my fill of looking at my own son. She killed me first.

And here is one more thing; put it away in your mind. Bring your ship in to your own dear country secretly, not in the open. There is no trusting women.

But tell me — have you heard anything about my son? Is he alive? Because noble Orestes is not dead anywhere on this earth.

Son of Atreus, why ask me this? I have no idea whether he is alive or dead, and it is a bad thing to talk empty as the wind.

So the two of us stood there exchanging these unhappy words, grieving, letting the tears fall.

And then came the soul of Achilles, and of Patroclus, and of faultless Antilochus, and of Ajax, who was the best of the Greeks in looks and in build after the son of Peleus. And the soul of Achilles knew me.

Son of Laertes. You reckless man. What enormous thing will you think of next? How did you dare to come down to Hades, where the senseless dead live, the worn-out images of men?

Achilles, son of Peleus — far the strongest of the Greeks. I came for Teiresias, to see if he could tell me any plan for getting back to rugged Ithaca. Because I have not been near Greece yet, or set foot on my own country, and I have had nothing but trouble. But you, Achilles — no man was ever more blessed than you, and no man ever will be. When you were alive we Greeks honoured you like a god, and now you are down here you rule mightily among the dead. So do not grieve at being dead, Achilles.

Do not talk to me smoothly about death, glorious Odysseus. I would rather be alive and working the soil for another man — a landless man, with nothing much to live on — than be king over all the dead who are used up.

That is Achilles, who was offered the choice in the older poem between a long quiet life at home and a short one ending under the walls of Troy with a name that would never die, and who took the short one on purpose, knowing the terms; and who is the reason that poem exists. He has had a while to think about it. The *Iliad* is a poem about a young man choosing glory over length of life, and the *Odyssey* puts that young man in a hole in the ground and asks him how it went.

But tell me about my son. Did he follow you to the war, to be a leader? And tell me about noble Peleus, if you have heard anything. Do the Myrmidons still honour him, or do they treat him badly through Greece, because old age has him by the hands and feet? I am not up there under the sun's rays to help him — not the man I used to be, when I killed the best of their army on the wide plain of Troy. If I could come to my father's house like that for even a little while, I would make my strength and my untouchable hands something to be afraid of, for anyone doing him violence.

And I told him about Neoptolemus: that I had brought him myself from Scyros; that in council he was always first to speak and never got it wrong, and only Nestor and I could beat him at it; that in the fighting he never stayed in the crowd but ran far out in front, and gave way to nobody, and killed a great many men. And I told him about the horse — how all the best of us sat inside it, and the leaders were weeping and their legs were shaking, and I never once saw that young man's fine skin go pale or saw him wipe a tear off his face; he kept begging me to let him out, handling his sword-hilt and his heavy bronze spear. And I told him that when we had sacked the steep city of Priam he went aboard his ship with his share and a fine prize, without a scratch on him.

And the soul of Achilles went away over the field of asphodel with long strides — glad, because I had told him his son was outstanding.

The other souls of the dead and gone stood about grieving, and each one asked me about the people they cared for. Only the soul of Ajax kept away, still furious about the victory I had won over him beside

the ships, in the contest for the armour of Achilles.

I wish I had never won a contest like that. For the sake of that armour the earth closed over a head like his — Ajax, who was above all the other Greeks in his looks and in what he did, after the son of Peleus.

And I spoke to him gently. *Ajax, son of faultless Telamon. Were you not going to forget your anger with me, even in death, over that ruinous armour? The gods made it a disaster for the Greeks. Such a tower of a man we lost in you. We grieve for you constantly, the way we grieve for the life of Achilles; and nobody is to blame but Zeus, who hated the Greek army terribly and laid your fate on you. Come here, my lord. Hear what I am saying. Put down your anger and your lordly spirit.*

He did not answer me. He went off into the darkness after the other souls of the dead.

Even then he might have spoken to me, angry as he was, or I to him — but the heart in my breast wanted to see the souls of the others.

In a book whose entire machinery exists to make the dead speak, one man is addressed by name, apologised to, praised and begged, and turns round and walks away without a syllable. And notice what it costs the speaker: *I wish I had never won a contest like that* is the only place in twenty-four books where Odysseus wishes he had lost. He does not say it about the Cyclops's eye, or the horse, or the town at Ismarus. He says it about a prize he won fairly.

And I saw Minos, the son of Zeus, holding a golden staff, sitting and giving judgements to the dead; and they sat and stood about him through the wide-gated house of Hades, asking him to settle their cases. And after him I saw huge Orion, driving the wild beasts together over the field of asphodel, the same ones he killed himself on the lonely hills, with an unbreakable bronze club in his hands.

And I saw Tityos, the son of Earth, lying on the ground; he covered nine acres of it. Two vultures sat on either side of him tearing at his liver, going right into the flesh, and his hands could not push them off. He had laid hands on Leto as she was going to Delphi.

And I saw Tantalus, in hard pain, standing in a pool with the water up against his chin. He looked like a man dying of thirst and he could not get anything to drink: every time the old man stooped down, mad for a drink, the water was swallowed away and vanished, and the black earth showed round his feet. And there were tall trees over his head dropping their fruit down at him — pears and pomegranates and shining apples and sweet figs and ripe olives — and every time he reached up for them, the wind tossed them away to the shadowy clouds.

And I saw Sisyphus, in violent pain, wrestling a monstrous stone with both arms. He would brace his hands and feet and shove it up towards the top of a hill; and just as he was about to get it over the crest, the weight of it would turn him back, and the shameless stone would come rolling down to the flat ground again. And he would strain and shove it back up, and the sweat poured off his limbs, and the dust rose off his head.[57]

And after him I saw the mighty Heracles — his phantom. He himself is among the immortal gods,

[57] **What the three punishments have in common.** Tityos assaulted Leto. Tantalus and Sisyphus are here for offences the poem does not spell out, but the tradition is consistent that both personally cheated or insulted the gods — Tantalus by abusing their hospitality, Sisyphus by trying to outwit death itself. Every one of the three is being punished for an offence *against a god*, personally, and not for wickedness in general. This is the Elysium note from Book Four arriving from the other side, and worth stating plainly because it cuts against everything later readers brought with them: there is no ordinary moral accounting in this afterlife. Bad men who did not offend the gods are not punished, and good men who did not please them are not rewarded. There are three individuals in agony, and everybody else is simply dead, in the grey, forever. When Achilles says what he says thirty lines later, this is the place he is talking about.

enjoying their feasts, and he has Hebe for a wife. Round him there was a clamour from the dead like the noise of birds, and they scattered everywhere in terror; and he came on like the black night, with his bow bare and an arrow on the string, glaring terribly, like a man about to shoot. There was a fearful belt about his chest, a golden baldric, and marvellous things were worked on it: bears and wild boars and lions with their eyes flashing, and battles and fighting and killings and men being slaughtered. I hope whoever put his craft into that belt never made another one.

He knew me the moment he saw me. *Son of Laertes. Are you dragging out a bad destiny too, the same as the one I carried under the rays of the sun? I was the son of Zeus, and I had trouble past all measuring. I was made subject to a man far worse than I was, and he laid hard labours on me. He even sent me down here once, to bring up the hound — because he thought there could be no harder task; and I brought the hound up and led him out of Hades, and Hermes guided me, and Athena.*[58]

And he went back into the house of Hades.

But I stayed there, in case some other one of the heroes who died long ago might come, and I might have seen the men I wanted to see, Theseus and Peirithous. But before that, the tribes of the dead came thronging up with an unearthly cry, and a pale fear took hold of me, in case dread Persephone should send me up the head of the Gorgon out of the house of Hades.

So I went back to the ship at once and told my men to get aboard and cast off the cables. They went aboard and sat down at the oars. And the current carried us down the stream of Ocean; oars first, and after that a fair wind.

NOTES TO BOOK ELEVEN

Book Twelve: In Which There Is Singing, a Choice Between Two Deaths, and the Last of the Ships.

[58] **Heracles in two places at once.** He is standing in front of Odysseus with an arrow on the string — and the poem stops to tell you that this is only his phantom, and that Heracles himself is up on Olympus at the feast, married to the goddess of youth. Both statements are in the text, one line apart. This is the plainest theological contradiction in Homer and there is no reconciling it: either a man's shade goes to the grey place or he becomes a god, and Heracles is doing both. Most scholars think the Olympus line is a later addition, patched in by somebody who could not bear to have the greatest hero of them all shuffling about in the dark with everybody else. I mention it because it is a useful reminder of what this text is. It is not one man's manuscript. It is a tradition that was sung and re-sung and repaired for centuries before anyone wrote it down, and occasionally you can see the join.

Book 12

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK TWELVE

In Which There Is Singing, a Choice Between Two Deaths, and the Last of the Ships

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This is the last of the four books he tells himself, and it is the one where everything runs out: the ship, the men, the food, all of it, until there is one man in the water holding two pieces of wood. I mention it in advance because the poem will not stop to mark it. He simply gets to the end, and stops, and turns back into a guest who has talked rather too long.

When our ship had left the stream of Ocean and come to the wave of the wide sea, and to the island of Aeaea, where the house of early Dawn is and her dancing floors and the risings of the sun — we ran her ashore on the sand and went out onto the beach, and there we slept and waited for the bright morning.

And when Dawn came up I sent my companions to Circe's house to fetch the body of dead Elpenor. We cut logs quickly and buried him on the furthest point of the headland, grieving, letting the big tears fall. And when the corpse and the dead man's armour had burned, we heaped up a mound and dragged a standing stone onto it, and on the very top of the mound we planted his oar.

And Circe knew perfectly well that we had come back from the house of Hades, and she dressed and came down quickly, and her women came with her carrying bread and a great deal of meat and sparkling red wine. And the shining goddess stood among us.

You reckless men. You have gone down alive into the house of Hades. You will be twice dead, when other men die only once. Come — eat here, and drink wine, all day long. And at first light you shall sail; and I will show you the way and make every part of it plain, so that you do not come to grief through some miserable piece of bad planning, on the sea or on the land.

And our proud hearts agreed to that. So all day until sunset we sat and feasted on meat past counting and sweet wine; and when the sun went down and the darkness came, they lay down to sleep beside the ship's cables. But she took me by the hand and sat me down away from the others, and lay down beside me and asked about every single thing; and I told her all of it, in the right order. And then she said this.

All of that is finished, then. Now listen to what I tell you — and a god himself will remind you of it.

You will come first to the Sirens, who bewitch every man who comes near them. Whoever comes on them without knowing, and hears the Sirens' voice, his wife and his little children never stand round him and welcome him home again. The Sirens bewitch him with their clear singing, sitting in a meadow; and there is a great heap of men's bones round about them, rotting, with the skin shrivelling on them.

Drive past. And knead sweet wax and stop up your companions' ears, so that none of them can hear. But if you want to hear it yourself, then have them tie you hand and foot in the fast ship, standing upright against the

mast-step, with the ropes made fast to the mast itself — so that you can listen to the voices of the two Sirens and enjoy it. And if you beg them and order them to let you go, then let them tie you down with more ropes still.

And when your companions have driven the ship past them, then I am not going to tell you which of two roads you should take. You must work that out in your own mind. I shall describe them both.

On one side there are overhanging rocks, and the great wave of dark-eyed Amphitrite (Poseidon's wife, who breeds the monsters of the sea) roars against them. The blessed gods call them the Wandering Rocks. Nothing that flies gets past — not even the timid doves that carry ambrosia to father Zeus; the smooth rock always takes one of them, and the father sends another up to make the number right. And no ship of men that ever came there has got away; the waves of the sea and the blasts of destroying fire carry off ships' timbers and men's bodies together. One seagoing ship alone ever sailed past — the Argo, that everybody sings about — on her way home from Aeetes; and even her the wave would have thrown against the great rocks, but Hera (queen of the gods) sent her through, because Jason was dear to her.[59]

On the other side there are two cliffs. One of them reaches the wide sky with its sharp peak, and a dark cloud stands round it and never streams away, and there is never clear air about the top of it, in summer or in autumn. No mortal man could climb it, not if he had twenty hands and twenty feet, because the rock is smooth, like something polished. And halfway up that cliff there is a misty cave, facing west, towards the darkness. That is where you will steer your hollow ship past, glorious Odysseus. A strong man shooting from a ship could not reach that cave with an arrow.

And Scylla lives in it, yelping horribly. Her voice is no bigger than the voice of a new-born puppy, but she herself is a dreadful monster; nobody would be glad to look at her, not even a god. She has twelve feet, all of them dangling, and six necks, immensely long, and on each of them an appalling head with three rows of teeth in it, thick and close together, full of black death. She is sunk to her middle inside the hollow cave, but she holds her heads out beyond the terrible gulf and fishes there, sweeping round the rock for dolphins and sea-dogs and whatever bigger thing she can catch. No sailors have ever yet got past her and been able to boast that their ship came through untouched. She takes a man in each head, and carries him off out of the dark-prowed ship.

The other cliff is lower — you will see; they are close together, and you could shoot an arrow across. On that one there is a great fig tree covered in leaves, and underneath it divine Charybdis sucks the black water down. Three times a day she throws it up, and three times she sucks it down, terribly. Do not be there when she sucks it down. Nobody could save you from destruction then, not even the Earthshaker.

Go close along Scylla's cliff instead, and drive the ship past fast. It is far better to grieve for six of your companions than for all of them together.

Goddess, tell me this truly. Could I somehow get clear of deadly Charybdis and still fight the other one off, when she goes for my men?

You obstinate man. So your mind is on fighting again, and on hard work. Will you not give way even to the immortal gods? She is not mortal. She is an immortal evil — terrible, savage, impossible to fight. There is no defending yourself. Running is best. If you stop to put your armour on beside that rock, I am afraid she will come out at you again with as many heads as before, and take as many men. Drive past hard, and shout for Crataiis, who is Scylla's mother, and who bore her as a curse to men. She will stop her coming a second time.

[59]**The Argo, and a poem that is not this one.** Circe drops the name of another ship and another voyage as though everybody knew all about it, which they did — the story of Jason and the golden fleece was old and famous when this poem was young. Notice how the reference is made: not *there was a ship called Argo*, but *the Argo that everybody sings about*, which is one poet acknowledging a rival hit. It is the clearest single sign that the two poems we have are survivors from a whole crowded literature. There were epics about Thebes, about the war before the war at Troy, about the homecomings of all the other Greek captains, about Heracles, about the Argo; there were men who could sing every one of them; and all of it is gone, except the odd line quoted by a later writer, and except for moments like this, where one poem waves at another across the water as it goes past.

Then you will reach the island of Thrinacia. And there a great many cattle of Helios (the Sun, who sees everything and hears everything) graze, and his fat flocks: seven herds of cattle, and as many fine flocks of sheep, and fifty in each. They bear no young and they never die, and goddesses are their shepherds. If you leave those alone, and keep your mind on getting home, then you may still all reach Ithaca, badly off as you will be. But if you do them any harm, then I am telling you now: destruction for your ship and your men. And if you get out of it yourself, you will come home late and in a bad way, having lost every one of them.

And the Dawn came up while she was still speaking; and the shining goddess went away up the island.

Almost everybody arrives at the Sirens carrying the wrong picture, and it is not the reader's fault but two and a half thousand years of paintings. Homer never describes them. Not their faces, not their bodies, not their number beyond Circe's passing *the two Sirens*; and there is no suggestion anywhere of the bedroom about them. The bird-bodies came later out of vase-painting, the fish-tails out of a medieval muddle with mermaids, and the seductress with the comb and the mirror is largely the nineteenth century. What the poem gives is a meadow, a heap of men with the skin drying on their bones, and a song — and when we hear the song, in a page or two, it will turn out to be an offer of *knowledge*. We know what happened at Troy, they sing, and everything that happens anywhere on the earth. Come and be told; you will go away knowing more.

Which means the hook is baited with precision for exactly one man's weakness, and it is not lust. It is the thing that took him into a stranger's cave to see what gift he might be given, and up every lookout on every island, and down to a pit at the edge of the world to ask the dead questions after he already had his answer.

So I went to the ship and roused my men, and Circe sent us a following wind behind the dark-prowed ship, a good companion, filling the sail. And then I spoke to my companions, sick at heart.

Friends. It is not right that only one or two of us should know the prophecies Circe told me. I shall tell you, so that we may all know them, and then either die, or get away from death and out from under our fate. First of all she told us to keep away from the voices of the marvellous Singers, and from their flowering meadow. She said I alone might listen. But you must tie me with hard bonds, standing upright against the mast-step, with the ropes made fast to the mast itself. And if I beg you and order you to let me go, then you must tie me with more ropes still.

And meanwhile the ship came quickly to the island of the Sirens, because a fair wind drove her. And then the wind dropped, all at once, and there was a windless calm, and some god put the swell to sleep. My companions stood up and furled the sail and stowed it, and sat down to the oars and made the water white with the polished pine.

And I took a great round cake of wax and cut it up small with the sharp bronze and worked it in my strong hands; and the wax grew warm quickly, because of the great pressure and the rays of the lord Sun; and I went along the line and stopped the ears of every man of them. And they tied me hand and foot in the ship, upright against the mast-step, with the ropes made fast to the mast; and then they sat down and struck the grey sea with their oars.

And when we were within calling distance, driving hard, the Sirens saw the fast ship coming close, and they raised their clear song.

Come here, famous Odysseus, great glory of the Greeks. Stop your ship, so that you can listen to the two of us. No man has ever yet driven his black ship past this place without listening to the honey-sweet voice out

of our mouths. Every man has gone away delighted with it, and knowing more than he did. Because we know everything — everything the Greeks and the Trojans suffered on the wide plain of Troy, by the will of the gods. And we know everything that happens on the fruitful earth.

That is what they sang, in beautiful voices, and my heart wanted to listen. And I made signs with my eyebrows to my companions to untie me. They fell forward on the oars and rowed; and Perimedes and Eurylochus got up at once and tied me with more ropes, and pulled them tighter.

And when they had rowed past, and we could no longer hear the Sirens' voices or their song, my trusty companions took the wax out of their ears and untied me.[60]

Odysseus could have stopped his own ears, of course. There was wax enough, and nothing in Circe's instructions obliged him to listen; she offered it as an option, and it is the option nobody sensible would take. So he deafened every man aboard and had himself made helpless instead, and arranged to be the only person in the world who has heard that song and lived — and, as it happens, the only man on that ship who would ever be in a position to tell anybody about it. Which he is doing, at this moment, at dinner.

And the moment we had left that island behind, I saw smoke, and a great wave, and I heard a booming. And the oars flew out of their hands in terror, and all the oars splashed down along the current, and the ship stopped dead where she was.

And I went along the ship and stood over every man and heartened him with soft words. *Friends. We are not exactly ignorant of trouble. This is no worse than when the Cyclops shut us in his hollow cave by main force. Even out of that we got away, by my courage and my planning and my wits; and I think we shall remember this one too, one day. So come — hit the deep surf of the sea with your oars, and see whether Zeus will let us get out from under our destruction. And you, steersman — here are your orders, and keep them in your mind. Hold the ship out beyond that smoke and that surf, and hug the cliff on the other side, and do not let her drift off the other way without your noticing, or you will throw us all into disaster.*

And they did as I said, quickly.

I did not say a word to them about Scylla — a trouble there was no dealing with — in case my companions were frightened and stopped rowing and huddled together down inside the ship. And at that point I let Circe's grim instructions go clean out of my head, when she told me not to arm at all. I put my famous armour on, and took two long spears in my hands, and went up onto the fore-deck, because that was where I expected rocky Scylla to appear from first. And I could not make her out anywhere. My eyes got tired with staring, everywhere, up at that misty rock.

So we sailed up the narrow strait, and we were crying: Scylla on one side, and on the other divine Charybdis sucking the salt sea water down horribly. When she threw it up, she seethed and bubbled all over in a churning mess, like a cauldron on a great fire, and the spray flew high overhead and fell on the tops of both cliffs. And when she sucked the salt water down, the whole inside of her showed, churning, and the rock roared terribly all round, and the sea floor showed underneath, black with

[60]**The Sirens, and what they are not.** Homer never describes them: not their faces, not their bodies, not their number beyond Circe's passing *the two Sirens* — nothing but a meadow, a heap of rotting men, and a voice. The bird-bodies come from Greek vase-painting and funerary sculpture; the fish-tails come from a medieval muddle with mermaids in the north; and the seductress with the comb and the mirror is largely the nineteenth century, which had its own reasons for wanting the danger at sea to be a woman. What the poem does give, and gives precisely, is the content of the song, and it is a promise of knowledge: we know what happened at Troy, and we know everything that happens on the earth. That is what is written on the hook. The bones in that meadow belong to men who stopped rowing because they wanted to be told something.

sand. And a green fear took hold of my men.

We were looking at *her*, frightened of dying — and Scylla took six of my companions out of the hollow ship, the six best of them in strength and in their hands.

I turned my eyes back to the fast ship, looking for my men, and I saw their feet and their hands already above me as they were lifted up. And they screamed and called out to me by name, that one last time, with their hearts in agony.

The way a fisherman on a jutting rock, with a long pole, throws his bait down as a trap for the little fishes, and when he catches one he pulls it up and out and throws it on the shore, writhing: that is how they were pulled up towards the rocks, writhing. And there in her doorway she ate them, while they screamed and stretched their hands out towards me, in the most terrible struggle of all.

That was the most pitiful thing my eyes ever saw, out of everything I suffered searching out the ways of the sea.

That is the only place in the poem where somebody is told the exact price of a course of action in advance and pays it deliberately. Circe does not hint and she does not speak in riddles: one way loses the whole ship, the other loses six men, and six is better than all. He does the arithmetic and takes the six. It is the correct decision, and a commander who refused it would kill everybody — but it is worth saying plainly that this is what command is, in a way the older poem never quite has to face, since in the *Iliad* men die in battle facing an enemy, and here six men who have done nothing are given away in advance on a goddess's recommendation.

And they are not told. He says so, and gives his reason, and the reason is professional and almost certainly right: had they known there was something overhead that could not be fought, they would have dropped the oars, and then the ship would have drifted, and Charybdis would have had all of them. Nevertheless he stood in the bows in full armour with two spears, watching for her, having been told plainly that arming was useless and would only cost him a second six. He did it anyway; he could not help it. So the picture to carry out of this book is of a man in armour at the front of a ship, staring up at a cliff for something he has been assured he cannot fight, while behind him the men he did not warn pull at their oars in ignorance and six of them go up off the deck like fish on a line.

So we got clear of the rocks and of Charybdis and of Scylla; and then we came to the island of the god, where the fine broad-browed cattle of the Sun were, and his many fat flocks. And while I was still out at sea in the black ship I could hear the lowing of cattle being penned, and sheep bleating. And into my mind came the words of the blind prophet Teiresias, and of Circe, who had both told me very strictly to keep away from that island.

So I spoke to my companions, sick at heart, and told them both prophecies and named both sources, and said: drive the black ship past the island.

And their spirits broke in them. And Eurylochus answered me straight away, and there was hate in it.

You are a hard man, Odysseus. There is more strength in you than in other men and your limbs never get tired. You must be made entirely of iron, if you will not let your companions — worn out with hard work and lack of sleep — set foot on dry land, where we might get a decent supper ready on an island in the sea. Instead you tell us to go blundering off through the fast-coming night, driven away from the island over the misty water.

It is out of the night that the hard winds come, the ones that break ships up. How is any man to get out from under a sheer destruction, if a squall comes suddenly out of the South Wind or the blustering West — the ones

that most often smash a ship apart, whatever the gods who rule us may want? No. Let us give way to the black night now and get our supper, and stay beside the fast ship. In the morning we will go aboard and put out into the wide sea.

That is the best speech Eurylochus ever makes and nearly all of it is true. The men are exhausted; they have just watched six friends lifted off the deck and eaten; night is coming; and everything he says about the weather is not merely reasonable but professionally right. He is a seaman making a seaman's case. He is also entirely wrong, for the oldest of reasons: he does not know what his captain knows. He has not stood beside a pit in the dark and heard a dead prophet name that island. He is arguing about the weather with a man who is not arguing about the weather.

And all the rest of them agreed with him. And then I knew that some god was arranging trouble for us.

Eurylochus, you force my hand; I am one man against all of you. Very well. But all of you swear me a great oath: that if we find a herd of cattle or a big flock of sheep, no man will kill a single cow or a single sheep out of the wicked folly of his heart. Sit quietly and eat the food that immortal Circe gave us.

And they swore it, exactly as I told them to. And we moored the well-built ship in a hollow harbour beside a spring of sweet water, and my companions went ashore and made supper skilfully. And when they had put away all desire for food and drink, they began to weep, remembering the companions Scylla had taken and eaten. And a sweet sleep came over them while they were crying.

Then in the third watch of the night Zeus got up a screaming wind and an extraordinary storm, and hid the land and the sea alike in cloud, and night came rushing down out of the sky. And when Dawn came up we hauled the ship in and made her fast in a hollow cave, where the nymphs had their dancing floors and their seats. And I called them all together and said: friends, there is food and drink in the fast ship; let us keep our hands off these cattle, in case we come to harm; these belong to a dreadful god, the Sun, who sees everything and hears everything.

And their proud hearts agreed.

And then the South Wind blew for a whole month, and no other wind came at all, except the East and the South. Now as long as my men had food and red wine, they kept their hands off the cattle, because they wanted to live. But when all the provisions in the ship were used up, they had to go roving after game, whatever they could get: fish, and birds, anything that came to their hands, with bent hooks — because hunger was wearing away their stomachs.

And I went up the island to pray to the gods, hoping one of them would show me a way home. And when I had got away from my companions I washed my hands somewhere out of the wind and prayed to all the gods who hold Olympus.

And they poured a sweet sleep over my eyelids.

And Eurylochus began to put an evil plan to my companions.

Listen to me, my companions, for all the bad things you have suffered. Every kind of death is hateful to us miserable men. But dying of hunger, and meeting your fate that way, is the most pitiful of all. Come on. Let us drive off the best of the Sun's cattle and sacrifice to the immortals who hold the wide sky. And if we ever get back to Ithaca, our own country, we will build a rich temple to the Sun straight away and put a great many fine offerings in it. And if he is angry about his straight-horned cattle, and wants to wreck our ship, and the other gods agree with him — then I would rather lose my life all at once, with one gulp at the wave, than be squeezed slowly to death on a desert island.

And all the rest of them agreed with him. And at once they drove off the best of the Sun's cattle

from close by. And they stood round them and prayed to the gods, pulling the soft leaves off a tall oak, because they had no white barley on the ship. And when they had prayed and cut the throats and flayed them, they cut out the thigh pieces and covered them with a double fold of fat and laid raw meat on top; and they had no wine to pour over the burning offerings, so they poured water instead, and roasted all the entrails.

And at that moment the sweet sleep went off my eyelids, and I went down to the fast ship and the shore of the sea. And when I was close to the ship the warm smell of the fat came round me, and I cried out to the immortal gods: *Father Zeus, and the rest of you blessed gods who live forever — you lulled me into a pitiless sleep, to destroy me. And my companions, left to themselves, have planned a monstrous thing.*

There is the pattern this poem has been assembling since the beach at Ismarus, complete at last. He warned them, in full, with both sources named. He lost the argument. He took the only step left and made them swear an oath, and they swore it and meant it. And then the wind blew for a month, and the food ran out, and he was up a hill asleep.

And Lampetie went as a messenger to the Sun to tell him we had killed his cattle. And he spoke among the immortals, furious.

Father Zeus, and the rest of you blessed gods — take vengeance on the companions of Odysseus, who have insolently killed my cattle, the cattle I always took pleasure in, going up into the starry sky and turning back down again to earth. If they do not pay me a proper compensation, I shall go down into the house of Hades and shine among the dead.

Sun — go on shining among the immortals and among mortal men on the grain-giving earth. I shall very soon strike their fast ship with a bright thunderbolt and smash it to pieces in the middle of the wine-dark sea.

(I had that from Calypso of the beautiful hair. She told me she had heard it herself from Hermes the messenger.)[61]

And when I got down to the ship I rebuked them, going from one to another. And we could find no remedy: the cattle were already dead. And then the gods began showing us portents. The hides crawled. The meat on the spits bellowed, both the roasted and the raw. And there was a noise like the voice of cattle.

For six days my trusty companions feasted on the best of the Sun's cattle. And when Zeus brought on the seventh day, then the wind stopped raging in a storm, and we went aboard at once and put out into the wide sea, and set up the mast and hoisted the white sail.

But when we had left that island behind, and no other land showed, nothing but sky and sea, then Zeus set a black cloud over the hollow ship, and the sea went dark underneath it.

She did not run for very long after that. The West Wind came at once, shrieking, blowing in a great

[61] **How he knows what Zeus said.** This is one of my favourite lines in the poem and it is nearly always skipped. Odysseus has just reported a private conversation on Olympus between the Sun and the king of the gods — and he stops dead, mid-story, to tell his audience where he got it. Calypso told him; and she said Hermes had told her. Think what that means: somewhere on that island, in the middle of those seven years, a goddess and a man sat down and she passed on a piece of divine gossip about the day his crew died, which she had from the messenger of the gods, and he has carried it ever since and is retailing it now at a dinner party. The poem makes nothing of it. It simply notes the chain of custody, the way a careful witness does — and it is the only place in four books where the teller stops to explain how he came by something he could not have seen. It is exactly the sort of thing an honest man does, and exactly the sort of thing a very good liar does, and there is no way on earth to tell which from the outside.

tempest, and the blast of it snapped both the forestays of the mast; and the mast fell backwards, and all the gear spilled down into the bilge; and the mast caught the steersman on the head in the stern of the ship and smashed every bone in his skull together, and he went down off the deck like a diver, and his proud spirit left his bones.

And Zeus thundered at the same moment and threw his bolt into the ship. And she shuddered from end to end, struck by the bolt of Zeus, and filled with the smell of sulphur; and my men fell out of her. They were carried on the waves round the black ship like sea-crows, and the god took away their homecoming.

And I kept going up and down the ship until the sea tore the sides away from the keel, and the wave carried the bare hull along. And it broke the mast off level with the keel — and the backstay had been thrown over it, a rope made of oxhide — and with that I lashed the keel and the mast together, and sat on the two of them, and was carried along by the ruinous winds.

Then the West Wind stopped raging. And the South Wind came on quickly, bringing pain to my heart, because it meant I would have to measure out the road back to deadly Charybdis all over again. All night I was carried, and at sunrise I came to Scylla's cliff and to terrible Charybdis. And she was sucking the salt sea water down.

And I sprang up towards the tall fig tree and got hold of it and hung on like a bat. There was nowhere I could get a footing or climb up: the roots were far below and the branches were out of reach above, long and heavy, and they overshadowed Charybdis. And I held on grimly and waited for her to spit the mast and the keel up again. And they came at last, to my great relief. At the hour when a man gets up from the assembly and goes to his supper — a man who has been settling a great many quarrels among young men who want a judgement — at that hour the timbers came out of Charybdis.

And I let go with my hands and feet and dropped, and came down with a crash in the water beside those long timbers; and I got up on them and rowed along with my hands. And the father of gods and men did not let Scylla catch sight of me. Otherwise I would not have got out from under a sheer destruction.

Nine days I was carried, and on the tenth night the gods brought me to Ogygia, where Calypso lives, who took me in and looked after me.

But why should I tell you all this? I told it to you and your good wife yesterday, in this house, and I hate telling a story twice when it has already been told properly.

And he stops there, which is a very fine last line: not a flourish, not a summary and certainly not a moral, but a small piece of good manners. *You have heard the rest. It would be rude to repeat myself.* It closes the frame, too. From here to the end there is no more first person and no more monsters. The next time we see him he will be asleep in the bottom of somebody else's boat, and when he wakes he will be on a beach he does not recognise, in his own country, and he will start lying again for quite different reasons.

I shall take it back from here.

NOTES TO BOOK TWELVE

Book Thirteen: In Which a Man Is Carried Home Asleep, and Does Not Know Where He Is.

Unreferenced Footnote Definitions These note definitions are present in the source Markdown even though no footnote marker links to them.

Note 4. The cattle of the Sun, and a promise kept. Turn back to the first page of Book One and look at what the poem chose to say about the crew in its opening breath: that they died through their own recklessness, the fools, because they ate the cattle of the Sun, and the Sun took away their day of homecoming. That is the only specific event in the entire twelve-year voyage that the poem announces in advance. Not the Cyclops, not the witch, not the descent to the dead. This. Which tells you what the poem thinks the story of the crew actually is; and it has now delivered exactly what it promised, eleven books later, with the reasons attached — they were starving, they had sworn an oath, their captain was asleep on a hillside, and the man who talked them into it made a speech about how a quick death is better than a slow one.

Note 5. Between Scylla and Charybdis. The phrase has been in English for centuries and most people who use it do not know it means something quite specific: not merely two dangers, but two dangers of *unequal and known* cost, where the whole art lies in choosing the smaller deliberately and paying it. The rock will certainly take six men; the whirlpool may take everybody. Circe's advice is not to be brave and not to be clever — it is to steer close to the thing that will definitely maim you in order to stay clear of the thing that might destroy you altogether. People have been trying to put the pair on a map since antiquity, the usual candidate being the Strait of Messina, which has a real tidal race in it; I would not lean on it. Charting this poem is a very old amusement that has produced a large library and no agreement whatever, and the poem is doing something more interesting than describing a coastline. It is describing a decision, of a kind anybody who has had to make one will recognise, and it has been lending people the words for it ever since.

Book 13

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK THIRTEEN

In Which a Man Is Carried Home Asleep, and Does Not Know Where He Is

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I have the story back, and I should say at once that everything is about to change. For twelve books we have been travelling, and if you have been keeping a map in your head it is by now a large and crowded one. From here there is no map at all. We arrive in one small place and stay in it for twelve books and never leave, and the whole of the rest of this poem happens on a rocky island you could walk across in a day, mostly indoors, and mostly among people talking to one another. The monsters are finished; there is not another one in the book. What takes their place is a farmhouse, a pigsty, a hall full of young men eating another man's dinner, and a woman upstairs who has been thinking for twenty years — and I will say plainly that I find the second half the greater achievement, because anybody with a good imagination can put a giant in a cave, and it takes something else to make you hold your breath over a husband and wife who both know more than they are saying.

They all sat in silence, held in the spell of it, through the shadowy hall. And Alcinous answered him:

"Odysseus — since you have come to my house with its bronze floor and its high roof, I do not think you will be driven off your course again, badly as you have suffered. And to every one of you here, who are always drinking the sparkling wine of the elders in my halls and listening to the singer, I say this. There are clothes already stored in the polished chest for the stranger, and worked gold, and all the other gifts the Phaeacian counsellors brought here. Come — let us each of us give him a great tripod and a cauldron as well; and then we will collect it back from the people afterwards, because it is a hard thing for one man to give freely without being repaid."

That pleased them all, and they went off home to bed. And when Dawn came up they hurried down to the ship carrying the bronze; and the king himself went about the ship and stowed everything under the benches with his own hands, so that none of it would get in the crew's way when they were pulling on the oars.

Then they went back to the house and made a feast, and Alcinous sacrificed an ox to Zeus; and they burned the thigh pieces and enjoyed a splendid dinner, and Demodocus sang among them, the singer whom the people honoured.

But Odysseus kept turning his head towards the blazing sun, willing it to set, because he was longing to be gone. The way a man longs for his supper when a pair of wine-dark oxen have been dragging the jointed plough through fallow ground all day for him, and the sun going down is a very welcome thing, so that he can go to his supper at last, and his knees ache as he walks — that is how welcome the setting of the sun was to Odysseus.

"Lord Alcinous, most distinguished of all your people. Pour your libations now and send me off

unharmed; and my good wishes to all of you. Everything my heart wanted is done: my passage home, and gifts given in friendship. May the gods make them prosper for me. And may I find my faultless wife at home when I come, and everyone I love unhurt. And may all of you here make your wedded wives and your children glad, and may the gods grant you every kind of excellence, and may no trouble ever come near your people."

They all approved. And Odysseus stood up and put his two-handled cup into Arete's hands. "Fare well, queen, all your years, until old age comes, and death, which come to everybody. I am going now. May you have joy in this house of your children and your people, and of Alcinous the king."

And with that he stepped over the threshold. Heralds went with him down to the fast ship, and Arete sent her women too: one carrying a clean cloak and tunic, and one bringing the strong chest, and another with bread and red wine. And when they had got it all aboard, they spread a rug and a linen sheet for Odysseus on the deck at the stern of the hollow ship, so that he could sleep soundly. And he went aboard and lay down in silence.

They sat down in order at the oars and cast the cable off the pierced stone, and leaned back and threw up the sea with their blades. And a sweet sleep fell on his eyelids: unbroken, very sweet, and extremely like death.

The way four stallions harnessed abreast on a plain spring forward together under the lash, and rise high in their stride and get through the road quickly — that is how the stern of that ship lifted, and behind her the dark wave of the loud-roaring sea went seething past. She ran on, steady and safe, and not even the wheeling hawk could have kept up with her, which is the fastest thing that flies. So she ran, cutting the waves, carrying a man whose mind was like the mind of the gods, who had suffered a great many griefs in his heart, and who was now asleep, quite still, and had forgotten everything he had suffered.

And when the brightest star came up, the one that most often announces the light of early Dawn, the seafaring ship drew in to the island.

There is a harbour there belonging to Phorcys, the old man of the sea, in the country of Ithaca; and two headlands run out into it, sheer on the seaward side but sloping down towards the harbour, and they keep off the great waves that hard winds raise outside, so that inside, once they have come to their anchorage, well-benched ships can lie without any mooring at all. And at the head of the harbour there is a long-leaved olive tree, and close beside it a lovely cave, full of shadow, sacred to the nymphs who are called Naiads. Inside it there are mixing bowls and jars made of stone, and the bees store their honey in them; and there are long looms of stone, where the nymphs weave their sea-purple webs, and it is a wonder to see; and there is water in there, always running. And it has two doors. One faces the North Wind, and that is the way men go down into it. The other faces the South, and belongs to the gods; and men do not go in that way at all. It is the road of the immortals.[62]

[62]**The cave with two doors.** A cave at the head of the harbour, sacred to the water-nymphs, with stone mixing bowls and stone looms inside it, bees making honey in the jars, water always running, and two entrances — a northern one for men and a southern one that only gods use. It is a beautiful piece of description and later readers could not leave it alone. There survives a whole treatise on it, written some nine hundred years after the poem by the philosopher Porphyry, arguing that every detail is an allegory of the soul's descent into the body and its return: the cave is the material world, the honey is the pleasure that traps us, the two doors are the gates by which souls come into life and go out of it, and so on for many pages. I mention it partly because it is charming and partly as a warning, since this poem attracts that kind of reading the way a wall attracts ivy, and the ivy is often lovely and occasionally tells you more about the reader than the wall. At the plain level the cave is doing something simple and rather good: he is being put ashore, unconscious, at the threshold of a place where the gods have their own private door.

They rowed in there, knowing the place from old days; and the ship ran up onto the beach for half her length, driven on by the hands of the rowers. And they lifted Odysseus out of the hollow ship, still in the linen sheet and the bright rug, and laid him down on the sand, overpowered with sleep. And they carried out the goods the Phaeacians had given him and piled it all together beside the trunk of the olive tree, well off the road, in case some traveller came by and robbed him before he woke.

Then they went home again.

But Poseidon had not forgotten the threats he made against Odysseus long ago, and he went to ask Zeus what he meant to do about it.

"Father Zeus. I shall not be honoured among the immortal gods any longer, when mortal men do not honour me in the least — the Phaeacians, who are of my own blood. I always said Odysseus would get home only after a great deal of suffering; I never denied him a homecoming altogether, since you had promised him one and bowed your head on it. And now they have carried him asleep in a fast ship over the sea and set him down in Ithaca, and given him gifts past counting — bronze and gold and woven cloth, more than he could ever have brought out of Troy if he had come home unhurt with his fair share of the plunder."

"What a thing to say, wide-ruling Earthshaker. The gods do not dishonour you at all; it would be a hard business to assail the eldest and best of us with dishonour. And if any man gives way to his own strength and does not honour you, you always have your revenge afterwards. Do whatever you like, and whatever pleases your heart."

"I would have done it long ago, exactly as you say — but I always hold back from your anger and keep out of its way. What I should like now is to smash that beautiful Phaeacian ship on the misty sea as she comes back from her escort duty, so that they will stop this business and give up ferrying men about. And I should like to put a great mountain over their city."

"Here is what seems best to me. When all the people are looking out from the town, watching her come on — then turn her into a stone close inshore, a stone shaped like a fast ship, so that everyone will marvel at it. And then put your great mountain over their city."

So Poseidon went to Scheria and waited there. And when the seafaring ship came in, running fast and close, the Earthshaker came up to her and struck her flat with the palm of his hand and turned her into stone, and rooted her to the bottom by pressing down; and then he went away.

And the Phaeacians stood talking to one another, and one would look at the man beside him and say: "Who has bound our fast ship on the sea as she was running home? We could see the whole of her a moment ago."

And Alcinous spoke among them. "This is the fulfilment of the old prophecy my father used to tell me. He said Poseidon was angry with us because we give safe passage to everybody, and that one day, as a beautiful Phaeacian ship came home from an escort, the god would smash her on the misty sea and put a great mountain over our city. That is what the old man said. And now all of it is coming true.

"So let every one of us do as I say. Stop escorting mortals, from now on, whoever comes to our city. And let us sacrifice twelve chosen bulls to Poseidon, and hope he may pity us and not put a long mountain over our town."

And they were frightened, and got the bulls ready. So they were praying to the lord Poseidon — the leaders and the counsellors of the Phaeacian people — standing about the altar.

And there the poem leaves them, and never goes back. We are not told whether the mountain fell.

The last we see of the kindest people in this book — who took a naked stranger off a beach, fed him before asking his name, gave him a chair their own prince had to get out of, loaded him with treasure and refused to be thanked, and carried him home for nothing while he slept — is a crowd of them at an altar with twelve bulls, praying that a hill will not come down on their harbour. I have found no way of making that comfortable. Alcinous did not overreach; he kept the law of guest-friendship rather better than it required. What has happened is that a nation whose whole vocation is carrying lost men home has crossed a god whose particular business, for twenty years, has been stopping one lost man from getting home — and has done it by being good at the thing they are good at. Their virtue is the offence. And the poem stops the sentence halfway, so that we are left with the raised hands and the shadow of a hill that may or may not be coming.[63]

And Odysseus woke up in his own country, and did not know it. He had been away a long time; and besides, Athena had poured a mist round the place, so that she could make him unrecognisable to everyone and tell him what he needed to know, and so that his wife and his townspeople and his friends should not know him until the suitors had paid for every one of their offences. So everything looked strange to its own master: the long paths, and the harbours where ships can lie, and the steep rocks, and the trees in leaf.

He sprang up and stood and looked at his own country, and groaned, and struck both his thighs with the flat of his hands.

"What is it now? Whose country have I come to this time? Are they violent and wild and unjust, or do they welcome strangers, and have they god-fearing minds? And where am I to take all this property? And where am I to go myself?

"I wish it had stayed with the Phaeacians. I could have gone to some other great king, who would have entertained me and sent me on my way. As it is, I do not know where to put this, and I am not going to leave it here for somebody else to walk off with.

"It seems the Phaeacian leaders were not so wise and just after all. They have taken me to the wrong country. They said they would bring me to Ithaca, and they have not done it. May Zeus of the suppliants pay them out.

"But come — let me count my goods and see whether they have gone off with anything in their hollow ship."

And he counted the beautiful tripods and the cauldrons, and the gold, and the fine woven cloth. And not one thing was missing. And then he cried for his own country, dragging himself along the shore of the loud-roaring sea, grieving heavily.

Home at last, after twenty years, and the first thing he does on the soil of Ithaca is take an inventory. I would not make him small for it — he has woken alone on an unknown beach with no crew, no ship

[63] **The sentence that is never finished.** The prophecy was planted in Book Eight, note 4, where Alcinous mentioned it in the middle of a boast and shrugged it off. It has now half come true: the ship is stone. Whether the mountain came down, the poem does not say. Ancient readers argued about it hard, and the argument turned on one Greek word in Zeus's instructions, which can be read either as *and cover their city* or as *but do not cover their city* — the whole fate of a nation resting on a syllable, with some manuscripts and some ancient critics going each way. So the ambiguity may not merely be the poem declining to tell us; it may be built into the text at the level of the grammar, and it has been unresolved since antiquity. I find I would rather it stayed that way. A poem that has spent three books teaching you to love a people, and then puts them at an altar under a shadow and looks away, is doing something no tidier ending would do half so well.

and a heap of portable wealth lying in the open, which in this world is less a fortune than a reason for somebody to kill you. But notice that he finds nothing missing, and it does not shift him an inch: the Phaeacians have done exactly what they promised and stacked his treasure under a tree with more care than most men would take with their own, and he counts every cup and goes on grieving. He has been right to be suspicious so often that his mind runs there before his eyes can argue. The mist that is really keeping him from recognising the place is not entirely the goddess's.

Then Athena came up to him in the likeness of a young man, a shepherd of sheep, delicate-looking, the way kings' sons are, with a well-made double cloak round his shoulders and a javelin in his hand. And Odysseus was glad to see him.

"Friend — since you are the first person I have met in this place — good day to you. Do not come at me with any ill will. Save these goods of mine, and save me. I pray to you as I would to a god, and I have come to your knees. Tell me this truly. What country is this? What people? Is it one of the clear-seen islands, or some coast of the mainland sloping down to the sea?"

"You must be a fool, stranger, or you have come a very long way, if you are asking about this country. It is not so nameless as all that. A great many people know it. It is rugged, and no good for driving horses; but it is not a poor place either, for all that it is narrow. There is grain here past describing, and wine as well; and there is always rain on it and fresh dew; it is good country for goats and for cattle; there is timber of every kind, and the watering places never fail. So the name of Ithaca, stranger, has reached even to Troy, which they tell me is a long way from the land of Greece."

And the heart of the much-enduring man leapt, and he was glad because of his own country. And then he did not tell her the truth. He held back the thing he had been about to say, always turning over some very shrewd counsel in his breast.

"Yes — I heard of Ithaca even in Crete, out over the sea; and now I have come here myself, with these goods. And I left as much again behind for my children when I ran, because I killed a man: the son of Idomeneus, Orsilochus, who was quicker on his feet than anybody in the whole of Crete. He wanted to rob me of my plunder from Troy, that I had gone through so much for, because I would not do his father a favour and serve under him at Troy, but had my own command. I struck him with a bronze-tipped spear as he came in from the field; I lay in wait for him beside the road with one companion, and a black night covered the sky, and nobody saw us.

"And when I had killed him I went to a ship at once and begged the lordly Phoenicians, and gave them as much plunder as satisfied them. I asked them to take me and set me down at Pylos, or at Elis. But the force of the wind drove them away from there, very much against their will; they were not trying to cheat me. And we came here off our course in the night. We rowed into the harbour with a great deal of trouble, and not one of us gave a thought to supper, badly as we wanted it; we simply got out of the ship and lay down. And a sweet sleep came over me, tired as I was; and they took my goods out of the hollow ship and set them down beside me where I was lying on the sand, and went aboard, and sailed for Sidon. And I was left behind, sick at heart."

And Athena smiled at him, and stroked him with her hand.[64]

[64]**The Cretan lies.** This is the first of several — he will tell four or five more before the poem ends, to the swineherd, to the suitors, to Penelope and to his own father — and they are worth watching as a set, because they are not improvisations. They are variations on one story, told with such consistency that scholars call them the Cretan tales: he is always a Cretan of good family, there is always a killing or a wrong done to him, there is always a flight by sea, and there are almost always Phoenician traders involved. He can produce it under any pressure, in any company, at any length. Two things make Crete a good choice. It was a real and famous place with a real and famous king, far enough from Ithaca to be unverifiable but close enough to be plausible, and exactly the sort of place a wandering man of rank might genuinely have come from. And

She turned into a woman then, tall and beautiful and skilled at glorious handiwork.

"He would have to be a cunning man, and a thief, who could get past you in any kind of trickery — even if it were a god who met you. You terrible man. Crafty-minded. Never tired of deceiving. So even in your own country you were not going to give up your tricks and your lying stories, which you love from the bottom of your heart.

"Come — let us not talk about it any more. The two of us know all about craft. You are far the best of all men at planning and at speaking, and I am famous among all the gods for wisdom and for sharpness. And you did not know Athena, the daughter of Zeus, who always stands beside you and guards you in every trouble — and who made you loved by all the Phaeacians.

"And I have come here now to weave a plan with you, and to hide the goods the Phaeacians gave you, because I put it in their minds; and to tell you how much you still have to suffer in your own well-built house. Endure it. You must. And do not tell anybody, man or woman, that you have come back from your wandering. Take a great deal of pain in silence, and put up with men's violence."

"Goddess, it is hard for a mortal man to know you when he meets you, however clever he is, because you take whatever shape you please. But I do know this: you were kind to me in the old days, all the while we sons of the Greeks were fighting at Troy. And when we had sacked the steep city of Priam (Troy) and gone away in our ships, and a god scattered the Greeks — after that I never saw you. I never noticed you coming aboard my ship to keep grief away from me. I went on wandering with a torn heart until the gods let me out of it.

"So now I beg you by your father — because I do not believe I have come to Ithaca; I think I am roaming about in some other country and you are saying this to mock me — tell me whether I really have come home."

"That is always the way your mind runs. And that is exactly why I cannot abandon you when you are in trouble — because you are civil, and quick-witted, and steady. Any other man coming home from wandering would have rushed off gladly to see his children and his wife in his own halls. You do not even want to *ask* about them, or find anything out, until you have first put your wife to the test — who is sitting in your halls exactly as she always was, and the nights and the days waste away for her, miserably, while she cries.

"I was never in any doubt about it myself. I knew you would come home, after losing all your companions. But I did not want to fight with Poseidon, my father's brother, who nursed his anger against you and was furious because you blinded his own son.

"But come, and I will show you the country of Ithaca, so that you can be sure."[65]

And she scattered the mist, and the land appeared. And Odysseus was glad, delighted with his own country, and kissed the grain-giving earth; and he lifted his hands and prayed to the nymphs.

Cretans already had a certain reputation in the Greek world for telling stories; the proverb about Cretan liars is later than this poem, but the joke it draws on is not. When Odysseus wants a false name and a false country, he reaches for the one that comes with a wink attached.

[65] **Why Athena stayed away.** She gives her reason plainly, and it is worth having, because it explains how the gods work here and will save a good deal of puzzling later. She did not abandon him and was never in doubt that he would survive; she simply would not fight her uncle. Poseidon was angry, Poseidon had a right to be angry, and no other god was going to stand in his way while the anger lasted — not out of fear exactly, but because that is not how these gods deal with one another. They do not overrule; they wait. Zeus does the same thing in this very book: told that his brother wants to punish a whole nation, he says, in effect, *please yourself.* So divine favour in this poem is not protection. Athena loves this man and has loved him for twenty years, and it did not save one of his ships or one of his men. What it does is arrive at the right moment with the right information, once the other god's back is turned. Worth knowing, when people call the *Odyssey* a poem in which the gods look after their favourites.

"Naiad nymphs, daughters of Zeus — I never expected to see you again. Now I greet you with these loving prayers. And we shall give you gifts as we used to, if the daughter of Zeus is kind and lets me live, and brings my dear son up to be a man."

That exchange is the hinge of the whole second half, and it goes past very lightly because she is laughing at him while she says it. *Any other man would have run home to his wife and children; you will not even ask after them until you have tested her.* His mother is dead of missing him and he has spoken to her ghost; his father is sleeping in the ashes; his son has grown up without ever seeing his face; and his wife has held off a hundred and eight armed men with a loom and her wits. He has landed, and his first instinct is not to find them but to find out. Athena is not scolding him — she admires it, and it is why she has stayed — but the poem is not the goddess, and it will spend ten books making us feel what it costs.

Then they sat down together beside the trunk of the sacred olive and planned death for the suitors.

"Son of Laertes. Think how you are going to get your hands on those shameless men, who have been lording it in your halls for three years now, courting your godlike wife and offering her wedding gifts. And she is forever grieving for you to come home, and she holds out hope to all of them, and makes each man promises, and sends them messages — and her mind is on something else entirely."

"Well. So I was very nearly going to die in my own halls the way Agamemnon died, if you had not told me all this, goddess. Come — weave me a plan, so that I can pay them back. And stand beside me, and put the same courage and daring into me that you did when we untied the shining diadem of Troy. If you would stand by me with that much fire in you, lady goddess, I would fight three hundred men."

"I shall be with you, certainly, and I shall not lose sight of you when we are about this work. And I think a good deal of the floor is going to be spattered with the blood and brains of the men who are eating up your living.

"Come now — I shall make you unrecognisable to everybody. I shall shrivel the good skin on your supple limbs, and take the fair hair off your head, and put a rag round you that anybody would shudder to see a man wearing; and I shall film over your eyes, that were so fine before — so that you look contemptible to all the suitors, and to your wife, and to the son you left behind.

"And you go first of all to the swineherd, who looks after your pigs. He is loyal to you, and fond of your son, and fond of steady Penelope. You will find him sitting with the swine, beside the Raven's Rock and the spring of Arethusa, eating acorns and drinking the black water — the things that make swine run to good fat. Stay there, and sit with him, and ask him about everything, while I go to Sparta to call your son home."

"Then why on earth did you not tell him, when you knew the whole of it? Was it so that he could wander about the barren sea in misery as well, while other men eat his living?"

"Do not let him weigh on you. I sent him myself, and I went with him, so that he might come out of it with a good name. He is not suffering at all; he is sitting comfortably in the house of Menelaus with an endless supply of everything beside him. There are young men lying in wait for him in a black ship, meaning to kill him before he can get back. I do not think it will happen. I think the earth will cover a few of those suitors first."

And with that she touched him with her wand. She shrivelled the good skin on his supple limbs and destroyed the fair hair on his head and put an old man's skin all over him, and filmed over his

eyes, which had been so fine. And she put a different cloak on him, and a tunic — filthy things, torn, blackened with foul smoke — and over it all she threw the big hide of a fast deer, worn bald. And she gave him a staff, and a shabby bag full of holes with a twisted cord to sling it by.

And when they had settled everything the two of them parted; and she went off to Sparta, to fetch his son.[66]

NOTES TO BOOK THIRTEEN

Book Fourteen: In Which a Swineherd Gives Away What He Cannot Spare, and Is Told a Great Many Lies.

[66]**The beggar's kit, and a debt paid.** Note what she gives him: a staff, and a bag with holes in it on a twisted string. That is the whole equipment of a professional beggar in this world, and beggary was a recognised way of living rather than a simple catastrophe — a man went from house to house, was given scraps, carried them in the bag, and had a place, of a low kind, in the order of things. Hospitality worked at the bottom of society as well as the top, and there were rules about it that men were expected to keep even towards the poorest arrival; much of what happens in the next eight books turns on who keeps them. — And there is a larger thing here. In Book Nine this man stood in the stern of a ship, out of danger, with his crew hanging off his arms begging him to be quiet, and shouted his own name across the water to a blinded giant, because he could not bear that the deed should belong to nobody. It cost him ten years. He is now going to walk into his own house in a filthy hide with a holed bag over his shoulder and not say that name to a living soul for eight books, while men throw furniture at him. Of everything the wand does to him on that beach, that is the real disguise, and it is the hardest thing this poem ever asks him to do.

Book 14

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK FOURTEEN

In Which a Swineherd Gives Away What He Cannot Spare, and Is Told a Great Many Lies

He went up from the harbour by a rough track, through wooded country and over the hills, to the place Athena had told him of, where he would find the good swineherd, who looked after his property better than any of the servants Odysseus had ever acquired.

He found him sitting in the doorway of his yard — a high yard, built in the open with a view all round, big and handsome, and standing free. The swineherd had built it himself for the pigs of his absent master, without saying anything to his mistress or to old Laertes: he had quarried the stones and put a hedge of wild pear along the top. And outside he had driven in a stockade of split oak stakes, all round, close together, taking the dark part of the wood. And inside the yard he had made twelve sties, side by side, for the sows to sleep in, and fifty breeding pigs were penned in each. The boars slept outside; there were far fewer of them, because the lordly suitors kept eating them and thinning them down, since the swineherd had to send them the pick of his fattest hog every day. There were three hundred and sixty left. And four dogs lay beside them, like wild beasts, which the swineherd had reared himself.

The dogs saw Odysseus and came at him barking, and he sat down cunningly and let the staff drop out of his hand. And there in his own farmyard he would have been badly mauled, but the swineherd came out fast on quick feet, and the leather fell out of his hands as he ran through the doorway shouting, and he drove the dogs off in all directions with a shower of stones.

"Old man, the dogs very nearly tore you to pieces, all in a moment, and you would have poured shame all over me. And the gods have given me plenty else to grieve about. Here I sit mourning for a master who was like a god, and rearing fat hogs for other men to eat, while he is very likely somewhere in a foreign country going hungry — if he is even alive and still sees the light of the sun.

"Come along in, old man. Come into the hut. When you have had bread and wine and eaten your fill, you can tell me where you are from and what you have suffered."

And the good swineherd led him in and sat him down, throwing down a great heap of brushwood and spreading over it the shaggy hide of a wild goat, which he slept on himself, and it was big and thick. And Odysseus was glad to be received like that, and said so.

"Stranger, it would not be right for me to turn away a stranger, not even one worse off than you. All strangers and beggars come from Zeus. What we give is small, and welcome; that is the way with servants, who live in fear when young men are the masters. The gods have certainly blocked the homecoming of the man who would have been fond of me and given me things of my own — a house, and a piece of land, and a wife other men wanted — the sort of thing a kind master gives a servant who has worked hard for him and whose work the gods have prospered. My work has prospered here. He would have looked after me handsomely if he had grown old in this place. But he is dead.

"I wish Helen's whole tribe had been wiped out root and branch, since she loosened the knees of so many men."[67]

He got up at once and pulled his belt tight round his tunic and went out to the sties where the young pigs were penned, and picked out two and brought them in and sacrificed them both, and singed them and cut them up and spitted them. And when he had roasted it all he brought it and set it in front of Odysseus, hot, still on the spits, and sprinkled white barley meal over it; and he mixed honey-sweet wine in an ivy-wood bowl and sat down opposite and told him to eat.

"Eat now, stranger — such as servants have. Sucking pigs. The suitors eat the fatted hogs, and they have no thought in their minds of the anger of the gods, and no pity.

"The blessed gods do not love a cruel action. They honour justice, and the right things men do. Even men who go out raiding another man's country, and Zeus grants them plunder and they load their ships and come home — even on their hearts there falls a heavy fear of what the gods will do.

"But these men know something. They have heard the voice of some god about my master's grim death, and so they will not court honestly and they will not go back to their own houses, but eat up his goods at their ease, insolently, and spare nothing. Every day and every night that comes from Zeus they slaughter victims, and not one or two either; and they draw the wine off and waste it.

"His living was enormous. No lord had so much, not on the dark mainland and not on Ithaca itself. Twenty men together have not so much wealth. I will count it for you. Twelve herds of cattle on the mainland, and as many flocks of sheep, and as many droves of pigs, and as many wide-ranging herds of goats, all pastured by hired men and by his own herdsmen. And here in Ithaca there are eleven herds of goats grazing at the far end of the island, with good men watching them; and every day each man drives in a beast for the suitors, the best of the fattened goats he has. And I look after these pigs and guard them, and pick out the best boar and send it up to them."

Odysseus ate the meat and drank the wine, ravenously, and said nothing, sowing trouble for the suitors. And when he had eaten and his heart was satisfied, the swineherd filled the bowl he had been drinking from himself and handed it over, brimming; and Odysseus took it, and was glad.

"Friend — who is this man who bought you with his own property? You say he was rich and powerful, and that he died for Agamemnon's honour. Tell me his name. I may know him. Zeus and the other immortals know whether I have seen him and can bring you news. I have wandered a great deal."

"Old man, no wanderer who came here with news of him would ever persuade his wife and his dear son. Men who need a lodging tell lies as they please and are not interested in telling the truth. Anybody who turns up on Ithaca goes straight to my mistress and spins her a tale, and she takes them in kindly and asks about everything, and the tears run down her face, which is what a woman does when her husband has died somewhere else.

"You would soon make up a story yourself, old man, if somebody gave you a cloak and a tunic for it.

"But by now the dogs and the swift birds will have torn the skin off his bones, and the life will have

[67] **A swineherd who curses Helen.** It is worth registering how far the war reaches. Eumaeus has never been to Troy, has no rank, owns nothing, and lives at the far end of a small island looking after pigs; and his considered opinion, offered in his first speech, is that Helen's whole family should have been destroyed. Twenty years earlier a quarrel in a palace on the mainland took his master away, and everything that has gone wrong in his life since has come out of it — the lost prospects, the house he was never given, the estate being eaten in front of him. When the poem wants to show you the cost of the war it does not go to a battlefield. It goes to a farm.

left him. Or the fish will have eaten him in the sea, and his bones will be lying on some beach wrapped in sand. So he has died out there; and there is grief left for all his friends afterwards, and for me most of all. I shall never find so kind a master again, wherever I go — not if I went back to the house of my own father and mother, where I was born and where they brought me up.

"And I do not grieve so much for them, badly as I want to see them with my own eyes in my own country, as I am taken with longing for Odysseus, who is gone. I shrink from saying his name, stranger, even though he is not here. He was extremely fond of me and cared about me in his heart. I call him *honoured sir*, though he is a long way off."

I should like to introduce this man properly, because we have just met the most decent person in the poem and he is going to be in it for the rest of the way.

Eumaeus keeps pigs. He is a slave; he says so himself in the second sentence he speaks, and mentions, without any particular weight, that the master who bought him has been gone twenty years and that he has kept the herd up regardless. He has built the yard he is standing in with his own hands, quarried the stone himself, hedged it and stockaded it, and done the whole thing on his own initiative without troubling the mistress or the old man. And he has done it for a household that has not sent him an order in two decades.

Notice what he does when a filthy old vagrant with a holed bag comes out of the woods. He drives the dogs off, apologises for them, gives up his own bed of brushwood and goat hide, kills two of the pigs he is answerable for, and hands over his own drinking bowl full. He has nothing whatever, and he gives away rather more of it than he can afford, to a stranger with no claim on him at all, because all strangers come from Zeus.

Up at the house, a hundred and eight men of good family are eating the same estate at the rate of a hog a day, and have been for three years.

The poem does not point at that. It does not need to; it simply puts the two households side by side and lets you look. But it does do one thing here that it does almost nowhere else, and it is a very strange and touching mannerism: when Eumaeus speaks, the poem sometimes turns and addresses him directly — *and you said to him in reply, swineherd Eumaeus* — as though the poet had temporarily forgotten he was narrating and had begun talking to the man instead.[68]

"Friend, since you deny it altogether and say he will never come back — well, I will not merely say it, I will swear it. Odysseus is coming home. And let me have my reward for the news the moment he sets foot in his own house: dress me in a cloak and a tunic, good clothes. Before that I will not take anything, badly as I need it. I hate a man who gives way to poverty and tells lies as much as I hate the gates of death.

"Let Zeus be my witness first of all, and this table of hospitality, and the hearth of Odysseus that I have come to. All of it will happen exactly as I say. Within this very month Odysseus will come here. As the old moon goes out and the new one comes in, he will come home; and he will take his revenge

[68] **"And you said to him, Eumaeus."** Several times in the next few books the poem stops narrating this man and starts *addressing* him, switching into the second person for a line — you said, you answered — and then switching back. It is a small thing and it has fascinated readers for a very long time. Only a handful of characters in Homer are ever spoken to like this: Patroclus in the *Iliad*, and Menelaus, and here a slave who keeps pigs. Nobody knows for certain why. The dullest explanation is metrical convenience, and it may be right. The explanation most readers prefer, and I confess I am one of them, is that the poet grew fond of him. It is the only place in this poem where the teller's own affection leaks visibly through the surface of the telling, and it happens to the poorest man in the story.

on every man who is dishonouring his wife and his son."

"Old man, I shall never pay you that reward, and Odysseus is not coming home. Drink your wine in peace and let us talk about something else; do not remind me of it. The heart in my breast hurts when anybody mentions my honoured lord.

"We will let the oath alone. But I do wish Odysseus would come, as I want him to, and Penelope too, and old Laertes and godlike Telemachus. And now I am grieving without stopping for the boy — for Telemachus, whom the gods reared like a young tree, and I used to think he would be no worse than his father among men, a wonder to look at. And some god, or some man, has upset the balance of his mind, and he has gone off to sacred Pylos after news of his father; and the lordly suitors are lying in wait for him on the way home, so that the line of Arceisius may be wiped out of Ithaca and leave no name.

"But let him be, whether he is caught or gets away. Tell me about your own troubles. Who are you? Where do you come from? What ship did you come on? How did the sailors bring you to Ithaca?"

"I will tell you all of it truly. I only wish the two of us had food and sweet wine enough to sit here in the hut and feast quietly while other people did the work — then I could talk for a whole year and not get to the end of my heart's troubles.

"By birth I am from Crete, and my father was a rich man. He had a great many other sons born and brought up in his halls, lawful sons of a wedded wife; and my mother was a bought woman, a concubine. But Castor son of Hylax honoured me exactly as he honoured his lawful sons, and he was honoured like a god among the Cretans for his good fortune and his wealth and his fine sons. And the fates of death carried him off to the house of Hades, and his sons divided up the property and cast lots for it, and gave me a very small share and a house.

"But I married a wife from a rich family, on my own merits, because I was no fool and no coward. All that is gone now; though I think you can tell what the crop was by looking at the stubble.

"Ares and Athena gave me courage. Whenever I picked the best men for an ambush, sowing trouble for the enemy, my proud heart never once saw death in front of it: I would leap out far ahead of everybody and take my man with the spear if he gave ground at all. That is what I was like in war. Work was never dear to me, nor keeping a careful house and rearing fine children; what I loved was ships with oars, and battles, and polished spears and arrows — grim things, that other people shudder at. I suppose some god put that in my heart. Different men take joy in different work.

"Before the sons of the Greeks ever set foot in Troy, I had nine times been the leader of men and fast ships against foreign parts, and a great deal fell into my hands. I took my pick of it and drew plenty more by lot, and my house grew rich quickly, and I became a man to be feared and respected among the Cretans.

"And when Zeus arranged that hateful expedition which loosened the knees of so many men, they told me and famous Idomeneus to lead the ships to Troy, and there was no way of refusing; the people's voice was too hard against it. Nine years we sons of the Greeks fought there, and in the tenth we sacked the city of Priam (Troy) and went home in the ships, and a god scattered the Greeks.

"And Zeus arranged trouble for me. I stayed one month only, enjoying my children and my wedded wife and my property; and then my heart told me to fit out ships and sail to Egypt with a crew of good men."

And he told the swineherd the whole of it: how nine ships were fitted out and the men came quickly; how they feasted six days and sailed on the seventh with a fair North Wind, easily, as if going down-

stream, and came to Egypt on the fifth day. How he told his crews to stay by the ships and sent scouts up to the lookout places — and how they gave way to their own insolence instead and went straight off and plundered the Egyptians' beautiful fields, and carried off the women and the little children and killed the men. How the cry reached the city, and the people came out at dawn, and the whole plain filled with foot soldiers and chariots and the flash of bronze; and how Zeus put a coward's panic into his companions and none of them dared stand, so that a great many were cut down with the sharp bronze and the rest were led away alive to work as slaves.

"And Zeus put this into my mind — and I wish I had died in Egypt then and met my fate there, because there was still more sorrow waiting to welcome me. I took the helmet off my head at once and the shield off my shoulders and threw the spear out of my hand, and went straight to the king's chariot and took hold of his knees and kissed them. And he protected me and pitied me, and put me in the chariot and took me home with me weeping. A great many of them came at me with their ash spears, wanting to kill me, because they were extremely angry. But he kept them off, and had a proper regard for the anger of Zeus who protects strangers, and who is angrier than anyone at wicked deeds."

He stayed there seven years, he said, and gathered a great deal of property among the Egyptians, because everybody gave him something. And in the eighth year a Phoenician came along, a man well practised in deceit, a greedy rogue who had already done a great deal of harm to people; and he talked him round and took him to Phoenicia, where his house and his goods were, and kept him a full year. And when the months and days had gone by and the year had come round again, he put him on a ship for Libya, having lied that he was to carry a cargo with him — and meaning in fact to sell him there for a very large price.

"I went with him, suspecting it, because I had no choice. And the ship ran before a fresh North Wind, out in mid sea beyond Crete; and Zeus arranged destruction for them. When we had left Crete and no other land showed, nothing but sky and sea, then the son of Cronos set a black cloud over the hollow ship and the sea went dark beneath it, and he thundered and threw his bolt into her. She shuddered from end to end, struck by the bolt of Zeus, and filled with the smell of sulphur, and every man fell out of her. They were carried on the waves round the black ship like sea-crows, and the god took away their homecoming.

"And Zeus himself, though my heart was in agony, put the enormous mast of the dark-prowed ship into my hands, so that I might get out from under my destruction even yet. I got my arms round that and was carried along by the ruinous winds. Nine days I was carried, and on the tenth black night a great rolling wave put me ashore in the country of the Thesprotians. And there the king of the Thesprotians, the hero Pheidon, looked after me for nothing, because his own son came on me lying there beaten down with cold and exhaustion, and raised me up by the hand and took me to his father's house, and gave me a cloak and a tunic to wear.

"And it was there I heard about Odysseus."

That, if I may say so, is a masterpiece, and the reason I have let it run at this length is that it is going to happen four more times before the poem ends and this is the one where you can watch the machinery.

Look at the shape of it. A Cretan of good family; a wrong done at the division of an inheritance; a life of raiding and ships; Troy; a disastrous eastern voyage; a treacherous Phoenician; a shipwreck in which everyone drowns but the teller; a rescue by a kind king. Almost all of it is untrue and every part of it is *nearly* his own life, turned a few degrees. He really did go to Troy and really did come home by

way of eleven disasters and really was the only man of his crew to live. He is not inventing a stranger. He is telling his own story with the names filed off, which is why he can do it at this length without a stumble, and why it will come out the same shape again to the next four people who ask.

And there is one true thing buried in the middle of it, which is the whole point of the exercise: *Odysseus is alive, he is close by, and he is coming.* The lie is the delivery system.[69]

He told him the rest: that the king had entertained Odysseus on his way home and showed him the treasure Odysseus had gathered, bronze and gold and worked iron, enough to keep a man's household to the tenth generation; that Odysseus had gone up to Dodona to ask the great oak of Zeus how he should come back to his own country after so long, openly or in secret; and that the king had sworn, pouring a libation with his own hands, that the ship was launched and the crew ready to take him home.

"But he sent me off first, because a Thesprotian ship happened to be leaving for Dulichium. He told them to take me carefully to king Acastus. And they decided among themselves to do me harm instead, so that I should come to complete misery. When the ship was well out from land they set about making me a slave. They stripped the cloak and tunic off me and put this filthy rag on me instead, and this tunic, torn, the ones you can see with your own eyes.

"And in the evening they came in to the fields of Ithaca, and tied me up in the well-benched ship with a twisted rope, and went ashore in a hurry and had their supper on the beach. And the gods themselves undid the knot for me, easily; and I wrapped the rag round my head and slid down the smooth lading-plank and put my chest to the water and swam off with both hands, and very soon I was well clear of them. Then I went up into a thicket of flowering brush and lay there crouching, and they went about groaning and looking; and when they thought there was no profit in searching any further they went back aboard.

"And the gods hid me easily, and brought me here to the farm of a man who understands things. So it seems it is still my lot to live."

"You poor man. You have stirred my heart up with all that. But you have not got it right about Odysseus, and you will not persuade me. Why does a man like you have to lie for no reason?

"I know how it stands with my master's homecoming. He was hated by all the gods, utterly, or they would have let him die at Troy, or in the arms of his friends when he had wound the war up. Then the whole Greek army would have made him a tomb, and he would have won great glory for his son as well. Now the storm winds have snatched him away without a word said.

"And I keep to myself here with the pigs, and I do not go to the city, unless sensible Penelope tells me to come, when news has arrived from somewhere. And then they all sit round the newcomer and question him closely — the ones who are grieving for their long-absent lord, and the ones who are delighted, eating up his living for nothing.

"But I have had no appetite for asking questions since an Aetolian took me in with a story. He had killed a man and wandered a long way, and came to my house, and I treated him kindly. He told me

[69] **The Cretan tales.** This is the longest of them and the best place to watch how they are built, since he will do it four more times — to the suitors, to Penelope, and to his own father. They are not improvisations but variations on one standing story: a Cretan of good family, an inheritance grievance, a life of raiding, Troy, a voyage east that goes wrong, treacherous Phoenicians, a shipwreck nobody else survives, and a rescue by a decent stranger. What makes it work is that it is his own life at a few degrees' offset, so that he never has to invent anything from nothing and never contradicts himself. And every version carries the same small true cargo, planted where a listener will not notice it being planted: *Odysseus is alive and close by.* He is not lying instead of telling the truth. He is lying in order to deliver it.

he had seen Odysseus in Crete with Idomeneus, mending his ships after a storm had broken them up, and said he would come in the summer or the autumn, bringing a great deal of treasure and his godlike crew.

"So you, old man of many sorrows — since a god has brought you here to me — do not try to please me with lies. It is not for that I shall respect you and treat you as a friend. It is out of fear of Zeus who protects strangers, and out of pity for you."

"You have a very slow heart in your breast, if not even an oath brings you round. Come then, let us make a bargain, and let the gods on Olympus be witnesses. If your master comes back to this house, you shall dress me in a cloak and a tunic and send me on my way to Dulichium, which is where I want to go. And if he does not come as I say, then set your men on me and throw me off a great cliff, so that the next beggar thinks twice about lying to you."

"Stranger — that would do wonders for my good name and my reputation among men, now and in the future: to bring you to my hut and give you hospitality and then kill you. What a light heart I should have when I said my prayers to Zeus afterwards.

"But it is time to eat. I wish the men would come, so that we could get a good supper ready in the hut."

They came in with the pigs and penned them, and there was an enormous squealing as the sows were shut up. And the swineherd called out to his men to bring in the best boar, so that he could kill it for a stranger from far away — "and we shall get something out of it too, who have suffered a long time over the white-tusked swine, while other men eat what we work for and pay nothing."

He split the logs with the pitiless bronze, and they brought in a very fat boar five years old and stood it by the hearth. And the swineherd did not forget the immortals, because he had good sense: as a first offering he cut hairs from the head of the white-tusked boar and threw them in the fire, and prayed to all the gods that clever Odysseus might come back to his own house. Then he struck it with a billet of oak that he had left over from splitting, and the life left it; and they cut the throat and singed it and jointed it. And the swineherd laid raw pieces from every limb on the rich fat, and threw them into the fire sprinkled with barley meal; and they cut up the rest and spitted it and roasted it and drew it off and heaped it all on platters.

And the swineherd stood up to share it out, because he had a fine sense of what was fair, and divided the whole of it into seven portions. One he set aside with a prayer for the nymphs and for Hermes; and the rest he handed round to each man. And he honoured Odysseus with the long chine of the white-tusked boar, and made his master's heart glad.[70]

"Eumaeus — may you be as dear to father Zeus as you are to me, since you honour a man in my state with the best of what you have."

"Eat, my strange guest, and enjoy what there is. The god gives one thing and holds back another, whatever he pleases, because he can do anything."

So they ate, and when they had finished, Mesaulius cleared the food away — a man the swineherd

[70]**Seven portions, and the chine.** Watch the swineherd carve, because the whole social order is in it. He divides the meat into seven equal shares, one for each man present, which is the mark of a fair division and the reason the poem says he had a good sense of what was right; then he sets one share aside for the nymphs and for Hermes, who looks after herdsmen and travellers, before anybody eats. And then he takes the long chine — the best cut on the animal, the piece reserved for the guest of highest standing — and gives it to the filthy old beggar sitting by his fire. It is exactly what Odysseus himself did for the blind singer at the Phaeacian dinner, and the poem notes, in one line, that it made his master's heart glad. Eumaeus does not know he is honouring his master. He is simply honouring a guest, which is what he would have done for anybody.

had got for himself while his master was gone, without troubling his mistress or old Laertes; he had bought him from the Taphians with his own goods. And they put out their hands to the food, and when they had had enough of eating and drinking they turned their minds to bed.

And a bad night came on, black, and Zeus rained the whole of it, and the West Wind blew hard and wet.

And Odysseus said something, to try the swineherd out — to see whether he would take his own cloak off and give it to him, or tell one of his men to, since he was so careful of him.

"Listen to me now, Eumaeus, and all the rest of you. I am going to make a boast and tell you something, because the wine is telling me to, crazy wine, which sets even a sensible man singing and laughing softly, and gets him up to dance, and brings out a word that would have been better left in. Since I have started, I shall not hold it back.

"I wish I were young, and my strength what it was, on the day we laid an ambush under the walls of Troy. Odysseus was leading it, and Menelaus, and I was the third in command, because they asked for me.

"When we got to the city and the steep wall, we lay down in the thick brush among the reeds and the marsh, crouching under our arms; and night came on, a bad one, with the North Wind dropping, and frost; and snow came down over us like hoar frost, cold, and ice was forming on our shields.

"Now all the others had cloaks and tunics and slept comfortably with their shoulders covered by their shields. But I had left my cloak behind with my men when I set out, like a fool, because I did not think I would be cold; so I came along with nothing but a shield and a bright kilt.

"And in the third watch of the night, when the stars had gone over, I nudged Odysseus with my elbow — he was lying next to me — and he was awake at once.

"*Son of Laertes, I shall not be among the living much longer. This cold is finishing me. I have no cloak. Some god fooled me into coming out in a tunic, and now there is no way out of it.*

"And he had a thought in his mind on the instant, being the sort of man he was for planning as well as fighting. And he said quietly: *Be quiet, in case one of the other Greeks hears you.* And then he raised his head on his elbow and said:

"*Listen, friends. A dream has come to me in my sleep, a warning. We have come a very long way from the ships. I wish somebody would go and tell Agamemnon, in case he sends more men up from the ships.*

"And Thoas the son of Andraemon jumped up straight away and flung off his purple cloak and set off running for the ships. And I lay down gladly in his cloak, and Dawn came up on her golden throne.

"I wish I were young now, and my strength what it was. Then one of the swineherds in this farm would give me a cloak — out of friendliness, and out of respect for a good man. As it is, they look down on me, because I have poor clothes on my body."

And the swineherd said:

"Old man, that is a good story you have told, and there is not a word in it out of place or wasted. So you shall not go short of clothing or anything else that a hard-pressed suppliant deserves when he meets one — for tonight. In the morning you will be flapping about in your own rags again, because we have no store of cloaks here and no spare tunics; each man has one. But when the dear son of Odysseus comes, he will give you a cloak and a tunic himself and send you wherever your heart wants to go."

And he jumped up and made him a bed near the fire and threw sheepskins and goatskins over it; and Odysseus lay down, and Eumaeus threw over him a great thick cloak, which he kept beside him

for a change of clothing when a really bad storm came on.

That is the most charming thing in the book and I do not want it to go past unadmired.

He wants a blanket. He is a guest in a hut where there is exactly one spare cloak in the world and its owner is going out into the rain in a few minutes; and rather than ask, which would embarrass everybody, he tells a story — announcing at the top that the wine is making him boastful, so that nobody has to take it seriously — in which a cold night is solved by a clever trick, and in which he casts himself in a small part and gives the clever trick to Odysseus.

And Eumaeus, who has already said out loud that men in need make up tales for a cloak and a tunic, listens to a tale that is transparently a request for a cloak and a tunic, praises it as a good story with not a word out of place, and hands over his own cloak with the gentlest possible caveat — *for tonight; in the morning you will be in your rags again; we are not rich here.*

Neither of them mentions what is actually happening. They are both far too well-mannered.

So Odysseus slept, and the young men slept beside him. But the swineherd did not choose to sleep in there, away from the pigs; he got himself ready to go out, and Odysseus was glad to see how well he looked after his master's property while his master was far away.

First he slung a sharp sword over his broad shoulders, and then put on a very thick cloak against the wind, and picked up the fleece of a big well-fed goat, and took a sharp javelin to keep off dogs and men.

And he went off to lie down where the white-tusked boars were sleeping, under a hollow rock, out of the North Wind.

NOTES TO BOOK FOURTEEN

Book Fifteen: In Which a Young Man Comes Home by the Back Way, and an Old Slave Remembers Being a Prince.

Book 15

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK FIFTEEN

In Which a Young Man Comes Home by the Back Way, and an Old Slave Remembers Being a Prince

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Athena went to Sparta, to remind the son of Odysseus about going home and to hurry him along.

She found him and Peisistratus lying in the porch of the house of Menelaus. Nestor's son was fast asleep, but no sweet sleep held Telemachus; he was awake all through the immortal night, worrying about his father. And the goddess stood over him.

"Telemachus, it is not right to go on wandering far from home, leaving your property behind with men as insolent as that in your house. Take care they do not divide it all up and eat it, and your journey turn out to have been for nothing.

"Rouse Menelaus and get him to send you off, so that you may still find your excellent mother at home. Her father and her brothers are already urging her to marry Eurymachus, who is outbidding all the other suitors in presents and keeps raising his offer. Take care she does not carry off something from your house against your will.

"You know how it is with a woman's heart: she wants to build up the house of the man who marries her, and of her earlier children and the husband who is dead she takes no more thought and asks no questions. So go home and hand everything over to whichever of the servant women seems best to you, until the gods show you a wife of your own.

"And there is another thing I want to tell you. The best of the suitors are lying in wait for you in the strait between Ithaca and rugged Samos, meaning to kill you before you can reach home. I do not think it will happen; sooner than that the earth will cover a few of the men who are eating up your living.

"Keep your ship well away from the islands and sail through the night. Whichever god is watching over you will send a wind behind you. And when you reach the nearest headland of Ithaca, send the ship and the crew on to the town, and go yourself first of all to the swineherd, who keeps your pigs and is loyal to you. Sleep there, and send him into the town to tell sensible Penelope that you are safe and have come back from Pylos."

And with that she went away to Olympus.

Telemachus woke Nestor's son with a touch of his heel. "Get up, Peisistratus. Bring out the horses and put them under the yoke, and let us be on our way."

"Telemachus, however much we want to go, there is no driving through a dark night. It will be dawn soon enough. Wait until the hero Menelaus brings the gifts out and puts them in the chariot and sends us off with a kind word. A guest remembers, all his days, the host who showed him friendship."

I shall not detain you over Athena's opinion of women, which is brisk, cynical and tactically shaped for a young man she wants on a ship by morning. It is worth noticing only because the poem puts it

in the mouth of a goddess who knows perfectly well that it is not true of Penelope, and who has just finished telling Odysseus how faithfully his wife has held the house. She is not describing anybody. She is getting a boy to move.

When Dawn came up, Menelaus got out of bed and came to them; and Telemachus dressed quickly and asked to be sent home.

"Menelaus, send me back now to my own country. My heart is set on getting home."

"Telemachus, I shall not keep you here long when you want to be off. I disapprove of a host who is excessive in his kindness quite as much as one who is excessive the other way. Moderation is better in everything. It is as bad to press a guest to stay when he does not want to as it is to hold one back who is eager to go. One should look after a guest properly while he is there, and let him go when he wishes.

"But wait until I bring the gifts out and set them in the chariot, and until I tell the women to get a meal ready in the hall, out of the plenty we have. It is honour and glory and profit together to have dinner before setting out over a very wide stretch of country."

That is a small speech and I like it very much. Everything in this poem turns on the treatment of guests, and here is a man who has been thinking about the mechanics of it — who has worked out that the fault of holding somebody too long and the fault of pushing them out of the door are the same fault, and that the whole art of it is in reading what the other person actually wants. It is worth setting beside the household we visited at the end of the last book, where a slave with one spare cloak and no property at all arrived at precisely the same conclusion by himself.

Menelaus went down to the treasure chamber with Helen and his son Megapenthes, and chose a two-handled cup, and had the boy carry a silver mixing bowl. And Helen went to the chests where her embroidered robes lay, that she had made herself, and lifted out the largest and the most beautifully worked, which lay underneath all the others and shone like a star.

"Take this, dear child. Here is a gift from me, a keepsake from the hands of Menelaus, for you to use when you pour to the gods. Hephaestus made it, and Phaedimus the king of the Sidonians gave it to me when his house sheltered me on my way home."

And Helen put the robe into his hands. "I have a present for you too, dear child, a memory of Helen's hands — for your bride to wear on the day of your marriage, which you are longing for. Until then let it lie in your mother's keeping. And may you come with joy to your well-built house and your own country."

They poured the last of the wine and got into the chariot and drove out through the gateway. And as they went, Telemachus prayed to Athena; and while he was praying an eagle came over on the right with a great white goose in its talons, a tame bird out of the yard, and the men and women came running and shouting after it. And the eagle swung in close and darted away to the right, in front of the horses. And they were glad to see it, and their hearts warmed.

Peisistratus spoke first. "Consider, Menelaus, whether the god has shown this sign for the two of us, or for you."

And Menelaus began to think it over, so as to answer properly — and Helen got in before him.

"Listen to me. I shall prophesy, as the immortals put it in my heart and as I believe it will come out. That eagle came from the mountain where he was born and where his brood is, and took a goose that had been reared in the house. Just so will Odysseus come home after many hardships and much wandering, and take his revenge. Or he may be at home already, sowing trouble for every one of the

suitors."

"May Zeus grant it," said Telemachus. "Then I would pray to you as I would to a god."

That is the last thing Helen says in the poem, and she is the only person in it who reads an omen without being asked and turns out to be exactly right.

She was extremely good at this in Book Four as well, when she looked at a boy who had just arrived and named his father before anybody else in the room had thought to. Her husband is still working out what to say — the poem is quite explicit that he is composing an answer — and she interrupts him and gets it right, and the reading she gives is one nobody else in that courtyard could have given, because it takes an eagle carrying off a domestic bird from a house full of shouting people and sees the point of view of the household. She has been the goose. She knows what it looks like from underneath.

They came to Pherae and slept at the house of Diocles, and drove on next morning to Pylos. And there Telemachus said: "Peisistratus, will you promise me something and do it? We are guest-friends from our fathers' time, and we are of an age, and this journey will make us closer still. Do not take me past my ship, but leave me there — or the old man will keep me in his house out of pure kindness, and I need to get home."

Nestor's son turned it over and decided how to do it properly, and swung the horses down to the shore, and unloaded the gifts into the stern of the ship, and told him to hurry aboard before the old man heard of it and came down to fetch him.

And as the crew were making ready, a stranger came up — a man from a long line of prophets, who had killed a man of his own tribe in Argos and was on the run with the dead man's brothers hunting him. His name was Theoclymenus, and he asked whose ship it was and begged to be taken aboard.

"Stranger, I shall not refuse you. Come with us, and you shall have what we have."[71]

They took his bronze spear and laid it along the deck, and he came aboard and sat down beside Telemachus; and they cast off, and Athena sent them a fair wind that came on strong out of a clear sky, so that the ship might run through the salt water as fast as possible.

Meanwhile Odysseus and the swineherd were having their supper in the hut, and the other men with them; and when they had eaten enough, Odysseus tried him again, to see whether he would still be kind and tell him to stay on at the farm, or send him off to the city.

"Listen, Eumaeus, and all of you. In the morning I want to go into the town and beg, so as not to wear you and your men out here. Just give me your advice and a good guide to take me there; and once I am in the city I shall have to wander about on my own and see whether anybody will give me a cup of water and a piece of bread. I could go to the house of Odysseus and take my news to sensible Penelope, and mix with the arrogant suitors — they have plenty; they might give me a dinner. I would

[71] **Theoclymenus, and the long pedigree.** The poem introduces this man by giving five generations of his family before it tells you what he wants, which is a passage most readers find heavy going, and it is worth knowing why it is there. He is a seer, from the most famous seer-family in Greek legend — the line of Melampus, who understood the speech of birds, and of Amphiaraus, who went to the war at Thebes knowing it would kill him because his wife had been bribed with a necklace to send him. To name that ancestry was to establish, in the only way available, that this stranger's prophecies are worth listening to. He is also a murderer on the run, taken aboard without hesitation and without any questions asked about the killing — which tells you something about how blood-guilt worked. A man who had killed within his own tribe had to leave, immediately and permanently, and the family of the dead man would pursue him; but exile discharged the obligation, and elsewhere he was simply a stranger, and strangers come from Zeus.

do whatever they wanted, and do it well. Because Hermes, who gives grace and fame to every kind of work, has given me a gift for service: nobody could match me at splitting kindling, or getting a dry fire going, or carving and roasting meat, or pouring the wine — all the things that lesser men do for their betters."

And the swineherd was extremely upset.

"Good heavens, stranger — how did a notion like that get into your head? You must be very keen to die on the spot, if you really want to go into that crowd of suitors, whose insolence and violence reach the iron sky.

"Their servants are nothing like you. They are young men in fine cloaks and tunics, with their hair oiled and their faces handsome, and the polished tables in there are loaded with bread and meat and wine.

"Stay here. Nobody finds you a nuisance — not I, and not one of my men. And when the dear son of Odysseus comes, he will give you a cloak and a tunic and send you wherever you want to go."

"Eumaeus, may you be as dear to father Zeus as you are to me, for stopping my wandering and my miserable homelessness. There is nothing worse for a man than a life on the road; but it is for the sake of the cursed belly that men put up with such misery.

"But since you are keeping me here and telling me to wait for him — tell me about the mother of Odysseus, and the father he left behind on the threshold of old age. Are they still alive and looking at the light of the sun, or are they dead and gone into the house of Hades?"

"Laertes is alive. But he prays to Zeus constantly that the life may waste out of his body in his own halls, because he grieves terribly for his son who is gone, and for the wife he married, and it was her death that hurt him most and brought him to an early old age.

"She died of grief for her famous son, a pitiful death — and may nobody die that way who lives here and is a friend of mine.

"While she was alive, sorry as she was, it was always a pleasure to me to ask after her and to talk to her, because she brought me up herself along with her own daughter Ctimene, the youngest of her children. I was brought up with her, and her mother honoured me only a little less. And when the two of us reached the age everybody wants to reach, they married her to a man in Same and got a great many presents for her; and me the lady dressed in a cloak and a tunic, very fine clothes, and gave me sandals for my feet, and sent me out to the farm. And she loved me more in her heart than ever.

"Now I go without all that. But the blessed gods make the work I stay at prosper, and out of it I have eaten and drunk and given to people who deserved it. From my mistress there is nothing pleasant to be had these days, not a word and not a kindness, since that trouble fell on the house — overbearing men. And servants very much need to talk to their mistress and ask her things, and eat and drink there, and carry something back to the fields with them. Those are the things that warm a servant's heart."

"Then you must have been a small child, Eumaeus, when you were brought so far from your own country and your parents. Tell me — was the city sacked where your father and your lady mother lived? Or were you left alone with the sheep or the cattle, and enemies took you in their ships and sold you into this man's house, and he paid a good price for you?"

"Stranger, since you ask me that, listen quietly and enjoy yourself and sit and drink your wine. These nights are enormous. There is time to sleep and time to enjoy listening, and you need not lie down before you have to; too much sleep is wearisome. Let the rest of these go outside and sleep, and at first

light have their breakfast and go out with the master's pigs. But the two of us will stay in the hut and drink and eat and take a certain pleasure in going over each other's miseries — because afterwards a man does find pleasure even in his troubles, when he has suffered a great deal and wandered a great deal.

"There is an island called Syrie, if you have ever heard of it, above Ortygia, where the sun turns. It is not so very full of people, but it is a good country, rich in cattle and rich in sheep, full of vines and full of wheat. Famine never comes to those people, and no other hateful sickness comes upon them; but when the generations grow old in the town, Apollo comes with Artemis and kills them with his gentle arrows.

"There are two cities there, and everything is divided between them; and my father was king over both — Ctesius, the son of Ormenus, a man like the immortals.

"And Phoenicians came there, men famous for their ships, greedy rogues, with a great many trinkets in their black ship. Now there was a Phoenician woman in my father's house, tall and beautiful and skilled at fine handwork, and the crafty Phoenicians talked her round. One of them got her while she was washing clothes, lying with her beside the hollow ship; and afterwards he asked her who she was and where she came from, and she pointed at once to my father's high-roofed house.

"*I come from Sidon, rich in bronze, and I am the daughter of Arybas, who was very wealthy. Taphian pirates carried me off as I was coming in from the fields, and brought me here and sold me into this man's house, and he paid a good price for me.*

"And the man said: *Would you like to come home with us, then, and see the high-roofed house of your father and mother, and the two of them? Because they are still alive, and people say they are rich.*

"And the woman said: *That might be done, if you sailors would swear me an oath to bring me home unharmed.*

"So they all swore it. And when they had sworn and finished the oath, the woman said: *Now be quiet. Let none of your crew speak to me if he meets me in the street or at the well, in case somebody goes to the house and tells the old man, and he suspects and ties me up in cruel bonds and plans destruction for the lot of you. Keep it to yourselves, and get your cargo bought as fast as you can. And when the ship is loaded, send word to me quickly up at the house, because I shall bring gold as well, whatever comes to my hand. And I will tell you something else I would gladly give as my passage money. There is a child of my master's in the house that I nurse, a knowing little thing, who runs out of doors along with me. I would bring him aboard, and he would fetch you an enormous price wherever you sold him among people of another language.*

"And with that she went back up to the house.

"And they stayed there a whole year and got a great deal of goods into their hollow ship. And when the ship was loaded and it was time to go, they sent a man up to give the woman the word. He came to my father's house, a crafty fellow, with a gold chain strung with amber beads; and the maids in the hall and my lady mother handled it and looked at it and offered him a price — and he nodded to the woman without a word, and then went back to the hollow ship.

"And she took me by the hand and led me out of the house. In the front hall she found the cups and the tables of the men who had been dining with my father and had just gone out to the assembly, and she hid three goblets in the fold of her dress and carried them off; and I went along after her, in complete innocence.

"The sun went down and all the ways grew dark, and we came quickly to the harbour, where the Phoenicians' fast ship was. They put us aboard and sailed, and Zeus sent a following wind. Six days we sailed, night and day alike; and when Zeus brought on the seventh, Artemis of the arrows struck

the woman, and she dropped into the bilge like a sea-bird going down.

"And they threw her overboard, to be a meal for the seals and the fishes; and I was left there with my heart aching. And the wind and the water carried them to Ithaca, and there Laertes bought me with his own property.

"And that is how I came to see this country with my eyes."

So the two of them talked, and slept only a little, because Dawn came up quickly on her golden throne.

I do not think I need to say very much about that, but I will say two things.

The first is that this man is a king's son. He was born a prince on an island with two cities in it, and his father ruled both, and he was stolen at about five years old by a woman who had herself been stolen, and sold, and was trying to get home — and who used him as her fare. She died six days out and was thrown into the sea, and the child went on to Ithaca and was bought by an old man who was kind to him. He has kept pigs for that family for fifty years and calls his absent owner *honoured sir* and will not say his name.

The second is what he does with the story. Look at how he begins it: *these nights are enormous; there is time to sleep and time to enjoy listening*. He settles his guest with a drink, sends the other men off to bed so as not to bore them, and observes, quite deliberately, that going over old griefs together is a pleasure once the griefs are old enough. He is not complaining and he is not asking for sympathy. He is doing the thing a good host does on a long night, which is to offer a story in return for a story — and the man he is offering it to has just told him a magnificent pack of lies and is sitting there in disguise in his own farmhouse listening to the true one.[72]

And meanwhile Telemachus and his crew were coming in to the shore. They furled the sails and unstepped the mast and rowed her in to the anchorage and moored her, and got out and had their meal on the beach.

"Take the ship on to the town now," said Telemachus. "I am going out to the fields and the herdsmen. In the evening, when I have looked over my land, I shall come down to the town; and in the morning I shall give you a good dinner of meat and sweet wine as your wages for the journey."

And Theoclymenus said: "And where am I to go, dear child? Whose house shall I make for, among all the men who rule in rugged Ithaca? Or shall I go straight to your mother's house, and yours?"

"At any other time I would tell you to go to my own house; there is no lack of hospitality there. But it would be the worse for you now, because I shall be away and my mother will not see you. She does not appear often before the suitors in the hall; she keeps apart from them, upstairs, at her loom. But I can name you another man to go to: Eurymachus, the splendid son of Polybus, whom the people of Ithaca look at nowadays as though he were a god. He is much the best of them, and the keenest to marry my mother and have the honour that was Odysseus's.

[72] **What Eumaeus was, and what he is.** He is the son of a king, stolen as a small child and sold; and it is worth being plain that his story is not offered as an outrage. It is offered as a piece of ordinary bad luck of the kind that happened constantly on that sea. What the poem does with it is quieter and stranger: it gives the finest manners in the book to a slave, and lets him tell a prince's biography in a hut, at night, to a beggar who is really a king. Everybody in that room is in disguise, one way or another. — Two details reward a second look. The woman who steals him has herself been stolen — taken by pirates from her own country, sold, and now trying to buy her way home with somebody else's child — and the poem gives her a name, a father and a city, which it did not have to do. And Eumaeus, who has been a slave since he was five, has himself bought a slave, Mesaulius, with his own savings, as he mentioned in passing at the end of the last book. He is not outside the system. Nobody in this poem is outside it.

"But Zeus, who lives in the sky, knows whether he will not bring the day of doom down on all of them before any wedding."

And as he said it a bird flew over on the right: a hawk, the swift messenger of Apollo, with a dove in his talons, plucking her; and the feathers came drifting down to the ground between Telemachus and the ship.

And Theoclymenus called him away from his men and took him by the hand.

"Telemachus, that bird did not fly on your right without a god behind it. I knew it for an omen the moment I looked at it. There is no family in Ithaca more kingly than yours. You will have the power here, always."

"Stranger, I only wish that word may be fulfilled. Then you would very soon know my friendship, and get so many gifts from me that anybody meeting you would call you a lucky man."

And he turned to Peiraeus, whom he trusted more than any of his crew, and asked him to take the stranger home and look after him and honour him until he came himself; and Peiraeus said he would, and would keep him as long as he stayed, and there would be no want of hospitality.

Then he went aboard and told the crew to embark and cast off the cables, and they went aboard and sat down at the oars.

And Telemachus bound his good sandals under his feet and picked up his heavy spear with the sharp bronze point off the deck of the ship. And they cast off the cables, and pushed her out, and sailed for the town, as the son of Odysseus had told them.

And his feet carried him on, fast, until he came to the yard where his pigs were, thousands of them, and where the good swineherd slept beside them, always loyal to his masters.[73]

NOTES TO BOOK FIFTEEN

Book Sixteen: In Which a Father and a Son Are Alone in a Room, and Only One of Them Knows It.

[73]**Two birds, one book.** The poem frames this book with omens and it is doing it deliberately. At the start, an eagle takes a tame goose out of the yard of a great house, and Helen reads it: the wild thing comes down from the mountain and carries off the creature that has been fattening at home. At the end, a hawk strips a dove in flight and the feathers fall between the young man and his ship, and the seer reads that one. Both mean the same thing and neither of them needs to be spelled out to the reader, which is why the poem does not spell it out. Notice, though, who is allowed to interpret. A woman at a gate and a fugitive murderer picked up at a beach — the two people in this book with the least standing of anybody in it — are the two who can see what is coming. The kings say nothing.

Book 16

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK SIXTEEN

In Which a Father and a Son Are Alone in a Room, and Only One of Them Knows It

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At first light, in the hut, Odysseus and the good swineherd lit a fire and got their breakfast ready and sent the herdsmen out with the droves of pigs.

And the dogs, who bark at everybody, did not bark. They went fawning round somebody coming up the path.

Odysseus noticed it, and heard the sound of feet.

"Eumaeus — somebody is coming. A friend of yours, or somebody the dogs know, because they are not barking; they are making a fuss of him. And I can hear footsteps."

He had not finished saying it when his own son stood in the doorway.

The swineherd jumped up in amazement, and the bowls he had been mixing the bright wine in fell out of his hands. And he went to meet his master and kissed his head and both his beautiful eyes and both his hands, and the tears came pouring down.

The way a loving father greets a son who comes back in the tenth year out of a far country — an only son, a late child, for whom he has suffered a great deal — that is how the swineherd put his arms round godlike Telemachus and kissed him all over, as though he had got out from under his own death.

"You have come, Telemachus. Sweet light. I thought I should never see you again once you had gone off in the ship to Pylos. Come in, dear child, and let me have the pleasure of looking at you, newly here from somewhere else. You do not often come out to the farm and the herdsmen; you stay in the town — as though it were any pleasure to you to look at that destructive crowd of suitors."

"So be it, old friend. I have come out here for your sake — to see you with my own eyes, and to hear from you whether my mother is still at home, or whether some other man has married her by now, and the bed of Odysseus is lying empty, with nothing on it, and the cobwebs gathering."

"She is in your halls, with a steady heart, enduring; and the nights and the days waste away for her, wretchedly, while she cries."

He took the bronze spear from him, and Telemachus stepped in over the stone threshold. And as he came in, his father got up from his seat to make room for him.

And Telemachus stopped him. "Sit down, stranger. We shall find a seat somewhere else in our own farmyard; here is a man who will put one out."

So Odysseus sat down again, and the swineherd heaped green brushwood for the young man and threw a fleece on top; and Telemachus sat down there, and the swineherd set out platters of roast meat left over from the night before, and heaped bread into a basket, and mixed honey-sweet wine in an ivy bowl, and sat down opposite. And they put out their hands to the good things in front of them.

"Old friend, where does this stranger come from? How did the sailors bring him to Ithaca? Who did they say they were? Because I do not suppose he came here on foot."

And Eumaeus told him what he had been told: a Cretan, who had wandered through a great many cities of men, with a god driving him about; who had run away from a Thesprotian ship and come to the farm. "And now I put him in your hands. Do as you like. He says he is your suppliant."

"Eumaeus, that is a hard thing to say to me. How am I to take this stranger into my house? I am young, and I cannot yet trust my own hands to defend a man if somebody starts on him. My mother's heart is divided two ways: whether to stay here with me and keep the house, respecting her husband's bed and what the people say, or to go now with whichever of the Greeks courting her in the halls is the best man and offers most.

"But since this stranger has come to *your* house, I shall clothe him in a cloak and tunic, good clothes, and give him a two-edged sword and sandals for his feet, and send him on wherever his heart tells him to go. Or if you like, keep him here on the farm and look after him, and I shall send the clothes out here and all his food, so that he is not a drain on you and your men.

"But I will not have him go up there among the suitors. They are far too full of insolence and violence, and they will make a mockery of him, and that would be a bitter grief to me. It is hard for one man to get anything done against a crowd, however strong he is; they are a great deal stronger."

And the much-enduring Odysseus said:

"Friend, since it is right that I should answer — my heart is torn open, listening to you tell what these suitors get up to in your halls, against the will of a man like you.

"Tell me: do you put up with it willingly? Or do the people of your country hate you, following some voice from a god? Or do you blame your brothers, who are the men a fighter relies on when a serious quarrel comes?

"I wish I were as young as I am angry, and were the son of Odysseus, or Odysseus himself — then let some stranger cut my head off my neck if I did not walk into the halls of that man and make myself a plague to every one of them. And if they beat me down by weight of numbers, one against so many, I would rather be killed in my own house than have to watch these disgraceful things going on and on: guests knocked about, servant women dragged through the fine halls, wine drawn off and wasted, men eating up food idly and endlessly, for a thing that is never going to be brought off."

"Stranger, I shall tell you exactly. The people are not hostile to me and there is no quarrel with them. And there are no brothers to blame, either. Zeus made this a single line: Arceisius had one son, Laertes; Laertes had one son, Odysseus; and Odysseus left one son — me — in his halls, and had no joy of me.

"So the house is full of enemies. All the chief men of the islands — Dulichium, Same, wooded Zacynthus — and everyone who is anybody in rocky Ithaca, they are all courting my mother and wearing the house away. And she neither refuses the hateful marriage nor can bring herself to end it; and they eat my living away, and before long they will tear me to pieces too."

Then he turned to the swineherd. "Eumaeus, go quickly and tell my mother that I am back safe from Pylos. And come straight back here; tell nobody else. There are a great many Greeks planning trouble for me."

"Shall I take the same message to Laertes as I go? The old man used to look after his farm, whatever grief he had for Odysseus, and eat and drink with the servants when he felt like it. But they say that since you went off in the ship he has not eaten or drunk, and has not looked at the work of the farm,

but sits grieving and crying, and the flesh is wasting off his bones."

"Sad as it is, we shall let him alone. Tell my mother, and have her send the housekeeper out to him quietly, and she can tell the old man."

And he sent the swineherd off; and Eumaeus tied his sandals on and went to the town.

And Athena did not fail to notice that the swineherd had gone. She came up to the hut in the likeness of a woman, tall and beautiful and skilled at fine handwork, and stood in the doorway where Odysseus could see her.

Telemachus did not see her at all; the gods do not appear plainly to everybody. But Odysseus saw her, and so did the dogs, and they did not bark; they whimpered and shrank away across the yard.

She signalled with her eyebrows. Odysseus understood and came out of the hall, past the great wall of the yard, and stood in front of her.

"Son of Laertes. Speak to your son now and hide it no longer, so that the two of you can plan the killing of the suitors and go into the town. And I shall not be far away; I am ready for the fight."

And she touched him with her golden wand. She put a freshly washed cloak and tunic about him first, and made him taller and younger; the brown came back into his skin, his cheeks filled out, and his beard turned dark again.

Then she went away, and Odysseus went back into the hut. And his own son stared at him and was frightened, and turned his eyes away, in case this was a god.

"Stranger — you look different than you did a moment ago. Your clothes are not the same, and your skin is not the same. You must be one of the gods who hold the wide sky. Be gracious to us. We will give you acceptable offerings and worked gold. Spare us."

"I am no god. Why do you compare me to the immortals?

"I am your father. The one you have been grieving for, and suffering for, and putting up with other men's violence for."

And he kissed his son, and let a tear fall to the ground, which until then he had held back, every one of them.

And Telemachus did not believe him.

"You are not Odysseus. You are not my father. Some god is deceiving me, to make me cry harder. No mortal man could arrange this by his own devising — not unless a god came himself and easily made him young or old, whichever he wanted. Just now you were an old man in filthy clothes; now you look like one of the gods."

"Telemachus, it is not right for you to be so amazed that your father is in the house, or to stand there wondering. No other Odysseus is ever going to come here. I am he. I have suffered a great deal and wandered a great deal, and I have come in the twentieth year to my own country.

"This is Athena's doing. She makes me whatever she likes, because she can; one moment a beggar, the next a young man with fine clothes on his body. It is an easy thing for the gods who hold the wide sky to glorify a mortal man or to bring him low."

And he sat down. And Telemachus threw his arms round his good father and wept.

And in both of them the longing to cry rose up, and they cried out loud, harder than birds — sea-eagles, or vultures with hooked claws, whose young the country people have taken out of the nest before they could fly. That is how pitifully the tears fell from under their eyelids.

And the light of the sun would have gone down on the two of them crying, if Telemachus had not

suddenly said: "But what ship brought you here? What sailors? Who did they say they were? Because I do not suppose you came to Ithaca on foot."

There is the reunion, and I want to point at one thing in it and then leave it alone.

He does not prove anything.

Every other recognition in this poem has a token attached: there will be a scar in a few books' time, and a piece of furniture at the very end, and each of them is a hard fact produced under pressure to satisfy somebody who has decided not to be fooled. Here there is nothing of the kind. His father simply says *I am your father*, and the boy says he does not believe it, and the man says it again and adds that Athena did the rest — and that is the whole of the evidence, and it is accepted.

Which makes sense, when you think about it, because there is nothing available. Telemachus was an infant in arms when this man sailed. He has no memory of a face, no voice to compare, no scar he was ever shown. He cannot recognise his father; he can only be told, and decide. And what settles it is not proof at all: it is the crying, which goes on for so long that the poem says the sun would have set on it.

He is the only person in the book who has to take it on trust.

Odysseus told him the truth: that the Phaeacians had brought him and put him ashore asleep, and given him bronze and gold and woven cloth, which was now stored in a cave by the will of the gods; and that Athena had sent him here to plan how the suitors might be killed.

"Now tell me the number of them, so that I know how many there are and what sort of men. Then I shall turn it over in my own mind and decide whether the two of us can take them on alone, or whether we should look for help."

"Father, I have always heard of your great name — that you were a mighty spearman and a wise head in council. But this is a very large thing you have said. Two men cannot fight a crowd of strong ones.

"The suitors are not ten, and not twice ten. They are a great many more than that. Count them here, and now. From Dulichium there are fifty-two picked young men, with six servants; from Same, twenty-four; from Zacynthus, twenty; and from Ithaca itself, twelve, all of them the best. And with them are Medon the herald and the divine singer, and two attendants who are skilled at carving meat.

"If we go against all of that inside the hall, I am afraid your revenge would turn out bitter and terrible when you came to take it. Think whether you can find a helper — somebody who would stand up for us both with a ready heart."[74]

"Then I shall tell you, and you turn it over. Do you think Athena and father Zeus will be enough for us, or shall I think about another helper?"

"Those are excellent helpers you name, though they sit up high among the clouds and hold power over all men and all immortals."

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[74] **A hundred and eight men.** This is the only place the poem does the arithmetic, and it is worth writing down, because the vagueness of "the suitors" can make them feel like a crowd of extras. Fifty-two from Dulichium with six servants; twenty-four from Same; twenty from Zacynthus; twelve from Ithaca itself, and those the best men on the island. A herald, a singer, and two carvers. That is a hundred and eight armed young men of good family, plus staff, against two — and shortly against four. Telemachus gives the figures because he is trying to talk his father out of it, and his objection is entirely sound. Note also what the numbers say about Ithaca: the twelve local men are outnumbered eight to one by outsiders. This is not a village quarrel. It is most of the aristocracy of four islands, camped in one house, waiting for a kingdom to fall vacant.

Then Odysseus gave him the plan, and it is worth having in full, because everything from here to the end of the poem runs on it.

"In the morning, go home and join that overbearing crowd. The swineherd will bring me to the town later, looking like an old beggar in a bad way. And if they insult me in the house, let the heart in your breast put up with it while I am badly treated. Even if they drag me by the feet through the hall and out of the door, or throw things at me — watch it and endure it. Tell them to stop being foolish, certainly, and coax them with gentle words. They will not listen; their day is standing beside them.

"And I shall tell you something else; keep it in your mind. When Athena, who thinks of everything, puts it into my head, I shall nod to you. And the moment you see it, take all the weapons of war that are lying in the hall and carry them up and store them in the corner of the high chamber — every one of them.

"And when the suitors miss them and ask you, put them off with soft words. Say: *I have laid them away out of the smoke, because they are not what they were when Odysseus left them and went to Troy; they are spoiled, as far as the breath of the fire has reached them. And besides, the son of Cronos (Zeus) has put a bigger fear in my heart — that you may quarrel over your wine and wound each other and disgrace the feast and the courtship. Iron by itself draws a man on.*[75]

"But leave two swords behind for the two of us, and two spears, and two oxhide shields, where our hands can snatch them up.

"And nobody is to know that Odysseus is in the house. Not Laertes, not the swineherd, not any of the servants, and not Penelope herself. You and I alone will find out how the women stand; and let us test some of the men as well, and see who honours us and fears us in his heart, and who does not care and slights you, young as you are and worthy as you are."

"Father, I think you will find out what sort of spirit I have in due course; I am not soft in the head. But I do not think this particular plan will profit the two of us, and I ask you to consider it. You will be a very long time going round the farms testing every man, while at their ease those others go on eating your goods in the halls, without sparing anything.

"The women I do agree you should find out about — which of them dishonour you and which are innocent. But I would rather not go round the farms testing the men now. Let us see to that later, if you really know some sign from Zeus."

Meanwhile the ship that had brought Telemachus from Pylos came in to the town, and they hauled her up and carried the gifts to the house of Clytius, and sent a herald to the house of Odysseus to tell Penelope that her son was out in the country and had ordered the ship into the city, so that she should not be frightened and cry.

And the herald and the good swineherd met, both of them carrying the same message to the lady. And when they reached the house, the herald said it out loud in the middle of the servant women: "Your dear son, my queen, has come back from Pylos." And the swineherd went up close to Penelope and told her quietly everything her son had told him to say; and when he had said it all he went out through the courtyard and back to his pigs.

[75] **"Iron by itself draws a man on."** The excuse Telemachus is coached to give for clearing the weapons out of the hall has two halves, and the second half is a proverb: the mere presence of a weapon pulls a man towards using it. It is offered here as a piece of ordinary wisdom that no one would think to argue with — of course you do not leave spears standing about a room where men are drinking — and it is doing double work, because it is also a perfectly accurate description of what is about to happen in that room. The plan depends on the suitors accepting a commonplace about human nature and failing to notice that it is being used against them.

And the suitors were dismayed, and went out and sat down in front of the wall of the yard, outside the gates.

Eurymachus spoke first. “Friends, this is a large thing that Telemachus has brought off in the most insolent way — this journey. And we said it would never happen. Come, let us launch a black ship, the best there is, and get a crew of rowers together, to go quickly and tell the others to come home.”

He had not finished when Amphinomus turned in his place and saw a ship inside the deep harbour, with men taking the sails down and oars in their hands. And he laughed pleasantly and said: “There is no need to send any message. They are here. Either some god told them, or they saw her going past themselves and could not catch her.”

So the men from the ambush came up from the shore and went to the assembly, and would not let anybody else, young or old, sit down with them.

And Antinous said:

”So the gods have got the man out of trouble. Day after day our lookouts sat on the windy heights, one relieving another; and at sunset we never slept on shore but stayed at sea in the fast ship waiting for the bright Dawn, lying in wait for Telemachus so as to catch him and kill him. And meanwhile some god has brought him home.

”So let us think here about a miserable end for him. He must not get away. I do not believe our business will ever be brought off while he is alive. He is shrewd himself in judgement and planning, and the people are not showing us any particular favour any more.

”Come — before he calls the Greeks to assembly. Because I do not think he will be slack about it. He will be full of anger, and he will stand up in front of everybody and tell them how we plotted his death and failed to catch him; and they will not approve when they hear an ugly thing like that. Take care they do not do us harm, and drive us out of the country, and we go off to somebody else’s.

”Let us get in first and take him out in the fields, well away from the town, or on the road. And let us keep his living and his goods, dividing them fairly among ourselves, and give the house to his mother to keep, and to whichever of us marries her.

“But if that does not please you, and you want him to live and keep everything his father left him — then let us stop gathering here and eating up his treasure, and let each man court her from his own house with wedding gifts. And she can marry the one who gives most and comes as her destined husband.”

Nobody said anything at all.

Then Amphinomus stood up and spoke among them — the son of Nisus, and the leading man from Dulichium, and the one whose conversation pleased Penelope most, because he had a decent mind.

“Friends, I would not want to kill Telemachus. It is a dreadful thing to kill a man of royal blood. Let us first find out what the gods think about it. If the decrees of great Zeus approve, I shall kill him myself and tell everybody else to. But if the gods turn us away from it, then I say we stop.”

They all thought that was well said, and got up and went back into the house of Odysseus and sat down on the polished chairs.

Hold on to Amphinomus. He is the only one of the hundred and eight who is ever given a good motive for anything, and he has just talked the others out of a murder; and Penelope likes him, and the poem says so plainly and tells you why. Nothing more will be made of him for two books. He is not going to be spared.

But Penelope had heard. The herald Medon had been standing outside the courtyard while they wove the plot inside, and he came and told her; and she came down the long stairs to the hall with her women, and stood by the doorpost with her bright veil in front of her face, and spoke to Antinous by name.

"Antinous. Insolent man. Contriver of wickedness. They say you are the best of all the men of your age in Ithaca for judgement and for speech. You were never any such thing.

"Madman — why do you spin out death and doom for Telemachus, and take no notice of suppliants, whose witness is Zeus? It is an unholy thing to plot evil against one another.

"Do you not know that your own father came here as a fugitive, in terror of the people? They were furious with him, because he had joined up with Taphian pirates and raided the Thesprotians, who were at peace with us. They wanted to destroy him, and tear the heart out of him, and eat up all that great living of his.

"And Odysseus held them off and stopped them, angry as they were.

"And now you eat up his house without paying for it, and court his wife, and try to kill his son, and grieve me terribly. I tell you to stop, and to make the others stop."

And Eurymachus answered her — smoothly.

"Daughter of Icarius, wise Penelope. Take heart. Do not let these things trouble your mind. That man does not exist, and never will, who will lay hands on Telemachus your son while I am alive and looking at the light of the sun.

"Because I tell you this, and it will be brought to pass: his black blood would run round my spear at once. Odysseus himself used to sit me on his knees, often, and put roast meat in my hands and hold the red wine to my lips. So Telemachus is far the dearest of all men to me, and I tell him to have no fear of death — not from the suitors. From the gods it cannot be avoided."

So he said, cheering her up; and he was arranging Telemachus's death in his own mind while he said it.

And she went up to her bright upper room and cried for Odysseus, her own husband, until Athena cast sweet sleep on her eyelids.

And in the evening the good swineherd came back to Odysseus and his son. They were getting supper ready, having sacrificed a yearling pig; and Athena had come first and struck Odysseus with her wand and made him an old man again and put the shabby clothes back on him — in case the swineherd looked him in the face and knew him, and went off and told Penelope and did not keep it in his heart.

Telemachus spoke first. "You are back, Eumaeus. What is the news in the town? Are the lordly suitors home from their ambush yet, or are they still out there watching for me?"

"I did not care to go about the city asking. My heart told me to give my message and come straight back. But a fast messenger from your crew met me, a herald, and he got to your mother first. And there is one thing I do know, because I saw it with my own eyes. I was above the town, where the hill of Hermes is, when I saw a fast ship coming into our harbour, with a great many men in her, and she was loaded with shields and double-edged spears. I thought it was them. I do not know."

And Telemachus smiled, and looked across at his father — and took care not to catch the swineherd's eye.

Then they finished the work and laid out the meal and ate; and when they had had enough of eating and drinking they thought about bed, and took the gift of sleep.

NOTES TO BOOK SIXTEEN

Book Seventeen: In Which an Old Dog Waits on a Dunghill, and a Stool Is Thrown.

Book 17

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK SEVENTEEN

In Which an Old Dog Waits on a Dunghill, and a Stool Is Thrown

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When Dawn came up, rosy-fingered, Telemachus tied his good sandals under his feet and picked up his heavy spear, ready for the town.

"Old friend, I am going to the city, so that my mother can see me. I do not think she will stop her miserable crying and her weeping until she looks at me with her own eyes. And here is what I want you to do. Take this unlucky stranger to the town so that he can beg his dinner there; whoever likes will give him a crust and a cup. I cannot possibly carry every man in the world; I have troubles enough of my own. And if the stranger is annoyed at that, it will be the worse for him. I like to say what I mean."

"My friend, I have no wish to be kept here either. It is better to beg one's dinner in a town than in the fields; whoever likes will give me something. I am not of an age to stay about a farm and do everything a master tells me. Go on. This man will guide me, as you have said, when I have warmed myself at the fire and the sun has got up. These clothes of mine are miserably thin, and the frost before dawn might finish me; and you say the town is a long way off."

So Telemachus went off out of the yard, walking fast, sowing trouble for the suitors.

And when he came to the fine house he set his spear against a tall pillar and stepped in over the stone threshold.

Eurycleia saw him long before anybody else, as she was spreading fleeces over the carved chairs, and she came straight to him crying, and the other women of the house came crowding round and kissed his head and his shoulders in welcome.

And Penelope came out of her room, looking like Artemis (goddess of the hunt) or golden Aphrodite (goddess of love), and threw her arms round her son crying, and kissed his head and both his beautiful eyes.

"You have come, Telemachus. Sweet light. I thought I should never see you again, after you went off to Pylos in a ship, secretly, against my will, to ask after your father. Come, tell me what sight you had of him."

"Mother, do not stir up crying in me, and do not set my heart going in my breast, when I have just got out from under a sheer destruction. Wash, and put clean clothes on, and go upstairs with your women, and promise a full offering to all the gods, in the hope that Zeus may grant us a day of requital. I am going to the assembly, to call in a stranger who came with me from Pylos. I sent him on ahead with my crew, and told Peiraeus to take him home and look after him and honour him until I came."

She did as he said.

And Telemachus went out through the hall with his spear in his hand, and two swift dogs went with him; and Athena poured a supernatural grace over him, so that all the people stared at him as he

came. And the lordly suitors gathered round him with fine words on their lips and plans for trouble in their hearts; but he kept clear of the crowd of them and went and sat down with Mentor, and Antiphus, and Halitherses, who had been his father's friends from the beginning.

And Peiraeus came up bringing Theoclymenus through the town, and Telemachus went straight to the stranger.

"Peiraeus, keep the gifts at your house for the moment. If the suitors kill me quietly in the halls and divide up my father's goods among them, I would rather you had them and enjoyed them than any of those men. And if I manage to sow death and doom for them, then bring them to my house and be glad with me."

And he brought the stranger home; and there they bathed and oiled and dressed him and sat him down, and the housekeeper brought bread and a great many good things.

And Penelope sat opposite them by the doorpost of the hall, leaning back in her chair, spinning fine yarn.

"Telemachus, I shall go upstairs and lie down on that bed of mine which has become a bed of sorrows, always wet with my tears since the day Odysseus went off to Troy with the sons of Atreus. And you could not bring yourself, before those insolent men came into this house, to tell me plainly about your father's homecoming, if you have heard anything."

So he told her: how Nestor had received him kindly at Pylos, like a father receiving a son, but knew nothing; how he had been sent on to Sparta, and how Menelaus had told him what the old man of the sea had reported — that Odysseus was alive on an island, weeping, in the house of the nymph Calypso, who was holding him there against his will, and that he had no ship and no crew to carry him over the wide back of the sea.

And her heart was stirred in her breast as she listened.

And then Theoclymenus spoke.

"Honoured wife of Odysseus — this man has no clear knowledge of it. Listen to me instead. I shall prophesy to you exactly, and hide nothing.

"Let Zeus be my witness first of all, and this table of hospitality, and the hearth of Odysseus that I have come to: Odysseus is already here, in his own country. He is sitting still somewhere or moving about, and he is learning about these evil deeds, and he is planting the seed of destruction for every one of the suitors."

"Ah, stranger — I only wish that word may be fulfilled. Then you would very soon know my friendship, and get so many gifts from me that anybody who met you would call you a lucky man."

Meanwhile the suitors were amusing themselves in front of the hall with the discus and the throwing spear, on the levelled ground where they always did it, in their usual insolent style; and when it was dinner time and the flocks came in from the fields all round, Medon called them in to eat.

And Odysseus and the good swineherd were setting out from the farm for the town. Eumaeus gave him a staff, and slung a wretched wallet round him, full of holes, on a twisted cord.

And on the way, where the road runs by a spring — a fine built spring with cold water flowing out of the rock, and a grove of water-loving poplars round it in a circle, and an altar of the nymphs above it where every traveller made an offering — they met Melanthius, the son of Dolius, coming down with the pick of the goats for the suitors' dinner, and two herdsmen with him.

And when he saw them he abused them, shockingly.

"There you are: the vile leading the vile. The god always brings like to like. Where are you taking this pig, you miserable swineherd — this disgusting beggar, this spoiler of feasts? He will stand rubbing his shoulders against a great many doorposts, begging for scraps, and no swords and no cauldrons.

"If you gave him to me to look after my farm, and sweep out the stalls, and carry green stuff to the kids, he could drink whey and put some muscle on his thigh. But since he has learnt nothing but bad habits he will not go near an honest job; he would rather go cringing round the neighbourhood begging food for that bottomless belly of his.

"And I will tell you this, and it will happen. If he goes to the house of great Odysseus, a great many footstools thrown from men's hands will fly round his head and be broken on his ribs, as he gets pelted through the house."

And as he passed he kicked Odysseus on the hip, stupidly; and did not knock him off the path. He stood firm.

And Odysseus considered whether to go for him with the staff and take the life out of him, or lift him up bodily and dash his head on the ground. And he held it in and endured it.

But the swineherd looked the man in the face and cursed him, and lifted up his hands and prayed aloud.

"Nymphs of the spring, daughters of Zeus — if ever Odysseus burned you the thigh pieces of lambs and kids, wrapped in rich fat, then grant me this prayer. Let that man come back. Let some god guide him home. He would knock all this display out of you, all these airs you flaunt as you go swaggering about the town, while worthless herdsmen ruin the flocks."

"Listen to the cunning dog talk. One day I shall take him off in a black ship well away from Ithaca and sell him for a good price. And I only wish Apollo would strike Telemachus down in the halls today, or that the suitors would do for him — as surely as the day of homecoming is lost for Odysseus, far away."

And he left them going slowly along, and went on quickly and reached the house and went in and sat down among the suitors, opposite Eurymachus, who liked him best of all of them.

The two of them came up and stopped outside; and the sound of the hollow lyre came out to them, because Phemius was striking up a song. And Odysseus took the swineherd's hand.

"Eumaeus, this must be the fine house of Odysseus. Anybody could pick it out of a crowd of buildings. One part leads on to the next; the courtyard is finished off with a wall and a coping, and the double doors are strong. No man could force it. And I can tell there are a great many men at dinner in there, because the smell of roast is coming out, and the lyre is going, which the gods have made the companion of a feast."

"You have picked it out easily enough; you are not a fool in other things either. But let us think what we are going to do. Either you go in first and I stay here; or you stay and I go first. Do not wait about outside, in case somebody sees you and throws something at you or hits you."

"I understand. My mind takes it in. Go in first; I shall stay here. I know all about being hit and having things thrown at me. My heart is patient, because I have had a great deal of trouble on the sea and in war. Let this be added to it.

"But there is no hiding a ravening belly, that cursed thing, which gives men so much trouble. It is for the belly's sake that ships with good benches are fitted out and sent over the barren sea to bring harm to enemies."

And while they were talking, a dog that had been lying there raised his head and pricked up his ears.

Argos. Odysseus's own dog, whom he had bred himself and never had the use of, because he went off to holy Ilios first. In the old days the young men used to take him out after wild goats and deer and hares. Now he lay where he had been thrown, on the deep pile of mule dung and cattle dung that was heaped in front of the doors until the servants got round to carting it away to manure the great estate. There lay the dog Argos, full of vermin.

And when he saw Odysseus standing near he wagged his tail and dropped both his ears; and he had not the strength to get any closer to his master.

And Odysseus looked away and wiped a tear off, easily, so that Eumaeus should not see it, and asked him a question at once.

"Eumaeus, it is a strange thing that this dog is lying here on the dung heap. He is well made; though I cannot tell whether he had any speed to go with the looks, or whether he was one of those table dogs that gentlemen keep for show."

"That is the dog of a man who died a long way off. If he were still in body and in action what he was when Odysseus left him and went to Troy, you would be astonished if you saw his speed and his strength. Nothing he ever chased in the deep wood got away from him; he was a wonder at following a scent.

"But now he is in a bad way. His master has died somewhere abroad, and the women do not care and will not look after him. Servants stop doing their work properly the moment their masters are no longer over them. Zeus who sees everything takes away half a man's worth on the day that slavery comes on him."[76]

And with that he went into the house, straight in among the suitors.

And the fate of black death took hold of Argos, at once, when he had seen Odysseus in the twentieth year.

I shall not do anything to that, because it does not need me. I shall only point out two things and then let it alone.

The first is that the dog is the first creature in Ithaca to know him. Not his son, who had to be told; not the nurse, who will find the scar in a few books' time; not his wife, who will make him prove it. A half-dead animal on a manure heap, with no evidence at all, gets it right instantly and has plainly been getting it right, and waiting, for twenty years.

The second is what Odysseus does about it. He looks away and wipes his face where the swineherd cannot see, and then asks a casual question about the animal's breeding. He does not go to him. He cannot: the whole plan depends on it, and it would cost him everything, and he knows it. So the only

[76] **Argos, and what Eumaeus says over him.** The dog's name simply means *swift*, or *bright* — an entirely ordinary name for a hunting dog, of the sort a man would give an animal without thinking about it, which is part of the point. — What deserves as much attention as the dog is the sentence the swineherd attaches to him, because it is one of the bleakest things anybody says in this poem: that Zeus takes away half a man's worth on the day slavery comes upon him. Eumaeus is himself a slave. He is explaining, without self-pity and as a piece of general knowledge, why the women of the house no longer bother to feed an old dog — servants stop doing their work well once nobody is over them — and in the middle of it he states, as a fact about the world, that people like him are worth half what they were. He is at that moment the most honourable person in the book, and he has just cleaned up after the suitors' goats. The poem sets his opinion of himself beside his conduct and says nothing.

creature in the country who recognises him gets nothing at all — no word, no hand, no acknowledgement — and dies about ninety seconds later.

Telemachus saw the swineherd first, and nodded to him and called him over; and Eumaeus looked round and picked up a stool and sat down opposite, and Telemachus cut off a portion of meat and gave him bread out of the basket.

And Odysseus came in behind him, like an old and pitiful beggar, leaning on a stick, with wretched clothes on his body, and sat down on the ash-wood threshold inside the doorway, leaning against the cypress doorpost.

And Telemachus took a whole loaf and as much meat as his two hands would hold, and told the swineherd to carry it over to him and tell him to go round the suitors and beg from each of them: "Shame is a bad companion for a man in need."

So the beggar took it, and prayed for the young man, and ate.

And when the singer had finished, the suitors made a noise through the hall; and Athena came and stood by Odysseus and told him to go and gather scraps from them, so that he might learn which of them were decent and which were lawless — and even so she was not going to save a single one of them from destruction.

So he went from left to right, holding his hand out, exactly like a man who had been begging all his life. And they pitied him and gave him something, and wondered at him, and asked each other who he was and where he came from.

And Melanthius the goatherd spoke up.

"Listen to me, suitors of the famous queen. I have seen this stranger before; the swineherd brought him here. I do not know for certain who he says he is."

And Antinous turned on Eumaeus.

"You notorious swineherd. What did you bring this fellow into the town for? Have we not enough vagabonds already, disgusting beggars who spoil a feast? Do you think it a small thing that they gather here and eat up your master's living, that you have called this one in as well?"

"Antinous, that is not well said, noble as you are. Who ever goes out and invites a stranger from abroad, unless he is one of the men who work for the public good — a prophet, or a healer of sicknesses, or a carpenter, or a divine singer, who gives delight with his song? Those are the men who are asked for all over the boundless earth. Nobody would invite a beggar to make trouble for himself.

"But you are always harder than any of the suitors on the servants of Odysseus, and hardest of all on me. And I do not care, so long as sensible Penelope is alive in these halls, and godlike Telemachus."

"Be quiet. Do not answer him at any length. Antinous is always harsh, and provoking, with ugly words; and he stirs up the others too."

And then he turned on Antinous himself.

"You take care of me exactly as a father takes care of his son, telling me to drive this stranger out of the hall with a hard word. God forbid. Take something and give it to him; I do not grudge it — I tell you to. And do not worry about my mother in this matter, or any of the servants in the house of Odysseus.

"But that is not the thought in your mind at all. You would very much rather eat a great deal yourself than give any of it away."

"Telemachus, you great orator, you unstoppable temper — what a thing to say. If all the suitors

gave him as much as I am going to, this house would keep him off for three whole months."

And he pulled out the footstool from under the table where he had been resting his shining feet, and showed it to him.

But all the others gave, and filled the wallet with bread and meat.

And Odysseus was on his way back to the threshold to eat what the Greeks had given him, when he stopped beside Antinous and spoke to him.

"Give, friend. You do not seem to me the worst of the Greeks, but the best; you look like a king. So you ought to give a better piece of bread than the others, and I should sing your praises all over the boundless earth.

"Because I too once lived in a house among men, a rich man in a wealthy house, and I gave often to a wanderer, whoever he was and whatever he came needing. I had servants past counting and everything else that men live well on and are called rich for.

"And Zeus made nothing of it all. He put it in my heart to go off to Egypt with roving pirates, a long voyage, so that I should be destroyed."

And he told him the shape of it: the crews who would not be held, the plundering, the country roused, the men killed and the men led off alive into slavery.

"And they gave me to a friend of theirs to take to Cyprus. And from there I have come here, and I have had nothing but trouble."

And Antinous answered him.

"What god has brought this nuisance here to spoil our dinner? Stand out there in the middle, away from my table, or you will find yourself back in a bitter Egypt and a bitter Cyprus. What a bold and shameless beggar you are. You go up to every man in turn, and they give recklessly, because there is no holding back and no grudging when a man is being generous with somebody else's goods, and every one of them has plenty of it in front of him."

And Odysseus drew back and said:

"Well, well. So your looks are better than your sense. You would not give a suppliant so much as a grain of salt out of your own house, you who are sitting at another man's table and cannot bring yourself to take up a piece of bread and hand it over — with all that in front of you."

That made Antinous angrier still, and he glared at him and spoke.

"Now I do not think you are going to get out of this hall in one piece, since you have started on abuse."

And he took up the footstool and threw it, and hit him on the right shoulder, at the base of the back.

And Odysseus stood there like a rock. The blow from Antinous did not so much as shift him. He shook his head in silence, deep down planning trouble.

And he went back and sat down on the threshold and put his well-filled wallet down and spoke to the suitors.

"Hear me, suitors of the famous queen, while I say what my heart tells me. There is no grief in a man's mind and no pain when he is hit fighting for his own property — for his cattle, or his white sheep. Antinous hit me because of my miserable belly, that cursed thing which brings so much trouble on men.

"But if there are gods anywhere for beggars, and avenging spirits, then let the end of death come for Antinous before ever he is married."

"Sit and eat quietly, stranger, or get out. Otherwise the young men will drag you through the house by the hand or the foot for talking like that, and skin you alive."

And every one of the others was extremely angry, and one of the arrogant young men would say:

"Antinous, you did wrong to hit that unlucky wanderer. You are a doomed man, if there happens to be some god up in the sky. And the gods do put on the shape of strangers from far countries, and take every kind of form, and go about the cities watching to see which men are violent and which are law-abiding."

Antinous took no notice whatever.

And Telemachus nursed a great grief in his heart at his father being struck; but he did not let a single tear fall to the ground. He shook his head in silence, deep down planning trouble.[77]

Penelope heard about it upstairs, and said, among her women: "May Apollo the famous archer strike *you* like that, Antinous." And the housekeeper Eurynome said: "If our prayers were answered, not one of them would ever see the fair-throned Dawn again."

"Nurse, they are all hateful, because they plan wickedness. But Antinous is like black death itself. Some unlucky stranger is going through the house begging alms of the men, because want drives him; and all the others filled his wallet and gave him something. And Antinous threw a footstool and hit him on the right shoulder."

And she sent for the swineherd and told him to bring the stranger to her, so that she could greet him and ask whether he had heard anything of Odysseus.

"My queen, I only wish the suitors would be quiet. He tells such tales as would put a spell on your heart. I had him three nights and kept him three days in my hut — he came to me first, when he ran away from a ship — and he had not got to the end of the story of his troubles.

"It is like watching a singer who has been taught by the gods to sing songs of longing to men, and they cannot stop listening while he goes on. That is how he held me, sitting beside me in the hut. He says he is a friend of Odysseus's family and lives in Crete. And he says he has heard that Odysseus is close by, alive, in the rich country of the Thesprotians, and is bringing a great deal of treasure home."

"Go and call him here, so that he can tell it to my face."

And then Telemachus sneezed loudly, and the whole house rang with it; and Penelope laughed, and her words came out fast.

"Go and call the stranger to me. Did you not hear my son sneeze at everything I said? So may death be brought about for every one of the suitors; not one of them shall get away from death and the fates. And here is another thing; keep it in your mind. If I find that everything he says is true, I shall dress him in a cloak and a tunic, good clothes."[78]

[77] **The stool, and the suitors' own unease.** Notice who objects. It is not Telemachus, who says nothing and lets no tear fall; and it is not Eumaeus, who has already been slapped down once. It is the other suitors — the anonymous ones, the crowd — who tell Antinous he did wrong, and their reason is worth having in full: *you are a doomed man, if there happens to be a god about; the gods put on the shape of strangers and go round the cities watching who is violent and who is not.* They are exactly right, in every particular, including the disguise. And having said it they go back to their dinner. Nobody gets up. It is a very precise picture of how a bad thing carries on happening in a room full of people who can all see it is wrong: the objection gets made, out loud, by somebody with no stake in it, and then the plates are passed.

[78] **The sneeze.** A sneeze at the moment a wish is spoken was a good omen, and a well-attested one — the idea outlived antiquity by a very long way, and is the distant ancestor of blessing somebody who sneezes. What makes this one delightful is the timing and the fact that Penelope *laughs*. She has just finished saying she hopes every suitor in the house will die; her son sneezes somewhere down the hall; and she takes it, quite seriously and also with real amusement, as heaven signing the document. It is the only time she laughs in the poem.

So the swineherd went and gave the message.

"Eumaeus, I should be glad to tell the whole truth to wise Penelope, because I know all about that man; the two of us have had the same troubles. But I am afraid of that crowd of hard suitors, whose insolence and violence reach the iron sky. Just now, when I was going through the hall doing no harm to anybody, that man hit me and hurt me, and neither Telemachus nor anybody else did anything about it.

"So tell Penelope to wait in the hall until the sun goes down, eager as she is. And then let her ask me about her husband's homecoming, and give me a seat nearer the fire; because the clothes I have on are poor, as you know, since it was you I first appealed to."

And the swineherd went back with that, and Penelope was surprised he had not come. "You are not bringing him, Eumaeus. What does the vagrant mean by that? Is he unusually afraid of somebody? Or is he ashamed of himself in the house? A shy beggar is a bad beggar."

And when Eumaeus explained, she said: "The stranger is no fool. He is guessing at what may very well be true. I do not think there are any other men on earth quite so outrageous, or so given to reckless behaviour."

Then the swineherd went back to Telemachus and told him he was going out to the farm to look after the pigs, and to see to their living and his; and Telemachus told him to have his supper first and come back in the morning and bring good victims for sacrifice.

So he sat down again and ate and drank his fill, and then went back to his pigs, leaving the courtyard and the halls full of feasters.

And they took their pleasure in dancing and singing, because by now the evening had come on.

NOTES TO BOOK SEVENTEEN

Book Eighteen: In Which Two Beggars Fight for a Sausage, and a Wife Comes Downstairs.

Book 18

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK EIGHTEEN

In Which Two Beggars Fight for a Sausage, and a Wife Comes Downstairs

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Then a beggar came in, a public one, who used to go begging round the town of Ithaca, and who was famous for a greedy belly and eating and drinking without stopping. He had no strength and no muscle, though he was very big to look at.

His name was Arnaeus; his mother had given him that at birth. But all the young men called him Irus, because he ran errands for anybody who asked.[79]

He came in and tried to drive Odysseus out of his own house.

"Get away from the door, old man, before you get dragged out by the foot. Do you not see them all winking at me and telling me to haul you out? I would be ashamed to. Get up, or the two of us will be settling it with our hands."

And Odysseus looked at him from under his brows.

"You strange man. I am doing you no harm and saying nothing about you, and I do not grudge it if somebody gives you something, even a good deal. This threshold will take both of us, and you have no call to be jealous over other men's property. You look to me like a vagrant, the same as I am; it is the gods who hand out prosperity.

"Do not push me too far with your hands, or you will make me angry; and old as I am I shall spoil your chest and your lips with blood. And I should have a quieter day of it tomorrow, because I do not think you would come back a second time to the hall of Odysseus."

"Listen to the tramp rattling away, like an old woman at the oven. I shall work him over with both hands and knock every tooth out of his jaws onto the floor, the way you do with a pig caught in the corn. Put your belt on, and let all these gentlemen see us fight. How are you going to take on a younger man?"

Antinous heard them squabbling on the polished threshold, and laughed with real pleasure.

"Friends, there has never been anything like this. What sport the god has brought into this house. The stranger and Irus are challenging each other to a fight. Let us set them on."

They all jumped up laughing and gathered round the two beggars in their rags.

"Listen to me, suitors," said Antinous. "There are goats' paunches lying at the fire that we set aside for supper, stuffed with fat and blood. Whichever of the two wins and proves the better man can stand up and take whichever of them he likes. And he shall always eat with us afterwards, and we will let

[79] **Irus, who is not called Irus.** His name is Arnaeus. *Irus* is a nickname the young men of the town gave him, and it is a joke: it is made from Iris, the goddess who carries messages for the gods, because this man will carry a message for anybody who pays him in food. It is the sort of name that sticks to a person and slowly replaces him, and the poem tells you his real one exactly once, in the line before it stops using it. There is a second turn of the same joke a page later, when the suitors say he is about to be *un-Irused* — which in Greek is a single coined word, made by putting a negative in front of his nickname, and is the kind of thing a hall full of drunk young men would find extremely funny.

no other beggar come in and beg among us."

They all liked that. And Odysseus, with cunning in his mind, said:

"Friends, there is no possible way for an old man worn down with trouble to fight a younger one. But my belly tells me to — my belly, that does all the harm — so that I get myself beaten. But swear me all a great oath first: that no man of you, out of favour to Irus, will hit me with his heavy hand and put me down for him unfairly."

They swore it. And Telemachus said: "Stranger, if your proud heart tells you to defend yourself against this man, then have no fear of any other Greek here, because whoever strikes you will have more men to fight. I am the host; and the princes Antinous and Eurymachus agree, and they are both sensible men."

Then Odysseus pulled his rags up and belted them round his loins, and out came his thighs, big and handsome, and his broad shoulders showed, and his chest and his powerful arms; and Athena stood beside him and made the limbs of the shepherd of the people greater still.

The suitors were extremely surprised, and one would look at the man beside him and say: "Irus will very soon be un-Irused, and it will be trouble he asked for. What a thigh the old man shows from under those rags."

And Irus's spirit went badly to pieces. The servants had to belt him up and bring him out by force, terrified, with the flesh trembling on his bones.

And Antinous rounded on him. "You braggart. Better if you had never been born, if you are shaking like that at an old man worn out by the misery he carries about with him. I will tell you plainly, and it will be brought about: if he beats you, I shall put you on a black ship and send you to the mainland to king Echetus, who mutilates everybody — and he will cut off your nose and your ears with the pitiless bronze and tear away your privates and give them raw to the dogs to eat."[80]

That made him tremble a great deal more; and they led him into the middle, and both men put their hands up.

Then Odysseus considered whether to hit him so as to knock the life out of him where he stood, or to fell him gently and stretch him out. And gently seemed better, in case the Greeks looked too closely at him.

So when they had their hands up, Irus hit him on the right shoulder, and Odysseus hit him on the neck under the ear and crushed the bones inside, and the red blood came up through his mouth at once, and he went down in the dust bellowing, with his teeth chattering and his heels drumming on the ground.

And the lordly suitors threw up their hands and died laughing.

And Odysseus took him by the foot and dragged him out through the doorway into the courtyard and propped him against the wall and put his staff in his hand.

"Sit there now and keep the pigs and the dogs off. And do not go setting yourself up as lord over strangers and beggars, you miserable creature, or you may get something worse."

[80] **King Echetus.** He is mentioned three times in this poem and nowhere else in Greek literature, always in the same breath as mutilation, always as a threat, and always to somebody helpless. Nobody knows whether he was a figure from some lost story or simply a bogey — the equivalent of naming a place people are sent and do not come back from. What matters is that Antinous produces him casually, as a piece of ordinary banter, to frighten a beggar into fighting; and that nothing in the scene suggests anybody present thought the threat outlandish. It is worth remembering when the reckoning comes, and readers begin to feel that it goes too far.

Then he slung the shabby bag over his shoulders, with all its holes, and went back and sat down on the threshold.

And they went in laughing and made him welcome. "May Zeus and the other gods give you whatever you want most, stranger, since you have stopped that insatiable creature begging round the country. We shall very soon be shipping him over to king Echetus."

And Odysseus was glad at the sound of it.

I should like you to hold two things about that scene at once, because the poem plainly does.

It is funny. A hall full of men roaring, a bragging beggar who cannot fight being belted into the ring by servants while his knees knock, and a supposed old man who turns out, when he lifts his rags, to have the thighs of a wrestler. The suitors' joke about being *un-Irused* is a genuine joke and it is meant to be laughed at, and the poem is enjoying itself.

And underneath it, look at what is actually happening. A man with nothing is being made to fight another man with nothing, by rich men, for the amusement of the rich men, with a bag of tripe as the prize; and when he loses, the sponsor of the entertainment promises to have him shipped to a foreign torturer who will cut pieces off him. Nobody objects. The oath Odysseus asks for — that none of them will join in and hold him down — was not a foolish precaution.

Irus is a bully and a fool and he picked the fight. He is also the only person in this book who tries to defend that doorway from an intruder, and he is thrashed for it by the intruder, in front of the men who are actually stealing the house.

Then Amphinomus took two loaves out of the basket and brought them to him, and pledged him in a golden cup.

"Good health, father stranger. May you have prosperity in time to come; you are held down by a great many troubles now."

And Odysseus answered him.

"Amphinomus, you strike me as a man of good sense; you are your father's son, and I have heard his good name — Nisus of Dulichium, a good man and a rich one. They say you are his, and you seem a reasonable man. So listen to me, and take in what I say.

"Of everything that breathes and moves upon the earth, the earth raises nothing feebler than a man.

"While the gods give him prosperity and his knees are quick, he thinks he will never suffer anything in time to come. And when the blessed gods measure him out sorrow, he carries that too, unwillingly, with an enduring heart. Because the mind of men on the earth is like the day the father of gods and men brings on them.

"I too was once on my way to being a prosperous man, and I did a great many reckless things, giving way to my own strength and power, and trusting in my father and my brothers. So let no man ever be lawless. Let him keep whatever the gods give him in silence.

"And these are the sort of reckless things I see the suitors devising — wasting the property and dishonouring the wife of a man who I do not think will be away from his friends and his own country much longer. He is very near.

"May some god take you home out of his path. May you not meet him when he comes back to his own dear country. Because I do not think the suitors and he will be parted without blood, once he is under his own roof."

And he poured a libation and drank the honey-sweet wine and put the cup back into the prince's hands.

And Amphinomus went off through the hall with his head down and his heart heavy, because his spirit foresaw trouble. And even so he did not escape his fate; Athena had bound him too, to be beaten down by the hands and the spear of Telemachus.

And he sat down again in the chair he had got up from.

That is the only warning Odysseus gives anybody in this poem, and it is a real one — not a threat dressed as advice, but a genuine attempt to get one man out of the building before the roof comes in. He does it because Amphinomus brought him bread and spoke to him kindly, which nobody else in that hall has done.

And it does not work. Not because the man is stupid — he understands it perfectly; the poem says his heart foresaw trouble — but because he goes and sits down again in the same chair. Which is, I am afraid, what most people do.

Then Athena put it into the mind of Penelope to show herself to the suitors, so as to set their hearts fluttering and make herself more honoured than before in the eyes of her husband and her son.

She gave a little laugh, for no reason, and said: "Eurynome, my heart wants something it never wanted before: I want to show myself to the suitors, hateful as they are to me. And I should like to say a word to my son that would do him good — not to spend all his time with those overbearing men, who speak kindly to him and are planning harm."

"All of that is well said, child. Go and speak to your son. But wash first, and put oil on your cheeks. Do not go down with your face all stained with crying; it does no good to grieve endlessly. And your son is now the age you always prayed to see him."

"Eurynome, do not urge me to wash and oil myself out of kindness. The gods who hold Olympus destroyed my beauty on the day my husband went away in the hollow ships. But tell Autonoe and Hippodameia to come and stand beside me in the hall. I will not go among men alone. I am ashamed to."

And while the old woman was gone to call them, Athena thought of something else, and poured a sweet sleep over the daughter of Icarius (Penelope); and she sank back and slept where she sat, and all her joints let go.

And the shining goddess gave her immortal gifts, so that the Greeks should marvel at her. She washed her beautiful face with the ambrosial beauty that Aphrodite (goddess of love) uses when she goes into the lovely dance of the Graces; and she made her taller and fuller to look at, and whiter than new-sawn ivory.

Then she went away; and the women came in, chattering, and the sound of them woke Penelope, and she rubbed her cheeks with her hands.

"That was a soft sleep that wrapped me round, miserable as I am. I wish pure Artemis (goddess of the hunt) would give me so soft a death, now, this minute, so that I need not go on wasting my life away grieving and longing for the excellence of my husband, who was the best of all the Greeks."

And she went down from her bright upper room, not alone; two women went with her. And when she came among the suitors she stood beside the doorpost of the great hall, holding her shining veil in front of her face, and a faithful woman stood on either side of her.

And their knees went weak where they stood, and their hearts were bewitched with desire, and every one of them prayed to lie in her bed.

But she spoke to her son.

"Telemachus, your mind is no longer steady. When you were a child you had better judgement. Now you are grown and have come to the measure of a man, and any stranger looking at your height and your looks would say you were the son of a wealthy house; and your mind and your judgement are no longer what they were.

"What a thing to have happened in these halls — that you let this stranger be knocked about so shamefully. How would it be if a stranger, sitting in our house, came to harm from being handled like that? It would be your shame and your disgrace among men."

"Mother, I do not blame you for being angry. But I do notice things and understand them, both good and bad, and I am not the child I was.

"All the same, I cannot manage everything sensibly. These men sit on either side of me knocking me off balance, planning harm, and I have nobody to help me. And the fight between the stranger and Irus did not turn out the way the suitors wanted; the stranger was the better man.

"I wish to heaven the suitors were sitting in our halls at this moment with their heads hanging, beaten — some of them in the courtyard and some inside — the way Irus is sitting out there by the courtyard gate now, with his head lolling like a drunk, unable to stand up straight or get home, because his legs have gone."

Then Eurymachus said: "Daughter of Icarius, sensible Penelope, if all the Greeks in Argos could see you, there would be more suitors than these feasting in your halls from tomorrow morning; because you are beyond all other women in beauty and in stature and in the balance of the mind inside you."

"Eurymachus, the immortals destroyed my excellence and my beauty and my figure on the day the Greeks embarked for Ilium (Troy), and my husband Odysseus went with them. If he were to come home and take care of my life, my name would be greater and better than it is. As it is I am in trouble; a god has let loose so much of it on me.

"When he was going he took me by the wrist of my right hand and said: *Wife, I do not think all the Greeks will come home from Troy unhurt. So I do not know whether a god will spare me or whether I shall be caught there. Take care of everything here. Look after my father and my mother in the house as you do now, or more, while I am away. And when you see our son with a beard on his face, then marry whom you like and leave your house.*

"That is what he said, and all of it is coming about. The night will come when a hateful marriage finds me, whose happiness Zeus has taken away.

"But here is what grieves me to the heart. This was never the way of suitors before. Men who want to court a good woman, the daughter of a rich house, and to compete with each other for her, bring in their own cattle and their own fat sheep and make a feast for the bride's friends, and give her splendid gifts. They do not eat up somebody else's living for nothing."

And Odysseus was glad, because she was drawing gifts out of them and charming their hearts with soft words, while her mind was set on something else entirely.

And Antinous said: "Daughter of Icarius, whatever gifts any of the Greeks wants to bring here, take them; it is not right to refuse a gift. But we shall not go back to our own lands, or anywhere else, until

you marry the best man among us."

So they all sent their heralds to fetch presents. Antinous's man brought a great embroidered robe, very beautiful, with twelve golden brooches on it fitted with curved clasps. Eurymachus's brought a chain of gold strung with amber beads, that shone like the sun. Two men brought Eurydamas a pair of earrings, three drops to each of them, with a great grace shining out of them. Another brought Peisander a necklace. And every one of the Greeks gave something fine.

And the queen went up to her upper room, and her women carried the beautiful presents up behind her.

Now: watch what has just happened, because it is one of the cleverest things anybody does in this poem and it is done in about nine sentences.

She comes down looking better than she has looked in twenty years, at a moment she did not choose and by an intervention she does not know about. She reproaches her son in front of everybody for allowing a guest to be abused, which puts her firmly on the side of the household and the law. She then quotes her absent husband's own parting instructions, which have the effect of announcing that she is now, technically, free to marry — and she gets the sob in the right place.

And then she observes, sweetly, that the gentlemen have not been doing this properly. Real suitors bring cattle. Real suitors bring gifts.

Within a minute there are heralds running all over Ithaca and the property is flowing the right way up the road for the first time in three years.

Her husband is sitting ten feet away in rags watching it, and the poem says he was *glad* — glad because she was getting presents out of them while her mind was on something else. He does not admire her because she is loyal, or because she is sad, or because she is beautiful, though she is all three. He admires her because she is working the room.

That is the marriage this whole poem has been walking towards, and here is the first glimpse of the two of them in the same space, doing the same thing, on the same side, and only one of them knows it.

Then they turned to dancing and singing and enjoyed themselves and waited for the evening to come on; and the dark evening came on them while they were enjoying themselves.

And they set up three braziers in the hall to give light, and put dry firewood in them, long seasoned and newly split, and mixed torches in; and the maids of enduring Odysseus took turns to keep the flame going.

And Odysseus said to them:

"Maids of Odysseus, of the master who has been away so long — go into the house where the honoured queen is. Sit with her and turn the spindle and comfort her, or card the wool in your hands. I will provide the light for all these gentlemen. Even if they want to sit here till the golden Dawn, they will not tire me out. I am very used to enduring."

And the women laughed and looked at one another. And Melantho abused him — a girl with pretty cheeks, the daughter of Dolius, whom Penelope had brought up herself and treated like her own child and given toys to whenever she wanted them. And even so she had no grief in her heart for Penelope; she was Eurymachus's lover.

"You miserable stranger, you must be out of your wits, if you will not go off and sleep at a smithy

or a lodging-house instead of standing here talking loudly among all these lords, and not the least bit frightened. Either the wine has your wits, or your mind is always like this and you talk nonsense. Are you so beside yourself because you beat that tramp Irus? Take care a better man than Irus does not stand up against you and knock your head about with his strong hands and throw you out of the house covered in blood."

And Odysseus looked at her from under his brows. "You bitch. I shall go straight over there and tell Telemachus what you have said, and he will cut you to pieces where you stand."

And that frightened the women off. They fled through the hall with their knees shaking, because they thought he meant it.[81]

And he took his stand beside the burning braziers and kept the light going, looking at all of them; and his mind was turning over other things, which were not going to be left unfinished.

But Athena would not let the arrogant suitors leave off their biting insults, so that the pain should sink deeper still into the heart of Odysseus.

And Eurymachus started it, raising a laugh at him.

"Listen to me, suitors of the glorious queen. It cannot be without a god's hand that this man has come to the house of Odysseus. At any rate the torchlight seems to be coming from the man himself — off the top of his head, where there is not one hair, no, nor even a few."

And then to Odysseus: "Stranger, would you be willing to work for hire, if I took you on at a farm on the boundary — your wages guaranteed — gathering stones for walls and planting tall trees? I would keep you in bread all the year round and give you clothes for your body and sandals for your feet. But since you have learned nothing but bad habits, you will not want to work; you would rather beg round the country and feed that bottomless belly of yours."

And Odysseus said:

"Eurymachus, I only wish there could be a contest between the two of us in the spring, when the days grow long — in a hayfield, and I with a curved scythe in my hands and you with another, and plenty of grass, and the two of us at work with nothing to eat until it was fully dark.

"Or oxen to drive, the best there are, big tawny beasts, both of them well fed on grass, the same age and the same strength, and their power not easy to wear out; and a field of four acres, with the soil giving way under the plough. Then you would see whether I could cut an unbroken furrow all the way.

"Or if Zeus were to raise a war somewhere this very day, and I had a shield and two spears and a bronze helmet fitted to my temples — then you would see me in among the front-line men, and you would not be standing there making jokes about my belly.

"But you are extremely insolent and your mind is hard, and you think you are a great man and a strong one because you keep company with a few worthless people. If Odysseus were to come back to his own country, those doors, wide as they are, would very soon be too narrow for you as you ran

[81] **Melantho, and what the poem tells you about her.** Four facts, in one sentence, delivered without comment: Penelope raised her from a child, treated her as her own daughter, gave her whatever toys she asked for — and she feels nothing for Penelope, and sleeps with Eurymachus. She is the sister of Melanthius the goatherd, who kicked Odysseus at the spring in Book Seventeen; the two of them are the household's answer to Eumaeus and the cowherd, and the poem is arranging its servants into two columns. — She is also one of the twelve women who will be hanged in Book Twenty-Two, and I will not pretend her behaviour here is anything but cruel. But I said in Book Two that I would keep the question open, and I shall: the poem gives her a motive that is entirely her own, and gives her a lover who is the second most powerful man in that hall, and never once asks what a young slave woman's alternatives were when he came looking for her.

out through them."

Eurymachus went black with rage. "You wretch, I shall very soon do you an injury for talking so freely among all these men, and not the least bit frightened. Either the wine has your wits, or your mind is always like this and you talk nonsense. Are you so beside yourself because you beat that tramp Irus?"

And he snatched up a footstool. And Odysseus sat down quickly at the knees of Amphinomus of Dulichium, out of the way of Eurymachus; and the stool hit the wine-steward on the right hand, and the jug went down with a clang and the man went over backwards in the dust, groaning.

The suitors made an uproar in the shadowy hall, and one would look at the man beside him and say: "I wish this stranger had died somewhere else before he came here; then he would not have made all this trouble. Now we are brawling about beggars, and there will be no pleasure in a good dinner, because the worse things are winning."

And Telemachus said: "Sirs, you are mad. You are no longer hiding what the food and drink are doing to you; some god is driving you. Now that you have dined well, go home and go to bed whenever your heart tells you. I am not driving anybody out."

They bit their lips and stared at Telemachus, astonished that he had spoken so boldly.

And Amphinomus said: "Friends, when a fair word has been spoken, nobody should take offence and answer it roughly. Do not manhandle the stranger, or any of the servants in the house of godlike Odysseus. Come — let the steward pour a drop into the cups so that we can make our libations and go home to bed. And leave the stranger in the hall of Odysseus for Telemachus to look after; it is to his house that he has come."

That pleased them all. And when they had poured and drunk as much as they wanted, they went off to their own houses to sleep.

NOTES TO BOOK EIGHTEEN

Book Nineteen: In Which a Husband and a Wife Talk All Night, and an Old Woman Washes His Feet.

Book 19

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK NINETEEN

In Which a Husband and a Wife Talk All Night, and an Old Woman Washes His Feet

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Odysseus was left behind in the hall, turning over the killing of the suitors with Athena's help. And he spoke quickly to Telemachus.

"Telemachus, we must get the weapons of war stowed away, every one of them. And when the suitors miss them and ask you about it, put them off with soft words: *I have laid them away out of the smoke, because they are no longer what they were when Odysseus left them behind and went to Troy; they are quite spoiled, as far as the breath of the fire has got at them. And here is a better reason, which some god put into my mind: I was afraid you might quarrel when you were in drink and wound one another and shame the feast and the courtship. Iron by itself draws a man on.*"

Telemachus called out to Eurycleia. "Nurse, shut the women up in their rooms while I put my father's weapons away in the store — good weapons, standing about neglected in the house, going dull with the smoke, since my father went away. I was a child then. I want to lay them away where the breath of the fire will not reach them."

"Child, I only wish you would take charge of the house and look after all your property. But who is to go with you and carry a light, if you will not let the maids come out?"

"This stranger. I will not have a man idle who eats my bread, however far away he has come from."

So she shut the doors of the hall. And the two of them jumped up, Odysseus and his son, and carried in the helmets and the bossed shields and the sharp spears; and Athena went in front of them with a golden lamp and made a beautiful light.

And Telemachus said suddenly: "Father, this is a great marvel I am looking at. The walls of the hall and the fine panels and the crossbeams of pine and the pillars standing up — they are all shining in my eyes as though there were a fire in here. Some god must be inside, one of those who hold the wide sky."

"Be quiet. Hold your thoughts in and ask no questions. This is the way of the gods who hold Olympus. Go to bed now. I shall stay here, to try the maids a little more, and your mother; and in her grief she will ask me about everything."

So Telemachus went off through the hall by the light of the blazing torches, to the room where he always slept, and lay down and waited for morning. And Odysseus was left in the hall, turning over the killing of the suitors with Athena's help.

Then Penelope came down out of her room, looking like Artemis (goddess of the hunt) or like golden Aphrodite (goddess of love). They set her chair by the fire where she always sat, worked with ivory and silver, which the craftsman Icmalius had made long ago; and he had put a footstool on it, part of the same piece, and a great fleece was thrown over it.

And the women came out and cleared away the piles of bread and the tables and the cups the men had been drinking from; and they threw the fire out of the braziers onto the ground and heaped fresh logs on them, for light and for warmth.

And Melantho started on Odysseus for the second time.

"Stranger, are you going to be a nuisance here all night as well, wandering about the house and spying on the women? Get out of doors and be satisfied with your dinner, or you will be hit with a torch and go out that way."

And Odysseus looked at her from under his brows.

"Strange woman, why do you come at me with such anger in your heart? Is it because I am dirty and wearing bad clothes on my body and I beg round the country? Necessity is on me. That is what beggars and vagrants are like.

"I too once lived in a house of my own among men, and I was rich, and my house was rich; and I gave a great many times to a wanderer, whoever he was and whatever he came in need of. And I had servants past counting and everything else that men live well by and are called wealthy for.

"And Zeus brought it all to nothing; he chose to. So take care, woman, that you do not lose all the beauty you shine with among the maids at present — in case your mistress grows angry with you and turns hard, or Odysseus comes home; there is still some share of hope left. And if he really has died and is never coming back, still there is his son Telemachus, who by the grace of Apollo is a grown man now; and there is not a woman in these halls behaving badly who will escape his notice, because he is not a child any longer."

Penelope heard him and rounded on the girl.

"You bold and shameless creature. You are not hiding your monstrous behaviour from me in the least, and you shall wipe it off with your own head. You knew perfectly well — you heard it from me — that I meant to question this stranger in my halls about my husband, because I am in great distress."

Then she said to the housekeeper: "Eurynome, bring a chair over and put a fleece on it, so the stranger can sit and talk to me and listen; I want to ask him some things."

She began where anybody would begin. "Stranger, this I shall ask you myself, first of all. Who are you, and where do you come from? Where is your city, and who are your parents?"

And he turned it aside without seeming to.

"Lady, no mortal on the boundless earth could find fault with you. Your name goes up to the wide sky, like the name of a blameless king, a god-fearing man ruling over many strong people and upholding justice, so that the dark earth bears him wheat and barley, and the trees are heavy with fruit, and the flocks never fail to bear, and the sea gives fish, all because of his good leadership; and the people prosper under him.

"So ask me anything else you like here in your house, but do not ask about my family and my own country, in case you fill my heart still fuller of pain by making me remember. I am a man of many sorrows. And it is not fitting for me to sit crying and grieving in another person's house; endless mourning does no good. One of your women might be angry with me, or you might yourself, and say I was swimming in tears because my head was heavy with wine."

"Stranger, the immortals destroyed my excellence and my beauty and my figure on the day the Greeks embarked for Ilium (Troy), and my husband Odysseus went with them. If he were to come and take care of my life, my name would be greater and better. As it is I am in trouble; a god has let

loose so much of it on me.

"All the nobles who rule the islands — Dulichium and Same and wooded Zacynthus — and those who live in clear-seen Ithaca itself, are courting me against my will and wearing away my house. And so I take no thought for strangers or suppliants or heralds, but I waste my heart away wanting Odysseus.

"They press on with the marriage, and I wind my schemes.

"First a god breathed it into me to set up a great loom in the hall and weave at a wide fine web; and I said to them: *Young men, my suitors — since Odysseus is dead, be patient about the marriage, however eager you are, until I finish this cloth; I do not want my spinning wasted. It is a shroud for the lord Laertes (father of Odysseus), against the day the pitiless end of death takes him. I will not have the Greek women in this country talking against me, that a man who won so much should lie without a covering.*

"So I said, and their proud hearts agreed. And after that I wove at the great web by day, and unravelled it by night, when I had torches set beside me. Three years I kept it from them and got away with it. But when the fourth came round with the seasons, then my women told them — shameless creatures — and they came and caught me at it, and shouted at me; and I finished it, against my will, because I had to.

"And now I cannot escape the marriage, and I cannot think of any other trick. My parents are pressing me to marry, and my son is angry as he watches his living eaten up, because he understands it now; he is a man, well able to look after a house that Zeus grants honour to.

"But tell me your family, all the same, and where you come from. Because you are not sprung from the oak in the old story, or from a rock."

And Odysseus told her a lie.

He told her he came from Crete, from the great city of Cnossus, where Minos was king; that his father was Deucalion, and his brother Idomeneus, who had gone off to Troy in the beaked ships; and that his own name was Aethon, and he was the younger of the two.

And he told her he had met Odysseus there — that the wind had driven Odysseus off course past Malea on his way to Troy and forced him into an awkward anchorage; that he had come up to the city looking for Idomeneus, calling him a dear and honoured friend, and had missed him by ten days or eleven; that he himself had taken Odysseus in and entertained him properly out of the household stores, and gathered barley and wine and cattle for sacrifice out of the public store for the men who were with him; and that they had stayed twelve days, penned in by a North Wind that some hard god had raised, and had put to sea on the thirteenth when it dropped.

He made all these lies of his sound like the truth as he told them.

And as she listened, the tears ran down and her face melted. The way the snow melts on the high mountains, that the East Wind thaws when the West Wind has piled it up, and as it melts the rivers run full — that is how her lovely cheeks melted as she cried for her husband, who was sitting there beside her.

And Odysseus pitied his wife in his heart as she grieved.

But his eyes stood in his head as though they were made of horn or iron, and he did not move them; and by guile he kept his tears back.

There is nothing in the poem I find harder than that pair of sentences, and I do not think the poem

finds it easy either.

He pities her. The text says so plainly, and gives him the emotion before it gives him the concealment. And then it describes the concealment with a piece of physical detail so precise that you can feel him doing it: the eyes held still, not blinking, because a blink would spill it.

Everything he has been praised for in eighteen books is in that stillness. It is the same faculty that got him out of the cave and off the beach at Scheria and past the dogs at the farm, and it is not being used on an enemy. It is being used to watch his wife cry over him for as long as it takes.

I shall not tell you whether he is right. He has been told by a goddess to trust nobody, and there are a hundred and eight armed men in the town, and one loose word from a servant would finish him and his son together. The reasoning is sound. What the poem does is refuse to let the soundness of the reasoning make the thing comfortable, and it does that by giving him the pity first.

Then she decided to test him.

"Now, stranger, I think I shall try you, and find out whether you really did entertain my husband there in your halls with his companions, as you say. Tell me what sort of clothes he was wearing, and what kind of man he was himself, and tell me about the companions who went with him."

"Lady, it is hard to say, after so long. It is twenty years now since he went away from there and left my country. But I shall tell you as my heart pictures it.

"Odysseus was wearing a fleecy purple cloak, doubled over; and there was a brooch on it made of gold with a double clasp, and the front of it was worked in a curious way. A hound was holding a dappled fawn down between his forepaws and gripping it as it struggled; and everybody was amazed at it, at the way the two of them were gold and yet the hound was throttling the fawn and looking at it, and the fawn was writhing with its feet and trying to get away.

"And I noticed the tunic on his body, shining like the skin of a dried onion, it was so soft; and bright as the sun. A great many women looked at it and wondered.

"But I will tell you something else, and you must take it in. I do not know whether Odysseus wore those clothes at home, or whether one of his crew gave them to him when he went aboard the fast ship, or whether some host did; because Odysseus was dear to a great many men, and few Greeks were his equal.

"I gave him a bronze sword myself, and a fine purple cloak with a double fold, and a fringed tunic, and I sent him off with honour in his well-benched ship.

"And there was a herald attending him, a little older than he was, and I will tell you about him too. He was round in the shoulders and dark-skinned and curly-headed, and his name was Eurybates; and Odysseus honoured him above the rest of his companions, because the two of them thought alike."

And she cried still harder, because she knew the tokens Odysseus had given her, and they were unmistakable.[82]

And when she had had her fill of weeping she said: "Stranger, until now you have only been pitied in this house; from now on you shall be loved and honoured. I gave him those clothes myself, the

[82]**The tokens.** In a poem full of recognitions this is the first, and it establishes the pattern all the others follow: not a face, not a voice, but a *thing that only two people could know*. Penelope does not ask what her husband looked like; she asks what he was wearing, which is the harder question and the better one. Anybody who had seen Odysseus could describe his build. Only somebody who was there could describe the pin. — Note also what she does with the answer. She does not leap up. She weeps, and says that from now on he will be honoured in her house, and then goes on talking. Every recognition in this poem is followed immediately by a test of some kind, and by somebody keeping their head.

ones you describe. I folded them and brought them out of the store-room and put the bright brooch on them to be an ornament for him.

"And I shall never welcome him home again, coming back to his own dear country. It was an evil fate that took Odysseus off in the hollow ship to see that Ilium (Troy) that should not be named."

I want to point at the brooch, because of what he does with it.

He is asked for proof and he produces it, and he produces the right thing: not the sword, which she never saw, but the cloak she folded with her own hands and the pin she fastened on it. And the thing worked on that pin is a hound holding down a fawn and watching it struggle.

He picked that out of twenty years of memory and described it to her, in detail, twice — the gold that seems to move, the fawn's feet working, the eyes of the dog on it — while she sat opposite him and wept and did not know who she was talking to.

The poem does not remark on it. It simply hands you a little golden object, in a room where one person is being slowly and deliberately held, and lets it lie there.

Then he told her the rest of what he had told the swineherd — that he had heard of Odysseus close by, in the rich country of the Thesprotians, alive, and gathering treasure to bring home; that his ship and his companions had been lost off Thrinacia because the crew ate the cattle of the Sun; that the Phaeacians had honoured him like a god and were ready to send him home; and that he had gone to Dodona to ask the great oak of Zeus how he should come back to his own country, openly or in secret.

"So he is safe, and he will be here very soon. He will not be far from his friends and his own country much longer. And I shall swear you an oath on it. Let Zeus be my witness first, and this table of hospitality, and the hearth of Odysseus that I have come to: all of it will happen exactly as I say. Within this very month Odysseus will come here — as the old moon goes out and the new one comes in."

"Ah, stranger. I wish that word might be fulfilled. Then you would know my friendship soon enough, and get so many gifts from me that any man who met you would call you a lucky one.

"But this is how it will be, I think, in my heart. Odysseus is not coming home, and you will not get your passage from here, since there are no such masters in this house as Odysseus was among men — if there ever was such a man — to welcome honoured strangers and send them on their way.

"But come, women, wash him, and make up a bed — a bedstead and blankets and bright rugs — so that he can lie warm until the golden Dawn. And in the morning bathe him and rub him with oil, so that he can sit in the hall beside Telemachus and think about his breakfast. And it will be the worse for any man of them who annoys him and grieves his heart; that man will get nothing done here after that, however furiously he rages.

"Because how are you to find out about me, stranger — whether I really am better than other women in judgement and careful sense — if you sit down to eat in my hall unwashed and badly dressed? Men do not live long. If a man is harsh himself, and his mind is harsh, everybody prays that he may suffer while he lives, and when he is dead they all mock him. But if a man is blameless, and his mind is blameless, strangers carry his name far and wide across the world, and a great many people call him a good man."

"Honoured wife of Odysseus, cloaks and bright rugs became hateful to me on the day I left the snowy mountains of Crete behind me and went off in my long-oared ship. I shall lie down as I have lain through many sleepless nights before this. I have spent a great many nights on a poor bed, waiting

for the bright Dawn.

"And footbaths give me no pleasure either. No woman of those who are servants in your house is going to touch my foot — unless there is some old and faithful one who has suffered as much in her heart as I have. I should not begrudge such a woman touching my feet."

"Dear stranger, no man so sensible has ever come to my house out of all the strangers from far away; everything you say is so well judged. I have an old woman with an understanding heart, who nursed and reared that unlucky man and took him in her arms the day his mother bore him. She shall wash your feet, weak as she is.

"Come now, sensible Eurycleia, get up and wash a man of your master's own age. Odysseus's feet must be like this by now, and his hands like this. Men grow old quickly in bad fortune."

The old woman covered her face with her hands and let the hot tears come.

"Oh, my child. I can do nothing for you. Zeus must have hated you above all men, god-fearing as your heart was. No mortal ever burned so many fat thigh-pieces to him, or such chosen sacrifices, as you gave him — praying that you might come to a sleek old age and bring up your glorious son. And now he has taken your day of homecoming away from you alone.

"I suppose the women in some strange country mocked at him the way these bitches all mock at you here, when he came to some great lord's fine house; and it is to get away from their insults and their taunting that you will not let them wash you.

"But the daughter of Icarius, sensible Penelope, has told me to, and I am not unwilling. I shall wash your feet, for Penelope's sake and for your own, because the heart in me is stirred with sorrow.

"And listen to what I am going to say. A great many hard-tried strangers have come here, but I do not think I ever saw a man so like another as you are like Odysseus — in your build, and your voice, and your feet."

"Old woman, everybody who has seen the two of us with their own eyes says the same: that we are extraordinarily like one another. You have noticed it yourself, and said so."

So the old woman took the shining cauldron she used for washing feet and poured cold water into it and added hot.

And Odysseus sat down at the hearth and turned quickly towards the dark, because it came to him all at once that when she handled him she might notice the scar, and everything would come out.

She came up and began to wash her master. And she knew the scar at once.

He had been given it long ago by a boar, with its white tusk, on Parnassus, when he had gone there to visit Autolycus and the sons of Autolycus — his mother's father, who was the finest man alive at thieving and at swearing oaths, a skill the god himself had given him, Hermes (the god of travellers, of luck, and of theft), because Odysseus's grandfather used to burn him acceptable offerings of the thighs of lambs and kids, and Hermes went along with him willingly.

Autolycus had come once to the rich country of Ithaca and found his daughter's son newly born; and Eurycleia had set the baby on his knees as he finished his supper, and said: "Autolycus, find a name yourself now for your child's own child. He has been prayed for a long time."

And Autolycus said: "Son-in-law, daughter — give him the name I say. I have come here as a man who has been angry with a great many people, men and women both, over the fruitful earth. So let his name be **Odysseus**, the man of anger. And when he is grown and comes to his mother's family's great

house on Parnassus, where my property is, I shall give him some of it and send him home happy."[83]

So he had gone there for the gifts, when he was a young man; and Autolycus and his sons had welcomed him and clasped his hands, and his grandmother Amphithea had put her arms round him and kissed his head and both his beautiful eyes; and they had killed a five-year-old bull and feasted all day.

And at first light they had gone out hunting, the dogs and the sons of Autolycus, and Odysseus with them, up the steep wooded mountain, into the windy hollows. The sun was just striking on the fields, coming up out of the deep-flowing Ocean, when the beaters came into a glade. The dogs went in front, tracking, and the sons of Autolycus behind them, and Odysseus close up behind the dogs with his long spear swinging.

There was a great boar lying in a thick lair, where the force of the wet winds never blew and the bright sun never struck through and the rain could not get in, it was so thick; and there was a great heap of fallen leaves in it. And the noise of the feet of men and dogs came round him as they closed in, and he came out of the lair against them with his back bristling and his eyes flashing, and stood at bay close in front of them.

Odysseus went in first, holding the long spear up in his heavy hand, wanting to strike. And the boar was too quick for him and came in sideways above the knee, and tore a long gash in the flesh with his tusk, and did not reach the bone. And Odysseus hit him in the right shoulder, and the point of the bright spear went clean through, and he went down in the dust with a scream and the life flew out of him.

And the sons of Autolycus busied themselves over the carcass and bound up the wound of faultless godlike Odysseus skilfully, and stopped the black blood with a charm; and they went back quickly to their father's house, and healed him, and gave him splendid presents, and sent him off gladly to Ithaca. And his father and his honoured mother were glad when he came, and asked about everything, and about the scar, and how he had come by it. And he told them the whole story properly.

That is where the name came from, and the poem has kept it back for nineteen books.

I told you in Book Nine that *Odysseus* is built on a verb meaning to be angry with, to hate, to deal out pain, and that it runs both ways at once — the man who is hated, and the man who causes trouble. Here at last is the naming itself, and it is done by a grandfather who is famous for thieving and for perjury, over his supper, with the baby on his knees. He does not name the child for a hope, or a god, or an ancestor. He names it after his own bad temper.

And the poem produces the whole story here, of all the places — inside the sentence where an old woman's hands are moving down a leg towards the mark that will tell her who he is. It is the longest digression in the poem and it arrives at the worst possible moment, and readers have complained about it for two thousand years. I think the placing is the point. Everything is suspended: the water, the hands, the room, the wife eight feet away. And into that gap the poem pours the one thing it has never told you, which is what this man's name means and who gave it to him.

Then the hands find the scar.

[83] **The name, and the man who gave it.** See Book Nine, note 1, where the meaning was set out and the story promised. Here it is: Autolycus, the hero's grandfather on his mother's side, celebrated for two accomplishments — theft and perjury — both of them gifts from Hermes, who was pleased with his offerings. He arrives, finds a newborn on the premises, and is invited to name it; and he chooses a name that means, roughly, *the one who gives and gets grief*, on the grounds that he himself has been angry with a great many people in his time. It is the only naming scene in the poem and it explains a good deal, including where the cleverness came from and why nobody in this family expects the world to be simple.

The old woman took the scar in the flat of her hands and knew it by the touch, and let the foot go. The leg dropped into the basin, and the bronze rang, and it tipped over, and the water went out on the floor.

And joy and grief took hold of her at the same moment, and both her eyes filled with tears, and her voice would not come out.

She put her hand on his chin and said: "You are Odysseus. Dear child. And I never knew you — not until I had handled the whole body of my master."

And she looked across at Penelope, wanting to tell her that her husband was in the room.

And Penelope could not meet her eye and did not notice, because Athena had turned her mind aside.

And Odysseus felt for the old woman's throat with his right hand and took hold of it, and pulled her closer to him with the other.

"Mother. Do you want to destroy me? You nursed me yourself at your own breast. And now, after suffering a great deal, I have come in the twentieth year to my own country. But since you have found me out, and a god has put it in your heart — be quiet. Let nobody else in this house hear of it.

"Because I will tell you plainly, and it will be brought about. If a god beats the lordly suitors down under me, I shall not spare you, nurse though you are and though you nursed me, when I kill the other serving women in my halls."

"My child, what a thing to let past the barrier of your teeth. You know how firm I am, and how unyielding. I shall hold as hard as solid stone, or iron.

"And I will tell you something else; take it in. If a god beats the lordly suitors down under you, then I shall tell you about the women in the halls — which of them dishonour you and which are innocent."

"Nurse, why would you tell me about them? There is no need. I shall take note of every one of them myself and find them out. Keep it to yourself, and leave the rest to the gods."

Sit with that for a moment, because it is the coldest thing he does in the poem.

An old woman who fed him at her own breast has just recognised him, from a scar, on her knees, with her hands in the water; and she is crying with joy; and his response is to take her by the throat.

He does it for the same reason he does everything, and the reason is good: she was on the point of calling across the room, and if she had, he and his son would both be dead by morning. And he does not merely silence her. He tells her that when the killing starts he will kill her too if she is among the women who have gone over, nurse or no nurse.

She is not offended, which is the strangest part. She says only that she will hold like stone, and then offers to give him the names — and he refuses even that, because he does not want the list from her. He wants to watch them himself.

Then she went off to fetch more water, since the first lot was all spilled; and when she had washed him and rubbed him with oil, Odysseus pulled his chair nearer the fire again to get warm, and hid the scar under his rags.

And Penelope said:

"Stranger, I shall ask you one small thing more myself, because it will soon be time for rest — for anybody on whom sweet sleep comes, however troubled he is. But a god has given me sorrow past all

measuring. All day I take a kind of pleasure in mourning and grieving while I see to my own work and the women's in the house; and when the night comes and sleep takes everyone, I lie on my bed, and the sharp cares come crowding thick about my beating heart and torment me while I mourn.

"And my heart goes to and fro in doubt — whether to stay with my son and keep everything safe, my property and my servants and my great high-roofed house, respecting my husband's bed and what the people say; or to go now with whichever of the Greeks courting me in the halls is the best man and brings the most gifts.

"My son, while he was a child and thoughtless, would not let me marry and leave my husband's house. Now he is grown and has come to the full measure of manhood, and he prays me to go out of the hall again, because he is troubled about his property, which the Greeks are eating in front of him.

"But listen to this dream of mine, and interpret it for me.

"I have twenty geese about the house that come out of the water and eat wheat, and it warms me to watch them. And a great eagle with a crooked beak came down off the mountain and broke all their necks and killed them; and they lay strewn about the hall in a heap, and he went up into the bright sky.

"And I cried and wailed, in the dream, and the Greek women gathered round me while I grieved bitterly because the eagle had killed my geese.

"And he came back and perched on a jutting roof-beam, and checked my crying with a mortal man's voice, and said: *Take heart, daughter of far-famed Icarius. This is no dream but a waking vision, a good one, and it will be brought about. The geese are the suitors; and I who was the eagle a moment ago am your husband, back again, and I shall let loose a cruel death on all of them.*

"And the honey-sweet sleep let me go. And I looked round and saw the geese in the hall pecking at their wheat by the trough, exactly where they always are."[84]

"Lady, there is no way of turning that dream aside and reading it otherwise. Odysseus himself has told you how he means to bring it about. Destruction is plain for every one of the suitors; not a man of them will get away from death."

"Stranger, dreams are awkward things, and hard to read, and they do not all come true for people.

"There are two gates for shadowy dreams. One is made of horn and one of ivory. The dreams that come through the sawn ivory deceive us, and bring words that come to nothing. The ones that come out through the polished horn bring true things to pass, when a mortal sees them.

"But I do not think my strange dream came from there. If it had, it would have been very welcome to me and to my son.

"And I will tell you something else; take it in. This coming dawn is the evil-named one that will take me out of the house of Odysseus. Because now I mean to set them a contest: the axes, which he used to stand up in a row in his halls, like the props of a ship, twelve of them altogether; and he would stand a long way off and shoot an arrow through the whole line.

"Now I shall set this contest before the suitors. And whichever man most easily strings the bow in his hands and shoots an arrow through all twelve axes — with him I shall go, and leave this house of

[84]**The gates of horn and ivory.** This is the passage's most famous line and it is a pun, which is why it works in Greek and merely sounds handsome in English. The Greek for *horn* is close to a verb meaning to fulfil or bring to pass, and the Greek for *ivory* is close to a verb meaning to deceive. So true dreams come through the gate whose name sounds like *fulfil*, and false ones through the gate whose name sounds like *deceive*. It is not an explanation; it is a piece of wordplay offered as one — and Penelope, who has just been told a dream that says exactly what she wants to hear, uses it to argue herself out of believing it. That is the real point of the passage, and it is heartbreakingly ordinary: it is what people do with good news they cannot afford to trust.

my marriage, so beautiful, and so full of everything a life needs, which I think I shall remember even in my dreams."

"Honoured wife of Odysseus. Do not put this contest off any longer in your halls. Odysseus of the many devices will be here before these men can handle that polished bow and string it and shoot an arrow through the iron."

"Stranger, if you were willing to sit beside me in the hall and give me pleasure, sleep would never be shed on my eyelids. But people cannot go without sleep forever. I shall go up to my room and lie down on my bed, which has become a bed of mourning for me, always wet with my tears since the day Odysseus went off to see that Ilium that should not be named. I shall lie down there; and you lie here in the house — either put something on the floor, or let them set a bedstead for you."

And she went up to her bright upper room, and her women went with her; and when she had gone up she cried for Odysseus, her own dear husband, until Athena cast a sweet sleep on her eyelids.

I shall not tell you what she knows, because I do not think anybody can, and I would rather leave you holding the question than hand you a bad answer.

Consider only the order of events. She has spent the evening with a stranger who described her husband's clothes, down to the pin she fastened herself. He has sworn her a formal oath, on the hearth, that Odysseus will be here inside the month. She has told him a dream in which an eagle kills the suitors and announces that he is her husband — and then said, immediately, that she does not think it was a true dream, which is a thing people say when they have been told something they want too much to believe.

And then, that same night, having waited twenty years and put the marriage off by every device she could invent, she announces that tomorrow she will bring out her husband's bow and marry whichever man can use it.

It may be despair. She says it is: this is the evil dawn, my son is grown, I cannot hold them off any longer. It may be that a woman who has been listening very carefully all evening has decided to put a bow into the room and see what happens. The poem does not say, and the argument has run for two thousand years without settling.[85]

What I will say is this. Whatever she does or does not suspect, she has just arranged the one contest in the world that her husband cannot lose and no other man can win, on the one night he happens to be sitting by her fire, and she has done it herself, without being asked, without being told to, and against her own interest.

NOTES TO BOOK NINETEEN

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[85] **Does she know?** The central argument of *Odyssey* criticism, and nobody has won it. The case for yes: she suddenly finds this beggar dearer than any guest she has had; she asks him for exactly the proof he can give; she tells him her most private dream; she comes down and announces the contest of the bow within an hour of being given a sworn oath that her husband will arrive this month; and the contest she chooses is one only her husband can win. The case for no: the poem says several times that Athena put things into her mind, which would be a strange way to describe a woman acting on her own conclusions; she says plainly and repeatedly that she does not believe he is coming; and when the truth finally arrives she does not behave in the least like someone who suspected it. — My own view, for what it is worth, is that the question may be badly posed. People are perfectly capable of knowing a thing and not knowing it at the same time, and of taking an action for reasons they could not state if you asked them. The poem gives us her behaviour and withholds her mind, and it does that on purpose, and it does it to nobody else in the book.

Book Twenty: In Which Nobody Sleeps, and the Last Dinner Is Served.

Book 20

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK TWENTY

In Which Nobody Sleeps, and the Last Dinner Is Served

Odysseus lay down to sleep in the forecourt. He spread an undressed oxhide on the ground and heaped over it a great many fleeces from the sheep the Greeks had been killing, and Eurynome threw a cloak over him when he had lain down. And there he lay awake, turning over trouble for the suitors in his mind.

And the women came out of the hall, the ones who had been going with the suitors, laughing among themselves and making merry together. And the heart in his breast was stirred, and he debated hard, in his mind and in his heart, whether to rush out and deal death to every one of them, or to let them lie with the arrogant suitors this one last time. And the heart inside him growled.

As a bitch stands over her tender puppies and growls at a man she does not know, and is ready to fight him, so the heart growled inside him at their wickedness. And he struck himself on the breast and spoke to his own heart.

"Endure this, heart. You put up with something fouler than this on the day the Cyclops, who had no restraint in him, ate my strong companions. And you held out, until cunning got you out of that cave when you had thought you were dead."

So he spoke, rebuking the heart in his own breast; and his heart held firm and stayed obedient. But the man himself went on tossing from side to side.

As a man turns a paunch stuffed with fat and blood this way and that over a blazing fire, wanting it roasted quickly, so he rolled from side to side, working out how he was ever going to lay hands on the shameless suitors, one man against so many.[86]

And Athena came down to him from the sky, in the likeness of a woman, and stood over his head.

"Why are you awake, unluckiest of all men? This is your house. Your wife is in it, and your son — and a son any man would be glad of."

"Goddess, everything you say is right. But my heart keeps working at this: how am I to lay hands on the shameless suitors, alone as I am, when they are always here in a body? And there is a bigger thing than that which I keep turning over. If I do kill them, by the will of Zeus and yourself, where am

[86] **"Endure, my heart."** A man lying awake in the dark, so angry that he can feel it moving in his chest, hits himself and tells the thing to be quiet — and then reminds it, as one might remind a frightened animal or a subordinate, of a worse night the two of them got through together. It is one of the earliest passages in European literature in which a person addresses part of himself as though it were somebody else in the room, and it was still being quoted a thousand years later by philosophers who took it for the model of self-command: the reasoning man speaking to his own passion, and the passion obeying him. Two things are worth noticing beyond that. The first is that it does not entirely work, since the heart obeys and the man himself lies there rolling from side to side like something on a griddle, and the poem gives that its own simile, which is the least dignified in the book and exactly right. The second is what he reaches for when he needs steadying: not his wife, not his son, not his kingdom, but the cave, and the men who were eaten in it, and the fact that he got out — which after twenty years is still the thing he uses to prove to himself that he can bear something.

I to escape to afterwards? I ask you to think about that."

"You obstinate man. Most people are content to trust a weaker friend than I am — a mortal, who does not know as much. I am a god, and I have guarded you the whole way through, in every one of your troubles. I shall put it plainly: if fifty companies of mortal men stood round the two of us, wanting to kill us in a fight, you would drive their cattle and their fat sheep away afterwards. So let sleep take you. It is a weariness to lie awake and keep watch all night. You are coming up out of your troubles now."

And she poured sleep over his eyelids and went back to Olympus.

But as sleep took hold of him, loosening the cares of his heart, his true wife woke, and sat up in her soft bed and cried; and when she had had her fill of crying she prayed first of all to Artemis (goddess of the hunt, whose arrows bring a quiet death to women).

"Artemis, honoured goddess, daughter of Zeus — I wish you would put an arrow in my breast this minute and take my life away. Or let a storm wind catch me up and carry me off down the misty ways and throw me out where the circling Ocean pours in, the way the storm winds carried off the daughters of Pandareus.

"The gods had killed their parents and left them orphans in the house; and Aphrodite (goddess of love) fed them on cheese and sweet honey and good wine, and Hera (queen of the gods) gave them beauty and sense beyond all other women, and holy Artemis gave them height, and Athena taught them how to do glorious work with their hands. And while Aphrodite was going up to high Olympus to ask Zeus to arrange happy marriages for them, the storm winds snatched the girls away and handed them over to the hateful Furies to look after.

"I wish those who live on Olympus would blot me out that way, or that Artemis of the lovely hair would strike me, so that I might go down under the hateful earth still looking at Odysseus, and never gladden the heart of a lesser man.

"An evil is bearable when a person cries all day, with a heavy heart, but sleep takes hold of them at night; because sleep makes you forget everything, good and bad, once it has closed your eyelids. But some god sends me bad dreams as well.

"This very night there was somebody lying beside me, like him, looking as he did when he went away with the army; and my heart was glad, because I thought it was not a dream but the truth at last."

She said that, and the golden Dawn came up.

And Odysseus, lying there, heard the sound of her crying; and in the drowsy state between sleeping and waking it seemed to him that she already knew him, and was standing beside his head. So he gathered up the cloak and the fleeces he had been lying on and put them on a chair in the hall, and carried the oxhide out of doors, and lifted his hands and prayed to Zeus.

"Father Zeus, if you gods brought me over the dry land and the water to my own country of your own will, after you had afflicted me so badly — then let one of the people waking in this house speak a word of omen for me, and let some other sign be shown to me outside."

And Zeus the counsellor heard him, and thundered at once out of shining Olympus, from high up above the clouds; and Odysseus was glad.

And a woman grinding grain spoke the word, close by, in the house, where the king's mills stood. Twelve women in all worked at them, making barley meal and wheat flour, which is the marrow of men. The others were asleep, having ground their wheat, but this one alone had not finished yet,

because she was the weakest of them. She stopped her mill and spoke the words that were a sign for her master.

"Father Zeus, who rule over gods and men — you have thundered loudly out of the starry sky, and there is not a cloud anywhere. You must be showing somebody a sign.

"Bring about what I am going to say, wretched as I am. Let this be the very last day the suitors take their sweet dinner in the halls of Odysseus. They have loosened my knees with the miserable work of grinding their meal. Let them eat their last supper now."

And Odysseus was glad at the word of omen and at the thunder of Zeus, because he believed he was going to make the guilty pay.[87]

The other women were gathering in the fine house by now and kindling the unwearying fire on the hearth; and Telemachus got out of bed and dressed and slung his sharp sword over his shoulder and tied his good sandals under his shining feet, and took up his heavy spear with the sharp bronze point.

He stopped in the doorway and said to Eurycleia: "Dear nurse, did you honour the stranger in the house with a bed and food, or is he lying about uncared for? Because that is my mother's way, sensible as she is. She will honour a worse man blindly, and send a better one away without honour."

"You should not blame her now, child, when she is not to blame. He sat and drank his wine as long as he wanted, and said he was not hungry any more, because she asked him. And when he began to think about bed and sleep, she told the women to make one up for him. But he was like a man who is completely miserable and out of luck, and he refused to sleep in a bed under blankets. He lay in the forecourt on an undressed oxhide and some sheepskins, and we threw a cloak over him."

So Telemachus went out through the hall with his spear in his hand, and two swift dogs went with him, and he made his way to the assembly place. And Eurycleia set the women to work: sweeping the house and sprinkling the floors, putting the purple covers on the chairs, wiping down the tables with sponges, cleaning the mixing bowls and the two-handled cups. Twenty of them went off to the spring for water, and the rest worked in the house, deft about their business.

And the suitors' men came in and began splitting wood skilfully; and the women came back from the spring. And Eumaeus came after them, driving three fat hogs, the best of the whole herd. He left them to feed in the fine yard, and he spoke to Odysseus kindly.

"Stranger, are the Greeks looking at you any better now, or are they still treating you badly in the halls, as before?"

"Eumaeus, I only wish the gods would pay them back for the outrage they commit in another man's house, insolently, without a shred of shame in them."

And while they were talking, Melanthius the goatherd came up, driving in the best goats of all his flocks for the suitors' dinner, and two herdsmen came with him; and he tied the goats under the echoing colonnade and spoke to Odysseus again with his usual sneer.

[87] **Two omens, and the woman at the mill.** He asks for two signs and is given both at once, which is how these things tend to work in this poem: a sign from the sky, and a word spoken inside the house by somebody who has no idea they are speaking it. The thunder comes out of a clear sky, and the words come from the last woman still working at the querns after the other eleven have finished and gone to sleep, because she is the weakest of them and the slowest at the work. What she prays for is not justice, or vengeance, or her master's return, but simply that the men whose bread she is grinding should eat their last meal today, because her knees hurt. It is the only time in the whole poem that we hear from one of the women who do the grinding, and it lasts eight lines; the mills of a great house were worked by hand, all day, by slaves, and it was reckoned the hardest indoor work there was. The poem knows that perfectly well, and it gives the omen to the person in the building who is worst off, and Odysseus takes it as heaven speaking.

"Stranger, are you still going to be a nuisance here in this house, begging off the gentlemen? Are you never going to clear out? I do not think the two of us are going to part without tasting each other's fists, because you beg past all decency. There are other dinners among the Greeks."

Odysseus did not answer him a word. He shook his head in silence, turning over trouble in the depths of him.

And a third man came in, Philoetius, a leader among men, bringing a barren heifer and some fat goats for the suitors; the ferrymen had brought them over, who take anybody across who comes their way. He tied the animals up carefully under the echoing colonnade, and came and stood beside the swineherd.

"Who is this stranger, swineherd, who has just come to our house? What family does he claim? Where are his people and his father's fields? Poor man. He has the build of a king about him; but the gods bring misery on men who have wandered a long way, once they have spun trouble for them, kings included."

And he took Odysseus by the hand and said:

"Good day, father stranger. May you have some happiness in the time to come; you are held down by a great many troubles at present.

"Father Zeus, no god is more deadly than you. You have no pity for men, though you made them yourself; you let them get acquainted with misery and hard pain.

"I broke out in a sweat when I saw you, and my eyes are full of tears, because I thought of Odysseus. I expect he is dressed in rags like these too, wandering about among people somewhere, if he is still alive and looking at the sunlight.

"And if he is dead already and in the house of Hades — then I grieve for faultless Odysseus, who set me over his cattle when I was only a boy in the country of the Cephallenians. They have increased past counting since then. No man's herd of broad-browed cattle could have grown better.

"And now other men order me to drive them in for themselves to eat. They take no notice of the son in the house and no notice of the anger of the gods, because they are in a hurry to divide up the property of a master who has been away too long.

"And here is the thing that keeps turning over in my heart. It is a very bad business, while the son is alive, to take the cattle and go off to another country, to strangers. And it is worse still to stay here in misery, minding cattle that belong to other men. I would have run long ago and gone to one of the other great kings, because this is past bearing. But I keep thinking about that unhappy man, and hoping he may come from somewhere and scatter the suitors through the halls."

"Cowherd," said Odysseus, "since you seem to be neither a bad man nor a fool, and I can see for myself that you have sense in your mind, I shall tell you something and swear a great oath on it. Let Zeus be my witness first, and this table of hospitality, and the hearth of Odysseus that I have come to: Odysseus will come home while you are still here, and you shall see with your own eyes, if you want to, the killing of the suitors who lord it in this house."

"Stranger, I wish the son of Cronos would bring that word about. Then you would find out what my strength is, and how these hands of mine obey me."

And Eumaeus prayed to all the gods in the same way, that clever Odysseus might come back to his own house.

Meanwhile the suitors were weaving death and destruction for Telemachus. But a bird came over

on their left, an eagle flying high with a trembling dove in its claws; and Amphinomus said: "Friends, this plan of ours will not run smoothly — the killing of Telemachus. Let us think about dinner instead." That pleased them all, and they went into the house and laid their cloaks on the chairs and benches and set about killing sheep and goats and fat hogs and a heifer from the herd.

And Telemachus put Odysseus in the great hall itself, beside the stone threshold, on a shabby stool at a small table, and gave him a portion of the inner meat and poured wine for him in a golden cup.

"Sit there now among the gentlemen and drink your wine. I shall keep the taunts and the hands of all the suitors off you myself, because this is not a public house; it is the house of Odysseus, and he won it for me. And you, suitors, hold your tongues from insults and your hands from blows, so that no quarrel and no fighting starts."

They all bit their lips and were astonished at Telemachus, that he spoke so boldly. And Antinous said: "Hard as it is, let us take what Telemachus says, though he threatens us a good deal. Zeus did not allow it, or we should have stopped him talking in these halls before now, clear speaker though he is."

Telemachus took no notice of him at all.

And by now the heralds were bringing the holy sacrifice for the gods through the town, and the long-haired Greeks were gathering in the shady grove of Apollo, who shoots from far off.[88]

And in the house they roasted the outer meat and drew it off the spits and divided the portions and had a splendid dinner; and the men who were serving put down a portion in front of Odysseus equal to their own, because Telemachus had told them to.

But Athena would not let the arrogant suitors leave off their bitter insulting altogether, so that the pain might sink deeper still into the heart of Odysseus.

There was a man among them with a lawless mind, whose name was Ctesippus, and he lived on Same; and trusting in his enormous wealth he was courting the wife of the long-absent master of the house. And he spoke up now to the arrogant suitors.

"Listen to me, my lords. The stranger has had an equal portion for some time, as is only proper; it would not be decent or right to cheat the guests of Telemachus, whoever comes to this house. But come — I shall give him a guest-gift myself, so that he can pass it on as a present to the bath-woman, or to one of the other slaves in the house of Odysseus."

And with that he picked up an ox's foot out of the basket where it lay, and threw it with his heavy hand.

And Odysseus avoided it by turning his head aside a little, and smiled in his heart a very grim smile indeed; and the foot hit the well-built wall.

And Telemachus rounded on Ctesippus.

"It has turned out a great deal better for your life that you did not hit the stranger; he got out of the way of your missile himself. Otherwise I should have run you through the middle with my sharp spear, and your father would have been arranging a funeral here instead of a wedding.

"So let nobody in my house make a display of unseemly behaviour. I notice everything now and I

[88] **A feast day of Apollo.** The line goes past in half a sentence and is easy to miss, but the whole of the next two books rests on it. This is a public festival of Apollo, the archer god, whose particular business is the bow; the townspeople are out at his grove making sacrifice while the suitors dine. So the contest that Penelope announced last night, and everything that comes of it, falls on the god's own day — which is why nobody in the story finds it odd that a bow should be brought out, and why, when the arrow finally goes, the poem can let a reader feel that something older and larger than this household has taken a hand in the business.

understand it, the good and the bad alike; before this I was a child.

"But even so we put up with watching all this — sheep slaughtered and wine drunk and food eaten — because it is hard for one man to hold back a great many. Still: do me no more harm out of your hostility. And if you are set on killing me with the sword, then I would rather have that. It would be far better to die than to go on watching these disgraceful things forever — guests knocked about, and men dragging the serving women shamefully through this beautiful house."

They all went very quiet. And after a while Agelaus said:

"Friends, when a just word has been spoken nobody should take offence and answer it back angrily. Do not manhandle the stranger, or any of the servants in the house of godlike Odysseus.

"But I would say a gentle word to Telemachus himself and to his mother, in the hope that it pleases them both. As long as the hearts in your breasts still hoped that Odysseus would come home, nobody could blame you for waiting and keeping the suitors in the house; that was the better course, if Odysseus had come back. But now it is perfectly plain that he never will.

"So go and sit beside your mother and tell her this: to marry the best man, the one who offers the most, so that you can keep everything your father owned, eating and drinking, while she looks after somebody else's house."

"Agelaus, I swear by Zeus and by my father's sufferings, who has died somewhere far from Ithaca or is wandering still — I am not putting my mother's marriage off in any way. I tell her to marry whoever she likes, and I offer gifts past counting.

"But I am ashamed to drive her out of the hall against her will by saying so outright. God forbid that."

And then Athena stirred up unquenchable laughter in the suitors and knocked their wits sideways.

They were laughing now with jaws that seemed to belong to somebody else. The meat they were eating was fouled with blood, and their eyes were filling with tears, and their hearts had turned towards wailing.

And Theoclymenus, who saw as a prophet sees, spoke among them.

"You poor wretches, what is this trouble you are suffering? Your heads and your faces and your knees are wrapped in night. There is a burning sound of wailing going up, and your cheeks are wet with tears. The walls are sprinkled with blood, and the fine crossbeams too. The porch is full of ghosts and the courtyard is full of them, hurrying down into the dark under the earth. And the sun has died out of the sky, and an evil mist has run over everything."

And they all laughed at him very merrily, and Eurymachus said: "This stranger has just come from abroad and he has lost his mind. Quick, young men, take him out of doors and see him to the assembly place, since he finds it dark in here."

"Eurymachus, I am not asking you for an escort. I have eyes and ears and both my feet and a perfectly sound mind in my breast. I shall take myself out through that door, because I can see the evil coming for you, and not one of the suitors will get away from it — not one of you who insult men and plan wanton things in the house of godlike Odysseus."

And with that he went out of the hall and came to the house of Peiraeus, who was glad to see him.

I must stop for a moment over that passage, because it is the strangest in the poem and a reader who is not warned may take it for nonsense. What is being described is a room in which twenty or so

young men are laughing helplessly and cannot stop, so that their own jaws seem to have been borrowed from somebody else; and their eyes are streaming, as eyes will when laughter has gone past the point of pleasure; and the meat in their hands is running with blood, which is the ordinary condition of half-cooked meat and also, this evening, something else altogether. They are enjoying themselves enormously, and every single thing about the way they are enjoying themselves is wrong, and not one of them can see it. Only the prophet standing in the middle of the room sees it, and what he sees is the same room a few hours later, with the blood on the walls and the crowd of ghosts going out through the porch and down into the dark; and he tells them so, plainly and at once, and they laugh at him as well and suggest that somebody show him to the door. For twenty lines the poem lifts the roof off a dining room and lets us look at the men inside it from outside time, as the dead men they have already become; and then it puts the roof back on, and they go on with their dinner.

And they went on provoking Telemachus, glancing at one another and making fun of his guests. And one of the arrogant young men would say:

"Telemachus, nobody in the world has worse luck with visitors than you. Look at the tramp you keep, wanting his bread and his wine, no use at any kind of work, no strength in him, a dead weight on the good earth. And this other one gets up on his feet to prophesy at us. If you would take my advice, it would pay you much better to throw the pair of them onto a ship and send them off to the Sicilians. They would fetch you a good price."

That is what the suitors said; and Telemachus took no notice of them. He watched his father in silence, waiting for the moment when he would put out his hands against the shameless men.

And Penelope, the daughter of Icarius, had set her lovely chair opposite them, and she heard every word every man of them spoke in that hall.

They had prepared their dinner with a great deal of laughter, and it was a good one and there was plenty of it, because they had killed a great many animals.

But there could never be a dinner less pleasant than the one the goddess and the powerful man were shortly going to set in front of them. And they had brought it on themselves.[89]

NOTES TO BOOK TWENTY

Book Twenty-One: In Which a Bow Comes Down Off Its Peg.

[89]**Theoclymenus, and where he goes.** This is the last we see of him. He was picked up on a beach in Book Fifteen, a fugitive with blood on his hands and the most distinguished prophetic ancestry in Greece, and he has now done the one thing he was brought into the poem to do. It is worth noticing that of everybody in that hall he is the only man who walks out of it alive by his own choice — and that he does so immediately after being told, by the second most powerful man in the room, that he must be mad and had better be shown to the door. The suitors are offered exactly one clear warning apiece in these last books: Amphinomus got his from Odysseus and sat down again, and the rest get theirs from a prophet standing in front of them describing their own deaths, and they laugh.

Book 21

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK TWENTY-ONE

In Which a Bow Comes Down Off Its Peg

Then Athena put it into the mind of Penelope to set the bow and the grey iron before the suitors in the halls of Odysseus, as a contest for them and the beginning of their killing.

She went up the high staircase of her house and took the bent key in her strong hand, a good one, made of bronze, with an ivory handle on it; and she went with her women to the innermost store-room, where her husband's treasures lay, the bronze and the gold and the worked iron. And there lay the back-bent bow and the quiver for the arrows, with a great many grievous shafts in it, which a friend had given him when they met once in Lacedaemon (Sparta): Iphitus, the son of Eurytus, a man like the immortals.

The two of them had met in Messene, in the house of Ortilochus. Odysseus had come there over a debt the whole people owed him, because Messenian men had carried off three hundred sheep from Ithaca in their benched ships, and the shepherds with them; and he had come the long journey after them while he was still a boy, sent by his father and the other elders. And Iphitus had come looking for twelve brood mares he had lost, with hardy mules still at the teat. Those mares were the death of him in the end, because when he came to the house of the son of Zeus — Heracles, the man of the great labours — Heracles killed him, guest though he was under his roof. He had no fear of the gods' anger in him and no respect for the table he had set in front of the man; he killed him anyway, and kept the strong-hoofed mares in his own stables.

It was while he was looking for those that Iphitus met Odysseus and gave him the bow, which great Eurytus had carried in his day and left to his son when he died. And Odysseus gave him a sharp sword and a heavy spear, the beginning of a friendship between two houses; but they never came to know each other at the table, because the son of Zeus killed Iphitus first.

And Odysseus never took that bow with him in the black ships when he went to the war. It lay at home in his halls as a keepsake of a friend, and he carried it only in his own country.[90]

Penelope came to the room and stepped up onto the oak threshold, which a carpenter had planed skilfully long ago and made true to the line, and had set the doorposts on it and hung the shining

[90]**The bow, and the man who gave it.** The poem stops for thirty lines to tell us where this weapon came from, which is a long time in a book that is moving as fast as this one, and the detail is doing several things. First it establishes that the bow is a guest-gift — the formal exchange between two men that made their houses friends for good, which we have been watching people honour and violate since Book One — and that Odysseus gave a sword and a spear in return. Then it tells us that the friendship never had time to grow, because Heracles murdered Iphitus in his own house, over some horses, having fed him first. That is the worst crime available in this world, and it is dropped in without comment, about the most famous hero in Greek legend, in a single sentence. — And last, the detail that decides everything: Odysseus did not take this bow to Troy. He left it at home as a keepsake of a dead friend and used it only on his own land. Which is why it is in a locked room upstairs rather than at the bottom of the sea with his ships, and why there is exactly one man alive who has ever strung it.

doors. She slipped the thong off the handle and pushed the key in and shot the bolts back, aiming carefully.

And as a bull bellows when he is grazing in a meadow, so those beautiful doors bellowed when the key struck them; and they flew open in front of her.

She stepped up onto the high floor where the chests stood with the sweet-smelling clothes in them, and reached up and took the bow down off its peg, in the bright case that was round it. And she sat down there with the case on her knees and cried aloud, and took her husband's bow out of it.

And when she had had her fill of weeping she went off to the hall, to the lordly suitors, carrying the back-bent bow and the quiver, with a great many grievous shafts in it; and her women carried a chest behind her with a quantity of iron and bronze in it, her husband's prizes.

She came among the suitors and stood by the doorpost of the great hall, holding her shining veil in front of her face, with a faithful woman standing on either side of her; and she spoke to them at once.

"Listen to me, my lords. You have fastened on this house to eat and drink in it, without a break, while its master has been a long time gone; and you have not been able to find any other pretext for it except that you want to marry me.

"So here is your prize, gentlemen, set out in front of you. I shall put down the great bow of godlike Odysseus. And whichever man most easily strings it in his hands and shoots an arrow clean through all twelve axes — with him I shall go, and leave this house of my marriage, so beautiful, and so full of everything a life needs, which I think I shall remember even in my dreams."

And she told Eumaeus to set the bow and the grey iron down in front of them. He took them from her, crying, and set them down; and the cowherd cried too when he saw his master's bow.

And Antinous rounded on the pair of them. "You stupid peasants, who think no further than today. You wretched creatures, what are you snivelling for? You are upsetting the lady, whose heart is already lying low with grief because she has lost her husband. Sit down and eat in silence, or go outside and cry there, and leave the bow here for us — an unambiguous sort of contest, because I do not think this polished bow will be strung at all easily. There is no man among the whole company here of the sort Odysseus was. I saw him myself and I remember him, though I was only a child."

So he said; and the heart in his breast was hoping he would string it himself and shoot through the iron. And in fact he was going to be the first man to taste an arrow from the hands of the great Odysseus, whom at that moment he was dishonouring where he sat, and urging all his friends to do the same.

And Telemachus said: "Zeus must have made me stupid. Here is my dear mother, sensible as she is, saying she will go off with another man and leave this house — and I laugh, and I am glad, with my wits gone.

"So come along, gentlemen, since here is your prize set in front of you: a woman such as there is not now in all the Greek country, not in sacred Pylos, not in Argos or Mycenae, not in Ithaca itself nor on the dark mainland. You know that perfectly well yourselves. What need is there for me to praise my own mother?

"Come, no putting it off with excuses, and no turning away from the drawing of the bow any longer; let us see how it goes. And I should like a try at the bow myself. If I string it and shoot an arrow through the iron, then my honoured mother would not be leaving this house to go off with another man and grieve me, and leave me behind — now that I am old enough to take up my father's prizes."

And he sprang up and threw off his purple cloak and unslung his sharp sword.

First he set up the axes. He dug one long trench for the whole row of them, and lined them all up to a string, and stamped the earth down round them. And everybody was astonished at how neatly he set them out, though he had never seen it done in his life.

Then he went and stood on the threshold and tried the bow.

Three times he made it quiver, straining to draw it, and three times he let the effort go, though in his heart he was hoping to string it and shoot through the iron. And he would have got it strung at the fourth attempt, hauling at it with all his strength — but Odysseus shook his head and stopped him, keen as he was.

"Well," he said, "I am going to be a weakling and a coward all my life, or else I am simply too young, and cannot trust my hands yet to keep off a man who starts a quarrel. But come along, you who are stronger than I am, and try the bow, and let us settle this contest."

And he put the bow down on the ground, leaning it against the smooth-jointed doors, and stood the swift arrow against the fine curve of the bow, and went and sat down again on the chair he had got up from.

I should stop here for a moment, because a modern reader is very likely to be picturing something quite different from what is happening in that hall, and the picture matters a good deal over the next hour.

Nobody is entirely certain what shooting through twelve axes means, and I would not trust anyone who tells you they are. Homer's audience knew, and never needed telling, so the poem describes the trench and the lining-up and the stamping down and never once explains what the target actually is; and we have been guessing ever since. The likeliest arrangement, and the one most people who have handled the tools have settled on, is this. The heads of these axes were not the shape of a modern woodsman's axe. They had a socket or a ring at the base where the handle went in, and if you take a dozen of them and bed the handles in a trench in the floor with the heads standing up in a row, all lined true and all the same height, you have a line of twelve rings hanging in the air one behind another, and a very narrow tunnel of daylight running through them. The shot is to put an arrow down that tunnel from the far end of a long hall, from a sitting position, without touching any of the twelve.

Which tells you two things at once. The first is that this is not a test of strength at all; it is a test of an almost absurd precision, of a kind that would be a fine trick at any distance and is barely credible at that one. And the second is that the man who used to do it for entertainment in this room, standing a long way off and putting the arrow through, is the man now sitting by the door in rags — and that his son, who has never once seen it done, sets the axes up so exactly that a hall full of hostile men stops talking to watch him do it.

Then Antinous said: "Get up in turn, all of you, from left to right, starting from where the wine is poured."

And Leiodes stood up first, the son of Oenops, who was their soothsayer and always sat by the fine mixing bowl at the far end of the hall. He was the only one of them to whom their outrages were hateful, and he was indignant with the whole company. He took the bow and the swift arrow and went and stood on the threshold and tried it; and he could not string it, because he wore his hands out with pulling first — they were soft hands, and unused to work.

"Friends, I cannot string it. Let somebody else take it. This bow is going to rob a great many of our leading men of their spirit and their lives — because it is far better to be dead than to go on living and

fail to get the thing we gather here for every single day, waiting and hoping. There is many a man here now hoping and wanting to marry Penelope. But when he has tried this bow and seen for himself, then let him go and court some other well-dressed Greek woman with gifts; and Penelope can marry whichever man gives most, and comes as the one fate has appointed."

And he set the bow aside, leaning it against the doors.[91]

Antinous rounded on him too. "Leiodes, what a thing to let past the barrier of your teeth. A grim word, and an ugly one, and it makes me angry to hear it — that this bow is going to rob our best men of their lives, just because you cannot string it. Your honoured mother did not bear you to be a drawer of bows and a shooter of arrows. There are other lordly gentlemen here who will string it soon enough."

And he called to Melanthius the goatherd. "Get a fire going in the hall and put a big stool beside it with a fleece on it, and bring out a great cake of fat from the store, so that we young men can warm the bow and rub the grease into it and try it, and finish this contest."

So Melanthius lit the fire and put the stool there with the fleece over it and brought a great cake of fat out of the store; and the young men warmed the bow and tried it.

And they could not string it. They were a very long way short of the strength for it. But Antinous still held back, and so did godlike Eurymachus, the leaders of the suitors, who were far the best of them.

Here, if you will bear with me, is the other thing worth knowing, because without it the whole afternoon looks like a simple trial of muscle, and it is not.

A bow of this kind was not a bent stick. It was a composite: a wooden core with strips of animal horn glued along the belly and layers of sinew laid along the back, the whole thing bound and seasoned and left to cure for a very long time — a year or two, in the making — and the finished weapon curves the wrong way when it is unstrung, so that stringing it means bending it backwards against itself. Such a bow is enormously powerful for its size, and it is also fussy. It hates damp, which is why this one has lived in a locked room in a case; the glue goes soft with heat, which is why warming it at the fire and rubbing it with fat is a real technique and not a piece of superstition; and it can be ruined by worm in the horn while nobody is using it, which is exactly what Odysseus will be checking for in a few pages when he turns it over and over in his hands and the suitors laugh at him for a connoisseur.

And stringing one is a knack. It is not done by hauling on both ends. It is done by bracing the bow against the body in a particular way, with a particular leg through it or a particular grip, so that the strength you have goes exactly where it is needed; and a man who has never been shown will fail at it however strong he is, and will look foolish, and will not know why. That is what a hall full of young athletes is discovering. They are not weaklings. They are amateurs with somebody else's specialist equipment, and the one man in the room who has been shown is sitting by the door with a bag full of holes, watching them heat his bow.

While they were at it, the cowherd and the swineherd went out of the house together; and Odysseus went out after them.

[91] **Leiodes.** The suitors' own diviner, who sat apart at the mixing bowl and disliked what the others did — the nearest thing to a decent man among them after Amphinomus, and the first to try the bow and fail. What he says as he sets it down is worth marking: that this bow will cost a great many of them their lives. He means it as a figure of speech, in the way a man might say a thing is the death of him; he is a professional reader of signs, and he does not notice that he has just made a true prophecy about his own house. He will ask Odysseus for his life in Book Twenty-Two, on the grounds that he never joined in, and it will not save him.

When they were past the door and outside the courtyard he spoke to them gently.

"Cowherd — and you, swineherd — shall I say a certain thing, or keep it to myself? My heart tells me to say it. What sort of men would you be for defending Odysseus, if he were to come from somewhere, quite suddenly, and some god were to bring him? Would you stand with the suitors, or with Odysseus? Say what your heart and your spirit tell you."

"Father Zeus," said Philoetius, "I only wish you would bring that about — that the man might come, and some god bring him home. Then you would find out what my strength is, and how these hands of mine obey me."

And Eumaeus prayed to all the gods in the same way, that clever Odysseus might come back to his own house.

And when he had seen their minds were sound and true, he answered them.

"Here he is. I am the man. I have come home in the twentieth year to my own country, after suffering a great deal. And I know that of all my servants you two alone are glad of my coming; I have not heard one of the others praying that I might come home again.

"So I shall tell you the truth about what is going to happen. If the god beats the lordly suitors down under me, I shall bring the two of you wives, and give you property and houses built close to my own; and after that you shall be companions to me and brothers to Telemachus.

"Come — I shall show you a plain sign as well, so that you know me for certain and are sure in your hearts."

And he pulled the rags aside from the great scar.

And when the two of them had looked it over and taken in every part of it, they burst into tears and threw their arms round Odysseus and kissed his head and his shoulders in welcome; and he kissed their heads and their hands in the same way. And the light of the sun would have gone down on their weeping, if Odysseus himself had not stopped them.

"That is enough crying and wailing, or somebody may come out of the hall and see us and go in and tell them. Go back in one at a time, not together. I shall go first and you come after.

"And let this be the signal. All the rest of them, all the lordly suitors, will refuse to let the bow and the quiver be given to me. But you, good Eumaeus, carry the bow through the hall and put it into my hands; and then tell the women to bar the close-fitting doors of their quarters, and if any of them hears the sound of groaning or of men fighting inside our walls, she is not to come running out but to stay where she is, in silence, at her work.

"And you, good Philoetius (the cowherd), I put in charge of the courtyard gate. Bolt it with the bar, and get the cord round it quickly."

And he went in and sat down again on the chair he had got up from; and the two servants of godlike Odysseus came in afterwards.

Eurymachus by now was handling the bow, warming it this way and that in the light of the fire. And even so he could not string it, and his proud heart groaned aloud.

"This is a bad business, and I am sorry for myself and for all of us. I do not grieve so much about the marriage, distressed as I am; there are plenty of other Greek women, some here in sea-girt Ithaca and some in the other towns. What I mind is that we should turn out so far short of godlike Odysseus in strength that we cannot even string his bow. That is a shame men will hear about for a long time to come."

"Eurymachus," said Antinous, "it will not be like that, and you know it yourself. Today is a holy feast day of the god throughout the country. Who would be bending a bow on a day like this? Put it down quietly. As for the axes, we may as well leave them standing where they are; I do not think anybody is going to walk into the hall of Odysseus and carry them off.

"Come, let the wine-steward pour a few drops into the cups so that we can make our libations and put the curved bow away. And in the morning tell Melanthius to bring in goats, the very best in all his herds, so that we can lay thigh pieces before Apollo, the archer god, and then try the bow and finish the contest."[92]

That pleased them all; and the heralds poured water over their hands, and the young men filled the mixing bowls to the brim and served the wine round, pouring the first drops into each cup for the libation.

And when they had poured and drunk as much as they wanted, Odysseus spoke, with his own purposes in his mind.

"Listen to me, suitors of the glorious queen, and let me say what my heart tells me. I appeal to Eurymachus in particular, and to godlike Antinous, since he has just spoken very sensibly: leave the bow for now and let the gods decide it; in the morning the god will give the strength to whichever man he chooses.

"But hand me the polished bow, so that I can test my hands and my strength among you — and see whether I still have the force I once had in my supple limbs, or whether the wandering and the neglect have worn it out of me."

That made all of them furious, because they were afraid he might string it.

And Antinous turned on him.

"You wretched stranger, you have not the smallest scrap of sense left. Is it not enough for you to sit and eat at your ease among us gentlemen, going short of nothing, and listen to our talk and our conversation, when no other stranger and no other beggar gets to hear us?

"It is the wine that has your wits, honey-sweet wine, which does harm to any man who takes it in great gulps and drinks past what is decent. Wine was what maddened the famous centaur Eurytion, in the hall of great-hearted Peirithous, when he came among the Lapiths; and when the wine had turned his wits, in his madness he did wicked things in that house. Grief took hold of the heroes, and they leapt up and dragged him out through the porch and cut off his ears and his nose with the pitiless bronze; and off he went with his mind still deranged, carrying his own ruin about with him in his witless heart. And out of that came the long feud between men and centaurs — but he brought the first evil on himself, being heavy with wine.

"And I promise you great trouble in the same way, if you string this bow. You will get no kindness from anybody in this country. We shall put you straight on a black ship and send you to king Echetus, who mutilates everybody, and you will not get away from him alive. So drink your wine in peace, and do not set yourself against men who are younger than you."[93]

[92]**The excuse about the feast day.** Antinous produces a reason for adjourning that is entirely respectable and, as far as it goes, perfectly true: this is a public holy day of Apollo, the archer god, and bending a bow on it might well look like poor form. Everyone accepts it with relief. What none of them notice is what the reader was told in the last book — that it being the archer god's own festival is not an argument against the contest at all, but the single most ominous fact in the building. They are postponing an archery competition out of respect for the god of archery, on the day he might be expected to be paying attention, in a hall where the man who owns the bow is sitting by the door.

[93]**The centaur at the wedding.** Antinous's warning story would have needed no explaining to his listeners. The Lapiths

And Penelope answered him.

"Antinous, it is neither decent nor just to cheat the guests of Telemachus, whoever comes to this house.

"Do you really suppose that if this stranger strings the great bow of Odysseus, trusting to his hands and his strength, he will take me home and make me his wife? I do not believe he has any such hope in his own breast. So let none of you sit here eating his dinner with a heavy heart on that account. It is not in the least a reasonable thing to think."

And Eurymachus said: "Daughter of Icarius, sensible Penelope, we do not think this man is going to marry you; that would be an absurdity. What we mind is the talk of men and women — that some day one of the baser Greeks might say: *Truly these are much meaner men courting the wife of a blameless man, and they cannot even string his polished bow; and then some beggar came wandering in and strung it easily and shot through the iron.* That is what they will say, and it will be thrown at us."

"Eurymachus, there is no possible way that men can have a good name in this country who consume and dishonour the house of a prince. Why do you count this particular thing a disgrace?

"This stranger is a big man and well built, and he says he comes of a good father. Give him the polished bow, then, and let us see.

"And I shall tell you plainly, and it will be brought about: if he strings it, and Apollo grants him the glory of it, I shall dress him in a cloak and a tunic, good clothes, and give him a sharp javelin to keep off dogs and men, and a two-edged sword, and sandals for his feet; and I shall send him wherever his heart wants to go."

And Telemachus said:

"Mother, as far as the bow goes, no Greek has a better right than I have to give it or refuse it to whoever I like — not one of the men who are lords in rocky Ithaca or in the islands over towards Elis. Not one of them will thwart me against my will, not even if I choose to give this bow to the stranger outright, to carry away with him.

"So go to your own part of the house and see to your own work, the loom and the distaff, and tell your women to get on with theirs. The bow is men's business, and mine most of all; because the authority in this house is mine."

And she went back up in astonishment, taking her son's wise saying to heart. And she went up to her upper room with her women and cried for Odysseus, her dear husband, until Athena cast a sweet sleep on her eyelids.

Then the good swineherd picked up the curved bow and started carrying it; and all the suitors began shouting at him through the hall, and one of the arrogant young men would say:

"Where are you carrying that curved bow, you miserable swineherd, you crazy creature? The swift dogs you reared yourself will eat you out there among your pigs, away from everybody, if Apollo and the other immortals are kind to us."

And he was frightened, and put the bow down where he stood, because a great many of them were

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were a people of Thessaly, and at the wedding feast of their king Peirithous the centaurs among the guests got drunk and attempted to carry off the women, and a general slaughter followed; it was one of the best-known stories in Greece and was carved on temples all over the country as an image of civilisation against savagery. — The joke, which Antinous is much too pleased with himself to see, is the exact fit of the parallel and which end of it he is standing at. He is warning a stranger about a guest who abused his host's hospitality and got mutilated for it, at a feast, in a hall he has been eating out of for three years without paying, while threatening to have the stranger shipped off to a torturer. Every particular of the story he chooses is about to be true of him, and he has the details the wrong way round.

shouting at him in the hall.

And Telemachus shouted at him too, from the other side, and threatened him.

"Old man, take that bow forward. You will find out soon enough that you cannot obey everybody. Take care I do not chase you back to the fields with a shower of stones, young as I am and strong as you are. I only wish I were as much stronger than all the suitors in this hall; I would very soon send a good few of them out of this house in a miserable state, because they plan wicked things."

And at that they all laughed merrily at him, and stopped being angry with Telemachus. And the swineherd carried the bow through the hall and put it into the hands of clever Odysseus.

Then he called Eurycleia out and said to her: "Telemachus tells you, sensible Eurycleia, to bar the close-fitting doors of the hall; and if any of the women hears the sound of groaning or of men fighting inside our walls, she is not to come out but to stay where she is, in silence, at her work."

So she said nothing, and barred the doors of the great hall.

And Philoetius went silently out of the house and barred the gates of the fenced courtyard. There was a ship's cable of papyrus fibre lying under the colonnade, and he used that to lash the gates fast; and then he came in and sat down again on the chair he had got up from, watching Odysseus.

And Odysseus was already handling the bow, turning it round and round and trying it here and there, in case worms had eaten into the horn while its owner was away.

And one man would glance at his neighbour and say: "Here is a real connoisseur, an expert on bows. I dare say he has bows like it lying at home himself, or is planning to make one, the way he turns it over and over in his hands — this vagabond, so well practised in trouble."

And another of the arrogant young men would say: "I hope he gets as much profit out of his life as he is ever going to get out of stringing that bow."

That is what the suitors said.

And Odysseus, when he had lifted the great bow and looked it over on every side —

as a man skilled at the lyre and at singing stretches a string easily round a new peg, fastening the twisted sheep-gut at either end —

just so, without any effort at all, did Odysseus string the great bow.

And he took it in his right hand and tried the string; and it sang sweetly under his touch, with a note like a swallow's.

A great grief came over the suitors, and the colour changed in all their faces. And Zeus thundered loud, showing his signs.

And the much-enduring godlike Odysseus was glad, because the son of Cronos had sent him an omen.

He picked up a swift arrow that was lying on the table beside him, out of the quiver; the rest were still inside the hollow quiver, the ones the Greeks were shortly going to taste. And he laid it on the bridge of the bow and drew the string and the notched arrow back — sitting exactly where he was, in his chair — and let the shaft go, aiming true.

And he did not miss a single one of the axes, from the first handle onwards. The arrow with the bronze head went clean through the whole line and out at the far end.

And he said to Telemachus:

"Telemachus, the stranger sitting in your halls does not shame you. I did not miss the target, and

I was not long about stringing the bow. My strength is still where it was — not what the suitors say when they insult me.

"But now it is time to get supper ready for these gentlemen, while there is still light. And after that we must make other sport, with the lyre and with singing; because those are the things that go along with a feast."

And he signalled with his eyebrows. And Telemachus, the dear son of godlike Odysseus, slung his sharp sword about him and put his hand round his spear; and there he stood beside his father's chair, armed in gleaming bronze.

NOTES TO BOOK TWENTY-ONE

Book Twenty-Two: In Which the Doors Are Shut.

Book 22

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK TWENTY-TWO

In Which the Doors Are Shut

Then Odysseus of the many devices stripped off his rags and sprang onto the great threshold with the bow in his hands and the quiver full of arrows, and poured the swift shafts out at his feet, and spoke to the suitors.

"So that decisive contest is finished. Now I shall find out whether I can hit another mark, one that no man has hit yet — and may Apollo grant me the glory of it."

And he aimed a bitter arrow at Antinous.

Antinous was on the point of lifting a beautiful cup, a golden one with two handles, and he had it in his hands and was turning it about so as to drink. Death was nowhere in his thoughts. Who among a company of men at dinner would imagine that one man, alone against so many, however strong he was, would bring an evil death and a black fate down on him?

And Odysseus took aim and hit him in the throat, and the point went clean through the soft neck. He sank down sideways, and the cup fell out of his hand as he was hit, and a thick jet of blood came at once from his nostrils. He kicked the table away from him sharply with his foot, and the food went all over the floor, and the bread and the roast meat lay in the mess.

And the suitors began shouting through the hall when they saw the man go down, and they sprang up out of their chairs and rushed about, staring at the well-built walls on every side. There was not a shield anywhere, and not a heavy spear to lay a hand on.

And they shouted at Odysseus in fury.

"Stranger, you shoot at men to your own cost. You will never enter another contest. Your utter destruction is certain now. You have killed the man who was far the best of the young men in Ithaca. The vultures will eat you here."

Every one of them thought he had not meant to kill the man. They were fools. They did not know that the ropes of destruction had been made fast on the whole company.

And Odysseus looked at them from under his brows.

"You dogs. You thought I would never come home from the country of the Trojans, so you wore my house away, and forced the women of my household to lie with you, and courted my wife by stealth while I was still alive — and you had no fear of the gods who hold the wide sky, and no thought that any vengeance of men would come on you afterwards.

"Now the ropes of destruction are made fast on the whole company of you."

And a green fear took hold of all of them, and every man looked about him for somewhere to escape a sheer destruction.

Eurymachus was the only one who could answer him at all.

"If you are really Odysseus of Ithaca, come home, then everything you say about what the Greeks have done is just — a great many reckless things in your halls and out on your land.

"But the man who is to blame for all of it is lying dead already. Antinous. He was the one who set the whole business going, and not so much because he wanted the marriage or needed it, but with something else in mind, which the son of Cronos did not grant him: that he should be king himself over the people of well-built Ithaca, once he had lain in wait for your son and killed him.

"Now he is dead, and it served him right. Spare your own people. We will go round the country afterwards and make good everything that has been eaten and drunk in your halls, and each man will bring you the worth of twenty oxen out of his own property, and pay you back in bronze and gold until your heart is warmed. Until then, nobody could blame you for being angry."

And Odysseus looked at him from under his brows.

"Eurymachus. Not if you gave me the whole of your fathers' property, everything you have now and everything you could add to it from anywhere else — not even then would I hold my hands from killing, until the suitors had paid the whole price of their offence.

"The choice in front of you now is to fight or to run, if any man of you can get away from death and the fates. But I do not think a single one of you will escape a sheer destruction."

I should like to stop for one moment over that exchange, because it is easy to hear it as a furious man refusing to listen, and it is not quite that.

What Eurymachus is offering is not a bribe. It is the ordinary and honourable settlement of this world, and it has a name and a procedure and a long history behind it. When a man had been injured or killed, the injuring party or his family could offer compensation — cattle, bronze, gold, worked to a figure — and if it was accepted, that was the end of the matter, with no dishonour to anybody. It was how a society without police or courts of appeal stopped one killing turning into forty years of killings. In the older poem there is a shield with a whole city engraved on it, and in the middle of that city two men are arguing in front of a crowd over precisely this: whether a blood-price has been properly paid. Everyone listening knew the mechanism, and knew it as a good thing.

So Eurymachus is doing the correct thing, and doing it with some skill. He blames the dead man, who cannot contradict him; he concedes the whole charge; he offers full restitution and then a great deal on top of it, from every man present. Any ordinary hearing of the case would end there.

And Odysseus refuses it, which he is entitled to do — the offer always could be refused, and the refusal was itself a recognised move, and it meant blood. What he says is that no quantity of property will do, because what is owed is not property. It is the only moment in the poem where he is offered a way to have everything back except the satisfaction, and turns it down.

Their knees went loose under them and their hearts melted; and Eurymachus spoke to them a second time.

"Friends, this man is not going to hold his hands. Now that he has the polished bow and the quiver he will shoot from the smooth threshold until he has killed every one of us. So let us think about fighting. Draw your swords and hold the tables up against the arrows; let us all go at him together in a body, and see if we can push him off the threshold and out of the doorway, and get into the town and raise the alarm. Then this man would very soon have shot for the last time."

And he drew his sharp two-edged sword and sprang at him with a terrible shout. And in the same instant Odysseus let an arrow go and struck him in the chest beside the nipple, and drove the swift shaft into his liver. He let the sword drop out of his hand and pitched forward across the table, doubled up, and spilled the food and the two-handled cup on the floor; and he beat the ground with his forehead in his agony, and kicked at the chair with both feet until it rocked; and a mist came down over his eyes.

And Amphinomus went for Odysseus with his sword drawn, to try to force him back from the door. But Telemachus was too quick for him and hit him from behind with his bronze-tipped spear, between the shoulders, and drove it through his chest. He went down with a crash and struck the ground with the whole of his forehead. And Telemachus sprang away, leaving the long spear in the body, because he was afraid one of the Greeks might rush at him with a sword as he stooped to pull it out.

He ran to his father. "Father, I shall fetch you a shield now, and two spears, and a bronze helmet to fit your temples; and I shall arm myself as I go and give arms to the swineherd and to the cowherd. It is much better to be armed."

"Run and fetch them, while I still have arrows to keep them off — or they will push me away from the doorway when I am one man alone."

So Telemachus went to the store-room where the famous weapons were, and took four shields and eight spears and four bronze helmets with horsehair crests, and came back quickly to his father. And he armed himself first, and the two servants put on their fine armour, and they stood beside Odysseus, who was clever and full of schemes.

And as long as he had arrows he kept shooting, and picked the suitors off one by one in his own house, and they fell thick and fast. But when the arrows gave out he leaned the bow against the doorpost of the well-built hall, and slung a shield of four hides over his shoulders, and put a well-made helmet on his powerful head, with a horsehair crest that nodded terribly above it, and took up two heavy spears tipped with bronze.

Now there was a side door in the well-built wall, and at the level of the topmost part of the threshold of the great hall there was a way through into a passage, closed with well-fitting doors. Odysseus had told the swineherd to watch it and stand close by, because there was only the one approach.

And Agelaus called out to them all: "Friends, will nobody climb up to the side door and tell the people and get the alarm raised? Then this man would very soon have shot for the last time."

And Melanthius the goatherd answered him. "It cannot be done, Agelaus. The fine gates of the courtyard are terribly close, and the mouth of the passage is awkward; one man could hold it against the lot of us, if he had any courage. But wait — I shall fetch you arms out of the store-room. Because that is where Odysseus and his son have put them, I am sure of it, and nowhere else."

And he went up by the steps of the hall to the store-rooms of Odysseus, and took out twelve shields and as many spears and as many bronze helmets with horsehair crests, and brought them down and gave them to the suitors, very quickly.

And Odysseus felt his knees and his heart go under him when he saw them putting armour on and shaking their long spears in their hands. The task looked very large. And he said to Telemachus: "One of the women in the house is stirring up an ugly fight against us. Or it is Melanthius."

"Father, I am the one who made this mistake, and nobody else is to blame. I left the close-fitting door of the store-room ajar, and one of them was a better watcher than I was. Go, good Eumaeus, and shut the door of the store-room, and find out whether it is one of the women doing this, or Melanthius

the son of Dolius, which is what I think."

And while they were saying it, Melanthius went up to the store-room again for more armour; and the good swineherd saw him and said at once to Odysseus, who was standing near: "Son of Laertes, that pestilent fellow, the one we suspected, is going up to the store-room again. Tell me plainly — shall I kill him, if I turn out to be the better man, or bring him here to you, so that he can pay for all the crimes he has been planning in your house?"

"Telemachus and I will hold the lordly suitors inside the hall, however furiously they come on. You two twist his feet and his hands up behind his back and throw him into the store-room and tie boards behind him; and put a twisted rope round him and haul him up the tall pillar until he is close under the roof-beams, so that he stays alive a good long while and suffers hard pain."

They went up, and he did not see them, because he was hunting for weapons in a corner of the room; and they took their stand one on either side of the doorposts and waited. And when Melanthius came over the threshold, with a fine helmet in one hand and in the other a broad old shield, spotted with mould, which the hero Laertes had carried when he was young and which had been lying by with the stitching of the straps gone — the two of them rushed at him and got hold of him and dragged him in by the hair and threw him on the floor, in a very bad state of terror; and they tied his hands and feet together behind him with a painful knot, exactly as the son of Laertes had told them, and put a twisted rope round him and hauled him up the tall pillar until he was close under the roof-beams.

And you mocked him then, Eumaeus, swineherd, and said: "Now you will keep watch all night, Melanthius, lying on a soft bed, which is what you deserve; and you will not miss the early Dawn coming up on her golden throne out of the streams of Ocean, at the hour when you usually drive the goats in for the suitors to make their dinner in the hall."

So they left him there, stretched in that cruel bond, and put their armour on and closed the bright door, and went back to Odysseus, who was clever and full of schemes.

And there they stood, breathing fury: four men on the threshold, and inside the hall a great many, and good men.

And Athena came and stood near them, in the likeness of Mentor, and looking like him and sounding like him. And Odysseus was glad when he saw her, and said: "Mentor, keep destruction off us. Remember your old friend, who did you a good many kindnesses; and you are the same age as I am."

He said that, though he suspected it was Athena, who rouses armies.

And the suitors shouted threats at her from the other side of the hall, and Agelaus was the first of them.

"Mentor, do not let Odysseus talk you into fighting the suitors and defending him. Because I think this is how it will go for us: when we have killed these two, the father and the son, then you will be killed along with them, for the things you are proposing to do in this hall; you will pay for it with your own head. And when we have taken your strength away from you with the bronze, we shall mix everything you own, indoors and out, with the property of Odysseus; and we shall not let your sons live in your house, or your daughters, or your good wife go about the town of Ithaca."

That made Athena angrier still in her heart, and she turned on Odysseus with hard words.

"There is no steadiness left in your strength, Odysseus, and no courage, of the kind you had when you fought the Trojans for nine years without a break over Helen of the white arms, and killed a great many men in that terrible fighting, and took the wide streets of Priam's city by your own planning.

"How is it that now, when you have come home to your own house and your own possessions, you

complain about having to be strong against a crowd of suitors?

"Come here, my friend. Stand beside me and watch my work, and see what sort of man Mentor son of Alcimus is at repaying kindness in the middle of enemies."

And even so she did not yet give him the strength to settle the battle either way, because she was still making trial of the strength and the courage of Odysseus and of his glorious son. She darted up to the roof-beam of the smoky hall and sat there in the likeness of a swallow, and watched.[94]

And Agelaus and Eurynomus and Amphimedon and Demoptolemus and Peisander and Polybus urged the suitors on; these were by far the best men of those still alive, and they were fighting for their lives. The bow and the thick-flying arrows had already brought the rest down.

"Friends," said Agelaus, "this man is going to hold his hands at last. Mentor has gone off after all his empty boasting, and they are on their own at the outer door. So do not throw your long spears all together. Six of you cast first, and let us hope Zeus grants that Odysseus is hit and we win the glory. There will be nothing to worry about from the others once he has gone down."

So the six threw as he told them. And Athena made all of it come to nothing. One of them hit the doorpost of the great hall, and another the close-fitting door, and another's heavy ash spear struck the wall.

And when they had got past that volley, Odysseus said: "Friends, now I say it is our turn to throw into the crowd of them, who are trying to kill us on top of everything else they have done."

And all four of them threw, aiming carefully. Odysseus killed Demoptolemus, Telemachus killed Euryades, the swineherd killed Elatus, and the cowherd killed Peisander; and all of them bit the wide earth together. And the suitors drew back to the innermost part of the hall, and the four rushed in and pulled the spears out of the dead men.

And the suitors threw again, hard, and Athena made most of it come to nothing again — one hit the doorpost, another the door, another's ash spear struck the wall. But Amphimedon caught Telemachus on the wrist, a graze that took the skin off; and Ctesippus grazed the shoulder of Eumaeus with a long spear that went over the top of his shield and fell to the ground beyond.

And the four threw again into the crowd. Odysseus killed Eurydamas, Telemachus killed Amphimedon, the swineherd killed Polybus. And the cowherd hit Ctesippus in the chest, and boasted over him.

"Son of Polytherses, you great lover of jokes — do not ever give way to foolishness again and talk so big; leave the last word to the gods, since they are a great deal stronger than you are. That is a guest-gift in return for the ox's foot you gave to godlike Odysseus when he was begging round the house."

Then Odysseus wounded Agelaus with his long spear at close quarters, and Telemachus got Leiocritus in the flank and drove the bronze straight through, so that he pitched forward and struck the ground with the whole of his forehead.

[94] **The aegis, and the goddess on the roof-beam.** The aegis is Athena's — sometimes described as a goatskin, sometimes as a shield, fringed and tasselled and terrible, and its effect on mortals is not to wound them but to unmake their courage; when it is held up, armies run. So the moment it appears above the roof the fighting stops being a fight and becomes a slaughter, and the poem's similes change accordingly, from men throwing spears to cattle driven by a gadfly and small birds broken up by vultures. — What I like best is where she sits to do it. She has been present in the hall for some time in the shape of Mentor, taking part in the argument and being threatened by Agelaus, and when she finally acts she darts up to a beam and turns into a swallow. A goddess who has just declined to settle the battle for him, on the grounds that she wanted to see what he was made of first, watches the end of it from the rafters in the shape of a small bird.

And then Athena held up the deadly aegis high from the roof — the terrible thing she carries, that turns men's courage to water when they look at it — and their hearts were terrified, and they went fleeing through the hall like a herd of cattle that the darting gadfly falls on and drives before it in the spring, when the long days come.

And as vultures with hooked claws and curved beaks come down off the mountains and dart at the smaller birds, which fly low over the plain shunning the clouds, and the vultures fall on them and kill them, and there is no defence and no escape, and men are glad at the chase — so those four went at the suitors and struck them down right and left through the hall, and a hideous groaning went up as heads were broken, and the whole floor ran with blood.

And Leiodes rushed forward and got hold of the knees of Odysseus and begged him.

"I beg you by your knees, Odysseus. Respect me and pity me. I tell you I never yet did any wrong to one of the women in your halls, by word or by deed; and I tried to stop the other suitors when any of them was doing such things. And they would not listen to me and keep their hands off wickedness; so through their own reckless folly they have met a shameful end.

"And I was their soothsayer, and I have done nothing wrong, and I shall lie down among them. So there is no gratitude afterwards for good things done."

And Odysseus looked at him from under his brows.

"If you claim to have been the soothsayer of these men, then you must often have prayed in these halls that the day of my sweet homecoming should be kept far away from me, and that my dear wife should follow you and bear you children. So you shall not escape a bitter death."

And with his heavy hand he picked up a sword that was lying on the ground, which Agelaus had dropped when he was killed, and drove it full into his neck; and his head was in the dust while he was still speaking.[95]

And Phemius the singer was still trying to get away from the black fate — the man who sang for the suitors because they made him. He was standing near the side door with the clear-toned lyre in his hands, turning it over in his mind whether to slip out of the hall and sit down at the great altar of Zeus of the courtyard, where Laertes and Odysseus had burned so many thigh-pieces of oxen, or whether to run forward and take hold of the knees of Odysseus and beg.

And as he thought about it, taking hold of the knees seemed better. So he laid the hollow lyre down on the ground, between the mixing bowl and the silver-studded chair, and ran forward and got hold of the knees of Odysseus and begged him.

"I beg you by your knees, Odysseus. Respect me and pity me. It will be a grief to you yourself afterwards if you kill a singer — me, who sing for gods and for men.

"I am self-taught, and the god has planted every kind of song in my mind; and I am fit to sing beside

[95]**The two men who beg, and why one dies.** Leiodes and Phemius make almost the same appeal, in almost the same words, in the space of a page: they take hold of his knees, which is the binding form (see Book Six, note 3), and each says he is innocent and tried to hold back. One is killed in the middle of speaking and one is spared, and it is worth being clear about the difference, because it is not a matter of who is nicer. Phemius can point to a witness in the room — Telemachus, who confirms he was brought there by force — and his trade is one the gods protect. Leiodes has no witness, and his trade was to read the omens for the suitors, which means, as Odysseus points out immediately, that he had spent three years praying professionally for exactly the outcome the household most dreaded. Whether that is fair is another question; the poem told us in Book Twenty-One that he alone found their conduct hateful. But it is not arbitrary. Odysseus makes a judgement about complicity in about four seconds, on the evidence available, and it is the same judgement he is about to make about the women, and it goes the other way.

you as beside a god. So do not be in a hurry to cut my throat.

"And Telemachus will tell you this himself, your own dear son: that it was not of my own will and not for any profit that I came to your house to sing for the suitors at their dinners. They were too many and too strong for me, and they brought me here by force."

Telemachus heard him, and said quickly to his father, who was close by: "Hold — do not hurt this man with the bronze; he is innocent. And let us spare the herald Medon as well, who always looked after me in this house when I was a child — unless Philoetius has killed him already, or the swineherd, or he came in your way while you were going through the hall."

And Medon heard him say it. He was lying curled up under a chair with a newly flayed ox-hide over him, trying to keep off the black fate; and he got out from under the chair at once and stripped off the hide and ran to Telemachus and took hold of his knees.

"Friend, here I am. Hold back and tell your father, before he does me some harm with the sharp bronze in his strength, being so angry with the suitors, who wore away his property in this house and were fools enough to show you no honour at all."

And Odysseus smiled at him and said: "Take heart. He has got you out of it and saved you, so that you may know in your own heart, and tell it to somebody else, how much better doing good is than doing harm.

"But go out of the hall, the pair of you, and sit down in the courtyard away from the killing — you and the singer of many songs — while I get on with what has to be done in the house."

So the two of them went out of the hall and sat down at the altar of great Zeus, looking about them in every direction, expecting to be killed at any moment.

And Odysseus looked round his own house to see whether any man was still alive and hiding, keeping clear of the black fate. And he found the whole company of them fallen in the blood and the dust — a great many of them.

As fish that fishermen have dragged up out of the grey sea in the meshes of a net onto the curve of a beach, and they lie heaped on the sand longing for the salt water, and the bright sun takes the life out of them: so the suitors lay heaped on one another.

And Odysseus said to Telemachus: "Go and call the nurse Eurycleia for me. There is something I want to say to her."

So Eurycleia came, and found Odysseus among the bodies of the dead, spattered with blood and filth, like a lion that has been feeding on an ox of the farmyard, with his whole chest and his cheeks on both sides bloodied, so that he is a terrible thing to look at.

And when she saw the dead and the great pool of blood she was on the point of raising the cry of triumph, because she had seen a great work done. And Odysseus stopped her, and held her back, keen as she was.

"Be glad in your own heart, old woman, and hold it in, and do not cry out. It is not a holy thing to boast over dead men.

"It was the fate the gods sent and their own reckless behaviour that destroyed these men. They honoured nobody at all on the earth, bad or good, whoever came among them. So they brought a shameful death on themselves by their own folly."

That is a strange thing to say standing in that room, and I do not want it to slip past, because it is

one of the sharpest lines the poem draws and the modern reader is unlikely to have been expecting it.

The old woman's impulse is the natural one, and it was the ordinary one in that world too: a shrill cry of triumph over a fallen enemy, the noise a woman raised at a moment of victory or at a sacrifice. Nobody in the hall would have thought it out of place. And her master, who is standing in the blood with his hands and feet red to the ankles and the wrists, tells her to stop, and gives a reason — that it is unholy to exult over dead men.

He does not say that they did not deserve it, and he does not soften a word about what they were. What he says is that gloating is not permitted, and that the dead have passed out of the reach of it and into the hands of the gods. It is a piece of religious feeling rather than of mercy, and it comes from the same source as everything else he has been careful about all evening. He has just killed a hall full of people and he has one more thing to do tonight, and he is not going to add impiety to it.

I set it down without comment for the moment, and ask you only to hold on to it for the length of about two pages.

"But tell me about the women in these halls," he said, "which of them dishonour me and which are guiltless."

"I shall tell you the truth, child. There are fifty women servants in the house, whom we have taught to do their work — to card wool and to bear the life of slaves. Twelve of them altogether have gone the way of shamelessness, and take no notice of me, or of Penelope either. And Telemachus has only just grown up, and his mother would not let him give orders to the women."

"Do not wake her yet. Tell those women to come here — the ones who have been behaving disgracefully."

And the old woman went off through the hall to tell them.

Then he called Telemachus and the cowherd and the swineherd to him.

"Begin carrying the bodies out now, and tell the women to help you. And after that clean down the beautiful chairs and the tables with water and porous sponges. And when you have put the whole house in order, take the women out of the hall, between the round-house and the good fence of the courtyard, and strike them with your long swords until you have taken the life out of every one of them, and they have forgotten the love they had with the suitors when they lay with them in secret."

And the women came out all together, wailing terribly and letting the big tears fall. First they carried the bodies out and propped them against one another under the colonnade of the fenced courtyard, while Odysseus himself gave the orders and hurried them on; and they had to do it. Then they cleaned the beautiful chairs and the tables with water and sponges. And Telemachus and the two herdsmen scraped the floor of the well-built hall with hoes, and the women carried the scrapings out and threw them out of doors.

And when the whole hall had been put in order, they took the women out of the building, into the space between the round-house and the good fence of the courtyard, and shut them into a narrow place from which there was no getting away.

And Telemachus said: "I shall not take the lives of these women by any clean death — women who have poured insults on my head and on my mother's, and slept with the suitors."

And he tied the cable of a dark-prowed ship to a great pillar and threw it round the round-house, stretching it high up, so that none of them could touch the ground with her feet.

And as when long-winged thrushes or doves come into a net that has been set in a thicket, making

for their roost, and the bed that receives them is a hateful one — so the women held their heads in a row, and there were nooses round all their necks, so that they should die most pitiably. And their feet kicked a little while, but not for long.

And they brought Melanthius out through the doorway and the courtyard, and cut off his nose and his ears with the pitiless bronze, and tore away his privates to be eaten raw by the dogs, and cut off his hands and feet in the fury of their hearts.

Then they washed their own hands and feet and went back into the house to Odysseus, and the work was finished.[96]

I promised, a very long way back, that I would come to this and would not pretend it was something else, so here we are.

Twelve women are hanged in a row in a yard, by the son of the house, for having slept with the men who had occupied it; and a man is mutilated to death beside them; and the poem, which has spent five lines telling us the birds' feet kicked a little while, moves straight on to the housekeeping. There is no comment. Telemachus's stated reason is that a clean death — the sword, which he had been ordered to use — would be too good for women who had insulted him and his mother, and the poem lets that stand as sufficient.

I said in Book Two that the poem is quite sure about these women and that I am not, and everything since has made me less sure rather than more. Here is what the text itself gives us. They were slaves. Not one of them chose to be in that house. The men they went with were the effective masters of it for three years, and one of the twelve, Melantho, was the lover of the second most powerful man in the room, who is now dead on the floor inside. Nobody in the poem asks what a young woman in that position could have done instead, or what the cost of refusal would have been, or which of the twelve went willingly and which did not — and the poem, which has just had its hero forbid an old woman from so much as cheering because it is unholy to exult over the dead, does not extend to them a fraction of the scruple it extended to Antinous's corpse.

That is not a modern complaint smuggled in. It is the poem's own standard, applied a page later to the wrong people, and I think it is fair to notice the difference.

What I will not do is pretend the passage is an accident, or that Homer disapproved and left us clues. There are none. This is the world the poem is describing and largely the world it endorses, and the same book that gives us the swineherd's kindness and the warning against gloating gives us this yard, and expects us to read the whole of it with the same appetite. Two things can be true at once about a very old book, and both of them are.

Then Odysseus said to Eurycleia: "Bring me sulphur, old woman, that cleans away pollution, and bring me fire, so that I can fumigate the hall. And tell Penelope to come here with her women; and order all the women in the house to come."

"All that you say is right, my child. But let me bring you a cloak and a tunic to put on. Do not stand

[96] **The manner of it.** Two details are worth having. The first is that hanging was regarded as a peculiarly shameful death, the death of women who killed themselves in disgrace, and not a soldier's end at all; Telemachus chooses it deliberately, and says so, having been given an order that specified swords. The second is the rope: he uses a ship's cable, the same kind of cable Philoetius used to lash the courtyard gates shut an hour earlier, and the poem notes it without comment. — As for Melanthius, what is done to him is precisely what Antinous threatened to have done to a beggar in Book Eighteen, and what the Lapiths did to the drunken centaur in the story Antinous told in Book Twenty-One. The poem has mentioned this specific mutilation three times, always as something one hears about happening elsewhere, and then it happens.

about in your own halls with rags over your broad shoulders; that would be a thing to blame."

"Fire first. Let there be a fire made in this hall."

So she brought fire and sulphur, and Odysseus fumigated the hall thoroughly, and the rest of the house, and the courtyard.[97]

And the old woman went off through the fine house of Odysseus to take the message to the women and tell them to come. And they came out of their quarters holding torches, and gathered round Odysseus and welcomed him, and took hold of him and kissed his head and his shoulders and his hands.

And a sweet longing came over him to weep and to cry aloud, because in his heart he knew every one of them.

NOTES TO BOOK TWENTY-TWO

Book Twenty-Three: In Which a Wife Sets a Trap for Her Own Husband.

[97] **Sulphur, and what it is for.** This is not cleaning. Burning sulphur was used against *miasma* — the ritual pollution that killing produces, which attaches to a place and to a person regardless of whether the killing was just, and which has to be dealt with before ordinary life can resume there. It is closer to disinfecting a house against something invisible than to sweeping it. Note that Odysseus calls for the fire and the sulphur before he will accept a change of clothes: the nurse wants to make him presentable, and he wants the room made clean in the other sense first. Note also what it implies. The killing was lawful, and everybody in the poem agrees it was lawful, and it has still left the house in a condition that has to be burned out of the air before his wife can be brought downstairs into it.

Book 23

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK TWENTY-THREE

In Which a Wife Sets a Trap for Her Own Husband The old woman went up the stairs laughing. Her knees were hurrying under her faster than they had gone in years, and they hobbled her all the same, and she caught at the rail and laughed and went on. Eurycleia (the old nurse, the same who had found the scar at the washing of the feet) had been sent up to tell her mistress that her husband was in the house, and she stood at last at the head of the bed where Penelope lay in the first honest sleep she had had in twenty years, and said:

"Wake up, Penelope, dear child, and come down and see with your own eyes what you have waited for all these days. Odysseus is here. He has come home, late, but he has come, and he has killed the proud suitors who ate up his house and swallowed his goods and bullied his son."

And Penelope, waking, said: "Dear nurse, the gods have made you mad. They can do that; they can turn the most sensible person foolish, and they can set a silly one on the right road, and now they have touched you, who were always steady in your mind before. Why do you mock me, when my heart is full of grief already, telling me wild stories and waking me out of the sweetest sleep that ever held my eyes since Odysseus went away to that evil city I will not name? Go back down. If any other of my women had come and woken me with this, I should have sent her downstairs smarting for it. Your age protects you, and nothing else."

But Eurycleia said: "I am not mocking you, dear child. It is true. Odysseus is here, in this house, at the hearth — he is the stranger, the one they all abused in the hall. Telemachus knew it all along, and kept his father's counsel like a grown man, so that the suitors could be paid in full."

At that Penelope was up out of the bed with her arms round the old woman, and the tears came, and she said: "Then tell me truly, dear nurse — if he is really home, how did he ever lay hands on that shameless crowd, one man against so many?"

"I did not see it," said Eurycleia, "I only heard it. We sat locked in the back rooms, the doors fast, and we heard the groaning of men, until at last your son called me out — his father had sent him for me — and I found Odysseus standing among the bodies of the dead, and they lay around him on the trodden floor, heaped on one another. It would have warmed your heart to see him, spattered with blood and filth like a lion that has fed. Now the bodies are gathered at the courtyard gates, and he is purifying the beautiful house with sulphur, and he sent me to fetch you. Come down, so that the two of you can enter into gladness at last, after all your sorrow."

But Penelope said: "Dear nurse, do not laugh in triumph yet. You know how welcome the sight of him would be, to everyone in this house, and to me most of all, and to the son the two of us made. But this story is not true the way you tell it. It is one of the immortal gods who has killed the lordly suitors, out of anger at their insolence and their wicked deeds — for they honoured no one who came among them, good man or bad, and their own recklessness has destroyed them. But Odysseus has lost his homecoming, far away, and he is lost himself."

"Dear child," said the old woman, "what a word to let past your teeth — your husband at his own hearth, and you saying he will never come home. Your heart was always unbelieving. Very well: I will

give you a plain proof. The scar — the one the boar gave him long ago with its white tusk. I found it when I washed his feet, and I wanted to cry it out to you then, but he clapped his hand over my mouth, in the cleverness of his mind, and would not let me. Come down. I will stake my own life on it: if I am deceiving you, kill me by the worst death there is."

"Dear nurse," said Penelope, "it is hard for you to read the counsels of the everlasting gods, however wise you are. But let us go down to my son, so that I can see the suitors dead — and the man who killed them."

She came down the stairs turning one question over and over: whether to stand back and question him from across the room, or to go straight to him and take his head in her hands and kiss him. And when she had come in over the stone threshold, she went and sat in the firelight against the far wall, opposite him; and Odysseus sat by a tall pillar, looking down, waiting to hear whether his brave wife would say anything to him when she saw him with her own eyes. And she sat a long time in silence, and amazement held her heart. Sometimes she would look full at his face and it was his face; and then she would fail to know him, because of the miserable rags he wore.

It was Telemachus who broke first. "Mother," he said, "cruel mother, hard-hearted — why do you sit apart from my father like this, instead of sitting beside him and asking him everything? No other woman would hold herself back with a frozen heart from a husband who had come home in the twentieth year, through every kind of suffering. But your heart was always harder than stone."

And Penelope answered: "My child, the heart in my breast is astonished, and I cannot speak to him, or ask him anything, or look him in the face. But if he is truly Odysseus, come home, then the two of us will know each other, and be certain of each other, better than anyone else could — for we have signs between us, hidden signs, that no one else knows."

I should like you to be fair to her here, because it is easy not to be; most readers at this point are with Telemachus, and want her to run across the room. But she has had twenty years of men coming to that house with news of Odysseus, every drifter in the western sea trading a sighting of him for a cloak and a dinner, and every one of them lying; and she has just finished saying, quite seriously, that a god may have done this killing, and she knows as well as anyone in the poem that a god can walk in wearing any face that suits him. And behind every homecoming in this story stands the other homecoming, the one nobody speaks of at dinner — a husband who came back from Troy trusting, and was dead before nightfall. She has never heard the advice the ghost of Agamemnon gave her husband among the dead, and she is conducting herself as if she had written it.

And there is something more, which I would ask you to watch for through the rest of this scene, because it is the key to it. What she is doing is exactly what he does. When a goddess told him on Calypso's island that he was free, he demanded she swear an oath before he would get in the boat; when he woke on his own beach with a fortune piled round him, the first thing he did was count it. This is a man who has never in his life believed good news until it produced its papers, and he is now sitting across the fire from the one person on earth built on the same plan, and she is asking his good news for its papers. He is the only one in the room who understands what she is doing, which is why what happens next is a smile.

For Odysseus, the man of many endurances, smiled — and it is worth noticing that the only other smile the poem has given him was a grim one, in the hall, with no warmth in it at all — and he said to his son: "Telemachus, let your mother test me in the hall as she pleases; she will soon see more clearly. Just now I am filthy, and in bad clothes, and so she holds back and will not yet say I am he. But you

and I have something else to think about. A man who kills one man in a district — even a man with few friends to avenge him — goes into exile, and leaves his kin and his country. We have killed the prop and pillar of the town: the best of the young men of Ithaca. I ask you to consider it."

"You must consider it, dear father," said Telemachus. "They say you have the best head of any man alive, and no mortal can rival you. We will follow you, and I do not think we will fail you in courage, so far as our strength runs."

"Then I will tell you what seems best to me," said Odysseus. "First wash, and put on tunics, and have the women in the house dress themselves; and let the divine singer take his clear lyre and lead us in a dancing-tune, so that anyone hearing it from outside — a passer-by, a neighbour — will say there is a wedding in the house. That way the news of the suitors' killing will not run through the town before we can get out to our farm among the orchards. Once there, we shall see what advantage the Olympian puts in our hands."

They did as he said, and the house rang: the lyre, and the beat of dancing feet, men and well-dressed women together. And someone passing in the street said: "So somebody has married the much-courted queen at last. Hard-hearted woman — she had not the patience to keep her husband's great house until he came." That was the last public opinion ever passed on Penelope's marriage, and it was delivered, in the immemorial manner of public opinion, by someone who knew nothing whatever about it.

Meanwhile the housekeeper Eurynome bathed great-hearted Odysseus in his own house, and rubbed him with oil, and put a fine cloak and tunic on him; and Athena poured beauty over him, head and shoulders, and made him taller and stronger to look at, and made the hair of his head spring in curls like the hyacinth flower. As when a craftsman lays gold over silver — a man whom Hephaestus (the smith of the gods) and Athena have taught every kind of skill, and his work is full of grace — so she poured grace on his head and shoulders. He came out of the bath looking like one of the immortals, and sat back down on the chair he had risen from, opposite his wife, and said:

"Strange woman. To you beyond all others the gods of Olympus gave an unyielding heart. No other wife would hold herself apart, with a frozen spirit, from a husband come home to her in the twentieth year through every kind of suffering. Well then — nurse, make a bed up for me, and I will sleep alone. The heart in this woman's breast is made of iron."

And wise Penelope answered him: "Strange man. I am not proud, and I do not scorn you, and I am not astonished past my wits either; I know very well what you were when you sailed out of Ithaca on your long-oared ship. Very well — Eurycleia, make up the sturdy bed for him outside the well-built bridal chamber, the bed he made himself. Move the strong bedstead out there for him, and pile it with bedding — fleeces, and blankets, and bright coverlets."

She said it to test her husband. And Odysseus flared up, and spoke in anger to his careful wife: "Woman, that word cuts me to the heart. Who has moved my bed? That would be hard for the most skilled man alive — unless a god came down and shifted it at his pleasure, easily; but of men there is none living, however young and strong, who could lever it aside. For a great token is built into that bed, and I made it, and no other man. There was a long-leaved olive tree growing inside the courtyard, in full vigour, thick as a pillar. Round that tree I built our chamber, and finished it, with close-set stones, and roofed it well over, and hung the jointed doors, fitted close. Then I cut away the crown of the long-leaved olive, and trimmed the trunk from the root upward, and smoothed it all round with the adze, skilfully, and trued it to the line, and so made my bedpost, and bored it all with the auger. Beginning

from that post I worked the bed until it was finished, inlaying it with gold and silver and ivory, and I stretched across the frame thongs of oxhide, gleaming with purple. There is the token I tell you of. And what I do not know, wife, is whether my bed is still standing — or whether some man has cut through the olive at the root, and set it elsewhere."

Her knees went loose where she sat, and the heart in her, as she recognised the sure sign Odysseus had given her.

We must go slowly here, because we have arrived somewhere. A very long way back — he was building a boat on a beach at the time, at the far edge of the world — I told you that this man was a carpenter, and that the fact would come up again, a long way from there, in a room he built himself, and that it would settle everything. This is the room, and it has settled everything, and I hope you will let me point out exactly how, because the mechanism is the finest thing in the poem. Penelope has just done what no god, monster, king or Cyclops has managed in twenty-four books: she has caught Odysseus. She has taken the one man alive who cannot be trapped by a lie — a man who has lied his way across the known world and some way past it, who lied to a goddess on this island's own beach a week ago for the pure practice of it — and she has trapped him with one. And she could only have done it with this lie, because it is the only lie in the world he is not proof against. Tell him his wife has been unfaithful, and he will file it and watch the room; tell him his kingdom is lost, and he will start planning; he has heard his own death reported and eaten a good dinner afterward. But tell him that someone has moved the bed — that the one true thing he made with his own hands, the thing that cannot be moved, has been moved — and the great liar forgets, for exactly one speech, that he is being examined, and out comes the truth with the bark still on it: the tree, the adze, the auger, the whole chamber built round a living root, in the voice of a craftsman whose work has been insulted. He has met the only power in the poem that could disarm him, and it turns out to be his own craftsmanship, or rather the truth itself, which is the one weapon he has never learned to see coming.

And notice what the token is. It is not a password; passwords can be stolen, and she has just demonstrated the theft of this one, since she now speaks of the bed as movable precisely because she knows it is not. The token is the marriage: a made thing, worked to completion, with one living root in the ground and the whole house built around it, known entirely to two people — for the poem is careful to add a single maid, who kept the door — and incapable of being moved without being killed. The story of this poem, I told you at the very beginning, is not the story of a voyage; it is the story of a house; and here at last is the middle of the house, and it is a bed with a tree in it. When the poem flagged the word *homophrosynē* — two people thinking as one — as its whole cargo, this scene is what it was pointing at: the woman who held a hundred men off for three years with a weaving trick has just tested the champion deceiver of the age with a deception, and he has passed by failing it, and each of them now knows, past the reach of any god's disguising, that the other is the same kind of person. Agamemnon's ghost told him, down in the grey place, to come home in secret and trust no wife with everything. He took the first half of the advice. The second half the poem has just answered for him.

Then, bursting into tears, she ran straight to him and threw her arms around his neck and kissed his head, and said: "Do not be angry with me, Odysseus — you, who in everything else were always the most understanding of men. It is the gods who gave us sorrow, grudging us this: that we should stay beside each other and enjoy our youth and come together to the threshold of old age. So do not be angry with me now, and do not hold it against me that I did not welcome you like this the moment I saw you. Always the heart in my breast shivered with the fear that some man would come and cheat me with his talk; there are many men who scheme for gain. Even Helen of Argos would never have lain with a foreigner as she did, if she had known that the warlike sons of the Greeks would bring her

home again to her own country.[98] But now — now you have told the plain token of our bed, which no other mortal has ever seen, but only you and I and one single serving-woman, Actoris, whom my father gave me when I came here, and who kept the door of our strong bridal chamber — now you have persuaded my heart, unbending though it is."

And in him too the longing for weeping rose, and he wept, holding the wife of his heart, faithful and wise, in his arms. And as when land shows welcome to swimmers, whose well-made ship Poseidon has broken on the open sea, driven under wind and heavy wave, and a few of them have escaped the grey water swimming for the shore, and the salt is crusted thick on their skin, and gladly they set foot on land, having got clear of ruin — so welcome to her was her husband as she gazed at him, and she could not once let her white arms go from his neck.[99]

And rosy-fingered Dawn would have risen on their weeping, if the grey-eyed goddess Athena had not thought of something else. She held the long night back at the edge of its course, and kept golden-throned Dawn waiting at the Ocean's rim, and would not let her yoke her swift horses that bring men light.[100]

Then Odysseus said to his wife: "Wife, we have not yet come to the end of all our trials. There is still one measureless labour left, long and hard, and I must carry it through to the finish. So the soul of Teiresias (the blind prophet, whom I questioned among the dead) foretold to me, on the day I went down into the house of Hades to ask the way home for my companions and myself. But come — let us go to bed, wife, and take at last the sweetness of sleep, lying together."

"The bed is yours whenever your heart desires it," said Penelope, "now that the gods have brought you back to your own house and your own country. But since you have thought of it, and a god put it in your heart, tell me about this trial. I shall learn of it later in any case, I suppose, and it is no worse to know at once."

"Strange woman," he said, "why press me so? Well, I will tell it, and hide nothing — though your heart will get no joy of it, and neither does mine. He told me to go out again, through city after city of men, carrying a shapely oar, until I come to people who know nothing of the sea, and eat their food unsalted, and have never seen a red-painted ship, nor the shapely oars that are a ship's wings. And he gave me a sign that cannot be missed: when another traveller, meeting me, says that I am carrying a winnowing-fan on my shoulder, there I am to plant the oar in the earth, and make sacrifice to the lord Poseidon — a ram, a bull, and a boar — and then come home, and offer holy hecatombs to the

[98] **Penelope's defence, and Helen.** This is a strange argument, and ancient readers found it strange too — some of them suspected the lines were a later insertion, and wanted them cut. Read charitably, and I think she has earned charity, it runs like this: even Helen, the byword for everything a wife can do to a house, would not have done it had she seen the consequence; a god blinded her; and therefore deception — by gods, or by men who talk well — is the standing danger of the world, and a woman's suspicion is not coldness but the only armour issued to her. Penelope is not excusing Helen; she is explaining twenty years of locked doors. The reader may also hear, underneath it, the name she is too courteous to say, the other queen against whom this whole poem measures its people (*see Book One, note 4, and Book Eleven*). Helen erred and was carried home; Clytemnestra chose and killed; Penelope is claiming, correctly, to be the answer to both.

[99] **The borrowed simile.** It is worth pausing over who this famous simile is given to. The shipwrecked swimmer, salt-crusted, crawling to land at the last of his strength, is the poem's standing picture of Odysseus — we watched it happen, literally and at length, two days off the Phaeacian coast. Here, at the reunion, the poem hands the image across the marriage: *she* is the swimmer, and he is the land she has reached. She has not left the house in twenty years, and the poem says quietly that she has been at sea the whole time, and drowning. I point at this and add nothing, except that the arms at the end of the sentence belong to her, and the poem cannot make her let go.

[100] **The night held back.** Athena stops the dawn — keeps Night standing at the western edge of her course and holds Dawn waiting at the Ocean with her horses unyoked. The horses are named, the only time in Homer that Dawn's team is named: Lampus and Phaethon, which is to say Shiner and Blazer. The gods of these poems interfere constantly with events but almost never with time itself, which makes this small violation the more striking: one goddess, unasked, giving two mortals a longer night as a wedding present. It is the gentlest thing anyone does in the entire poem.

deathless gods who hold the wide heaven, all of them in order. And death will come to me from the sea — or away from the sea; the old words can honestly be read either way, and I would not trust anyone who tells you they are certain — a gentle death, and take me worn down by a sleek old age, with my people prosperous around me. All this, he said, will be brought to pass."

And wise Penelope said: "If the gods are really promising a better old age, then there is hope the last of our evils will find its escape."

While they talked, Eurynome and the nurse were making up the bed with soft coverings by the light of blazing torches; and when they had spread the sturdy bedstead, the old woman went off to her rest, and Eurynome, with a torch in her hands, walked before them to the chamber, and left them there; and they came, gladly, to the rite of their own old bed.[101] And Telemachus and the cowherd and the swineherd brought the dancing to an end, and ended it for the women, and lay down themselves to sleep through the shadowy halls.

And when the two of them had taken their pleasure of love, they took their pleasure of talking, each telling the other everything: she, shining among women, all she had endured in the house, watching that destroying crowd of suitors slaughter cattle and fat sheep in droves on her account, and draw off the wine by the jarful; and he, Odysseus sprung from Zeus, all the cares he had fastened on other men and all the misery he had toiled through himself. And she delighted to listen, and no sleep fell on her eyelids until he had told it all: how he beat the Cicones, and came to the rich land of the Lotus-eaters; what the Cyclops did, and how he made him pay the price of his brave companions, eaten without pity; how he came to Aeolus, who received him kindly and sent him on, though it was not yet his fate to reach home; how the Laestrygonians destroyed the ships and all their crews but his own; the wiles of Circe; the journey down to the dank house of Hades to consult the soul of Teiresias, where he saw all his old companions, and the mother who bore him and nursed him when he was small; the Sirens' unbroken song; the Clashing Rocks, and dread Charybdis, and Scylla, whom no man ever passed unhurt; how his companions killed the cattle of the Sun, and Zeus the high-thunderer smashed the ship with a smoking bolt, and every man of them was lost but him; how he came to Ogygia and the nymph Calypso, who kept him there, longing to make him her husband, and fed him, and promised to make him deathless and ageless all his days, and never persuaded the heart in his breast; and how after great suffering he came to the Phaeacians, who honoured him like a god, and sent him home in a ship with bronze and gold and clothing in plenty. That was the last word he spoke, as the loosener of limbs came over him — sleep, that unstrings the body's cares.[102]

[101] **The disputed ending.** Two of the greatest scholars of the ancient world — Aristophanes of Byzantium and Aristarchus, who edited Homer at the library of Alexandria — left a mark against this line, the pair coming gladly to their old bed, recording that this was the *end* of the *Odyssey*. Exactly what they meant is argued over to this day: perhaps that the poem originally stopped here, perhaps only that its business was complete here. They had a case. Everything the poem has promised since its first lines — the man, the homecoming, the vengeance, the wife — has now been delivered, and what remains can be made to look like appendix. And yet I am satisfied they were wrong, and I will tell you why in one sentence: this is a poem about a house, and a house does not stand in a vacuum — there is an old man in an orchard who has not been told his son is alive, and a town full of fresh graves, and until those two accounts are settled the house has a roof but no ground under it. We shall spend the last book settling them.

[102] **The second telling.** The whole of Books Nine to Twelve, which took Odysseus a long night in a king's hall and took us four books, is here retold in about thirty lines, in the third person, in strict order, like a table of contents — some scholars have suspected it is exactly that, a poet's index to his own poem. Two things deserve notice. First, the ghost of Agamemnon advised him to tell his wife part and keep part hidden; and so far as the poem records, he hides nothing — Circe is in the telling, and Calypso, and Calypso's offer, told plainly to his wife in their own bed. That advice has governed his conduct for ten books, and this is where he lays it down; whether he told these episodes quite as they were told on Scheria, the poem does not say, and I decline to guess. Second, the list ends where it ends — Phaeacia, the gifts, home — and sleep takes him on the last word, which is the poem's way of saying the story is finally allowed to be over for the man who has been carrying

And Athena, grey-eyed, thought of the next thing: when she judged that Odysseus had had his fill of his wife's side and of sleep, she stirred golden-throned Dawn up out of the Ocean at once, to bring light to men. And Odysseus rose from the soft bed, and said to his wife: "Wife, we have both had our fill of trials by now — you weeping here for my difficult homecoming, and I pinned in misery by Zeus and the other gods, far from the country I longed for. But since we have come at last to the bed we both desired, look after what is mine within the house. As for the flocks the overbearing suitors wasted, I shall raid a good part back myself, and the Greeks of Ithaca shall give the rest, until they have filled every pen. Now I am going out to the orchard farm, to see my noble father, who has grieved for me all this while. And for you, wife, wise as you are, I have this instruction: with sunrise the news will go abroad of the suitors I killed in the halls. Go up to your room with your serving-women, and sit there, and look at nobody, and ask no questions."

He put his fine armour on his shoulders, and roused Telemachus and the cowherd and the swineherd, and told them all to take weapons of war in their hands. They did not disobey him, but armed themselves in bronze, and opened the doors, and went out, and Odysseus led them. By now the light was over the earth; but Athena hid them in night, and led them quickly out of the town.

NOTES TO BOOK TWENTY-THREE

Next: In Which the Dead Compare Notes, an Old Man Is Found Digging in His Orchard, and the Last Fight Is Called Off. https://x.com/notifications

it.

Book 24

THE ODYSSEY

Retold in English, with Explanations

BOOK TWENTY-FOUR

In Which the Dead Compare Notes, an Old Man Is Found Digging in His Orchard, and the Last Fight Is Called Off Hermes (the messenger of the gods, and — an office we have not yet seen him at — the guide of dead souls) was calling the souls of the suitors out. He held in his hand the beautiful golden wand with which he seals men's eyes in sleep or wakes them as he pleases, and with it he stirred them and led them, and they followed, squeaking. As bats in the depths of a wonderful cave flit squeaking when one drops off the chain of them where they hang together from the rock, so the souls went squeaking after him, and Hermes the kindly led them down the dank ways: past the streams of Ocean and the White Rock, past the gates of the Sun and the country of dreams, until they came quickly to the meadow of asphodel, where the souls live, the images of worn-out men.[103]

There they found the soul of Achilles, and with him Patroclus, and blameless Antilochus, and Ajax, the finest of all the Greeks in beauty and stature after the peerless son of Peleus. These were gathered round Achilles; and now there came near them, grieving, the soul of Agamemnon (the king who led the Greeks to Troy, and was murdered on the day he came home), with all those around him who died beside him in Aegisthus's house.

The soul of Achilles spoke first: "Son of Atreus (Agamemnon), we used to say that of all heroes you were dearest, your whole life long, to Zeus who delights in thunder, because you were lord over many mighty men in the Trojans' country, where we Greeks suffered. And yet the deadly doom that no man born escapes was to come to you, too, and early. How much better if you had met your fate at Troy, in the fullness of the honour you commanded there; then all the Greeks together would have made you a tomb, and you would have won great glory for your son as well. Instead it was appointed that you should die the most pitiable death there is."

And the soul of Agamemnon answered: "Fortunate son of Peleus, godlike Achilles, who died at Troy, far from home — and around you the best sons of the Trojans and the Greeks died fighting over your body, while you lay in the swirl of dust, great in your greatness, your horsemanship forgotten. All day we fought, and would never have stopped, had Zeus not stopped it with a storm. We carried you out of the battle to the ships and washed your fine body with warm water and oil, and the men shed hot tears over you and cut their hair. And your mother came up out of the sea with the deathless girls of the water, when she heard, and a huge crying went out over the deep, and trembling took all the Greeks — they would have bolted for the hollow ships, if one man had not held them, a man wise in the old things: Nestor, whose counsel had proved best before. 'Hold, Greeks,' he said; 'do not run, young men; it is his mother, coming out of the sea with the immortal sea-nymphs, to meet

[103]**The road of ghosts, and the unburied dead.** This journey appears nowhere else in Homer: the White Rock, the gates of the Sun and the district of dreams belong to no other map in either poem, and Hermes appears as conductor of souls only here — the office became standard later, but in Homer this is its one performance. And a reader with a good memory will notice a difficulty: when we visited the dead in Book Eleven, Elpenor could not rest until his body was burned and mourned, and begged for it as the unburied dead's one need; here the suitors, whose bodies are still lying unwashed in the hall — Amphimedon complains of exactly this — walk straight down to the asphodel with no trouble at all. It is a seam, like the others we have seen (*see Book Eleven, note 4*), and I show it rather than smooth it: the tradition kept more than one belief about the dead, and this book sews with a different thread than Book Eleven did.

her dead son.' So the great-hearted Greeks stood their ground, and the daughters of the old man of the sea stood round you weeping, and dressed you in the clothing of the gods; and the Muses, all nine, sang the dirge over you, answering one another in their lovely voices, and you would not have seen one Greek dry-eyed, the clear song stirred them so. Seventeen days and seventeen nights we mourned you, deathless gods and mortal men together, and on the eighteenth we gave you to the fire, and slaughtered fat sheep and shambling cattle around you. You burned in the gods' own clothing, in quantities of oil and sweet honey, and heroes in armour, on foot and horsed, moved in procession round your burning pyre, and the sound of it was very great. And when the flame of Hephaestus (the smith of the gods, whose element the fire is) had finished you, at dawn we gathered your white bones, Achilles, into unmixed wine and oil. Your mother had given a golden two-handled jar; she said it was the gift of Dionysus (the god of wine), and the work of famous Hephaestus. In that your white bones lie, shining Achilles, mingled with the bones of dead Patroclus, and apart, but near, those of Antilochus, whom you honoured beyond all your companions after Patroclus died. And over them all we heaped a huge and perfect mound, we the sacred army of Greek spearmen, on a jutting headland above the wide Hellespont, so that it might be seen far out to sea by men now living and by men to come. Your mother begged splendid prizes from the gods and set them in the middle of the assembly, for the best of the Greeks to contend for; and I have stood at the funeral games of many heroes, but never saw my heart so full of wonder as at what the gods gave for your sake. So not even in dying did you lose your name; your fame will be great among all mankind forever, Achilles. But what pleasure was there for me in winding up the war? For at my homecoming Zeus was planning my dismal destruction, at the hands of Aegisthus and my accursed wife."

While they talked in this way, the guide, the killer of Argus, came near, bringing down the souls of the suitors Odysseus had slain; and the two kings, wondering, went straight toward them. And the soul of Agamemnon knew one of them: Amphimedon, the dear son of Melaneus, who had been his host once on Ithaca — for even in the grey place a man remembers whose roof he slept under. "Amphimedon," he said, "what has happened to you, that you all come down under the dark earth together, picked men, and all of an age? A man choosing through a city would not choose better. Did Poseidon raise a hard wind against your ships and sink you? Or did enemies cut you down on some coast, where you were driving off their cattle and their flocks of sheep, or fighting for a town and its women?"

And the soul of Amphimedon answered him, and told the whole story from the other end of it: the wooing of the wife who would neither refuse a marriage she hated nor conclude one, and the great web on the loom — how she wove the huge cloth by day and unwove it by torchlight for three years, and how in the fourth a woman who knew the truth told them, and they caught her unravelling the shining web, and she finished it against her will. "And then," he said, "some malicious god brought Odysseus from wherever he was — to the edge of the estate first, where the swineherd lived, and there his own son joined him, back from sandy Pylos in his black ship, and the two of them plotted our evil deaths and came into the famous town, Odysseus last, and late, in wretched rags, like an old ruined beggar, leaning on a stick, so that not one of us could know him when he appeared, not even the older men. We threw things at him and gave him hard words, and he endured it in his own halls with a patient heart. But when the will of Zeus roused him, he and his son took the beautiful armour out of the hall and locked it in the store-room, and then in his great cunning he told his wife to set before the suitors the bow and the grey iron — the contest that was the beginning of our slaughter.[104] Not

[104] **Amphimedon's version.** The dead man says that Odysseus, in his great cunning, ordered his wife to set the bow before the suitors. That is not what we watched: we watched Penelope conceive the contest herself, in Book Nineteen, and carry it out in Book Twenty-One, with the beggar doing no more than warmly approving. Either the poet nodded, or — and this

one of us could string that mighty bow; we fell far short of it. And when it came round to his hands, we all shouted that he should not be given it, whatever he said, and only Telemachus urged him on and told him to take it. And he took it in his hand, the much-enduring man, and strung it easily, and shot through the iron, and went and stood on the threshold and poured out the swift arrows, glancing terribly around him, and shot the king Antinous first. And then he sent his groaning shafts into the rest, aiming ever opposite, and men fell thick and fast, and you could tell some god was helping them, for they raged through the house cutting men down on every side, and there rose a hideous groaning as heads were struck, and the whole floor smoked with blood. So we died, Agamemnon, and our bodies are lying uncared-for even now in the halls of Odysseus; for the friends in each man's house do not yet know — the friends who would wash the black blood from our wounds, and lay us out, and mourn us, which is the honour owed the dead." I do not know a sadder small thing in the poem than that: a man's last recorded grievance, delivered in the underworld, is that nobody has washed him yet.

And the soul of Agamemnon cried out: "Fortunate son of Laertes, Odysseus of the many devices! What a wife you won, and what great virtue is in her — how sound the wits of blameless Penelope, the daughter of Icarius, and how well she kept the memory of the husband of her youth. And so the fame of her virtue will never die, and the immortals themselves will make for the people of the earth a lovely song for wise Penelope. Not so the daughter of Tyndareus, who devised evil and killed the husband of her youth: a hateful song she will be among men, and she has laid a hard name on all women after her, even on the ones who do good."

The reader has now heard the last movement of an argument that began on the first page. The very first scene of this poem was Zeus on Olympus, complaining about Aegisthus, and from that moment the story of Agamemnon's house has stood behind the story of Odysseus's house as the pattern everything is measured against — told in pieces, each time a little closer, in Books One and Three and Four and Eleven; and here at the end the poem gives the verdict to the murdered king himself, standing in the meadow of the dead among the fresh souls of the suitors, and the verdict is two songs. One wife will be a hateful song forever; the other will have a lovely song made for her by the immortals. And I would like you to notice something, quietly, before we go up into the daylight: the lovely song Agamemnon prophesies has in fact been made, and you are holding it. It is a strange and wonderful thing for a poem to do — to reach its last book and tell you what it is — and it is stranger still whose song it turns out to be. This is a poem in which a man crossed the world so that his name would be in every mouth, and heard himself sung in a stranger's hall, and shouted that name across the water at the cost of ten years; and its final word on fame is given to a woman who never left the house.

While the dead talked, the living were walking down from the town, and when they had left the city they came quickly to the fine well-tended farm of Laertes, which he had won for himself long ago, and laboured over greatly. His house was there, and running all round it the sheds where the slaves who did his work ate and sat and slept; and in the house was an old Sicilian woman who looked after the old man carefully, out there on the land far from the town.

There Odysseus spoke to the herdsmen and his son: "Go into the well-built house now, and kill the best of the pigs for our dinner. I will make trial of my father — whether he will know me when he sees

is the reading I prefer, though I hold it loosely — a freshly dead man is doing what people do, which is telling the story in the shape that hurts least: to have been beaten by one man's cunning is a better tale in the meadow of the dead than to have been dismantled by a household, wife included. Whether Penelope suspected more than she said is the one question this poem refuses to open for anybody (*see Book Nineteen, note 4*), and it is fitting that the last word muddying it comes from a man with every reason to muddy it.

me with his eyes, or fail to, after so long a time."

He gave his weapons to the slaves, and they went inside; and Odysseus went down into the fruitful orchard, testing as he went. He did not find Dolius as he came down into the great garden, nor any of Dolius's sons or slaves — they had gone off, and the old man at the head of them, to gather stones for a wall. He found his father alone in the tidy orchard, digging round a young plant, dressed in a dirty tunic, patched and shameful, with patched oxhide leggings tied round his shins against the scratches, and gloves on his hands because of the brambles, and on his head a goatskin cap; and he was feeding his sorrow. When much-enduring Odysseus saw him, worn out by old age and with that great grief on him, he stood under a tall pear tree and wept. And then he turned it over in his mind and heart: whether to kiss his father and take him in his arms, and tell him everything, how he had come home to his own country — or first to question him, and try him. And as he turned it over, this seemed to him the better way: to try him first, with words that would sting.

With that in mind, godlike Odysseus went straight up to him. His father was keeping his head down, digging round the plant, and his glorious son stood beside him and said: "Old man, there is no lack of skill in the way you keep this orchard. The care in it is everywhere; there is not one thing in the whole garden — not a plant, not a fig, not a vine, not an olive, not a pear, not a vegetable bed — that goes untended. But I will tell you something else, and do not take offence at it: you yourself are not well cared for. Hard old age is on you, and you are dismally unwashed, and dressed in rags. It is not for idleness, certainly, that your master neglects you; and there is nothing of the slave in your looks or your bearing — you have the look of a king. You have the look of a man who ought to bathe, and eat, and sleep soft; that is the right of the old. But come, tell me truly: whose slave are you, and whose orchard is this you keep? And tell me this exactly, because I need to know it: is this country I have come to really Ithaca, as a fellow told me just now on my way here — not a very obliging fellow, for he would not hear my questions out. For I am trying to find out about a guest-friend of mine, whether he is alive somewhere, or dead and in the house of Hades. I will tell you plainly: once, in my own dear country, I entertained a man in my house, and no mortal who ever came travelling to it was dearer. He said his family was of Ithaca, and that his father was Laertes, son of Arceisius. I took him in and entertained him well, with all the plenty that was in the house, and I gave him guest-gifts, such as were fitting: seven talents of worked gold, and a mixing-bowl of solid silver with flowers on it, and twelve single cloaks, and as many rugs, and as many fine mantles and tunics besides, and, apart from all that, four handsome women skilled in fine work, whom he chose for himself."

And his father answered him, weeping: "Stranger, this is indeed the country you ask about; but violent and reckless men hold it now, and the gifts you gave, those countless gifts, you gave for nothing. If you had found him alive in the land of Ithaca, he would have sent you on your way with gifts to match, and good entertainment; that is the right of whoever begins. But tell me this, and tell it exactly: how many years is it since you hosted him — that unlucky guest of yours, my son, if he ever existed — the ill-fated man whom the fish have eaten, somewhere far from his friends and his country, or the beasts and the birds have had, on land? His mother did not shroud him and mourn over him, nor his father, we who gave him life; nor did his richly-dowered wife, steady Penelope, keen over her husband on his bier, as is fitting, and close his eyes — which is the honour owed the dead. And tell me this too, truly, for I want to know it: who are you, and from where? Where is your city, and your parents? And where is the swift ship standing that brought you here with your godlike companions? Or did you come as a passenger on another man's ship, and they set you ashore and went on?"

And resourceful Odysseus answered: "I will tell you everything exactly. I am from Alybas, where I have a famous house, and I am the son of Apheidas, the son of lord Polypemon; my own name is

Eperitus. A god drove me off my course from Sicania, to come here against my will; and my ship is standing over there, off the open country away from the town.[105] As for Odysseus, it is five years now since he left my country. Poor man — and yet the birds were good when he went, on the right hand, and I was glad as I sent him off, and he was glad as he went; and the hearts in both of us hoped we would meet again in friendship, and give glorious gifts."

He said it, and a black cloud of grief covered the old man over; he took up the grimy dust in both hands and poured it down over his grey head, groaning without stopping.

Nobody has ever explained this scene to everyone's satisfaction, and I do not intend to pretend to. The poem gives no motive; Odysseus says only that trying his father first seemed the better way, and the poem walks on. Some readers have found it unforgivable, and I understand them: the war is over, the suitors are dead, the wife is won, and there is no imposter left in the world to guard against, and still he stands under the pear tree working out the sharpest lie, to an old man in gloves, alone, digging round a sapling and feeding his grief. But there are at least two kinder readings, and the reader should have them. The first is Athena's, delivered a long way back on a misty beach, when she said with open admiration that any other man come home from wandering would have rushed straight to his house and family, and that this man cannot do it — that testing is not a policy with him but the deepest habit he has, worn into him like the scar, and an orchard cannot be entered any differently than a kingdom. The second is harder to say of him, and I offer it carefully: this is a man who has never in his life believed good news without proof, and it may be that the proof he cannot do without here is the grief itself — that he needs to see what his absence cost before he can believe what his presence is worth. I decline to choose between these, and I note only what the poem does next, which is that Odysseus lasts about a minute. The sharp sting goes up through his nostrils as he watches his father, and the trial is abandoned unfinished, and he springs at the old man and kisses him.

"I am he, father — I myself, the man you are asking about, home in the twentieth year, in my own country. Stop your weeping and your tears now, for I tell you — and there is need of haste — I have killed the suitors in our house, and paid out their heart-stinging outrage and their evil deeds."

And Laertes answered him: "If you are really Odysseus, my son, come home, then tell me some sign, a plain one, so that I can believe."

For it is worth a half-sentence to observe that in this family absolutely everyone demands the papers — the wife, the father, and the son too, in his time. And resourceful Odysseus answered: "First, then, look at this scar with your own eyes — the one the boar gave me with his white tusk on Parnassus, when you and my honoured mother sent me to her dear father Autolycus, to collect the gifts he promised me when he came here. And come, I will tell you besides the trees in the tidy orchard that you gave me once. I was a small boy, following you through the garden, begging for this and that, and as we walked along among these very trees you named them for me and told me about each one. You gave me thirteen pear trees, and ten apple trees, and forty fig trees; and you named fifty rows of vines that were to be mine, each of them ripening in its own time, with grapes on them at every stage, whenever the seasons of Zeus came down heavy from above."

At that the old man's knees went loose where he stood, and the heart in him, as he recognised the sure signs Odysseus had told him; he threw his arms round his dear son, and much-enduring

[105] **Wandertown, son of Unsparing.** The names in the last lie are, in Greek, next door to being a joke told with a straight face: he is from Alybas, which sounds like the word for wandering; his father is Apheidas, the Unsparing; his grandfather is Polypemon, Much-suffering; and his own name, Eperitus, is close to a word for a man picked out, or a man of strife. It is the last of the Cretan-type tales (*see Book Thirteen, note 3*), and much the thinnest: his own biography at one degree of separation, barely dressed. Whether the thinness means the habit is running on empty at last, or means the old man was meant to have a fair chance of seeing through it, the poem does not say.

Odysseus caught him to himself, fainting.

You will allow me one paragraph here, because the poem has now finished doing something it has been doing slowly for eleven books, and it deserves to be seen whole. Odysseus has come home three times over, by three tokens, and no two of them are alike. The scar proved the body: an old wound, read by a nurse's hands in the dark. The bed proved the marriage: a made thing with a living root, known to two people, that cannot be moved without being killed. And the trees prove the land, and the tenderest of the three claims: an inheritance counted out to a small boy on a walk through this same orchard, thirteen pears and ten apples and forty figs, by a father patient enough to name them one by one to a child begging for this and that at his heels. The man has now been re-established in every register in which a man exists — flesh, marriage, ground — and each time by something old, particular, and true, which no god could counterfeit and no stranger could learn (*on tokens, see Book Nineteen, note 1*). The poem's answer to twenty years of beautiful lying turns out to be a short list of fruit trees.

When Laertes had got his breath back and his spirit was gathered in his heart again, he said: "Father Zeus — you gods are still there on high Olympus after all, if the suitors have truly paid for their reckless insolence. But now a terrible fear is on my heart, that the men of Ithaca will all be on us here very soon, and sending messengers everywhere to the Cephallenian (island next to Ithaca) towns besides."

"Take heart," said Odysseus; "do not let it trouble your mind. Let us go to the house here by the orchard; I sent Telemachus ahead, and the cowherd and the swineherd, to make dinner as quickly as they could."

So the two of them went to the fine house, and found Telemachus and the herdsmen carving quantities of meat and mixing the bright wine. And the Sicilian woman bathed great-hearted Laertes in his own house, and rubbed him with oil, and put a fine cloak about him; and Athena came near and filled out the limbs of the old shepherd of the people, and made him taller and sturdier to look at than before. He came out of the bath, and his dear son marvelled at him, seeing him like the deathless gods to look at, and said: "Father, surely one of the everlasting gods has made you better to see, in beauty and stature."

And sound-hearted Laertes answered: "Ah, by Zeus and Athena and Apollo — if only I could have stood beside you yesterday in our halls, with armour on my shoulders and the strength I had when I took the strong citadel of Nericus, on the mainland cape, leading my Cephallenians! I would have loosened the knees of many of them in the hall, and warmed your heart inside you." So they talked; and when the work was done and the meal was ready, they sat down in order on the chairs and benches. And as they were putting their hands to the food, the old man Dolius came in, and his sons with him, tired from their work, for the old Sicilian woman, their mother, had gone out and called them. When they saw Odysseus and took it in, they stood stock-still in the hall, astonished; but Odysseus spoke to them gently: "Sit down to your dinner, old man, and all of you forget your amazement; we have been waiting a long while in this hall, eager for the food, and expecting you every minute." But Dolius came straight at him with both arms out, and took Odysseus's hand and kissed it at the wrist, and asked the one practical question in the room: did Penelope know, or should a messenger run? "She knows already, old man," said Odysseus; "there is no need for you to trouble." And Dolius sat back down on his polished stool.

Meanwhile Rumour the messenger went swiftly all through the city, crying the news of the suitors' ugly death and their fate; and the people heard it and gathered from every side, with groaning and lamentation, in front of Odysseus's house. They carried out the dead and buried them, each family

its own, and the dead from other cities they loaded on fast ships for fishermen to carry home; and then they went in a body to the meeting-place, grieving at heart. And when they were assembled and gathered together, Eupeithes stood up among them and spoke — the father of Antinous, the first man godlike Odysseus killed, and grief for his son lay on him past forgetting. Weeping, he addressed them: "Friends, this man has contrived a monstrous thing against the Greeks. Some of us, many and good, he took away in his ships, and he lost the hollow ships and lost the men, every one; and others, and much the best of the Cephallenians, he has killed on his return. Come then, before he can slip away quickly to Pylos, or to sacred Elis where the Epeians rule — let us move, or we shall be hung with shame forever after. This is a disgrace even for men to come to hear of, if we do not take vengeance for the murder of our sons and our brothers. For my part there would be no sweetness in living; I would sooner die at once and be with the men who are gone. Let us move, before they get across the water ahead of us." So he spoke, weeping, and pity took all the Greeks. It is perhaps worth knowing about Eupeithes — whose name, more or less, means the Persuasive — that many years before, when the people of Ithaca were minded to kill him for a piece of piracy, the house he fled to for protection was Odysseus's, and that house held the mob off him. The man now raising the town against the house is a man that house once saved from the town; the poem mentioned it quietly some books ago and does not remind anyone of it here, and neither, at any length, will I.

But now Medon (the herald who was spared in the hall) and the divine singer came to them out of Odysseus's house, where sleep had released them, and stood in the middle of the assembly, and amazement took every man. And Medon, a man of sound sense, said: "Hear me now, men of Ithaca. Odysseus did not devise these deeds against the will of the deathless gods. I myself saw an immortal god, who stood close beside Odysseus in the exact likeness of Mentor; and now he would appear in front of Odysseus, heartening him, and now he went storming down the hall, stampeding the suitors, and they fell thick and fast." So he spoke, and pale fear took hold of them all. And then the old hero Halitherses, the son of Mastor, spoke among them — the one man who saw both forward and back, and who had read the bird-sign to this same assembly years before, and been laughed at: "Hear me now, men of Ithaca, and what I say. It is by your own cowardice, friends, that these deeds were done. You would not obey me, nor Mentor, the shepherd of the people, when we told you to make your sons stop their folly — your sons, who did a monstrous wickedness in their reckless pride, wasting the goods and dishonouring the wife of a great man, because they said he would come home no more. Now let it be this way; obey me as I say it: let us not go, or a man may find a trouble he has drawn down on his own head."

So he spoke; but more than half of them leapt up with a great shout — the rest stayed seated together — for his speech was not to their liking, and Eupeithes had persuaded them, and they ran at once for their armour. When they had got the shining bronze about their bodies, they gathered in a mass in front of the wide-wayed town, and Eupeithes led them, in his folly. He thought he would avenge his son's killing; but he was not to come back again himself, and was to meet his own fate there.

And Athena said to Zeus, the son of Cronos: "Our father, son of Cronos, highest of the powers — answer me, since I ask: what is your mind hiding now within you? Will you make more evil war and dread battle, or will you set friendship between the two sides?"

And Zeus who gathers the clouds answered her: "My child, why question me on this? Was it not your own idea, this plan — that Odysseus should indeed come home and take his payment of these men? Do exactly as you wish; but I will tell you what is fitting. Now that godlike Odysseus has paid the suitors out, let them cut faithful oaths, and let him be king all his days; and let us, for our part, put a forgetting of the killing of their sons and their brothers into the townsmen's minds; and let them love

one another as before, and let there be wealth and peace in plenty."[106]

So he set Athena going where she was already eager, and she went darting down from the peaks of Olympus.

At the farm, when they had put away their desire for the honey-sweet food, much-enduring Odysseus began: "Someone go out and look — in case they are coming, and already close." A son of Dolius went out as he was told, and stood on the threshold, and saw them all near at hand, and his words came out winged with alarm: "They are here, close by — arm, quickly!" Up they got and into their armour: the four around Odysseus, and the six sons of Dolius, and with them Laertes and Dolius put on armour too, grey-headed as they were, fighters because they had to be. And when they had the shining bronze about them, they opened the doors and went out, and Odysseus led them.

And Athena, the daughter of Zeus, came near them, likened to Mentor in body and in voice; and much-enduring Odysseus was glad when he saw her, and said at once to Telemachus his dear son: "Telemachus, now you are come yourself to the place where the best men are sorted out in the fighting, and you will know how not to shame the house of your fathers — we who in strength and courage have been marked out over all the earth."

And sensible Telemachus answered him: "You will see me, dear father, if you care to look, in this present spirit of mine, shaming the house of my fathers not at all — as you put it."

And Laertes was delighted, and said: "What a day this is for me, dear gods! I am a very happy man: my son and my grandson are quarrelling over which of them is braver."

And grey-eyed Athena stood beside the old man and said: "Son of Arceisius, dearest by far of all my companions — pray to the grey-eyed girl, and to father Zeus, and then swing back your long-shadowed spear at once, and let it fly." So she spoke, and breathed great strength into him; and he prayed to the daughter of great Zeus, and swung back his long-shadowed spear at once and let it fly, and struck Eupeithes through the bronze cheek-piece of his helmet, and the bronze did not hold the spear, and the point went through; and he fell with a crash, and his armour clattered on him.

The poem has one killing left in it after four hundred deaths at Troy and a hall full of dead men, and it gives that last spear-cast to the oldest man in the story — to the grandfather, praying first like a pious man, with his son on one side of him and his grandson on the other, all three in bronze in the same line of battle in front of the same farm. The story of this poem, said once at the beginning and once at the bed, is the story of a house; and this is the poem's last picture of the house it means: three generations of one family, standing together in arms on their own land. I will not add anything to that, because it does not want anything added.

Then Odysseus and his glorious son fell on the front rank of them, and struck with swords and leaf-headed spears; and they would have killed them all, and cut every man of them off from his homecoming, if Athena, the daughter of Zeus who bears the aegis, had not cried out in a great voice and held the whole host: "Break off this hard fighting, men of Ithaca — part, now, quickly, and without blood!"

So Athena spoke, and pale fear took hold of them; the weapons flew from their frightened hands and fell, all of them, to the ground at the goddess's voice, and they turned back toward the city, wanting

[106]**The imposed forgetting.** Zeus's settlement should be allowed its full strangeness: the town is full of fathers and brothers of the dead, the feud-machinery we saw priced in the hall (*see Book Twenty-Two on the blood-price*) is armed and running, and no payment, exile or vengeance will be made — instead the gods will put a *forgetting* of the killings into the townsmen's minds. Our word *amnesty* means exactly this: a deciding-not-to-remember. Centuries after Homer, real Greek cities ended civil wars with a sworn amnesty, the oath at Athens being famously worded "not to remember the evils"; what those cities demanded of human discipline, this poem, more honestly perhaps, hands to a god, because it knows what it is asking. Peace in Ithaca is not achieved in this poem. It is installed.

their lives. But much-enduring Odysseus screamed terribly, and gathered himself, and swooped like a high-flown eagle. And then the son of Cronos threw down a smoking thunderbolt, and it fell in front of the grey-eyed goddess, the daughter of the mighty father. And grey-eyed Athena said to Odysseus: "Son of Laertes, seed of Zeus, Odysseus of the many devices — hold, and stop this quarrel of levelling war, or Zeus of the wide brows, the son of Cronos, will be angry with you."

So Athena spoke; and he obeyed her, and his heart was glad.[107] And oaths of peace between the two sides, for all the days to come, were cut by Athena, the daughter of Zeus who bears the aegis, in the likeness of Mentor, in body and in voice.

NOTES TO BOOK TWENTY-FOUR

Here the story of the house of Odysseus ends — with the house standing, and everyone in it home.

[107]**The end, and the man who was glad to stop.** Ancient scholars doubted this book, as they marked a possible end at the bed in the last one (*see Book Twenty-Three, note 4*), and it is true that the poem stops with almost shocking speed — the treaty is cut in the final sentence, and there is no feast, no dispersal, not one line of afterward. I think the abruptness is right, and I will say why briefly: the book has just paid the poem's three outstanding debts — the pattern of Agamemnon's house closed, the father in the orchard found, the feud settled — and with the accounts clear there is nothing left to narrate except happiness, which Greek epic does not narrate. But the poem does spend four words on its hero before the door shuts, and they are the right ones: told by a goddess to stop fighting, he obeyed, *and his heart was glad*. The man of the many devices ends the poem relieved to be given an order — the first order in twenty years it costs him nothing to obey. And Teiresias's oar is still leaning in the corner of all this, unpaid; the gentle death is still a long way off, off the sea or away from it; the poem ends with its hero home, at peace, and owing one more journey, which is perhaps the truest thing it knows about peace.